Linger

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/77611626.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Underage Sex

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - High School, Rockstar!Mydei, Model!Phainon, Time Skips, high school romance, Possessive Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Yandere Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Stalking, Angst, Miscommunication, Waiter Waiter more Yearning please, Mydei is a YEARNER, Underaged Heavy Petting, Mutual Masturbation, freak4freak, Fighting as a Form of Foreplay, Breaking Up & Making Up, Jealous Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Jealous Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Nerdnon, Top Phainon/Bottom Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Masturbation in Bathroom, Blow Jobs, Hand Jobs, Dirty Talk, Manipulative Behavior, Teasing, Oral Fixation, Requesting your crush's bathwater, Anal Fingering, Anal Sex, Dry Humping, Virgin Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon is not a virgin, Additional Warnings in Author's Note, Choking Kink, Eventual Happy Ending, discussion of past sexual encounters, Shower Sex

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2026-01-13 Completed: 2026-05-14 Words: 97,060 Chapters: 10/10

Linger

by K1LLERDR4GON

Summary

> “No, no.” Cipher is saying as she follows his gaze, dread in her tone. “Please don’t tell me that guy’s your type.”
>
> *He dyed his hair back to white.* Mydei finds himself thinking, as Phainon throws his head back, laughing, and his bangs fall into his eyes.
>
> “Worse.” He says glumly. “That’s my ex boyfriend.”
>
> Cipher’s reaction is just a tad over the top. She chokes on her drink, spluttering unflatteringly as she stares at Mydei like he’s grown a second head. “And when were you going to tell me, your dearest friend Cifera…” She starts slowly.
>
> “...that your ex is Phainon fucking Khaslana?”

Mydei is supposed to be here to celebrate. After so much hard work he and his band—Titans of Calamity, had finally signed a recording contract.
The last person he wanted to run into was *him*. Popular, handsome, up-and-coming model Phainon, who had become unrecognizable from the boy he loved in high school.
Mydei never got over their disastrous breakup, and right now, he just wants to forget.
But Phainon won’t make it easy for him.

Chapter 1: You Were My Favourite

Chapter Summary

> Phainon leans closer to him, unaware of the way Mydei's breath hitches when he goes nearer. "Let's find a time and place to do 'it' later." he whispers.
>
> Mydei completely freezes in his seat, and then in a low, gruff voice like he is trying very hard to hold himself back, asks "Do 'it'?"
>
> Phainon blinks at him innocently, not understanding why he's giving such a strange reaction. "You know, to wrestle."
>
> Mydei shuts his eyes and gives a long, drawn-out sigh. He does not open them again for a long time.
>
> "Yes, of course. To wrestle. That was also my thought process."

Chapter Notes

> *slaps top of this fic* this baby can fit so many of my fave tropes in it.
>
> Please note the tags! Click away if any make you uncomfortable, take care of yourself.
> Any mischaracterizations or mistakes are my own fault.
>
> Now that disclaimers are out of the way, my fellow freaks, right this way please~
>
> Additional tags for this chapter: Teenagers jerking off to each other

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei has been blessed with a lot of advantages in life. Loving parents, financial security, a warm roof to grow up under, and he's not bad looking if

he does say so himself. But as a teenager in high school, he did not have any friends. Not a single one.

Because he stood out, and not in the good kind of way. He was too tall, too intimidating, all muscles and long limbs and face etched in a permanent scowl. His wardrobe didn't help his case either, he frequently got into trouble for violating the uniform dress code: His collared white shirt was never tucked in, and always worn open to reveal the black t-shirt underneath. He wore earrings, which were against school regulations, and always wore a thin, dangling gold chain around his neck. He thought it looked cool, but to the other students, he was obviously trouble on two legs, a possible gang member, even.

The other students looked away when he skulked down the corridors, gave his desk a large berth in class so they wouldn't have to pass him, and panicked when it was time to divide themselves into groups because who'd want to do a group project with a delinquent, are you *crazy*?

All except one guy.

All except Phainon.

"Hi." The white-haired boy said, cheerfully plopping his schoolbag on the empty seat opposite Mydei. "I need a project partner. You need a project partner. What do you say?"

Mydei raises an eyebrow. It's not that he doesn't appreciate the forwardness, but the other students are still assigning themselves, so it's not like he's short on options. Phainon is the smartest guy in their class, he's sure the other students would love to be his partner. There is no benefit to teaming up with Mydei, so he can't help but question his sanity.

"Did you lose a bet or something?" He asks blandly. Not that he cares, but he simply doesn't want to deal with the inconvenience of Phainon regretting his decision later and flaking out.

Because he'll end up doing twice the work, and that just sucks all around.

Phainon just peers at him over his thick-rimmed glasses. “No?” He sounds almost offended. “I made my own decision to approach you, what, you don’t want to be my partner? You dislike me that much?”

“I don’t even know you.” Mydei points out. He doesn’t waste energy disliking people, he simply takes the path of least resistance and avoids people he doesn’t care about. Since most of the student body already didn't like him, he hadn’t bothered to get to know them either. Why should he, when they wouldn’t extend him the same courtesy?

“Ouch, you know, that kind of hurts. I’ve been in your class for the whole year.” Phainon smiles ruefully. “But better late than never, right? Why don’t we get to know each other?”

And that was how Phainon wormed his way into his life.

They made an unlikely pair. Phainon was Mydei’s opposite in every way, with his nerdy glasses, messy, thick white hair, and dopey smile. He was always wearing an oversized sweater over his uniform that draped over him like a poncho. He was polite and meek and soft spoken and disappeared during lunch break to go play whatever game he brought to school on his handheld console, alone.

And then all of a sudden he was no longer alone, because Mydei started joining him.

He hadn’t planned on becoming Phainon’s friend outside of class too, but he saw him completely forget to eat his lunch once because he was so engrossed with his game. And if there’s anything Mydei can’t stand, it’s to see someone skipping meals. So he shoves his own lunch into Phainon’s hands, because Kephale forbid his project partner passes out from hunger.

Mydei isn’t a big gamer either but he does own a console and sometimes he can’t stop himself from looking over Phainon’s shoulder and making snarky comments at how he’s playing his game. This normally leads to Phainon

huffing, shoving the console at him and going “Then let’s see you do better, smart ass,” and it’s not his fault he’s easily baited by challenges.

“The other students think I’m bullying you,” Mydei says one day. It’s a very understandable conclusion, given the uh… stereotypes. It’s not that Mydei cares about what other people say, but he still has ears, and it’s tough to avoid the rumours.

“Maybe I should stop hanging out with you,” he continues. Because unlike Mydei, Phainon is well-liked among the student body. He is nerdy, sweet, a teacher’s pet, and always willing to lend a helping hand to others. Being seen around Mydei so often will only tarnish his reputation.

“Huh, why?” That makes Phainon look up from his game, blue eyes blown wide with alarm. Combined with his glasses, it makes them look unbelievably huge, like a bug.

“Didn’t you hear what I said? They think I’m beating you up!” Mydei explains, annoyed again.

It’s unfortunately true that Mydei gets into fights a lot, and he doesn’t bother to conceal the scrapes or bruises he sometimes comes to school with. For some reason, especially among the Kremnoans, people thought he was strong, and lined up in droves to challenge him. And well, there is no word for ‘backing down from a challenge’ in the Kremnoan dictionary.

It’s just self-defense, but that makes people more convinced that he’s a brute.

It doesn’t even make sense, if he was beating up Phainon, wouldn’t Phainon be the one with bruises, and not Mydei?

Phainon just laughs at his frustration. “Haha! I’m afraid I’ll have to disappoint you. I’m not so easy to beat up even if you wanted to.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. Phainon with his oversized sweater and dorky glasses is absolutely an easy target, even if he’s in denial. “I’m not going to do anything to you. You don’t have to act tough around me.”

“I’m not acting tough!” Phainon sulks. “Why don’t you wrestle me, right here, right now?”

“Are you crazy?” They’re sitting inside a discussion room in the library. It’s one of the few places to get some peace and quiet around here, and avoid the gawks of the other students. “We’re still inside the school, dumbass. What’s it going to look like if people see me beating you up in real time?”

At that, Phainon laughs so hard that his eyes crinkle into crescents and he has to hunch over because his stomach hurts. “I don’t think you can!” He finally says in between peals of mocking laughter. “Though you’re most welcome to try.”

Mydei tilts his head, an amused smirk dancing across his face. This nerd is not as meek as he appears, and has quite the smart mouth.

“I’m curious now… but I really shouldn’t. I can’t get suspended again.” Not like it was his fault the first time, since the other guy started it. But the look on his parent’s faces was so devastating that he can’t risk it happening again.

Come to think of it, he can’t blame the other students for giving him such a bad rep, since he has the history for it too…

“Uh… then… for now, let’s arm wrestle!” Phainon suggests.

“Okay, that’s acceptable.”

Mydei places his elbow on the table, flexing his arm in a way that makes the veins on his forearms pop. He doesn’t mean to brag, but he’s been lifting weights lately and his parents even built him a little home gym to workout in. It’s completely understandable if Phainon gets intimidated.

Except that he’s the one shocked when Phainon rolls up the sleeves of his oversized sweater. Instead of a skinny noodle arm, he’s greeted with muscle. Engorged veins trace the back of Phainon’s hand, running up his forearm and disappearing under his sleeve. When he curls his fingers into a fist, the muscles beneath the skin contract in a very visible way.

Mydei swallows and realizes he’s staring.

“I’m impressed. Maybe you’ll be a challenge after all.” Mydei says, trying to cover up his flusteredness with bravado.

Still, there was nobody who could beat Mydei at his own game. This will be an easy win.

They clasp their hands together, Phainon’s palm warm against his as they count down from three. On the mark, Mydei pushes down immediately with all his strength, expecting to slam Phainon’s arm onto the table in seconds.

But their entwined hands do not budge.

Phainon’s strength is equal to his, something Mydei has never experienced before. He’s not winning, damn, he’s not even moving.

Mydei can’t help but meet Phainon’s eyes, not knowing whether he should be feeling impressed or irritated, perhaps a mixture of both. At least he’s not making it easy for Phainon, because the veins on his forehead are bulging as he resists Mydei with all his might.

“Not bad Mydeimos! You’re pretty strong.” Phainon says. Even talking a little distracts him and Mydei gains just a little bit of leeway before their strengths even out again.

“Haha,” Mydei can’t help but bark out a laugh, gritting his teeth. “Not too bad yourself.”

Their arms interlock for a long time, contesting in a silent battle of wills, until Mydei finally manages to overpower Phainon with sheer endurance. It's a narrower win than he’d like, one that could have gone either way, depending on the day.

“How does a nerd that spends all their free time reading books or playing video games get so built anyway?” Mydei asks, having to shake out his arm to get rid of the pins and needles. Damn, his muscles are going to be sore tomorrow.

“Well, before I moved to Okhema, my parents owned a farm. I’ve been lifting heavy objects and helping in the fields since I was young! Even now I get antsy if I don’t exercise every day.”

Mydei can’t help but give Phainon a once over. He doesn’t look it because his posture is awful and he has a baby face, but he’s as tall as Mydei, who is not short in any sense of the word. Plus sometimes when he shifts and his sweater stretches over his shoulders it reveals the faint but undeniable lines of the musculature underneath.

It really makes Mydei wonder what he might look like underneath those baggy clothes.

“If you like to exercise, why don’t you join a sports team? That could increase your popularity among the other students too.” Mydei suggests.

“I don’t know, I rather spend my free time doing other stuff.” Phainon shrugs. “Why do I need to increase my popularity, anyway?”

“So… you won’t be on your own all the time.” Mydei says, it's an obvious answer. After all, nobody likes being lonely.

“I’m not lonely, aren’t I? I got you.”

Play stupid games, win stupid prizes. Mydei’s brain short circuits and he feels heat rise to his face. Does Phainon even realize the things he’s saying and how it might be taken the wrong way? All of a sudden, he realizes how close they’re sitting, and how he can still feel the warmth of Phainon’s palm on his.

Since he caught Phainon forgetting to eat that one time, Mydei had taken the initiative to bring double the lunches. One for himself and one to shove into Phainon’s hands to guilt him into having his meals.

Plus, the delighted look on his friend’s face whenever he opens the lunchbox to see what’s on the menu is never boring.

“Should we take turns bringing each other lunches?” Phainon asks, stuffing his face with the homemade sushi Mydei brought them today. “I feel bad that your mom is always cooking for me. I can make a pretty mean salad!”

“It’s alright. My mom’s not the one making the lunches.” Mydei says, digging into his own meal.

Phainon stops eating.

Mydei glances up too. “What?”

“Are you buying them? Mydei, you bring lunch for me almost everyday! You can’t spend that kind of money on me!” Phainon protests, eyes growing wide and panicked at the mere idea.

Mydei just rolls his eyes. “Relax, I made them.”

Phainon just blinks at him. “You… make these lunches? Everyday?”

Not long after he had gotten into bodybuilding and nutrition, Mydei realized that preparing and cooking his own healthy meals became a source of relaxation and enjoyment for him.

“Yes, making a little extra for you is no trouble at all.” Mydei says, hoping that puts the matter to rest.

“Oh, wow. You’re ama—I mean, that’s amazing!!!” Phainon stumbles over his words with a nervous laugh. “I didn’t know you could cook so well. I feel embarrassed now, cause some of my compliments were uhm… a little excessive.”

Mydei just scoffs. Phainon had moaned so loudly eating the lasagne he brought last week that it lingered in Mydei’s mind for days. But he doesn’t mind, it feels nice having someone praise his cooking so sincerely.

“Don’t worry about it. I think any chef would be happy that their cooking was enjoyed.”

“Then I’ll be sure to continue!” Phainon grins, eating with renewed gusto. “Man, you’re so cool, you’re strong, and you’re a great chef as well! Is there anything you’re not good at?”

Heat rises up his neck again, Mydei had never received such glowing praise on his character before and it was a little embarrassing. “It’s not a big deal… cooking is just a hobby.”

“Oh,” Phainon rolls his eyes as though to say ‘get a load of this guy’. “Any other hobbies I should know about, then?”

Now he’s really feeling shy, Mydei redirects his gaze, staring hard at the wall as he quietly admits. “I also like… baking, and singing… and playing the guitar.”

He knows they’re not the most masculine of hobbies, or hobbies that people expected a guy like him to have. And Phainon’s reaction reflects that as his eyebrows shoot straight up.

“Wow. I didn’t know our scary Mydeimos had such adorable hobbies!”

Phainon, with his big blue eyes, thick glasses, chubby cheeks, and fluffy overgrown white hair looks like an angel. But Mydei is convinced that he’s actually a devil, or at least a professional ragebaiter. Someone who has a phD in testing Mydei’s patience.

“I’m not cute!” He manages to choke out incredulously.

“I’d like to point out that’s a very cute response.”

“Shut up!” Mydei says with no venom. He likes his scary reputation, likes that it keeps others at arm’s length from him. Likes that his so-called ‘cute’ side is one that only Phainon knows. He wants to keep it that way. “You better not tell anyone.”

“Why would I when I get to keep your cute expressions all to myself?” Phainon says smugly. Mydei flushes even harder at how well he has echoed his thoughts, and thinks that the nerd is not as harmless as he appears.

“Gimme your homework.” Mydei demands, dropping his bag on the floor in front of Phainon’s desk, causing him to startle.

It’s a free period right now, Phainon’s time to catch up on his reading or revise like a responsible student, and Mydei’s time to speed run all his homework so that he can spend the rest of his evening in peace. It’s unusual to see Mydei so panicked, because he’s normally very on top of his schoolwork, to the point where he’s normally the one sending Phainon the reminders.

Mydei’s face is dour. It must be a desperate situation if he’s asking to copy Phainon’s homework.

“Is this some kind of bully-nerd roleplay?” Phainon asks, because he can’t resist getting a jab in.

Mydei’s eyes widen when he realizes what it looks like to the other students. It’s very cute. The idea that he could bully Phainon is quite laughable, to be honest. People who judge others on appearances alone are pathetic.

“What? No, I really need your help!” Mydei pleads.

Phainon puts his chin in his palm, grinning at Mydei cheekily. “I don’t know, I was pretty scared earlier. Maybe if you said ~please~.”

Mydei scowls at him. He rarely gets this stressed out about anything, so Phainon has to conclude that it must be related to math, his worst subject. He knows that Mydei’s parents had been threatening to send him for math tutoring if his grades drop any further, which was a fate worse than death for him.

Mydei sinks into the empty chair opposite Phainon and grabs the edge of the table, like he’s bracing himself. Phainon beams at him with his sunniest smile as he waits for it. Mydei takes a deep breath in and, in a voice so soft and rough that Phainon didn’t even know he was capable of it, begs:

“*Please,* Phainon.”

The way in which he said it would stick in Phainon’s memories for years to come. His own smirk falters, and he blinks rapidly as a faint heat creeps up his neck. He has to subtly adjust the collar of his shirt so that it’s not visible.

Mydei is definitely doing this just to fuck with him, but he doesn’t know the affect he has on him. Phainon has secretly admired him for ages now before getting the courage to talk to him.

He has to stop his hands from trembling as he reaches for his bag.

“Okay, okay, just take it!” Phainon doesn’t know which homework Mydei wants, so he just takes them all out, laying them across the table like an offering.

Mydei wastes no time in making a grab for the math worksheet—he knew it, Mydei’s so predictable—nearly flipping his own bag upside down in his haste to find his homework to start copying. As he upturns his bag, various things flutter to the floor, pencils, notebooks, random sheets of paper.

Phainon reaches his hand and grabs one lone piece of paper before it can hit the floor. When he flips it over, he finds that it’s just doodles of red symbols and markings, some jagged like lighting bolts, others swirling like ripples in a lake.

He squints at it, clearly not able to make heads or tails of it. A foreign language? He wasn’t aware that any had an alphabet like this.

“Mydei, what’s this?” He asks.

Across the table, Mydei barely glances up, too busy copying his answers with the speed of a man about to fail his classes. Despite his delinquent exterior his penmanship is surprisingly neat, clean letters with an almost flowy elegance to them.

“Some ideas for tattoos I want to get once I turn 18.” He says simply.

“So many?” The entire paper is filled with sketches. If Mydei gets all of these tattooed on himself, he’ll be inked from head to toe.

The idea of Mydei’s already quite beautiful body decorated with vivid red markings is making Phainon’s head want to explode.

“Tattoos are significant in Kremnoan culture, my parents have plenty of their own. Historically, they represented the spirit and courage of warriors, and are a mark of pride and victory.”

Mydei pauses for just a moment, before a small smile curls the corner of his mouth.

“Also, I just like tattoos.”

“I think they would look good on you.” Phainon praises, he means it.

They continue working in silence, Mydei slowly filling out his worksheet with Phainon’s answers, brow furrowed in concentration. Phainon tries to return to his own revision, he really does, but his eyes wander to Mydei more often than not. He can’t help it, he’d known he was attracted to guys for quite some time now, and after some self reflection has pinned down what he considers to be his ‘type’.

And to be honest, Mydei ticks all the boxes. He’s handsome, strong, cool, clever, and hides a surprisingly soft side behind that delinquent exterior.

At first Phainon had only approached him with the intention of being friends, but now he’s forced to admit that he might have a crush on the guy.

He watches the way Mydei’s forearm flexes as he writes, remembering the time they arm wrestled in the library. Mydei had won, but it was close. It would have been better if they actually went all out, pitting their full strength against each other, but Mydei had been against it at the time. And well, if he used his full strength they might have broken the table, and that would have been bad.

Phainon always liked that kind of thing, pitting his strength against someone else, seeing who came up on top. Growing up in Aedes Elysiae, he'd been like any other village kid, he loved roughhousing in the fields with other children. But as he continued to grow, his strength rapidly outpaced that of the other kids and he was forced to stop because he could accidentally hurt them, even if he hadn't meant to. He learned that lesson the hard way.

So Phainon learned to wrap himself up in soft fabric to make himself seem harmless.

But sometimes, the way Mydei looks at him seems to hint that he sees through Phainon's exterior.

He wonders what it would be like to fight him for real.

"Mydei, do you remember that conversation we had last time?"

Mydei just looks at him like he's the biggest idiot in the world. "Explain properly, I can't read your mind."

"You know, that day when we arm wrestled and I said you couldn't beat me up even if you tried."

Mydei's hand pauses, and he clears his throat nervously until he speaks again. The small gesture slips past Phainon, unnoticed. "I remember, also… I could definitely beat you up."

Still not backing down, so stubborn. But that's kind of what Phainon likes about him. Mydei doesn't go easy on someone just because they look meek.

Phainon leans closer to him, unaware of the way Mydei's breath hitches when he goes nearer. "Let's find a time and place to do 'it' later." he whispers.

Mydei completely freezes in his seat, and then in a low, gruff voice like he is trying very hard to hold himself back, asks "Do 'it'?"

Phainon blinks at him innocently, not understanding why he's giving such a strange reaction. "You know, to wrestle."

Mydei shuts his eyes and gives a long, drawn-out sigh. He does not open them again for a long time.

"Yes, of course. To wrestle. That was also my thought process."

"That doesn't sound too convincing to me. Tell me, what was really going through your mind?" Phainon flutters his eyelashes innocently, he knows that he's playing with fire, but Mydei is just too fun to mess with.

Mydei's response is to immediately push him away in the most dastardly way possible, by rubbing his fingertips against the lenses of Phainon's glasses.

Phainon gapes behind his now smudged vision, stunned into silence by the barbarism.

"You monster!"

"Let's find a time and place to do 'it' later." The mere memory of Phainon's words is enough to send heat rising up Mydei's face.

Is it just Mydei being a pervert? It can't be… he hasn't really had any thoughts on love or relationships or… sex. Of course, he gets horny like any other teenager, but those problems are easily resolved with his hand and pictures of some of the athletes on the sports magazines his father likes to buy.

He'd never felt this way over any other boy before, and it feels like he's a little too old to talk to his parents about getting his first crush. So Mydei tries to just deal with it on his own.

But the idea of sparring with Phainon starts to become more and more appealing. He's always wondered what Phainon's body will feel like over his… in a totally bro way, of course. And was also curious about the sleeper

build he seemed to carry underneath his baggy clothes… in a most platonic way, naturally. So with nothing but innocent curiosity in mind, he makes arrangements for them to have a safe and consensual se—SPAR outside of school.

When all the arrangements are settled, he sends Phainon a text

Mydei:
About our spar… There is a boxing gym near my house that I sometimes visit. It's spacious and quiet and we won't get interrupted. How about we wrestle there?

Phainon:
That sounds great!!! Just tell me the time and date and I'll be there.
I can't wait! <3

Mydei:
All this to beat each other up
You're such a weirdo.

Phainon has what Mydei would consider a cute and innocent appearance, so he would never in his wildest dreams imagine that this puppy had a lust for blood. The very idea makes him scoff in amusement. He was so full of hidden surprises that Mydei was proud to be one of the very few people who knew the real Phainon. Who knew the sharp, slightly aggressive, playful, competitive boy behind the glasses who wanted to test his mettle against a worthy opponent.

So Mydei is more than happy to meet him halfway, if it's a fair fight he wants, it's a fair fight he'll get.

Plus, he can't say he's not a little curious as to what strength he might be hiding.

On the day of their competition, which was a weekend, Mydei arrives at the gym nice and early. While waiting for Phainon he does his usual warmup, some light weight training, and a few laps around the ring. He's in the

middle of some flexibility exercises when Phainon arrives, right at their agreed upon time.

“Wow,” Phainon says, eyes widening. “I’ve never seen you in sportswear before… *wow*.”

Heat rises up his neck as he feels Phainon’s eyes devouring him hungrily. The second wow was so unnecessary. He’s only wearing his usual, a regular gym tank top with exercise shorts, nothing special. But to Phainon, this may be considered the pinnacle of fashion, considering the clothes he’s wearing now are objectively quite awful.

“Are you going to fight in that?” Mydei asks.

The bright yellow hoodie and purple track pants do not complement him at all, and he’s fully covered up, not showing an inch of skin. Despite the tragic outfit choice, Mydei’s heart still skips a beat at the sight of him outside of his usual school uniform.

“Won’t it get hot?”

Phainon just shrugs, tossing his bag on the ground. “It’ll be fine! It was much hotter out in the fields. I’m used to it.”

“Okay,” Mydei tries not to feel too disappointed. “Shall we begin after you warm up?”

“I’m so excited!” Phainon admits as they start the match by circling the ring, seizing each other up. His steps are confident and almost… skippy, his expression is gleeful, like this was playfighting instead of a serious test of strength.

He’s going to regret underestimating Mydei.

“*Hks*, take it seriously,” Mydei snaps, annoyed. He crouches down low, steadying his centre of gravity, muscles tensing in preparation.

He grits his teeth as he makes the first move, lunging for Phainon’s waist, trying to tackle him to the floor in the first movement. It’s a strategy that’s

worked well against most of his Kremnoan brethren, they didn't expect him to be fast and strong, and thus never see him coming. But Phainon was different, he reacted quickly, grabbing Mydei's shoulders in a deadlock, both of them pushing their body weights against each other, neither one wanting to give way.

"Not bad!" Phainon grins, smiling way too brightly for the occasion.

"Shut up!" Mydei growls, digging his heels deeper into the mat for stability.

They grapple, torsos twisting, legs stumbling for better footing. Mydei almost had Phainon in a headlock before the slippery bastard slithers out of his grasp like an eel.

Phainon stumbles backwards on his heels, struggling to keep his balance as Mydei has thrown him off. It doesn't help that they both had to take off their shoes and socks before entering the ring, and his pants are just a tad too long, the bottom of his trousers kissing the ground.

It's this wardrobe malfunction that causes him to trip slightly on the fabric and fall backwards, reaching out to grab any part of Mydei he can hold onto in an effort to take him down with him.

He succeeds, grabbing onto the hem of Mydei's shirt, their combined body weight causing them to fall together. They roll on the ground as one, both fighting for dominance until Mydei ends up on top, he slams down with his elbow, trying to pin Phainon down, but succeeds in pinning down only air as Phainon wriggles out of his grip again.

For such a large guy, Phainon sure is slippery.

Annoyed now, Mydei instinctively reaches a hand out, grabbing whatever he can find, which happens to be a large fistful of Phainon's obnoxious yellow hoodie. Curling his fingers into the soft fabric, he hangs on stubbornly, refusing to let go, keeping Phainon tethered to him.

"You're cheating!" Phainon gasps, wriggling like a fish caught in the net.

“You came unprepared,” Mydei smirks. He usually likes playing fair, and the Kremnoans valued honour and integrity, but something just snaps when it comes to Phainon. He just gets so insufferable about his victories, perhaps a little humbling would do him good.

But he should have seen it coming when Phainon does what he does best and escapes his grasp by… simply *slipping* out of his hoodie.

“Huh?” Mydei exclaims, faltering in surprise as he’s left with nothing but a floppy, hideously yellow hoodie in his hold. His eyes are glazed, staring at the scene in front of him like it’s going to disappear if he blinks.

Because Phainon isn’t wearing a shirt under that hoodie. No, sweat glistens on his bare torso, lean but strong, the result of years helping his parents out in the fields. The nerd has a sleeper build, a body that is undeniably criminal to hide under those baggy clothes. While Mydei’s is a little more sculpted and defined, admittedly because he has an interest towards bodybuilding and actively works towards that, Phainon is just plain… strong.

I’m doomed. Mydei remembers thinking to himself briefly as he drags his eyes away from the trail of sweat running down Phainon’s stomach only to watch the man rush forward, straight into Mydei.

A strong force grabs him around the waist, tackling him down to the ground. And for what it’s worth, Mydei makes a valiant attempt at resisting.

But he’s off balance, and it’s hard to gain it back with Phainon’s sweaty torso pressing down against him. And thus Mydei lets himself fall…

They both land on the mat with a soft thump, with Phainon’s elbows resting on both sides of Mydei’s head like he’s caging him in.

“I won…” Phainon gasps, totally out of breath. His white hair is all messy, matted bangs falling onto his forehead, sticking to the sweat on the nape on his neck. His glasses are askew, one side falling off his ear, and his eyes are so, so blue they nearly glow.

His sweatpants are sitting low on his bare hips, the barest peek of dark underwear visible over the waistline, contrasting with his pale skin. The muscles of his abdomen contract and relax to the rhythm of his heavy breathing.

Mydei swallows lightly, telling himself that the reason his heart is racing and feels like it's about to burst out of his chest is because of adrenaline, nothing more.

It's certainly not because every time he feels Phainon's warm breath on his cheek, he feels like he's going insane.

It's definitely not the way Phainon's thighs are tightly clenched around him to ensure he stays down.

Mydei's face is burning, and he does anything but look at Phainon in front of him.

"Fine… you win." Mydei begs to Nikador, to Kephale, to any god that is listening that Phainon will get off him soon.

He'll die of shame if Phainon realizes that he's hard underneath his exercise shorts.

"Mydei… are you okay?" Phainon asks. He crawls off Mydei, leaving the latter soaked (with sweat), and trembling (from exertion). Mydei sits up and they both spend some time recovering, chests heaving as they try to catch their breath.

"I'm fine." Mydei says. And then for reasons completely unknown to him, he blurts out. "...My house is nearby, why don't we head back there to hang out?"

And just to truly hammer the nail into his coffin, Mydei softly adds. "...My parents are away meeting friends. I'm home alone."

Then he fixes his gaze on a distant wall because he's a coward and doesn't want to see what kind of face Phainon is making.

He’s testing the waters, trying his luck. If he’s horribly wrong about this and Phainon doesn’t actually like him, he can just reject the invitation and Mydei could go home to lick his wounds.

But if he accepts…

Mydei could allow himself to hope a little bit..

“Okay, sure! But I didn’t bring a change of clothes.” Phainon accepts cheerfully without a second thought. With disappointment, Mydei notes that he hadn’t hesitated at all. Perhaps that sort of thing was just normal where he grew up, to simply visit your friend’s house alone without an ulterior motive. Mydei tries not to think too hard about it.

“You can take a shower at my house and I’ll lend you some of my clothes.” Mydei says.

“Sounds great to me! I’m really excited to see your house, Mydei!”

Mydei leads the way to his house, guiding Phainon like he’s a lost lamb, or more like an overenthusiastic dog who gets excited about every little thing from the cul de sac outside his house, to his fence, to his yard, and especially when his cat comes to greet them.

“And who’s this guy?” Phainon says, crouching down to give him a few scratches underneath the chin. The cat freezes, evaluating him for a few moments before it gives Phainon the silent seal of approval by rubbing its body across his legs.

“That’s the great beast of Kremnos, Kokopo the 3rd.”

Phainon blinks at him, then tilts his head to the side like a confused dog. “What happened to the 2nd and the 1st?”

Mydei shrugs “Kokopo the 2nd is living with my uncle in Castrum Kremnos and Kokopo the 1st unfortunately died several years ago.” He beckons for Phainon to move on. “Come on, my room’s upstairs.”

Phainon follows him obediently, pausing halfway up the stairs to look at his old family photos and coo with delight at how cute he looked as a child.

“Haha, you look just like your mom, Mydei!”

“Hmph.” He likes his dad just fine, and he guesses he’s alright looking for an old man, but Mydei is grateful every day that he takes after his mom.

“You’re pretty like her, too.”

Mydei stops in his tracks, turning around slowly to see Phainon still fixated on his family pictures. This could go one of two ways… either Phainon is calling him pretty, or he’s interested in Gorgo. He turns around and tries to forget about option two.

They finally enter his room at the top of the stairs, Mydei feeling secretly relieved that he’s generally a neat person who keeps his room tidy. Phainon is looking around with stars in his eyes, opening his mouth like he wants to start yapping. Mydei knows that once he gets started, he won’t stop for a long time. So to distract him, he quietly rummages in his closet and finds some loose, comfortable clothing that would fit Phainon.

“Here, you can shower first. There’s extra towels in the bathroom.”

He sees Phainon fighting an internal battle within himself. But ultimately, the need to be a polite houseguest outweighs his curiosity and he takes the clothes with muffled thanks, before disappearing into Mydei’s en-suite bathroom to shower.

It’s only when he hears the sound of the water running that Mydei realizes his crush is in his house right now, in his bathroom, taking a shower, naked.

How is Mydei expected to be normal about this?

He paces to and fro the perimeter of his room, pointing at himself in the mirror as he does so. “You are fine.” He says. “This is fine. You are not a pervert, you are *not* a pervert!”

But images of Phainon stark naked are running through his head against his will, and the twitching cock in his pants is really derailing his self-control.

Mydei pauses as he notices a darkening mark on his collarbone, stepping closer to the mirror and removing his shirt for a deeper inspection. It starts on the outer edge of his collarbone, spreading down his ribs and ending just above his nipple. It feels sore when he presses down over it. Phainon must have delivered this blow while they were sparring earlier. It's impressive, actually, to leave such a big bruise on Mydei and still win. There were a lot of people, larger and stronger than the both of them, who couldn't accomplish such a feat. If Phainon knew this, he'd get an even bigger head than he already has.

Mydei's heart skips a beat.

The confidence, bordering on arrogance is something he *really* likes about Phainon.

Just then, the door to the bathroom swings open and Phainon walks out after having finished his shower. His hair is damp, the white appearing almost grey as it sticks to his temples and his ears. He's wiping his glasses with his towel before he puts them back on his face. Mydei had failed to account that while they were almost the same in physique, there were slight differences.

For example, Mydei is a little wider around the hips, but only slightly smaller around the chest. His eyes nearly bulge out of his head at the sight of his own sweatshirt stretching so tightly over Phainon's torso, and he makes a mental note to double his chest days. It's hopeless because he's already chosen the ugliest clothes he owns, a mustard yellow sweatshirt and grey sweatpants with cat pawprints on them. How can he still think that Phainon looks good?

Meanwhile, Phainon is staring at him with equally widened eyes.

"Do you just usually walk around naked?" He blurts out.

“It’s my own home!” Mydei protests, starting to feel shy that Phainon is still ogling at his chest utterly shamelessly. Even though it’s counterproductive, he puts his hands over his chest to cover them, which only seems to draw attention even more.

“...Shower’s free now,” Phainon says, voice dazed, eyes distracted. Mydei nods and practically runs in so he won’t be further embarrassed.

He hisses as the shower water hits his body. Not expecting how *icy* cold it was!

He normally sets his shower temperature just the way he likes it, a toasty 41 degrees celsius. That’s why he didn’t think twice when he turned the knob. Does Phainon hail from the tundra? How can he stand this freezing temperature?

Mydei’s mind, unhelpfully, pivots once more to the idea of Phainon standing stark naked in this very shower, not even a mere 15 minutes ago. Painting terrible images of clear trails of water running across his pale skin, his muscular body, down his thick thighs and over his cock…

Mydei grits his teeth and decides that maybe he’ll have a cold shower today after all.

He’s drying his hair with his towel as he steps back into the bedroom, only to find Phainon rifling through his belongings. He has his elbows deep in his desk drawers, and Mydei sees several of his childhood notebooks out on the table.

“What are you doing?”

“Oh!” Phainon immediately stops, looking like a guilty dog who had been caught. “Sorry—I didn’t mean to pry, I just got curious! I mean, you don’t share much about yourself in school.”

Mydei tilts head, even someone who was curious knows that digging through someone’s drawers is off limits without permission. But luckily, he

doesn’t have anything to hide, so he doesn’t really mind. “And did you find anything incriminating?”

“No, but your room is really nice!” Phainon says, beaming. “Your guitars are super cool! And some of the posters on the walls are signed. Your parents must really spoil you!”

Mydei freezes. He knows he’d grown up luckier than most. He was ‘a little spoiled’, certainly, as his parents had given him anything he asked for growing up. But Mydei is aware of his own privileges and wouldn’t do anything to take advantage of it. More than anything, he tries to practice self-restraint, only asking for what he needs, unless it’s for his birthday or a special occasion.

But from what Phainon has told him about his life, they come from very different backgrounds. Phainon lives in a tiny apartment with his parents, and his living room could probably fit into Mydei’s room. His parents can’t afford to get a car because of how expensive it is, and his school fees were paid by scholarship, which is why he was always under pressure to keep his grades up.

“Does that bother you?” Mydei finds himself asking quietly.

“No! No, I wasn’t judging or anything. You don’t act spoiled, so I was just surprised. I just think… you have a cool space, it says a lot about you.”

“I see… thanks,” Mydei says, not knowing how else to respond. He smiles at Phainon, and Phainon smiles back, and that’s how he knows they’re good.

Phainon plops down on his bed, oohing and aahing about how big and soft it is. Mydei joins him, sitting stiffly by the edge of his own bed. They are so close that their shoulders are almost touching.

“Sorry…” Mydei apologizes. “My home’s kind of boring.” He hadn’t left home today with the anticipation that Phainon would come to visit. To be honest, he hadn’t expected to get this far, and doesn’t know what to do now.

“Stop apologizing!” Phainon laughs. “I had fun today, thanks to you. It’s fun hanging out with you.”

Phainon pauses, and then adds in a softer, more bashful tone. “I would like it if we could keep hanging out like this forever.”

He’s so close, so close that Mydei can feel his body warmth radiating, and his pinky finger is brushing against Mydei, and he can’t stop thinking about how hot Phainon was when he straddled him after their fight. His sweaty body, his pretty white hair, and his blue, blue, *blue* eyes.

Damn… he can’t think straight.

Then Phainon breaks the silence by asking “Hey, can you play a song for me?”

Mydei scoffs, shaking his head lightly. It’s just like Phainon to be so random.

“No.” He says immediately.

“Aww…” Phainon pouts at him. “I guess you’re no good after all. It’s ok, keep practicing, you’ll get there someday.”

Mydei glares. “It’s not that I’m not good.” He retorts, hating how he knows Phainon is doing this on purpose to get under his skin and he’s allowing it because he fucking *likes* him.

“Then why are you so shy?” Phainon laughs, poking the edge of his bicep. “Come on! I won’t laugh at you.”

Mydei sighs, getting off his bed to grab one of his guitars because even though he pretends otherwise, he would do anything Phainon asks of him.

And then he puts his hand on the fretbar and starts to play.

Beside him, Phainon stills, like the room is suspended in time. A moment crystallized in their own little world where the noise outside just falls silent, and the only sound comes from Mydei’s guitar, and his voice as he sings.

If you, if you could return
Don’t let it burn, don’t let it fade…

It’s not… perfect. Mydei has never played for someone else before, not even for his parents and it makes him nervous. He’s sure he’s played some chords wrong, or mispronounced a lyric, or goes off-pitch at some point. But he keeps going stubbornly, staring down at the guitar with clear and unfiltered concentration.

Trying to pretend that he can’t feel the heat from Phainon’s skin as he leans next to him.

He makes it all the way through without messing up too much, miraculous considering that his hands were shaking. The final chords of the song fade into silence and suddenly the room is too quiet. His cheeks are burning, and his throat is a little sore from singing. He finally gathers his courage and rips his gaze from his guitar to look at Phainon.

“There… happy?”

The look on Phainon’s face simply blows him away, because nobody has ever looked at him like that before. Phainon’s staring at him, his lips are parted slightly, his eyes are blown wide open. Almost like… almost like Mydei was the most beautiful thing in the world.

“Mydei…” He finally whispers, hoarse and reverent. “You’re…” Phainon stops, swallows, licks his lips. Mydei can’t stop staring at his pink tongue. “You’re amazing.”

Mydei knows he should think twice, or maybe even one time would be enough.

But he’s not thinking at all when he leans forward, and before he knows it, he’s kissing Phainon on the lips.

Phainon’s lips are soft, warm, and still a little wet from where he had licked them earlier.

And then his brain catches up to his body.

Mydei quickly pulls away, heat rushing to his neck, to his face, even down his chest. He's never been this embarrassed in his life. Fuck, he wants to jump into a hole and die right now.

"Sorry!" He apologizes immediately, panic rising through his veins. Phainon would probably never want to see him again, or talk to him again, and he'd deserve it! "I know we're just friends. I overstepped the boundary. I'm so sorry!"

He covers his face with his hands, as though simply not looking at the problem could make it go away.

Then he hears Phainon laughing, what he doesn't know is if it's angry laughter or disbelieving laughter or delighted laughter.

"Mydei, look at me." Phainon says, sounding gleeful.

"No, I'm busy. Get out of my room."

Phainon just laughs harder, Mydei feels him tugging his hands away from his face and has to relent because that guy is just too strong for his own good.

"You know… I was kind of hoping you'd kiss me first. Because I didn't have the courage to take that first step." Phainon continues, almost shyly. "You know, when I was on top of you earlier."

Mydei lets out a strangled noise. "Can you please stop saying things like that?"

Phainon just smirks, oh, he knows exactly what it sounds like, that *HKS*!

"Good thing you're so much braver than me," he whispers slyly.

"Oh." Mydei says, his head going blank. "Well, you're not going to lose to me, are you?"

Phainon leans in again, their lips meeting each other once more. It's soft, and shy, and his glasses keep stabbing Mydei in the nose because he keeps going at it from a front angle. Mydei decides to gently remove them, with Phainon peering up at him as he does so.

Mydei had never seen such a dazzling shade of blue in his life.

"You're beautiful…" Mydei murmurs.

Phainon freezes. Mydei didn't say the wrong thing, did he? Most guys didn't like being called beautiful. Maybe he should have said handsome, or hot.

"You don't think I'm too dorky?" Phainon asks a little worriedly.

Mydei is taken aback, was that what he was worried about? It seems like such a non-issue to him. Mydei likes that Phainon is dorky, likes that he's unapologetically himself. No matter how he presents himself, he's proven to Mydei that he is an equal, and should be respected as such.

"I like you as you are." Mydei replies, diving in for another kiss. He can't help himself, just the sight of Phainon sitting there, wearing his clothes, his lips pink from kissing, is driving him insane.

He feels Phainon dodge him, but Mydei doesn't even get time to doubt himself. The next thing he knows, Phainon is pushing him so hard that he falls back on the bed while he kneels over him, his elbows next to Mydei's head for balance.

It's the same position they found themselves in after the spar, but this time, Mydei doesn't have his sports shorts and shame to hide behind when his cock stirs again with interest. A cold shower wasn't enough, he should have relieved himself earlier because now his body is starting to remember how it felt to be underneath him.

Mydei shifts around on the bed uncomfortably. "Maybe we should stop here." He says.

“Why?” Phainon tilts his head to the side. What he normally interprets as a cute, clueless gesture now seems almost purposeful and predatory as Phainon’s hand wanders over his trackpants, landing purposefully on his bulge.

Mydei yelps as Phainon touches his crotch, his entire body jerking with shock.

“Oh, someone’s excited.” He says, and there was nothing innocent about the way he said it..

“Please… don’t keep bringing it up.” Mydei’s voice comes out higher-pitched than he’s used to. And he crosses his legs as though that might help matters. It doesn’t.

Phainon purses his lips, looking thoughtful. Mydei thinks that he looks awfully different like this, glasses off, bangs splattered messily across his forehead, the expression in his eyes hungry and wanting.

He gulps, not able to take his eyes off. He’s so grateful to be the only one to see this side of Phainon.

And then swiftly comes to regret it as Phainon shoves his thigh straight onto his cock.

Mydei hisses, nearly kicking out his leg in response.

“You sure you don’t want any help with that?” He asks innocently, but Mydei has come to understand that this boy is anything *but* innocent.

He presses his thigh down against Mydei’s groin, although they’re both still clothed, Mydei can feel the hard lines of muscle against the fabric of their pants, the way it flexes and contracts when he pushes down in a rhythmic fashion. The way that Phainon’s bulge also seems to be getting bigger incites Mydei’s curiosity.

It’s just… look… he hasn’t seen anyone else’s penis aside from his own, okay?

“Can we…” Mydei swallows nervously. “Can we do this without our pants?”

Phainon looks funny when he flushes, the red stands out starkly against his pale skin and white hair, and this close, Mydei can see just a hint of freckles.

“O-okay.” He says.

Phainon’s hands tremble just a little bit as he loosens the knot keeping his sweatpants tied together, and it slides off his narrow hips. Mydei gulps at the trail of fine, white hair that travels downwards from below his navel.

There is nothing between him and Phainon’s penis except his dark navy boxer shorts, of which the outline of his cock is straining against the thin fabric.

Mydei hasn’t really seen enough to know what’s big or not, but he thinks that Phainon is big, and he isn’t even done growing yet.

Mentally, in the back of his mind, Mydei thinks someday he wants to take that into himself. He doesn’t know how he’d be capable of doing such a thing but maybe if he practices…

Mydei slowly wriggles his own pants downwards, feeling a little shy. It feels weird, being so exposed to someone else, he hasn’t done anything like this before.

But from Phainon’s awestruck facial expression, it looks like he needn’t have worried. He looks like he is discovering his sexuality for the first time, the way his mouth hangs open and he stares unblinkingly.

While Mydei was fine with it for the first few seconds, the longer Phainon stared without saying anything the more nervous he felt.

“Is it… okay?” He asks hesitantly.

Phainon’s jaw closes with a snap as he nods his head to and fro so enthusiastically that his hair flips back and forth. “It’s perfect! More than

perfect! I mean, you're so perfect that it's making me…"

His voice trails off, unable to finish his words. Instead, his hips buckle with a small moan as Phainon loses what little self-control he has and sticks his hands underneath his boxers, stroking his cock furiously.

The sight turns Mydei on so much that his cock twitches without even being touched. Mydei finds himself doing the same, reaching for his own cock, rubbing it up and down in his palm, grunting slightly at the pleasurable feeling.

"Does it feel good?" Phainon says, a little breathless. His words are interspersed with soft moans as he strokes the underside of his cock.

"Yeah," Mydei slurs his speech, his eyes fluttering shut as he throws his neck back, wanting to savor the feeling of Phainon's warmth above him, and the sound of his breathy cries.

"Oh my god." Phainon mutters. "Can I… can I kiss you?"

"Yes." Mydei immediately feels Phainon's warm lips on his as he kisses him deeply, without inhibitions or technique. He's a messy kisser, sloppy, like he's been holding it in for far too long and needs to get everything out now, all at once. He's dominating, not even allowing Mydei to take a breath in until he's practically gasping in his mouth. And he's definitely using too much tongue, licking up the sides of Mydei's mouth, his lips, and sometimes even the edge of his jaw.

Well, Mydei is kinda into it though, judging by the way his cock jerks in his hand, and Mydei knows he's dangerously close to coming.

"Wait… wait!" He pulls apart so roughly that he knocks his head into Phainon's face on accident, and both of them separate from each other, wincing slightly from the pain.

"Sorry." Mydei apologizes.

"Hngh…" is all Phainon can say.

Mydei looks at him with worry, thinking that he’s hurt him unintentionally. He gets even more concerned when he sees Phainon clutching his nose with one hand.

“Are you alright?” Mydei asks, panic lacing his tone. If he seriously hurt Phainon because he couldn’t control himself that would be so…

“I came…” Phainon says in a mortified whisper. And when they both look down, it’s obvious that his other hand is coated with a sticky, white substance.

Mydei snorts, despite himself.

“Don’t laugh!” Phainon says in a voice that’s almost a squeak. Covering his furiously blushing face with the elbow of his clean arm. “It’s just… that… that was so hot!”

“Pft…” Mydei says, still trying not to laugh. He reaches across the bed and throws a box of tissues on the bed so that Phainon can clean himself up. While he does so, Mydei continues stroking himself, shutting his eyes and imagining the look on Phainon’s face when he’s kissing him.

It doesn't take long for him to be rock hard again, and thanks to a teenager's notoriously poor stamina, he feels his pleasure build up quickly until it finally releases in a wave of ecstasy.

“Hah…” Mydei sighs, breathing heavily, feeling sweat condense on his forehead. He makes a grab for the tissues, only for Phainon to stare at him with the biggest, wettest puppy eyes known to man.

“What?” Mydei asks.

“Mydei… I’m so sorry, I dirtied your bed.” Phainon says, panic lacing his tone.

Mydei looks down at his bed, right there, on the center of his sheets, is a small wet spot no larger than a coin. Phainon looks as guilty as a dog, and Mydei can’t help but find it amusing.

“It’s fine, I’ll clean it up later.” He’s not sensitive, especially not when it’s Phainon’s bodily fluids. Besides, his parents respect his privacy and won’t barge into his room since he’s generally a responsible son.

They clean up in silence, and then sit on the opposite ends of the bed again, still without speaking. Mydei doesn’t really know what to say, the fact that they jacked off to each other probably meant they couldn’t be just friends anymore. But at the same time, Mydei has always imagined a more… romantic proposal if he ever were to get a significant other.

“Uhm…” Phainon finally says, his face beetroot red. “I know this probably isn’t the best time after all that’s happened but would you like to be my boyf-”

“Yes.” Mydei says immediately without waiting for him to finish his sentence.

Chapter End Notes

I've been working on this since around November... I've been sitting on it for quite a while now, re-writing portion after portion but perfection is the enemy of good, as they say so I am just going to post it.

I'd like to list in each chapter a song that inspired me while writing and thus became the chapter title.
Today's song is Favourite by Fontaines D.C.
I have also made a spotify playlist of songs that inspired this fic! It's about 2 songs per chapter in chronological order. Do give it a listen for like... the vibes and stuff.

I'm on twitter where I yap and repost Phaidei mostly.
Thank you for reading!

Chapter 2: Who's Your Boyfriend Now?

Chapter Summary

> Phainon turns around and catches Mydei's gaze, and his eyes feel like a pair of bright blue headlights that beam straight into his soul.
>
> Those monster movies are obviously pure fiction, but just this time, he's inclined to believe that there's a skinwalker in Phainon's body.
>
> "Who the fuck are you?" Mydei growls, grabbing 'Phainon' by the lapels of his uniform shirt. Even the way he wears his uniform has changed. Gone were the frumpy sweaters and wrinkled shirts that look like he never bothered to iron. This Phainon looked like he stepped out of some uppity fashion magazine. His shirt neatly pressed with the top two buttons undone, the navy blazer accentuating his broad shoulders and the no longer hidden strength of his physique.
>
> All Mydei can do is glare.
> He looks exactly like Phainon.
> Yet he looks nothing like Phainon.

Chapter Notes

> The song of the day is Who's Your Boyfriend by Royel Otis!
> Spotify playlist
>
> **Additional CW for this chapter**: Breakups

See the end of the chapter for more notes

During his spar with Mydei, Phainon had gone all out, and Mydei had done the same. This left Phainon with a few lingering bruises on his body, blooming beautifully black and blue the next day. He wasn't so worried about the ones on his arms and torso, he could cover those up easily with his clothing, it was the one on his face that he was more concerned about.

Because… when Mydei got startled, he may have hit him in the face a little too hard, accidentally, of course! And Phainon doesn't hold it against him, Mydei's blushing face was just way too adorable! Unfortunately, his pale skin means he bruises quite easily. Now he's got a rapidly spreading purple mark that crosses his nose and his cheeks, looking like he tripped and ate concrete.

His parents were initially concerned, but luckily, he was able to talk his way out of it. After all, they had raised him and knew his penchant for getting into trouble, also, they knew he wasn't so easily made a victim of bullying.

In fact, Phainon was all giggly the rest of the weekend, floating on cloud nine. He has a boyfriend now.

A beautiful, gorgeous, handsome, super cute boyfriend named Mydei.

Who belonged to Phainon and no one else.

But like always, reality came crashing down on him come Monday. Although he was proud of his bruises, and wouldn't even mind if it took a longer time to recover, he forgot that the rest of the world saw something very different.

The moment the first classmate turned around to greet him good morning, her face fell and she let out a huge gasp that drew attention to them.

"What happened to your face?" She said in horror. "Did someone hit you?"

And that seemingly opened the floodgates to the fake 'concern' he was bombarded with for the rest of the day.

"Are you being bullied?"

"You know you can talk to us, right?"

Gentle inquiries became… not so gentle inquiries. Especially when Mydei strode in right before the bell with his usual confident demeanor, head held high, matching purple bruise on the edge of his collarbone. He didn't speak

to anyone, which was normal, but he did smile at Phainon when he took his seat, which made butterflies explode in his stomach.

But that only made things more complicated. If his classmates knew he got his bruises from Mydei, the rumours about him would spread far beyond either of their control. To the point where even the teachers would no longer be able to ignore it.

And the person who had the most to lose would be Mydei.

He couldn’t allow that to happen.

So Phainon makes the decision to lie, he tells people he tripped and landed on his face. His suspicious answer only makes the questioning more invasive.

“You shouldn’t get mixed up in fights.”

“Is it Mydei who hit you? You can be honest with us.”

“Do you need us to report it to a teacher?”

The so-called ‘good natured’ enquiries are starting to piss him off. Nobody ever bothered him or gave him the time of day before he started hanging out with Mydei. Now, all of a sudden, everybody cares, everybody is concerned.

It seemed like what they really cared about was villainizing someone they didn’t like, and not actually his wellbeing.

Sneaking out for his usual lunchtime with Mydei had become an almost impossible task. Phainon could barely take 2 steps before some well intentioned schoolmate stopped him, touched his shoulder, all with frowns on their faces and fake concern in their voices. It didn’t feel like they wanted to help him-

It felt more like they were trying to convince themselves that they were morally superior.

Mydei never did that to him. Mydei was simple, straightforward, blunt, and although he was stingy with his emotions, he was so, so honest.

“Just let them gossip.” Mydei tells him once they finally clawed some time alone. “I’m not worried about it.”

Phainon admires how he’s unperturbed by the bad rumours, how he’s so effortlessly calm about everything, like the worthless opinions of others simply didn’t reach him.

He wishes he could be more like that, instead of caring so much about what other people thought of both of them to the point where he lost sleep.

“Aren’t you afraid they might try something?” Phainon bites his lip, his nervousness showing through.

Mydei shrugs. “I can protect myself, so I dare them to try.” Then he looks at Phainon and caresses his jaw lightly with his hand. “I can protect you too.”

It’s a reassuring gesture, and Phainon nuzzles his chin into the warmth of his hand.

“I’m sorry about the bruise, by the way.” Mydei apologizes. “I feel horrible when I look at it.”

“Aw,” Phainon sulks. “What, you don’t think I’m pretty anymore?”

“If anything, it makes you even more attractive,” Mydei says with a light smirk. “But I don’t think that’s appropriate to say out loud.”

He’s right, it’s indeed inappropriate to say that considering the way it makes heat sink down to his loins. Phainon grits his teeth and groans, leaning forward to sink his head into Mydei’s shoulder.

“Mydeiiii~” He whines. “You can’t just say stuff like in the middle of the school day! How are you going to take responsibility for it?”

Since Mydei hadn’t been bothered about the whole bullying rumours, Phainon would have been content to just leave it there, if *that* hadn’t happened.

It was just an ordinary day in class when the PA system suddenly rang out with an announcement.

‘Could Phainon Khaslana please come to the principal’s office?’

Phainon feels his blood freeze as everyone in class turns their head to look at him, Mydei included. He… doesn’t think he’s done anything wrong to warrant a summoning. Phainon‘s always been a generally good student, good grades, good behaviour, on good terms with everyone. He doesn’t really have any enemies.

‘Could Phainon Khaslana please come to the principal’s office?’ The announcement repeats.

The class is silent as Phainon pushes his chair backwards, the legs screeching against the tiled floor..

“Excuse me. May I?” He gestures with his hands blindly, and the teacher nods and returns to writing on the board, giving him permission to slip out.

Mydei sends him a concerned look as he passes, and Phainon smiles and puts on a brave face so he won’t worry.

He’s never really been to the principal’s office before, except for that one time he was asked to run an errand for a teacher. The room is exactly how he remembered it, neat, orderly, stacked to the brim with various files and paperwork. In the center of it sits principal Caenis, working at her long desk surrounded by even more paperwork. A few chairs were positioned opposite her, for the unfortunate students, or parents, summoned to her office.

It looked like it hadn’t changed in 20 years, and neither had principal Caenis. Her neat grey bun, stern looking facial expression, and wrinkles were the same as he always remembered.

“Please, don’t look so nervous, you’re not in trouble.” She inclines her head and gestures for him to take the seat opposite her.

As he does so, Phainon thinks that it’s not actually himself that he’s worried about.

“How have you been, Khaslana? Are you well?” she asks, which truly baffles him, because she wasn’t exactly known to be the most empathetic person around.

“Yes, I’ve been fine.” He says. “Great, in fact.” he feels obliged to add the last part, just to emphasize how well everything’s been going lately.

“Hm…” Caenis shuffles some pieces of paper under her hands which he recognizes as his student file. When she looks at him, Phainon feels like she’s actually scrutinizing the partially healed bruise on the bridge of his nose. “You’re a bright student, Khaslana. On scholarship, too. I’ve heard good things about you. Have you ever thought of running for student council?”

“...Not really.” He admits, never having much interest in politics.

“A shame, we’re lacking quality candidates for student council president, and I think you’d be a good fit.”

Phainon doesn’t know how to respond to that.

The room lapses into silence yet again, Phainon just sits quietly, wondering when she is going to get to the point.

“Some of the students have… raised concerns over the company you keep.” Caenis finally says. Phainon’s heart sinks, of course it is about Mydei, as he feared. “You’re not being bullied by Mydeimos, are you? This is a safe space for you to speak out.”

Phainon feels nothing but frustration. He has been speaking out for months now that Mydei is a good person, and nobody is listening. The fact that someone decided to bring this all the way to the principal infuriates him,

because he knows nobody would do the same for Mydei if their positions were switched.

“There’s no bullying whatsoever.” Phainon says firmly. “We’re friends. Very good friends.” He doesn’t explain that they’re boyfriends, because he doesn’t want to complicate things for himself.

Caenis just looks at him, assessing him quietly, as she had already decided that he was lying by coercion. From who? From Mydei? The guy doesn’t even care!

She places her hands on her desk “As your principal, I feel it is my moral duty to offer advice to students when I think they’ve strayed onto the wrong path.” Caenis says. “Kremnoans are… very physical people. Prone to violence. I mean, just look at their history, their people consider duelling each other to the death the highest form of honour.”

That’s a stereotype at best, and Phainon’s jaw tightens. But there is no point in trying to change someone’s mind when they already had it made up. Especially not someone as prejudiced and narrow minded as principal Caenis.

“You are a good student, with a bright future. I think it would do you some good to distance yourself from students with… checkered pasts.”

“With all due respect, principal.” Phainon interrupts. “I don’t think Mydei has done anything wrong.”

Caenis sighs, as though he’s just walked into her trap. She flips open another folder, slow and deliberate enough for Phainon to see Mydei’s photo clipped onto the front page.

“Let’s see… one suspension, 5 student complaints, and he spends so much time in detention that it might as well be his extra-curricular.” She says blandly. “Must we wait for tragedy to strike before taking preventative action?”

Phainon is seething so hard that his head has gone blank, and he can't think of anything to refute her statements that wouldn't make things worse for the both of them. Caenis simply continues.

"Honestly, I wasn't too keen on letting Mydeimos into the school. We're quite prestigious, and our reputation is something we guard carefully. It's our responsibility to uphold the trust parents have placed in us. But well, when one's parents have a certain… financial disposition, it opens a lot of doors."

Phainon pauses. Could she be insinuating that Mydei's parents *bought* his way into the school? He knew they were well off, but Mydei had spoken before of studying and passing the entrance exams, same as any other student.

The baseless accusation makes hatred swirl in his chest.

"Since a model student like you is vouching, I am willing to overlook things this time. But please, don't hesitate to let me or any teacher know if you are being bullied. We have zero tolerance for that here."

"Noted," Phainon says, barely able to keep his voice under control. "If that is all, may I go now, principal?"

Caenis nods, returning to her work. "Yes, that's all. If what you say is true, perhaps it would be easier for Mydeimos if he knew someone in a position of responsibility, say, from the student council, to… guide the rest of the students' misguided assumptions."

Phainon is certainly sharp enough to pick up her implicit meaning. 'Join the student council, become my dog, and things might improve for Mydei.' It pains him to fall into her trap just like that, but perhaps she already knew that he was willing to do practically anything for Mydei, and was taking advantage of it.

Phainon returns to the classroom but his attention span is somewhere else. He's thinking about what Caenis said, mind going in circles. It infuriates him that someone reported Mydei to the principal anyway even though he

insisted back and forth that nothing was wrong. People were so eager to point fingers and blame someone because of their own prejudice rather than get to know the person instead.

If anything, Mydei is the one being bullied by the other students. But not with fists and words, that would have been easier to deal with. His is the more insidious kind, the kind where the cards are stacked against you without you even realizing it.

Mydei looks for him at lunch that day, a worried furrow on his brow. “What did the hag want? Did she threaten you?”

Phainon shakes his head. Principal Caenis had said nothing of value, and nothing that needed to be repeated. The last thing he wanted was to ruin Mydei’s day by telling him that some people believed that his parents bought his way into the school.

“She just wanted to do a wellbeing check. Apparently, some of the students raised concerns.”

Mydei clicks his tongue, facial expression relaxing. “Busybodies.”

But the tension doesn’t leave his shoulders. He goes silent after that as they both enjoy their lunch. Well, Phainon is enjoying it, Mydei looks like he’s putting fork to mouth on autopilot, his thoughts a million miles away.

“Is something on your mind?” Phainon asks. “Do you want to talk about it?”

Mydei hesitates, but he’s honest to a fault, and will always speak his mind if Phainon asks. “I was just thinking.”

“Oh no!” Phainon exclaims, trying to lighten the mood. “Mydeimos, thinking? I thought I’d never see the day!”

Mydei shoots him a look that indicates he’s equal parts amused and annoyed, and Phainon gestures encouragingly for him to go on.

“I just think it would be better for us to keep our relationship a secret for the time being.” He continues. “I think that might be for the best, actually.”

Phainon is stunned, his spoon hovering halfway to his mouth. Sure, he doesn’t go out of his way to brag about it, even though he sometimes really, really wants to. But he didn’t plan on denying it either.

“Huh?” He says, a little shaken. “But why?”

Mydei’s eyes flit to the floor, not meeting his gaze. “With all these rumours flying around about me I think it’d be best if people didn’t know we were dating.”

“I don’t care if-”

“I know.” Mydei interrupts him, soft but firm. “But I don’t want you getting dragged into this more than you already have. For now, I don’t mind if it remains like this.”

But Phainon minds, and even though Mydei claims otherwise, he knows he minds as well.

“Okay…” Phainon finally relents. Mydei asks for so little already, and he hates to deny him anything, even if it’s something he doesn’t agree with.

But he hates the whole situation, hate what it’s done to Mydei, specifically. That even someone who doesn’t give a fuck is forced to hide a part of himself just to appease others. And Phainon even hates himself a little bit for going along with it.

Perhaps, if he just had a little more influence, was a more reliable and liked figure in the school community then maybe he could change something.

Principal Caenis’ suggestion runs through his mind again. If he could charm his way into becoming the student body president then…

“By the way, how’s the search for a summer job going?” Mydei asks suddenly, clearly trying to pivot the subject. Phainon latches on, grateful for the change in topic. He didn’t want to bring up Caenis’ suggestion because

he knew that Mydei would absolutely hate it, and there was no point in spoiling the mood.

“You know that summer job as a fashion designer’s assistant I applied for?” Phainon grins. “She’s asking me to drop by after school tomorrow, I think she really likes me.”

Mydei huffs. “With your fashion sense, I can’t imagine why she chose you.” he teases, but his expression is fond and his eyes are warm.

“Hey!” Phainon pouts. “Perhaps she likes me for my organizational skills, or that I’m good at handling difficult people?”

“You are pretty good at that,” Mydei agrees easily. “I know I’m not easy to be around…”

“Well, I don’t think that.” Phainon says. “I mean yeah, you’re prickly, and you don’t like wasting time. But you’re easy to get along with, anyone who doesn’t see that is a fool.”

“Hmph.” Mydei says, his trademark go-to when he doesn’t have an adequate response for the situation. But there’s a light flush on his cheeks that indicates he’s rather pleased by Phainon’s answer.

It makes Phainon want to squeeze his cheeks, even though he knows he’ll get a walloping from it. My buff Kremnoan boyfriend can’t be this adorable!

“How about you? What are your plans over the summer?” Phainon asks. “I’ll be working but it’s only part time, I should have a lot of time to hang out.”

Mydei shuffles on his feet guiltily. “That’s what I wanted to talk to you about. My parents are taking me to Castrum Kremnos for the whole summer. There’ll be some big changes to their business and it involves me, apparently. We’re going to discuss it with my uncle Krateros.”

Phainon is disappointed, but Mydei must have felt even worse. The look on his face is gutted. He looks like he'd rather be doing anything than to be stuck in meetings with his parents and uncle over their first summer break as a couple.

He forces a smile on his face and reassures himself that it's only a few months, they'll have lots and lots of summers to spend together after this one. He'll make sure of that.

"You'll make it up to me after summer." Phainon says plainly.

Mydei smiles and steps forward, grabbing Phainon lightly by the chin. He leans in without hesitation, bold and brash in everything he does, kissing Phainon softly on the lips.

Without realizing it, Phainon's eyelids flutter shut. He steps forward, wanting more, but meeting only air.

"Oh? Is that a threat?" Mydei teases, his golden eyes are warm as he gazes right at Phainon.

Phainon feels his heart beating so quickly that it might as well break through his ribs and leap out of his chest. He's falling so hard that he wonders if Mydei can see the hearts in his eyes.

It's then that Phainon makes up his mind. If the world is going to treat this man unfairly, then he will be the one to change the world around him.

He'll become someone impossible to ignore. Somebody respected. Somebody with influence. He'll run for student council president next year and he'll win, whatever it takes. He will be the sword that stands between Mydei and those who wish him harm. Nobody, not even Caenis, will be able to do anything then.

He has a lot of work to do over the long summer break.

It starts with his part time job as Aglaea's personal assistant, simply put, it's hectic. She was reasonable with her expectations, and paid very generously,

but she was also high strung, uptight, and demanded perfection. There was never a slow day in her studio, but Phainon could say he learned a lot from the experience.

On his end, Mydei seemed equally as busy, judging by the sleepy cat emojis he sends Phainon when he has to be stuck all day in more ‘stuffy board meetings’. Phainon has briefly wondered what position he holds in the company where a mere teenager has to attend meetings.

When asked, Mydei dodges his question by replying ‘*If things go well this summer, I’ll never have to attend another one of these stupid meetings again!’* Followed by an emoji of a cat cheering.

He can’t get over how cute Mydei’s texting style is, for someone who looks like a delinquent. He misses his boyfriend so much.

Over the summer he studies something completely different from his usual academics. He studies social science; How to carry himself with confidence; How to make it sound like he knows what he’s doing, even if he doesn’t; How to be charismatic and attractive and to have everyone’s eyes on him. He experiments with his hair, his clothes, and even swaps out his glasses for contact lenses.

And since he gets along pretty well with his new boss, he eventually gathers the courage to ask the terrifyingly beautiful designer if she can help him with his style and fashion.

Aglaea looks up from her sewing machine, setting down her teacup like she’s been waiting her whole life for this. “Oh thank Mnestia, I thought I was going to have to put up with this until the end of summer.” She says, almost relieved.

“Let’s begin by burning your entire closet.”

At night, he collapses on his bed and begins texting Mydei, who’s also wrapping up a long, exhausting day. They talk about everything and nothing. Phainon talks about how Aglaea nearly bit his head off because he dropped a box of wool, and all the spools unraveled and got tangled up with

each other. Mydei tells him about how one of Krateros' executives had his fly unzipped throughout the whole meeting and he struggled trying not to laugh.

And then he stops there. He does not tell Mydei about his plans for the next school year, he does not tell him about the changes he's making to achieve that. The changes he's making for them.

Phainon tells himself it's because he wants it to be a surprise, but the other reason is because he knows that Mydei isn't going to like it. That guy is stubborn to a fault, and he'd probably try to talk Phainon out of it. He'd probably blame himself too, feeling guilty for forcing Phainon's hand, even though this has been Phainon's own decision.

If he stops too long to think about it, he's going to start feeling bad that he's essentially deceiving Mydei.

So he reassures himself by thinking that Mydei loves him too, and he'll understand that Phainon is doing this for the both of them. Even if he has to transform himself until he's something unrecognizable, to become something that he doesn't care for, he'll do it if it means they both get what they want.

Euryphon and Gorgo can't stop smiling to themselves as Mydei hurries off to the first day of the new school year. A few short months ago, seeing him this excited for school had seemed impossible. Yet here he was, bright-eyed, bushy-tailed, checking his reflection in the window before heading out, a small smile playing on his face.

Gorgo exchanges a knowing look with her husband. Their son had been constantly talking about a new friend, someone named 'Phainon', who was obviously the root cause of his recent happiness.

"Introduce us to him sometime," Gorgo tells her son teasingly.

Mydei flushes a faint pink. “Perhaps if the two of you stop being embarrassing, I’ll consider it.”

The teenager rolls his eyes, but leaves home with a veritable spring in his step. Euryphon has a deep frown on his face the entire time.

“Honey, you don’t think…” Euryphon looked aghast as he thought of something. “You don’t think our son is dating this boy, do you?”

Gorgo rolls her eyes in a way that is eerily similar to the way her son does it. “You’re a bit slow, aren’t you dear?”

On the way to school, Mydei is already mentally rehearsing what he’d do when he sees Phainon again. He’ll tease him a little bit, act nonchalant and chill. Then after Phainon starts sulking, he’ll drop the act and say that he missed him a lot.

For the cherry on top, Mydei would present the gift he picked out while he was in Castrum Kremnos. The one he spent a long time choosing. He knows Phainon isn’t big on jewelry, so he got him something a little more subtle, instead. It’s a pin, made of precious metals, that he carefully selected, paid for, and polished himself in the shape of a sun.

Why a sun? Well, the reason is a little embarrassing, but Phainon reminds him of the sun. Always bright, always warm, impossible to ignore.

Mydei’s own personal sunshine.

And then if he was lucky, they’d share a kiss. Thinking about that last part always sends heat rising up his neck.

He’s just passed the school gate when he hears Phainon’s name mentioned by an unfamiliar student, in an unfamiliar voice.

“Did you see that 3rd year? Phainon? He got really hot over the summer!”

Mydei stops, huh?

“I know! Why hadn’t I noticed him before?”

That couldn’t be his Phainon, right? But there was no one else by that name in school.

Maybe he had misheard the name. They say if you miss someone too much, you’ll start hearing their name all over the place. Mydei shakes his head and decides to carry on.

Something so big… Phainon would have definitely told him about it, and he’d heard nothing of the sort.

He’d barely gotten a few steps further into the school when he hears people talking again.

“Phainon’s shoulders, bro—I’m going to recruit him for the basketball team.”

“Was he always that tall? I swear he grew again.”

“I didn’t even know we had such eye candy in our own school!”

Mydei’s frown deepens, something prickling under his skin. He’s getting an uneasy feeling about this because something clearly had changed, and he wasn’t privy to it.

One of his acquaintances at school, if only because he doesn’t avoid Mydei as much as the other students, greets him at the lockers when he drops off his belongings. “Hey, you’re the guy who always hangs around Phainon, right?”

Mydei slams his locker shut, an unimpressed look upon his face. Phainon’s friend would have sufficed, but he supposes it was still slightly better than the title of ‘Phainon’s bully’.

The student flinches slightly at the sharp noise, a grimace upon his face. “Okay, chill out! I’m just trying to say that you better go get him before he causes an even bigger scene.”

Mydei’s eyebrow rises up. “What?” He says flatly.

The student gestures. “You know, he’s been stealing the attention of all the girls since this morning. They’re losing their minds.”

If Mydei was a weaker man, he would have collapsed on the spot. ‘Stealing the attention of all the girls’ just did *not* sound like the Phainon he knew.

Sweet and shy Phainon who preferred to spend his free time gaming in silence instead of socializing with his peers? Who was unapologetically unashamed of where his interests lie? Phainon who—Mydei thought—yielded to nobody and no one?

What was going on? He had to get to the bottom of this.

Mydei heads towards the courtyard, finally spotting him across the way. He’d almost walk past him if he didn’t catch the signature white glint of his hair. Because he nearly doesn’t recognize him. That’s not his Phainon.

His hair isn’t overgrown or as fluffy as he remembers it. It’s neatly trimmed, bangs parted in a way that’s flattering to his face, and reveals his eyes.

It’s so weird to be able to see those sparkling blue eyes clearly.

Wait.

Hold on a minute.

Where the *fuck* are his glasses?

Mydei’s footsteps quicken, and before he realizes it he’s storming over the courtyard, almost leaving a dust cloud where he strides. The students surrounding and gawking at Phainon immediately scatter like leaves to the wind when they see him coming. It looks as though he still has intimidation going for him, the crowd parts like the sea to let him through.

Phainon turns around and catches Mydei’s gaze, and his eyes feel like a pair of bright blue headlights that beam straight into his soul.

Those monster movies are obviously pure fiction, but just this time, he's inclined to believe that there's a skinwalker in Phainon's body.

"Who the fuck are you?" Mydei growls, grabbing 'Phainon' by the lapels of his uniform shirt. Even the way he wears his uniform has changed. Gone were the frumpy sweaters and wrinkled shirts that look like he never bothered to iron. This Phainon looked like he stepped out of some uppity fashion magazine. His shirt neatly pressed with the top two buttons undone, the navy blazer accentuating his broad shoulders and the no longer hidden strength of his physique.

All Mydei can do is glare.

He looks exactly like Phainon.

Yet he looks nothing like Phainon.

The difference is unsettling.

"Mydei? What… what are you doing?" Phainon blinks at him like a deer caught in headlights. He genuinely doesn't seem to understand why Mydei is pissed off.

Mydei doesn't understand it himself either. Phainon hasn't done anything wrong, for all intents and purposes Mydei was the one who stormed up here and started causing a scene. But he can't quell the uneasiness he feels at seeing how different Phainon is. Why the sudden change? And why didn't he feel like he could talk to Mydei about it?

He doesn't understand a damn thing.

And although time feels like it's frozen for Mydei, it hasn't really. Somewhere, a girl screams, some of the students are shouting about getting a teacher and running off. Phones are pointed in his direction, cameras are flashing. Another student is shouting for them to stop recording.

"Mydei, I can explain." Phainon doesn't get to talk to him like *he*'s the unreasonable one. But he's sensible enough to know that everyone's staring

at him. Knows that the teachers are on their way. He really doesn't need another black mark on his disciplinary record, not this early in the school year.

With a heavy sigh, he releases the imposter and takes a step back.

The whispers are all around him.

"Are they really going to start fighting here?"

"I told you Mydei was bullying him!"

"Why doesn't Phainon stand up for himself? The whole school would take his side."

It doesn't bother him. The words of people who mean nothing to him do not matter. What *does* bother Mydei is-

The way Phainon stands in front of him like he is someone who needs protection. Holding his hands out to appease the crowd like Mydei is the violent, dangerous one and he needs to apologize on his behalf.

"Wait, guys. It's okay, Mydei's not-"

"Do not presume to speak for me." Mydei snaps, which doesn't help his case at all.

Phainon remains calm, infuriatingly so. Holding out a hand towards Mydei like he's some wild animal that needs to be placated. "I'll explain everything later, okay?"

His soothing tone of voice is familiar. Despite the changes he looks like Phainon, sounds like the Phainon he knows. But Mydei can feel it deep down, something has changed, something is different.

The emptiness in his chest only grows.

Mydei forces himself to turn and walk away without another word, furiously blinking away the tears that burn around the corner of his eyes.

This is a stupid thing to get upset about.

Mydei can’t make heads or tails of what happened, but it makes him feel even more isolated, left out in the cold. Throughout class he’s distracted, not listening to the lecture, writing stupid shit in his notebook that doesn’t even make sense if he stares at it for more than 5 seconds. Phainon keeps sneaking glances at him from the other side of the classroom, but Mydei, out of pettiness, ignores him. Every now and again, his phone buzzes with texts from his desperate boyfriend.

Is he Mydei’s boyfriend still?

It feels like he doesn’t know him. Did he ever?

Why did he feel the need to make such a drastic change and why did Mydei seem like the last person to find out.

He doesn’t know anything.

Once Mydei had a chance to cool down and get over his shock, his reaction did seem a little over the top. He convinces himself there must be a good reason Phainon is acting this way, even if he doesn’t understand it yet. A face to face conversation would do well to clear these misunderstandings up and get them back on track again.

Mydei misses him, had missed him the whole summer. He didn’t expect to come back to this

Unfortunately, despite his promises to explain everything later, ‘later’ became far too vague for Mydei’s liking. Phainon was suddenly popular, he was swarmed by fellow students like they were bees and he was the most fragrant flower in the garden. Whenever Mydei thought he saw his chance, someone else had already hooked their arm through his and was pulling him along to whatever they had planned that day.

And what was utterly baffling was that Phainon just went along with it.

He didn’t protest or fight back, he smiled, nodded politely and played the part.

The first time it happened Mydei just stood there, staring in bewilderment, because the Phainon he knew was so fiercely independent that he was even opposed to joining a sports team because he would rather be spending his free time doing something else.

It was a quality that Mydei admired about him.

Now he shares his time so freely and sincerely with everybody else.

But once Mydei had made up his mind that he was going to be understanding, going to give Phainon a chance to explain himself, then he was going to stick with it no matter how much his instincts raged at him to put his walls back up.

“Mydei!” After what had seemed like a long, drawn-out battle, he finally cornered Phainon alone on the emergency stairs of the school, the place they used to claim as theirs. Phainon turns around as he approaches and gives him a blinding grin, the kind that he thought used to be reserved for him alone, but now seems to be given freely to everyone.

“I’m sorry-” Were the first words out of his mouth.

Mydei drops his bag, sighing deeply.

“I don’t want to hear your apologies.” He interrupts. Phainon immediately shuts his mouth, eyebrows furrowing in concern. “I’ll decide what to do once I hear you out, so talk.”

Phainon still has that kicked puppy look on his face, he looks pathetic.

“It all started when Caenis called me into her office before summer break. I think… that was the first time I realized how hard things were for you in this school.”

Mydei’s frown deepens. “I never thought that things were difficult for me. Stop making assumptions.” It was simply the hand he was dealt, and he did

what he could with it. Mydei even thought he was fairly lucky, all things considered.

“Well, I hated it. I hated how you were treated, and I hated how I couldn’t do anything for you.”

“I never asked you to-”

“Mydei, please.” Phainon pleads, and Mydei’s jaw clamps shut as he grimly nods to him to continue.

“I thought, if I was more popular, more well-liked, someone with authority, I could change things, I could protect you.”

Mydei’s face twitches because he’s dying to say something. It’s offensive that Phainon thinks he’s a damsel in distress who needs protection, it’s hurtful that Phainon went ahead with his own plans before even consulting Mydei on what he thinks of the situation. It’s ironic that Phainon’s attempts to help him have made him more lonely and isolated in return.

“That’s why I’m running for student council president… I wanted to tell you that.” Phainon punctuates it with a shaky laugh. “It’s the only way to make any lasting changes around here. And that’s why I’m acting like this… can’t make an omelette without breaking a few eggs, right?”

Mydei’s jaw shifts, his voice is low and guttural as he manages to whisper out. “Since when have you ever cared about stuff like that?”

“Since I started caring about you.” Phainon answers honestly.

Mydei is conflicted, because if Phainon’s intentions are pure, and he is truly doing this because he cares for Mydei, then why does it hurt him so much?

He should feel grateful that his boyfriend is going through such lengths, but instead he just feels… left behind.

But if this is something Phainon wants to do, however misguided it may seem, then Mydei would support him. He tells himself he can live with that, he’d always been a bit of a backstage assistant than someone who prefers to

be in the spotlight anyway. And he's not so shallow as to change the way he feels about Phainon because he looks a little different. Mydei likes to think that he's a better man than that.

So he really does try.

He plays the role of a supportive boyfriend with quiet diligence. He bakes cupcakes for Phainon's campaign, though the credit ultimately goes to some of the girls because he can't stand behind the booth to sell them, still aware of the bad image he holds among the student body. He continues bringing Phainon nutritious lunches, because the guy would forget to eat with how busy he is lately. And whenever he sees campaign posters peeling from the walls or displaced in some shape or form, he carefully presses them back into place—even though one time he got accused of vandalism. He tries not to let meaningless things like that bother him.

But the longer this goes on the harder it becomes to accept that this is something he has to be okay with.

Instead of feeling proud of how his boyfriend seems to shine so brightly, he just seems to feel a deep, profound emptiness inside.

Like this world Phainon is building isn't one meant for him.

"Listen, I know you haven't gotten the appreciation you deserve." Phainon says, holding him by the hands when they're alone, because of course, now he only touches Mydei when there's nobody around to see. "But it'll all get better once I become student council president. I'll make real changes, I promise."

Of course he will, Mydei hears that line in every one of his presidential campaign speeches while standing silently at the back.

It's becoming harder for Mydei to just overlook how different he is from the Phainon he knows. How he's become someone who has to speak so carefully because of the way he'd be perceived, who has to carry himself with dignity and poise at all times, who has to put on a mask to meet everyone else's expectations, balanced on his shoulders.

It can’t be easy for him, and that’s why it hurts Mydei even more. Because Phainon seems willing to bear everyone else’s dreams except Mydei’s extremely simple ones.

The hopes that they’ll remain exactly as they are.

“Phainon,” Mydei asks, a last ditch effort to get him to abandon this folly. “If I said I didn’t want things to change. Would you listen?”

Phainon hesitates. “But—I’m really close to achieving my goal.” he says, voice quietly confident. “If I stop now, then we’ll get nowhere at all. I need to protect you, remember?”

Mydei’s jaw tightens, he has a feeling that they’ve been getting nowhere for some time now. Phainon’s stubbornness, something he had once admired, was now being used against him.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t realize dating me has been such a burden to you.” He lets bitterness get the best of him, speaking between gritted teeth. He’s been enduring it silently for some time now, but even his patience had its limits.

“What?” Phainon blurts out, surprised by his sudden venom. Sometimes it feels like they’re walking on parallel tracks, close enough to see each other, but never to intersect. “That’s not what I meant. Let’s think of it this way, uhm, if I could shield you like a tree-”

Mydei’s glare sharpens. “Stop talking in metaphors and speak plainly. Why do you keep asking as though I’m someone that needs to be shielded?”

“I thought you would understand.” Phainon dodges the question, frustration slipping into his tone.

“I would understand,” Mydei starts, his temper flaring up for real this time. “If you bothered speaking to me like your boyfriend instead of reciting poetry when I ask you a simple question.”

Phainon’s jaw clamps shut, a clouded expression in his eyes. Mydei wonders if he’s going to back off or fight back, gods, he hopes Phainon

fights back. He wants to argue, wants to throw fists, wants to see that fire in his eyes again to know that he is not lost yet.

But instead, at the worst timing, Phainon's phone rings.

Phainon only needs to take one look at the screen before his expression scrunches into that stupid apologetic one that Mydei is starting to really hate.

"I'm so sorry Mydei, I have to go."

"You have to go?" He repeats mockingly. "I waited weeks to talk to you and you can't spare half an hour?"

Phainon just sighs, his entire shoulders shifting downwards as though Mydei just doesn't *understand*. "It's a student council election strategy meeting. Some of the debate club members have agreed to help me with my campaign, and they can only meet now."

Mydei feels something in him die. The fire is extinguished in just a snap.

"Right, can't have anything risking the campaign."

Phainon knows he's being sarcastic, if his sheepish expression is any indication.

Mydei just storms away, having nothing else to say. He feels a headache coming on. He hated when people did that, speaking in riddles, in ways that made it harder to grasp their true intentions. He always thought that Phainon wouldn't do that to him.

He thought he was the person who understood Phainon better than anyone, and vice versa.

Seems like they didn't understand each other at all.

Phainon wins the student council election by a landslide, of course he does, because Mydei knows he can do anything he sets his mind to. "The

committee members are throwing me a celebration party! You should come! I'll introduce you to everyone." Phainon says with sparkles in his eyes.

"I'll think about it," Mydei says, knowing he has no intention of showing up.

He spends that weekend moping at home instead, feeling like he's losing all the parts of Phainon that he loved, like sand slipping through his fingers.

The worst part about it is that Phainon has never looked happier. Laughing, smiling, chatting to other people, sharing his warmth and kindness with other people who are not Mydei. The fact that Mydei is still latching on to him for happiness must be a burden.

It's him that needs Phainon too much.

Phainon is like the sun, but the sun didn't only belong to one person. The sun shines for everyone. And the sooner Mydei accepted that, the better.

He makes up his mind and texts Phainon.

Mydei:
Can we meet up tonight? I know it's out of the blue.
There's something important I want to talk about.

Phainon:
Haha, did you have to say it so ominously?
I'm gonna think you're trying to break up with me or something

Mydei:
…
Don't overthink it.
I think it's better for us to talk in person.

Maybe Phainon does realize what's coming next, because he tries his hardest to deter Mydei from what he actually wants to say when they meet.

"We missed you at the celebration party, I missed you." Phainon immediately makes a grab for his hand as soon as he shows up. Mydei

angles his hand just slightly so he misses, but Phainon notices, of course he does, and hurt flits across his face for just a second before he plasters on a bright smile.

“I’m really sorry I couldn’t make it for a date last weekend.” He apologizes. “There was a student council bowling event and I needed to be there.”

“It’s fine.” Mydei says a little numbly, he’s lost count of how many times Phainon has been too busy for him.

“But look, now that the election is over I have some free time. Why don’t we go on a date tomorrow, just you and me? I’ll treat you to that dessert place you like.” Phainon’s actually trying so hard that it makes Mydei feel a little guilty, but he’s made up his mind already, and nothing will change it.

Mydei just huffs. “It’s okay, save your money.”

“What good is having money if I can’t treat my boyfriend to something nice?”

And if Phainon is too cowardly to approach the inevitable, then Mydei will do so for him.

“I think this relationship is not going to work out,” Mydei says plainly. “I want to break up.”

“What?” Phainon is still smiling, but it’s trembling at the edges, brittle. He looks like he wants to break at any moment, yet, that stupid smile stays on. Mydei wishes he’d show any kind of emotion at all, to cry, to beg, even get mad and punch him, call him an asshole.

Just… *something*.

Anything rather than the plastic mask he’s been wearing ever since he decided that he wanted to be a hero. The same mask he shows everyone else.

“Let’s not jump to something so drastic, can we talk about this?”

“I don’t think there’s anything to talk about.” Mydei can be stubbornly final once he’s made up his mind, and he’s had a lot of time to think. “You can go on and be the school’s hero, and I won’t get in your way or hold you back.”

That’s when his face falls. Phainon’s upper lip is quivering, and for a moment he looks so…so scared that Mydei almost takes his words back right here, right there.

But he remains resolute.

“There’s no point in being a hero if you’re not there with me.” Phainon says so softly that he has to strain his ears to listen. “Why…” Phainon starts, and then shakes his head. He obviously knew why, and didn’t care to hear it again. “What can I do to win you back?”

Mydei just sighs, what’s the point of trying to take back something that had already happened? “You didn’t do anything wrong. I just don’t think we’re compatible as we are now….” Then, because Phainon isn’t the only one who’s been hurt, he adds in a low tone.

“Why did you have to change?”

Phainon’s jaw tightens, he’d obviously hit a sore spot. His eyes darken and Mydei wonders if he finally got the reaction he was searching for.

“I see now,” Phainon mutters, low, dangerous. “Everyone’s adoration is conditional as long as I fit the image they wanted. I didn’t realize that you were the same.”

“I…” Mydei stops, growls a little from frustration. “You’re twisting my words-”

“No.” Phainon snaps. “Have you ever considered that maybe I like the way I am now? That it’s called *self-improvement* for a reason. And besides, I did it for you.”

“You keep saying that.” Mydei’s voice rises as he grows frustrated, his restraint breaking. “But you never asked once about how I feel. So if you’re

doing it for your own self-satisfaction, at least be honest about that."

Phainon doesn't speak, he looks like Mydei had just slapped him in the face.

There is nothing but silence between them now. They are both standing next to each other, yet the distance seems impossibly far.

"Let's just call this a mutual breakup, then." Phainon says bitterly. He stares up at Mydei, jaw clenches, face set, as though challenging him to deny it.

"Okay." Mydei is tired, he doesn't want to fight anymore. "I'm moving back to Castrum Kremnos, next week."

"What?" Phaionn raises his head again, his voice cracking. "You're leaving Okhema?"

Mydei shrugs. "Yes." He hadn't gotten a chance to tell Phainon about it, but the negotiations over the summer didn't go well. Mydei had initially planned to stay in Okhema while his parents sorted things out back home, but since his relationship is in shambles anyway, he might as well tag along. He'd be heartbroken either way, but he'd rather have family support than not.

Phainon just laughs, broken chuckles making his shoulders rack up and down. The lines are blurred to the point where Mydei doesn't know whether he's laughing or crying. "So you already decided everything from the start. You… you selfish bastard."

Mydei won't admit that he's secretly relieved. If Phainon had gotten on his knees crying, begging, pleading him not to go, Mydei might have broken his composure. Despite everything, he still loves Phainon. But anger? He can deal with anger.

"So you can understand how I feel after all." Is all he says, the final nail in the coffin.

He leaves Phainon there, alone, broken, and doesn’t look back. He doesn’t want to see the look on Phainon’s face if he does turn around.

Mydei’s final week at Okhema drags on, it’s horrible trying to avoid Phainon when they study in the same classroom, and he’s sure it’s the same for the white-haired boy. For the most part, Phainon seems unaffected, wearing his plastic smile like an absolute pro. Or maybe he just hides it better. Mydei has noticed him staring once or twice, when he thinks Mydei isn’t looking.

While clearing out his locker for the last time, Mydei finds the sun shaped pin he originally wanted to give Phainon after the summer break. Things have spiraled so quickly that he had forgotten all about it. Well, it’s not like he wants to keep it, but he can’t just give it to Phainon after they broke up.

Mydei should throw it away.

And yet he thinks about all the time he spent painstakingly picking out which shapes would best suit Phainon, which metals he should use, how to bend the rays just as he wanted them. It had taken so much effort… what a waste.

With a sigh, he tosses it back into his old locker, leaving it there. Maybe the janitor can throw it away, or another student will end up finding it and pawning it or something. Whatever, he just doesn’t care anymore.

Phainon is no longer his to care about, anyway.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for the warm reaction to chapter 1, really really appreciate everyone taking the time to read my fic, it means a lot!
> my twitter
>
> Were you surprised that the breakup ended up being like this? I wanted to write a situation where they were both wrong in some way and was left very unresolved. Plus you know... the dramaaaa I just love it.

Up next: A time skip and the start of a LOT of yearning (like really there's so much you guys are gonna be sick of me)

Chapter 3: Did You Have to Let It Linger?

Chapter Summary

> “He dyed his hair back to white,” Mydei points out, the alcohol loosening his usual inhibition, in addition to being with trusted friends. Phainon’s hair sits longer, fluffier on the top, messy bangs framing his face. Way better than the sharp and angular blond cut he was sporting in his previous fashion spread.
>
> Mydei hated the blond on him, it made him look so cold and so… so… foreign. “He looks better in white.”
>
> “Oh no, we’re not doing this today. Not on the day we get signed.” Cipher says, downing her entire drink in one gulp and motioning to the waiter for a refill. “Let’s talk about literally anything else. WORK! I wanna hear about all those documents for Ms Topaz.”

Chapter Notes

> These are my confessions: I love songfic I know a lot of people think it's cringe but I LOVE IT!
>
> I hope you're all ready for yearnatron and homotron 3000...
> There are some POV swaps in this chapter, the reason is because when I get stuck I swap to Phainon's POV and let him wax poetic about Mydei for thousands of words.
>
> As usual here is my twitter

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The ink on their brand new recording contract was barely dry when Cipher insisted they *had* to celebrate at the fanciest, most expensive bar in town.

When Mydei pointed out their advanced payment wouldn’t come in until the next payday, she simply winked at him and said.

“And that’s why all the expenses for tonight’s celebration will be covered by our resident rich boy, isn’t that right, little prince?”

And Mydei sighs and gives in because why the fuck not?

It feels surreal. All the time they spent trying to build their brand by playing in dingy underground bars, in student lounges where half the crowd was there for the free pizza, in back-alley clubs where the entire audience were drunk out of their minds, recording themselves with a shitty phone camera and posting it online in hopes that they’d hit it big. And finally, it all paid off.

They made it.

Him, Castorice, Cipher, and their band *Titans of Calamity* had been signed by a recording studio.

Not just any recording studio, by the IPC. One of the biggest, most prestigious companies in the music industry.

“A toast, to selling our souls to capitalism!” Cipher declares, lifting her cocktail into the air and tapping the glass with manicured fingernails. She had, naturally, ordered the most expensive, extravagant, luxurious drink on the menu. Aptly named *Fairy Tears*, it was a layered violet monstrosity of artisanal syrups and top-shelf liquor, decorated with edible gold foil and looked like someone had dunked an entire bowl of glitter into it.

“Look at this! See how the foil is cut into the shape of tiny flowers?” She tilts the glass to show Castorice, liquid sloshing around messily inside, “Now THIS is what I call fancy!”

Castorice hiccups loudly, already half drunk from the sweet drink in her hand that probably contained enough alcohol to down a dragon. “I’m just… I still feel like I’m going to wake up in my tiny dorm room at college, and think that this is all a dream…”

“Well then get ready to pinch yourself, Princess Homebody. Because this is real, and we worked hard for this, and we’re officially rockstars now!”

Cipher raises her glass to her lips, downing her drink in one fell swoop. “Another drink!”

“Slow down,” Mydei grumbles. “You’re going to break my wallet.”

“Hey! After those all nighters we spent in the garage writing lyrics and practicing until our ears bled and I got sores on my fingers, we deserve this!” Cipher insists. “Just ask for a top up from mommy and daddy when you run out.”

“Hmph.” Mydei says. He knows his parents have his back, but ever since he opted out of being a part of the family business, he doesn’t want to ask them for money unless there is no other choice. That’s why he finds himself living a humble life these days, a tiny apartment that he shares with Cipher and Castorice, working part-time jobs to make ends meet while trying to get their music careers to take off.

And to be honest, Mydei had never felt so free. For the first time in his life, he was comfortable in his own skin.

“Fine, whatever. Cheers to us.” Mydei raises his own glass in the air, a sickly sweet pink concoction containing pomegranate juice and some alcohol that wasn’t too bitter. “To *Titans of Calamity*. We made it.”

“That’s what I’m talking about! Let’s go crazy!” Cipher declares loudly, causing heads to turn in their direction.

They stood out in this otherwise classy bar, and it was hard not to feel out of place. Just three misfits in a rock band trying too hard to be fancy. Their styles clashed with each other dramatically—nobody could ever agree on anything in the group chat—but at least each person committed to the bit.

Castorice, the bassist, showed up in a dress that looked like it was made by her fairy godmother. It was pink and wispy with chiffon sleeves and tiny gemstones embroidered on the skirt. Passionate at handicrafts, she had thrifted the dress and sewn the gemstones individually by hand. It complemented her long lavender hair, which was tied into a single elaborate braid flowing down her back.

Cipher, their drummer, refused to take off the cat ear hoodie that Mydei swears she's been wearing for as long as he knew her. But at least she made some effort to dress up with her sleek black leather skirt and thigh high boots. Chunky earrings and mismatched bracelets completed the look, and around her throat sat a choker far too elegant and expensive looking for someone who claimed she was always broke. Cipher had insisted it was a gift, and Mydei was frankly too afraid to ask for further details.

As for Mydei himself, his fashion sense had matured from when he was younger. He still favoured dark colors and leather and studs and punk styled clothes, but tonight he wore a fitted black button-up, gold embroidery tracing the sides of his collar and curling down the front. His sleeves were rolled up to the elbows, revealing his muscular forearms and the swirling red tattoos wrapped around them. The moment he turned 18, he wasted no time in getting all the body ink his heart desired, and never looked back. The look was complete with straight black slacks, shiny boots, and his shoulder length hair tied in a ponytail behind his neck. He knew when to be classy when the time called for it.

As the initial clamour dwindles to a peaceful buzz—with Cipher and Castorice deep in conversation about how they'll spend their future rockstar money—Mydei tries to relax in his seat. This luxurious atmosphere, the velvet chairs, the soft jazz band performing in the corner, loud enough to drown out the background noise, not loud enough to disrupt conversations, is unusual to him.

Maybe one day, this will be the kind of place they're used to frequenting.

He huffs to himself, shakes his head. Nah, no matter how wealthy he gets, this kind of scene isn't for him.

Instead, Mydei tries to picture how their lives will change after this recording deal. No more part time jobs wedged in between classes, no more nights spent in rental practice rooms. Music would no longer be something they had to cram in with their other commitments, it'll be their lives, their full time jobs.

Instead of dingy nightclubs where the mics didn't even work sometimes, they'll be playing at small music festivals with an actual stage. Perhaps even with their own stage crews and sound techs. They wouldn't have to rig their own lights and sound systems anymore.

And maybe even some day… their band name on billboards, sold out rock stadium arenas with legions of fans screaming along to their songs.

Well, maybe not now, they still had a long way to go. But a guy could dream, couldn't he?

Castorice appeared hypnotized, taking pictures from several different angles of the sparkling cocktail that was her newest drink.

"This is just meh," Cipher sighs, on her second drink now. "I gotta say, I still prefer the cheap apple cider over at Dolos."

"You know that's just apple juice and beer, don't you?" Mydei huffs. Meanwhile, the fruity pomegranate cocktail he's holding in his hand is quite perfect. Sweet with only the barest hint of alcohol, just the way he likes it.

Cipher shrugs. "If it works, it works."

"Pft…" Mydei finds himself smiling, even though he grumbles, he's having a good time. He had been worried at first, moving away from his hometown Castrum Kremnos to return to Okhema, a place that held… not so good memories for him, to pursue his dream of becoming a musician. But it worked out. He's got a cat he adores, a few close friends who mean the world to him, and a record label contract.

Things are looking good.

"By the way, Cipher, about the documents we need to email Miss Topaz…" He says, suddenly remembering.

"Oh come on!" Cipher groans loudly, running a hand down her face. "Must we talk about work stuff now?"

"I just thought to mention before I forget…"

“Mydei, I’m drunk, I’ll definitely forget anything you say tonight anyway.” Cipher says, which isn’t true. She unfortunately, is a heavyweight with the memory of an elephant, but only conveniently remembers things that would benefit her.

Mydei sighs. “Fine, fine. I guess that shit can wait until tomorrow.”

He settles down, feeling the numbing buzz of alcohol in his head even though he’s only had that one cocktail. Despite his appearance, Mydei is a little bit of a lightweight, a vulnerability he’d rather not divulge unless it’s to his closest friends.

Mydei is content like this, listening to his friends joke over how many private jets they’ll own once they’re famous, Cipher’s sharp cackles and Castorice’s light giggles. He hears the door to the entrance open, and lifts his eyes almost lazily, not necessarily interested in whoever comes through.

Until he catches sight of a head of fluffy snowy white hair, laughing and talking to his companions. The person is tall, and his demeanor and appearance naturally draws attention, so he stands out among his friends.

Mydei hadn’t expected to see him here tonight.

Phainon.

His breath hitches as he temporarily forgets how to breathe, it feels like he’s been punched in the gut, seeing him.

He averts his eyes when Phainon looks his way, not at all mentally or emotionally prepared to deal with that piercing blue gaze right now. How many years has it been since they broke up? Four? Five?? Their lives are so different now, it would be a wonder if he even remembered Mydei.

“Little lion?” Cipher asks, noticing his weird behaviour. Her voice startles him, causing him to uncharacteristically jolt.

“Mydei, is something wrong? You look pale.” Castorice, bless her soul, has her eyebrows knitted in worry over him.

“I…” Mydei starts, at a loss for words. He better double check to make sure that it’s really Phainon before he drops that bombshell on his friends. He twists his head around to look at the newcomers, now settling by the bar counter.

It’s no use, he’s only buying time for himself. He’d known that face anywhere, those eyes, that smile. A thousand years could pass and he’d still recognize him from his stupid ahoge alone. He’d burned the memory of Phainon into his soul, and couldn’t wipe it off even if he tried.

And he *has* tried.

“No, no.” Cipher is saying as she follows his gaze, dread in her tone. “Please don’t tell me that guy’s your type.”

He dyed his hair back to white. Mydei finds himself thinking, as Phainon throws his head back, laughing, and his bangs fall into his eyes.

“Worse.” He says glumly. “That’s my ex boyfriend.”

Cipher’s reaction is just a tad over the top. She chokes on her drink, spluttering unflatteringly as she stares at Mydei like he’s grown a second head. “And when were you going to tell me, your dearest friend Cifera…” She starts slowly.

“...that your ex is Phainon *fucking* Khaslana?”

Mydei blinks at her, utterly lost. “You know him?”

“Who’s that?” Castorice chimes in, a more normal reaction from a reasonable human being. “Is he famous?”

Cipher raises a hand to her temples. “I suppose it falls to me to explain things to Princess Homebody again. Phainon’s a model, yeah he’s really famous, he’s got like—-what, several hundred thousand followers on Stellargram?”

“Oh, I see. Sorry for not knowing these things…” Castorice mumbles into her drink, blushing slightly from embarrassment.

“Don’t worry about it, It’s a compliment, babygirl.” Cipher reassures her, placing an arm around her shoulder, making Castorice giggle. “One of us has to be the normal one in the room because it’s definitely not Mydei right now.”

“Oh okay, yay.”

Meanwhile Mydei twirls his drink in his glass, he has been doing nothing but staring at Phainon for the past maybe two or three minutes now. He knows he’s coming across a little weird, maybe even creepy. But the bar is dark, and Phainon hasn’t looked his way at all, so he probably didn’t even notice him.

The thought stings a little bit.

“I thought he was supposed to walk Edo Star fashion week… What's he doing here?” He murmurs.

“How do you know what his schedule is supposed to be?” Unfortunately, Cipher caught on to his ramblings, she looks a little alarmed as she asks. “Why are you keeping tabs on your ex?”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “Like you said, he’s really popular. His posts show up on my feed occasionally, I have no say in the matter.”

He hopes his unbothered act is enough to get her to back off, because this is the first and last lie he will ever tell Cipher. He did have some say in the matter. He could have easily blocked any and all mention of Phainon and moved on with his life. That is what he should have done. It was the easier, more logical, mature, healthier thing to do.

What he *shouldn’t* have done is make a new Stellagram account under his cat’s name for the explicit purpose of following Phainon’s pages and fansites. An account where he shamelessly bookmarks all of his ex’s sexy photo shoots and gets into arguments defending his honour on the internet.

Yes, they were broken up, and to say that Mydei had not moved on would be the understatement of the century.

And of course, he remembers that he's the one who broke it off in the first place. He genuinely believed they would not have worked out at the time, and he still believes that.

Because look at how bright Phainon shines without Mydei holding him back. As he thought, he didn't need Mydei, not at all.

"He dyed his hair back to white," Mydei points out, the alcohol loosening his usual inhibition, in addition to being with trusted friends. Phainon's hair sits longer, fluffier on the top, messy bangs framing his face. Way better than the sharp and angular blond cut he was sporting in his previous fashion spread.

Mydei hated the blond on him, it made him look so cold and so… so… foreign. "He looks better in white."

"Oh no, we're not doing this today. Not on the day we get signed." Cipher says, downing her entire drink in one gulp and motioning to the waiter for a refill. "Let's talk about literally anything else. WORK! I wanna hear about all those documents for Ms Topaz."

Unfortunately, she's lost Mydei. The look he's giving Phainon may come across as brooding, or even intense to most people, but she knows him. There is a lovestruck foolishness in his expression that she has never seen from him before and it makes her sick.

Because, as far as Cipher and Castorice are concerned, Mydei has only ever been in one relationship in his life, and the experience had soured him on romance so badly that he's refused to date ever since.

It's not like he's hung up or delusional, in fact, Mydei is the most rational he's ever been. If there is nobody that can stir his heart like Phainon could, or make him feel the way he did in the early days of that relationship, then there was no point in trying to date at all. Mydei doesn't like wasting his time.

The problem is… there may never be another person like him.

Castorice puts her hand on his shoulder gently, anchoring him back to reality. “Please, Mydei, come back to us.” She pleads, like a siren beckoning a sailor from the brink of death.

“You need to let him go,” Cipher says, not hiding the distasteful glance she shoots Phainon and his friends. “He broke your heart.”

“I broke his heart too.”

Cipher throws her hands up in the air. “It’s not a competition!”

“He seems… nice.” Castorice observes. “But he also seems like he lives in the spotlight and is surrounded by people. You’d hate that kind of life.”

Mydei shuffles in his seat. Of course, authenticity is something almost sacred to him. One of the reasons they had taken so long to get signed was because Mydei was picky about the contract. He’d been adamant on total creative and marketing freedom, non-negotiable. They would write their own songs and perform as themselves without any manufactured personas or else he wouldn’t sign. Luckily, Topaz had agreed with his views.

And he knows his friends are trying to be kind, but it only stings when he’s reminded of how outclassed by his ex he is. They used to be equals, two nobodies who were each other’s first love. But those days were long gone.

These days, Phainon is on the cover of glossy magazine spreads, billboard ads, and has his arm draped around a new beautiful person every other day, if the pictures on his fansites are anything to go by. Forget about the same country, they probably don’t even live in the same universe.

His chest tightens again, a familiar ache. It no longer hurts, just a steady, unwanted presence he’s got used to carrying around. Like a phantom limb that’s long gone, but the pain still lingers from time to time.

But fine, since they asked so nicely for him to stop looking at Phainon, he will. Mydei shifts his gaze to Phainon’s friends instead. He’ll confess that he doesn’t really care about public figures outside of Phainon, so he doesn’t know if they’re famous or not.

A pretty girl with long pink hair, fading to a soft cyan at the tips, laughs and smiles beside Phainon. They seem really close, could that be his current girlfriend? Nearby, a mismatched trio—a grey-haired man in a black jacket, a black-haired man in xianzhou styled clothing, and a cheerful girl with a pink bob—look slightly out of place, awkward even. Maybe they're Phainon's college friends, regular people who wouldn't normally step into a place as fancy as this.

Mydei vaguely remembers seeing faces like theirs when Phainon used to post on his old social media account, the one that's now locked and abandoned when he blew up and couldn't have his personal pictures leaking to the public. Actually, Mydei was surprised Phainon never bothered to block him, considering that was way after they broke up.

Maybe he just meant that little to him. Hardly worth the consideration.

Oh well, Mydei isn't actually interested in any of his friends, Phainon has so many that it's hard to keep track anyway. His eyes stray back to the man in question, cataloguing his latest fit. He must admit, tonight's look might be one of his favourites so far.

The long navy blue coat draped perfectly over his broad shoulders, Mydei had always thought that blue was his colour. Beneath it, the black turtleneck clung tightly to the muscles of his chest and abs. Mydei had always admired his body, even when it was hidden under baggy sweaters and oversized hoodies. His already admirable physique was even more impressive now that he hit adulthood, successful enough to afford a robust exercise and nutrition plan.

But the real reason Mydei keeps staring isn't just because of how good Phainon looks, well, he's always looked good, that was literally his job description. No, it's the black rimmed glasses that he's wearing tonight.

Phainon doesn't usually wear accessories in his shoots. Things like necklaces, earrings, belts, or hats were kept to a minimum. His stylists tended to go for the boy-next-door look, and excessive accessorizing would just draw attention away from his natural beauty. For example, it would be a shame to cover up his stunning blue eyes with glasses. But Mydei always

liked the way he looked with them, how they softened his face, made him look younger and more innocent.

It makes him feel nostalgic for the Phainon of the past. The boy that wore oversized sweaters and played video games with him under the emergency stairs, the one who beat him in a wrestling match so badly that it made Mydei fall for him in more ways than one. The boy who was Mydei's first love, and the one that he's probably still in love with, even though he won't admit it.

As he's watching, Phainon's head turns in his direction mid conversation and they lock eyes. Mydei quickly looks away, face burning. He caught him mid-stare, it's going to be very hard to pretend that he hadn't been looking at Phainon. He can't bear to hold that gaze, though, he doesn't want to see the impassive non-recognition that would confirm that Phainon had moved on. That would truly be the nail in his coffin.

He does not notice the curl of Phainon's lips as he stares, unblinking, at Mydei who is now desperately trying to rejoin the conversation with his friends. He does not notice how his eyes darken with something that is almost obsessive as he rakes his gaze all over Mydei's body.

But Cipher does, she notices immediately, and glares at Phainon as though to say '*you don't have the right to look at him'*.

"If you're uncomfortable, we can leave." Castorice, the angel that she is, offers kindly. "I checked on maps, and I found another cocktail bar just down the street. It seems really nice too."

Mydei just huffs. "There is no word for 'running away' in the Kremnoan dictionary." He tells her. The last time he spoke to Phainon, he was the one who ran away. There will be no fleeing a second time. "I'm fine. It's just… seeing him takes me back."

Castorice sighs, laying her head on his shoulder. "I understand, you're a romantic, just like me." Mydei doesn't really agree with that, he doesn't think they're the same kind of romantic, but why the hell not. "It's very hard to get over one's first love. At least, that was the case in all the

romance novels I've read. And Phainon is very handsome—not that I'm trying to flirt with your ex, and not that I'm saying you can't move on. I know you could do so much better… nevermind, I think I'll just shut up now." She ends her rambling with a quiet hiccup.

Mydei smiles despite himself. "Thanks Cas, I know what you're trying to say." He picks up his forgotten glass, tipping the pink bittersweet concoction into his mouth, feeling it roll down his throat and coat his insides like honey.

Life is too short to waste pining over his ex-boyfriend, so he does his best to focus on the conversation with his friends, trying to enjoy their quality time together. This involves making an active effort to ignore the model and his companions, seated on barstools not too far away. If he feels any prickling stares on the back of his neck, Mydei tells himself to ignore them. He's used to being gawked at, to being scrutinized. Though these days people look at him more out of awe and admiration than of disdain, to him it feels the same.

He tries.

He really tries to ignore him.

But when there's a lull in the conversation, Mydei can't stop himself from tilting his head back over the seat of his chair. He keeps his movements casual, like he's just stretching instead of sneaking a peek. The ends of his hair that are too short to tie into his ponytail tickle his jawline, his bangs partially covering his eyes. His arms are spread across the back of the chair, relaxed, swirling his almost empty cocktail as condensation drips down his fingers.

His golden eyes drift half-lidded, almost sleepy as they peer at Phainon with undisguised longing. After all, Phainon doesn't notice him, he can do whatever he wants, stare at him however long he likes.

He's just looking, after all. It's not a crime.

That pink haired woman next to him looks really familiar, could she be one of those models who always appear in his socials standing next to him? She's really beautiful, her smile is so sweet, her white dress is so pretty, and they look like a picture perfect couple from afar.

Mydei feels a little sick seeing them so close. It must be the alcohol getting to him.

He shouldn't drink anymore. Shouldn't look either.

Mydei proceeds to ignore his own advice.

Phainon and the pink haired woman lean closer together, she whispers something in his ear, and then places a hand over her mouth to stifle her laughter while Phainon smiles at her.

Mydei puts the glass to his lips again and finds that his drink is empty.

Phainon is so attractive in those stupid glasses.

He needs another drink.

Cipher's a few drinks in but she's not even close to being intoxicated, she may be small, but she can hold her liquor. Usually, when they go out, Mydei's always the responsible one between them. He's the designated driver, their personal bodyguard, the gentle giant that takes care of them when the night gets rowdy.

She'd never seen him lose his composure like this. The speed at which the pink liquid of his second, *second,* drink of the night disappears down his throat is alarming, given what a lightweight he is. The way his eyes are glazed over, drawn to Phainon Khaslana like a magnetic pull, is not normal.

Mydei is never sloppy, he is never obvious, and he always keeps his cool no matter what.

Therefore, she can’t help but feel frustrated at the turn of events. Why tonight? Why now? They were having such a good time, celebrating the biggest achievement of their lives. Tonight was supposed to be about them, about him, about how far they’ve gotten in life. Not about Mydei’s doomed first love.

He never talks about his ex much, but Cipher has seen his tragic love songs, scribbled in between the pages of his notebooks when he thinks nobody is looking. He’s not over that guy, not at all.

If Mydei is too stubborn to leave, should she take one for the team and politely ask them to go somewhere else? No, Mydei wouldn’t want that either, he hated stirring up drama.

“Ugh, bathroom break.” She declares, pushing her chair back and getting up.

Castorice and Mydei let her go in peace, knowing that in Cipher’s language, a ‘bathroom break’ was synonymous to smoke break. What can she say, sometimes her thoughts race a little too quickly, and she needs something to help her calm down.

She steps out into the narrow alleyway behind the bar, the cool night wind immediately sobering her up. Cipher reaches into her pocket for a pack and her lighter, sighing in relief as it clicks to life, and the smell of nicotine invades her lungs.

But of course, a girl can’t even have a smoke break in peace when she hears some people talking.

Voices drift from the other side of the wall, where the restroom window is open. And it’s not like Cipher is purposefully eavesdropping, but she presses her back closer to the wall regardless.

“It’s nice to hang out with Phainon again after so long, he’s always so busy! Luckily I was able to clear out my schedule at the last minute.”

“...Is it really so difficult given that you’re unemployed?” The male voice that replies to her is playful, obviously teasing.

“HEY!” The yell makes the walls reverberate. “I’m self employed, *self employed* you asshole!”

“Sure, sure. Whatever you say, March. I’m sure his offer of paying the bill didn’t hurt your decision.”

“Of course not, hehe, with all that model money, I’m sure it’s not too much trouble to foot the bill for his dear college friends. Especially after all we had to put up with when we were students.”

“Ugh…” The guy groans loudly. “Don’t remind me. I thought I was the troublemaker of the group.”

“You are.” March says. “Unless there’s a handsome, sexy, blond guy in the room to make Phainon lose his mind.”

Cipher freezes, cigarette halfway to her lips.

“It’s all fun and jokes for you.” A different male voice says, softer, calmer but undeniably bitter. “You two weren’t the ones stuck comforting him afterwards. ‘I couldn’t go through with it,’ ‘I’m just the worst, Dan Heng,’ ‘How could I do this to him, I’m lower than scum’ like I’m his personal therapist. We’re psychology students, but I didn’t expect to be applying our coursework so soon.”

“...You suffered a lot, Dan Heng. There there.” March says. “By the way, what does he mean by that? Can’t do what? Does he have erectile dysfunction or something, Caelus?”

Cipher nearly loses her shit at that, clapping a hand over her mouth to stifle her laughter. Whoever this March girl is, she likes her already.

“Nope,” Caelus says dryly. “I was his roommate for two years, I can testify that guy is packing.”

“Ok, ew, wish I never learned that. Anyway, let’s get back to the bar,” March says. “I think I saw him eyeing up that pretty blond guy with the red tattoos that was sitting close by. Let’s drink all we can before he decides to flake out on us again.”

“Oh god.” Dan Heng says, sounding appropriately devastated. “If he asks you for my whereabouts tomorrow, tell him I’ve passed away.”

Cipher drops her cigarette to the ground, stomping it out with her boot. As entertaining as that conversation was to listen to, it did nothing but set off the alarm bells in her head. She had thought there was something off about Phainon from the moment he walked in, and that was before she found out that he was Mydei’s ex.

And the way he was staring at Mydei all night when her friend turned away… like he wanted to eat him alive, that scoundrel was planning something. Cipher had hesitated to bring it up, seeing how obviously miserable Mydei was, but she couldn't hold her tongue any longer.

She returns to the bar to find that Mydei and Castorice are toasting, their glasses full to the brim with brightly coloured, shimmery drinks once again. She mentally keeps count that it’s Mydei’s third drink of the night. And in any other situation, she’d be over the moon. She’s glad her friends are finally letting loose and having fun, but she kind of needs Mydei to be sharp right now.

Especially when he’s still looking over Phainon’s way every few seconds like a heartbroken cat.

Cipher wedges herself in between her friends, plucking the glass out of Mydei’s hands. He needs to be sober to hear this, well… as sober as he can be, really.

“I need to tell you guys something. Mydei, it’s about your ex.”

Mydei frowns at her, blinking at the sudden change in topic. “Huh?” He says intelligently.

It’s not like her to be serious, Cipher hates being serious, but she thinks this is something he needs to know.

Huddled like this, they are able to hear each other clearly over the soft jazz music, but nobody else can. It’s like they’re in their own bubble, isolated from the rest of the world.

“Listen, your ex apparently has a bit of an obsession with tall, blond, tattooed gym rats." Coincidentally, people who looked like Mydei, but she doesn't say the quiet part out loud.

"But he’s uh… incapable of going all the way with a hookup.” Does she feel bad airing out all of Khaslana’s dirty laundry like this? Perhaps, but he deserved it, for making her friend look so sad.

She stops, carefully assessing Mydei for a reaction. Honestly, that guy baffles her sometimes. He seems so chill most of the time, but gets bothered by the strangest things.

So she should have seen this coming, since he’s incapable of being normal at anything to do with Phainon, but she’s still caught off guard when his face completely crumples with devastation.

“I see.” Mydei says, his voice trembling. “It is as I feared, he is sleeping around. He’s moved on.”

“Excuse me?” Cipher blinks, not able to believe her ears, perhaps Mydei has cotton stuck in his. She shakes him by the shoulder roughly as she says. “Are you even listening to me? Did you miss the part where I say he’s incapable of going through with them? His friend thinks he has erectile dysfunction.”

Mydei shakes his head, eyes glassy. “No, he doesn’t. That guy’s packing.”

That’s the second time tonight she’s had to hear that and it makes Cipher wish she wasn’t born with ears.

“But he’s still trying, and meanwhile I…” Mydei’s shoulders slump, then his face transforms into something carefully neutral, like he’s making an obvious effort to hide how much it’s affecting him. “He doesn’t even look at me.”

Cipher wants to flip the table over, she really does. Here she is, trying to be a good friend, and this freak, this absolute freak, is just upset because his ex isn’t leering at him enough while he’s drunk at a bar.

It comes to a point where one is so overwhelmed that they just loop around to not caring at all, and Cipher thinks she’s reaching it. She suddenly feels totally calm because you know what, maybe they deserve each other. Perhaps this is a trainwreck that doesn’t need her intervention.

If that’s the only takeaway he gets from her warning, then she gives up. In fact, she feels sorry for Mydei for how blind he is, but it’s like they say: Love makes you stupid.

“Nevermind. Let’s drink!” Cipher raises her glass into the air. If things were going to turn out a disaster anyway, she might as well be drunk when it happens.

“That’s right!” Mydei doesn’t down his whole glass, but he takes a rather heavy swig. When he next speaks, his eyes are manic, his gaze unfocused. “We got signed, didn’t we?”

Castorice blinks hazily, as though she couldn’t believe it herself. “That surprised me yet again. It really does feel like a dream…”

Cipher, unlike the other two, has no qualms about downing her drink. In fact, she can’t get drunk fast enough.

“We should play a song,” Mydei suggests out of nowhere.

Castorice and Cipher exchange a glance.

“Where?” Castorice asks.

Mydei points at the stage, where the jazz band is taking an intermission. “Right there.” He says, like it’s the most obvious thing in the world. “It’s nicer than any stage we’ve ever played on.”

Well, he’s right, but…

“With what instruments?” Cipher says incredulously.

Mydei raises his eyebrow like they’re idiots. He gestures to the stage again… and the obvious instruments that are on it.

“Ugh…” Cipher wrinkles her nose. Firstly, she hates playing on any drum kit that isn’t calibrated by herself. Secondly, she doesn’t work for free. “Nu-uh, you can’t make me do any work today.”

“She’s right, Mydei. We’re here to relax.” Castorice says, ever the voice of reason.

“Fine, then I’ll go up myself,” Mydei stands up, his stance a little wobbly. He’s never gotten wasted like this in front of them before, he’s usually a man with ironclad restraint. With amusement, Cipher realizes that this is what he’s like intoxicated. Impulsive, even more honest than he usually is, loud, and a *karaoke drunk*!

That is the last thing she expected.

“Wait! Mydei!” Castorice reaches out an arm to stop him. “You’re tipsy. Think about how embarrassed you’ll be about this tomorrow!”

Mydei just looks at her, brows furrowed, mouth pursed in what is almost a pout. “But I want to get up and sing.” He says, betraying his true upbringing of being a spoiled only child of rich parents.

Castorice lets go, weakened by his pouting face. “Oh. Okay.”

“Just let him go.” Cipher waves almost lazily. Mydei hadn’t even noticed Phainon staring at him with his jaw hanging open wide enough to catch flies. He couldn’t be more obvious about his thinly veiled desire even if he tried, and it’s crazy that Mydei hadn’t caught on, almost entertaining, really.

“I better record this for posterity, else he’ll call me a liar again.” She reaches into her purse and takes out her phone just as Mydei starts talking to one of the band members.

The jazz band were a little surprised when a random stranger asked to speak to them in between sets, even more surprised when he asked if he could have a turn on the stage. But they were more than happy to let him have a go, and even generously lent him a band member’s electric guitar.

And when he strides to the front of the stage, grabbing the mic like it’s his god-given right, the chattering voices audibly hush as people look at him. It can’t be helped, he just draws attention naturally. Maybe because of his physique, his confidence, his demeanor, how effortlessly beautiful he looks even though he’s pissed drunk, maybe all of the above.

“This song is dedicated to… fuck you.” Mydei slurs into the mic, obviously not in his full sober mind.

Some of the audience members gasp, not knowing what to make of the situation.

“Oh man,” Cipher says with sympathy. He’s going to regret this tomorrow, he really will and he can’t say she didn’t warn him.

And then Mydei closes his eyes, taking a deep breath to steady himself. When he reopens them there is no trace of drunkenness in his gaze, only obvious longing. He shifts his thumb over the neck of the guitar and starts to strum cleanly, fingers sliding along the frets smooth as butter. And then he starts singing, tone clear, voice steady, like he hadn’t touched a single drop of alcohol.

The kind of professionalism expected of a rockstar.

“That’s… a new one,” Cipher murmurs. She hadn’t heard him sing this song before, but he played it like he had it memorized by heart. .

If you, if you could return.
Don’t let it burn, don’t let it fade.

I’m sure I might be rude, but it’s just your attitude,
That is tearing me apart, and it’s ruining everything

Mydei lifts his eyes to the bar counter to find that Phainon is finally, *finally*, looking at him. He’s staring at Mydei so intensely like he might physically disintegrate if he takes his eyes off him for just a second. His friend is gesticulating next to him, trying to get his attention, but Phainon doesn’t spare them a second glance.

It’s like nothing else in the world matters except for Phainon and Mydei, a laser point of focus that ties them together.

Even after all these years, the spark remains.

~*~

On the surface Phainon seems to have a perfect life, a story fit for a fairytale or an inspirational movie. Born to humble farmers in a small town called Aedes Elysiae, Phainon’s life changed when he received a scholarship to study in the city of Okhema. While he was there, he got scouted as a model while working as fashion designer Aglaea’s personal assistant. His success and adoration only skyrocketed from there.

What no one knew though was that he clawed his way up, had transformed and remolded himself so many times that he could hardly recognize himself when he looked into the mirror. He took the gifts he was given at birth—natural good looks and his sharp wit, and honed them into a mighty weapon.

The legions of adoring fans and followers on social media came naturally. All he needed was a fake smile, a wave, some kind words and they were putty in his hands. He portrayed an image that made people project sincerity, warmth and gentleness onto him. And while Phainon didn’t think

he possessed these qualities, the people had expectations, so he played the role of an idealized prince to the best of his abilities.

Phainon worked hard for everything he had, but he still felt like he didn't deserve any of it. Because although he had achieved a lot of things, he couldn't say that these were things he truly wanted. They were more like… things people thought he wanted.

There had only been one thing, or rather, one person, that Phainon desired for himself. He'd fucked up, let that chance slip through his fingers like quicksand. Letting Mydei go was the biggest mistake of his life, but by the time he realized it, Mydei was long gone.

Since then, he's been working slowly, steadily to fix his own mistakes. To get everything back to the way it used to be, when life was good.

He would.

He would.

Most people would refer to him as a workaholic but Phainon prefers the term 'devoted'.

One day he'll earn enough money from his career to retire early and move to Castrum Kremnos, where he'd truly dedicate himself to searching for Mydei. But until that day came, he'd keep working, he'd keep refining himself into becoming the type of man Mydei couldn't say no to.

He won't lose him a second time.

Finding out that Mydei actually moved back to Okhema in his early adulthood was great news, it pushed his plan forward by a few years.

Their meeting tonight was preordained, not accidental.

Though, if Phainon had his say, he would have preferred a little bit more meticulous planning, his long awaited first reunion with Mydei shouldn't be left to chance. He'd thought of a hundred different ways to meet-cute, perhaps create a situation where he'd run into Mydei at a restaurant, or have

one of their gigs coincide with Phainon's job. He even considered organizing a class reunion, but quickly tossed the idea out because there's no way Mydei would want to attend that.

And then when they're finally in the same room together, he'd pretend not to notice Mydei at first. But he'll be watching, always looking from the corner of his eye, quietly staking his claim. When he catches sight of Mydei's lingering gaze, he'd approach him gently, with his best innocent expression. Brows furrowed, doe eyed and a bright smile and he'll say:

"Mydei… is it really you? It's been way too long… I didn't even know you were back in Okhema."

Phainon fantasizes about how Mydei would respond. He doesn't expect a warm greeting, Mydei isn't like that, especially not since they parted on bad terms. He'd probably be politely cold, or even shocked. Maybe he'd even check him out, if he likes what he sees.

And then Phainon would say:

"You look good, Mydei. I… I really missed you."

That would be the first step of him worming his way back into Mydei's life.

Because watching Mydei from the sidelines isn't cutting it anymore. Refreshing his stellargram feed, tracking updates from his friends, going to places in the background of Mydei's pics only to barely see his shadow was driving him crazy. Like an addiction that kept running deeper and deeper, needing a bigger hit to feel the high, each new trace of Mydei, every sighting, however brief, left him wanting more.

It's not enough to know that he's in the same city, breathing the same air and visiting the same places. He needs to be near Mydei, to touch him, hold him. He couldn't wait for opportunity to deliver Mydei on a silver platter.

He'd have to reach out and take it himself.

His chance came in the form of a picture shared by one of Mydei's bandmates—the cat girl—on her public account. A picture of three hands flashing a devil horns sign in front of a familiar looking street, alongside the caption '*getting wasted with my ride or dies tonight! #TitansofCalamity*'

He recognized the street as it was near his home, and when he spotted the timestamp, he couldn't suppress the thrill of excitement that ran down his spine.

Posted 3 minutes ago

After that, it was simply a case of calling up all the bars and restaurants on that street to double check if any of them had a reservation under 'Mydeimos'. And lo and behold, the trap was set.

For once, he knew exactly where Mydei was going to be. He wasn't going to have to piece together the evidence after everything had already passed, left with nothing but the ghost of Mydei.

His fingers dialled one of his contacts before he even had time to process it.

"Hey, partner," he greets upon the call getting picked up, careful to keep his voice smooth, easygoing, casual "How's it going? Are you free tonight?"

Phainon had worried that he wouldn't be able to find anyone willing to tag along at such short notice, especially to such a fancy bar. Most people actually had lives, and plans, and the exorbitant price tag of the drinks were a deterrent to most. Luckily, his college friends, affectionately known as the Astral Express crew, always had his back, and his offer to foot the bill for the evening certainly sweetened the deal.

It'll be a hit to his wallet, for sure, but his modelling jobs have paid well lately and he loves pampering his friends.

Cyrene joining at the last minute was something he hadn't anticipated though. They were childhood friends who had grown apart, before

reconnecting in college by chance. She had a close friendship with Caelus and his group, Phainon understood that.

She was welcomed here, truly. He loved her, and rekindling their friendship even after so much time apart was easy.

But-

The problem is that Cyrene is perceptive, a little too perceptive. If he's not careful with it, she might see through his intentions for coming here tonight.

All these worries could have been avoided if Phainon came alone. He had considered it, briefly, he didn't want to miss his window of opportunity. But he tried to gather some company anyway because he preferred being surrounded by people.

His thoughts got too loud when he was by himself, reminding him of what he's lost, of what he could no longer get back. Whispering the names of everything he traded away for the life he had now, and asking him if it was worth it. Questioning if he was truly happy, telling him that all this praise, this prestige, this success he has accomplished was because of luck. That he was nothing but an imposter dressed in finery and people were going to wake up and realize at any moment now that he was *nothing*.

But when lively and noisy people like March and Caelus were around, it was easier to pretend to be himself, to keep the voices locked away in the back of his mind. Of course, those were not the only reasons he valued their friendship, but it was an important one nonetheless.

Mydei and his friends are already inside when Phainon arrives, clinking glasses and toasting to each other. Phainon spots him immediately even before he enters, through the window, and has to avert his eyes to avoid losing his sanity. He thought he had prepared for this, but nothing even came close to seeing the real thing.

Phainon can’t even meet his eyes, it was like looking at an angel, a sight that would blind him if he stared at it too long.

Mydei is… god.

Mydei is even more beautiful than he remembers, all the pictures and grainy recordings through a phone screen didn’t do him justice. He thought he’d kept up with every new change, each new tattoo he inked onto his body, the sharpening of his facial features as the last of the baby fat melted away, the way his body only got more sculpted over time due to his relentless training.

And his face, Phainon would go to war for that face, he’d conquer entire cities if it would make Mydei smile. The way that his stern expression would soften and his gaze would almost be tender as he looks at his friends. This tenderness used to belong to Phainon alone, used to.

Now it was freely shared with other people not called Phainon. People who probably didn’t understand what a privilege it is to see that smile.

And all Phainon can do is watch from a distance and pretend not to see it.

But on the inside, he is so jealous he could die.

He knows he deserves to suffer 10 times over, he was the one to bring ruin upon their relationship. Mydei had never asked for anything, but Phainon in his arrogance had presumed to know what was the best for them. In the end, he lost the only thing that ever mattered to him.

His lingering feelings for Mydei are a part of him, as deeply ingrained as the laws of physics. He would never be able to move on, even if all he can do is hover around his traces like a fallen star.

“Phainon… are you okay?” Cyrene’s brows are furrowed, concern flitting across her pretty face. She darts her head towards Mydei’s direction and it is just as he feared, she’s caught on to something.

And he had tried so hard not to stare too, but it's inevitable that he does because… have you seen how gorgeous he is?

"Of course, I'm fine, Cyrene. Just a little tired." Phainon forces himself to turn his entire body away, smiling at his friend.

She doesn't look convinced, but nods her head in understanding regardless. "You've been working really hard lately, don't push yourself."

That is when he makes the mistake of looking back at Mydei, and he really shouldn't have.

Because how is he supposed to be normal after seeing *that*?

Mydei's staring at him, looking like he jumped straight out of a 'sexiest men in Amphoreus' magazine spread. His head is tilted over the back of the chair, the red tips of his short blond hair framing his face, and Phainon can't stop staring at the bob of his throat, at the red tattoos that sneak up his neck.

Mydei's golden eyes are intense, almost glowing as they stare at him. At that moment, he looked like he wanted to devour Phainon, and he would gladly offer himself on a silver platter if it meant he would look at Phainon like that again.

Phainon's hands are sweaty as he clutches his shot glass so hard it could almost shatter in his palm. His heartbeat resonates so loudly in his ears that it's hard to focus on anything else.

Cyrene is looking between them like she's figuring out a secret that only she knows.

"You know," She leans closer conspiratorally, a hand over her mouth. Phainon instinctively copies her gesture. "That guy sitting over there is really sexy."

Phainon freezes. Cyrene is one of his closest friends, and he knows she's no threat to himself or Mydei. Regardless, it didn't stop his hackles from rising, a possessive, dark, ugly predatorial instinct that screams nobody

should be looking at Mydei in the context of ‘sexy’ other than him. Because Mydei is his, even though he isn’t.

Not yet, at least.

Instead, Phainon shoves his misgivings down his throat, laughing in what he hopes is a natural and carefree way as he chokes out. “Oh, you think so?”

Cyrene nods vigorously. “Yeah, he reminds me of that person you had as your phone wallpaper.”

She’s joking, he knows Cyrene’s teasing when he hears it. But Phainon jolts anyway, panic trickling down his spine. It had been poor judgement to set Mydei’s picture as his wallpaper, knowing how easily it would be for other people to catch a glimpse of his screen, accidentally or otherwise. But he hadn’t accounted for the sheer mortification when Cyrene did actually see it and questioned him on it, and he had to lie and say it was a celebrity he admired.

Because as far as any of his current friends are concerned, Phainon is perpetually single, with a distaste for romance due to various disastrous relationships in school and college. He explained that it was better for his career that way, and they ate it up without question. Because how would he even begin to explain that he was still obsessed with his high school boyfriend to this very day?

No, it was easier for everybody to think he was just another cocky model who was only looking for casual flings and nothing more. And sure, sometimes his pathetic side slips out whenever someone reminds him too much of Mydei, but he could always chalk that up to being drunk.

“He keeps looking this way, maybe he’s into you.” She whispers. “Or… maybe he’s into me.”

Phainon’s smile is stiff as he tries to think of something to say. She’s only joking… she’s only joking… Cyrene wouldn’t take Mydei away from him. She wouldn’t fucking *dare*--

She laughs, tapping him lightly on the chest to pull him back into reality. “Don’t need to look at me with such a scary expression. I’m only joking.”

“...Of course, hahaha.” Phainon laughs in a way that sounds fake even to him. He glances back to Mydei, to find that he’s returned to his conversation. But his friend, the cat girl, keeps glaring at Phainon, almost like she’s suspicious of him.

“By the way,” Cyrene says, “I didn’t know you wore glasses. You look good, Phainon.”

Phainon smiles tightly. “Thanks.” They were a deliberate fashion choice. He had hoped if he looked a little bit like how he used to, if he kept some of his youthful charm… Mydei would realize that he hadn’t changed that much, not where it truly matters.

Of course Cyrene noticed.

He’s being too obvious.

Phainon tries to tone it down a little, keeping his attention on himself and his friends. He makes an active effort to ignore Mydei because if he looks back and meets his gaze well… Phainon might just lose himself completely.

It’s like handing a starving dog fresh prey, it cannot be trusted to reasonably control its instinct in the face of overwhelming hunger. Even if it’s been leashed, even if it has been domesticated, it just wouldn’t be able to control itself.

There is nothing he wants more than to bend Mydei over the table and admire his ass in those tight black slacks before fucking him senseless. Many of his fantasies have included taking Mydei home and chaining him to his bed so he would never leave again. Phainon would take good care of him, obviously, treat him like a king, give him everything he desired, make sure he knew he was loved each and every day of his life. He would make Mydei happy, be the perfect, doting husband he deserved.

Still, he forces himself to be a good boy, to be patient. He'll have to take things slow, reacclimatize Mydei to his presence. He can't act too rashly, doesn't want to spook him.

But all his best laid plans go flying out the window when Mydei suddenly takes to the stage with a guitar.

"Wha— huh?" Phainon mouths, head jerking to attention. He knew Mydei had decided to pursue music as a career, it was why he came back to Okhema, but he never had the privilege of listening to him sing live. Going somewhere so crowded is asking for trouble, and would most certainly blow the cover he had tried so hard to maintain.

Besides… hearing that voice again, the one that used to sing only to him, being broadcasted in front of a live audience was just too overwhelming. At least in recordings, the voice was filtered first. Sound waves converted into electric current, stored as ones and zeroes before being relayed to the listener. A digital wall keeping them apart.

But make no mistake, Phainon is his biggest fan. He's watched all their videos, looped them over and over so many times it must seem obsessive. His favourite ones were the short song covers Mydei posted on his personal account, the ones where it was just his voice, his guitar, and the camera zoomed in to his glorious ~~pecs~~—the guitar, he means. And he owns more than a few pieces of merch, from t-shirts, to a signed poster from their first ever gig, and some strange finds like an old guitar pick Mydei had apparently used and threw away. If only so it would stay out of the hands of those less deserving.

And now… he is really going to hear Mydei sing in person.

Phainon didn't know if he had been blessed or cursed by the gods.

Mydei begins to play, and Phainon's breath hitches. Those notes… are so familiar to him that it hurts.

He had only heard them once, when Mydei played it for him in his room, the same day they had their first kiss. They had been two stupid teenagers

then, and everything was simpler.

Like all things, the memory faded with time to the point where Phainon couldn't recall the melody or the lyrics. But it was always in the back of his mind, some shattered remains of a tune he thought he would never hear again. Phainon had grieved, assuming that it was lost to him forever.

But hearing these opening notes makes all the memories return, and resurfaces the feelings that never went away.

Mydei's singing voice is deeper than he remembered. Older, more mature, definitely sexier. Every word sends chills down his spine.

And I'm in so deep
You know I'm such a fool for you
You got my wrapped around your finger
Did you have to let it linger?

Does he know what he does to Phainon, when he's singing so beautifully while looking at him like that? Phainon can feel the heat of his gaze, his golden eyes practically boring into him, stripping him bare.

Phainon hasn't had that much to drink at all this evening but he already feels drunk. He's drunk off yearning and longing and from the way Mydei's husky voice wraps around his heart in chokehold.

Does he know that Phainon still yearns for him? And is it even possible to hope that Mydei feels the same way?

No, no, Phainon must not allow himself to be delusional.

It's enough that he was able to hear that song again. He does not dare ask for more, doesn't want to overstep the line. This time, he'll keep that memory close to his heart, even if he can only admire from afar.

But Phainon desperately wanted to leap over that gap.

Chapter End Notes

Update 08/06/2026: I'M GONNA NEED Y'ALL TO FEAST YOUR EYES ON THIS AMAZING ART by dawnurora like oh my god Mydei's intense gaze, Phainon's stupefied face it's incredible and amazing please look and thank you so much dawn for blessing my eyes with this gorgeous piece!!!

Song of the day and the song that inspired this fic: Linger (The Cranberriees Cover) by Royel Otis.
Spotify playlist

I've been sitting on this chapter for quite some time now because to be honest I'm a bit insecure about this fic. I get worried about stuff like whether it's boring or draggy and I really want to make smth enjoyable for people.

But I also want to keep going because I really enjoy the process and well as long as you're having fun and I'm having fun then it's okay right?
Thank you as always for reading, I really appreciate each and every one of you! OTL

Chapter 4: Don't Blame Me, Blame My Ex

Chapter Summary

> Mydei forcibly drags his eyes away. It’s one thing to ogle the man when he thinks he’s not looking, it’s another to do it right in front of his face. “It has. I see you’re doing well.”
>
> “You can say that,” Phainon smiles at him, though it seems a little hollow. “Could be better.” His eyes are fixed on Mydei, like he’s the only person in the room. It’s intense but also… a little bit exciting. Their knees knock underneath the table, and Mydei pulls his legs back, breaking contact. He doesn’t want to indulge him too much, not until he knows what Phainon’s real intentions are.
>
> “What do you mean, better?” Mydei echoes.
>
> Mydei feels Phainon’s ankle hook around his leg again, possessive, dominating. At the same time, he leans forward on the table, putting himself in Mydei’s personal space.
>
> “Better if I didn’t see you flirting with another guy the second I walked out of the room.” Phainon says in a low voice, his tone bitter. “I can’t leave you alone for even a minute, can I?”

Chapter Notes

> Me knowing full well that I'm bad at writing fight scenes: but what about I do it ~anyway~
> This chapter is a long one! Phew, over 12k words, lock in.
>
> Additional content warnings: Male Original Character (don't mind him his only purpose is to move the plot along), Stalking

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei doesn’t think he’ll ever get tired of applause.

Adrenaline rushes through his veins when he hears the audience clap and cheer after he performs, filling him with a buzz that is like nothing else. There is no better feeling than knowing his work had been recognized, enjoyed, savoured, even. With the stage lights shining into his face and his ears ringing from the guitar reverb, the world is narrowed to only himself, and Phainon who keeps staring at him with lights in his stupid blue eyes.

Emboldened, he smirks into the mic. He's got a few choice words for the stupid, beautiful HKS sitting over there.

"You like that? The next song is called 'fuck you, you motherfucker, suck my-" And the speed at which Cipher darts up on stage and drags him away before he can get them all kicked out can only be described as superhuman.

"Thanks everyone for the love, but he'll be leaving now." She says cheerfully, adept at damage control.

"Geez, he's not even a rockstar yet and he's already causing trouble." Cipher sighs as they arrive back at their table, Castorice shoving a glass of ice water in his face. "You're never impulsive like this, Mydei. Seeing your ex must have gotten you really worked up."

"Maybe we should go home." Castorice suggests. "It's pretty late and we've been here for a while now…"

"No… I'm fine. I'm over him." Mydei insists, though they don't know if he's lying to convince them or to convince himself. Regardless, he's fooling no one.

"I can't believe I'm agreeing with Princess Homebody on this, but I also think we should go home." Cipher says. It's clear that Mydei isn't in the right headspace after seeing Phainon, and continuously being in the same room can't be good for either of them.

"No." Mydei says, firmly, stubbornly. He does practically everything but dig his heels petulantly into the ground. "We're staying until I say we can go home."

“Ughhhh…” Cipher places a palm over her face, dragging it downwards. When the little prince says he doesn’t want to do something, nothing will change his mind. It’s both his most admirable, and his most annoying quality. “Have it your way, you brat. But I’m cutting you off.”

And that’s how Mydei ends up sipping only water and fruit juice. His eyes stray over to Phainon again, whose friends, red-faced, some of them swaying and barely upright, are getting up to leave. Mydei knew he wasn’t mistaken, he had been staring at him like there was nothing else in the room. Surely, that song had sparked something within him, a forgotten feeling, a realization that he missed him, anything.

But if that was true, then how can he just sit there and talk to his friends like nothing’s happened while Mydei is sitting here in shambles? Perhaps he was wrong, and it was only his imagination and wishful thinking. Mydei had no choice but to curse himself, this is why he doesn’t bother with blind optimism.

He watches quietly as Phainon stands up with his arm around the beautiful pink-haired woman. He’s going to leave too, so it’s really coming to an end, just like that.

Phainon doesn’t spare Mydei a single glance as he escorts his drunk friends out of the bar, nodding to the bartender on his way out.

How cruel.

Maybe Mydei really is the only one clinging to the past, chasing a shadow that had never belonged to him. It’s clear that the Phainon of today is somebody who is warm, kind, talented, beautiful, the kind of person that everybody wants a piece of. Hell, a person who gives a piece of himself freely to everybody.

His heart aches with something that feels like grief, which is weird because the person he’s mourning is very much alive. But Mydei forces himself not to dwell on it, he’s wasted too much time grieving a relationship that has been dead and buried for a long time.

It would be great if he could drown out his feelings with even more drinks, but since Cipher has cut him off, that's probably for the best. With his returning sobriety, he realized he had caused trouble for his friends tonight.

"What is taking Cassie so long? I only asked her to get us a few non-alcoholic drinks." Cipher grumbles, looking over her shoulder.

Right, it had been a few minutes since Phainon and his friends left, and seeing how dejected he is, Castorice volunteered herself to get them some refills. Mydei hadn't even noticed her kind gesture, he truly is the worst.

He raises his eyes to the counter, and meets Cipher's gaze only for her to grin conspiratorily at him. A tall and handsome stranger is standing there, talking to Castorice. While she is usually an introvert who gets shy when talking to new people, she's conversing with him amicably, looking very invested in their conversation.

"Tonight is full of surprises," Cipher says. "Cassie getting along with someone aside from us… they grow up so quickly!"

Mydei squints at the scene in disbelief. The stranger is tall, broad-shouldered, dressed in an oversized black sweater and ripped black jeans. He can't get a good look at his face because his back is facing them but…

He certainly seems her type. "I thought Cas preferred women?" He asks aloud.

"She does, but she likes both." Cipher says. "Look at her speaking so confidently and passionately! I wonder what they're talking about?"

They didn't have to wonder for long, as a few moments later Castorice nearly skips up to their table, bringing the stranger with her.

"Hello," She greets, a little too cheerful for the occasion. "This is Nicola. He's the drummer of the band that was playing earlier and we went to the same alma mater."

"Hey." The stranger, Nicola, says.

“Hi.” Cipher greets. “I’m Cipher, this is Mydei.” She nudges his side, hard, motioning him to respond.

Mydei doesn’t even try to hide his sigh as he responds with the air of someone who’s being greatly inconvenienced. “Yo.”

He knows he’s being a brat and feels slightly guilty for it. It’s just that… he’s having a tough night, and he was kind of hoping it’ll just be the three of them instead of having to put up with a stranger.

Cipher nudges him again in the ribs even harder this time, making him flinch.

“Mydei, sure you don’t have something to say to the drummer of the band you interrupted earlier?” She says with gritted teeth.

“I apologize for disrupting your set earlier,” he says reluctantly. It feels weird, it’s usually him making Cipher apologize for the trouble she’s caused, oh, how the turntables.

“No, it’s alright. It was refreshing, actually.” The guy gestures to the empty chair at the table, and Castorice nods, giving him permission to sit. “It’s been a while since I’ve been that entertained.”

Okay, so this was happening after all. They were getting a fourth ranger, that’s fantastic. Mydei sighs, allowing Castorice and Cipher to carry the bulk of the conversation. He’d never been a particularly sociable person to begin with, so this is the norm for them.

But even though he doesn’t contribute to it, he’s still very much a part of the conversation. That’s how he learns that Nicola is a junior from Castorice’s alma mater, who did music as his major.

“Isn’t that amazing?” Castorice says, sparkles in her eyes as she directs her attention to Mydei. “You two must have so much in common. You have a degree in music too, don’t you Mydei?”

“I guess?” Mydei just says bluntly, furrowing his eyebrows. Why is she being so persistent and almost… hopeful? Surely, she does not seek Mydei’s approval that badly. He has no qualms about who she’s dating as long as the other person isn’t an asshole.

“Oh…” He feels almost bad at the way Castorice seems to wilt slightly at his nonchalant reply before turning her attention back to the stranger. “Do you have any hobbies, Nicola?”

“Boxing,” he replies confidently, and Mydei won’t lie, that kind of piques his interest.

“What a coincidence!” Castorice says. “Mydei is *very* passionate about mixed martial arts.”

“Huh.” Mydei says, finally taking notice of the man called Nicola for the first time. The guy’s obviously well-built underneath his loose jumper, so he’s probably not lying about the boxing thing. When he raises his hand to scratch at his nose, Mydei can see tattoos covering the back of his hand, extending to his wrists and possibly the rest of his arm as well. His face is, he supposes, objectively handsome. Sharp features with a multitude of facial piercings that seems to add to his good looks rather than detract from them. His jet black hair is messily cut, uneven layers framing his face, and his eyes are a piercing shade of bright red.

His gruff, badboy demeanor is the opposite of clean cut Phainon, Mydei thinks unhelpfully to himself.

“She’s right, I enjoy doing martial arts.” Mydei tells him. “I find that it helps with stamina and coordination, alongside a robust diet and exercise plan.” If anyone knows his kryptonite, it’s Castorice. He can discuss fitness for hours.

“I feel the same, I still lift regularly, but boxing improves my footwork and mobility.” Nicola says. “What’s your split between martial arts and functional training?” Castorice looks beside herself with delight that the conversation is finally moving somewhere.

“Martial arts two or three times a week, strength training in between, your usual push-pull-legs. One or two active recovery days a week depending on my schedule.”

“Look at that! You’re bonding!” Castorice squeals, sounding a little too excited about a conversation on fitness. Mydei never thought she’d go for a gymbro and is just about to tell her so when Castorice suddenly says-

“Cipher, I’m really craving a burger. Will you come with me to the fast food joint down the street?”

“Huh?” Cipher says, looking confused for once. “We can’t just leave Mydei here.”

“He’ll be *fine*!” Castorice insists, tugging her by the wrists. “He’ll have Nicola here to accompany him. Please?”

Cipher was never able to resist Castorice, especially not when she started begging. So as expected, she sighs and reaches for her bag, looking at Mydei as she stands up.

“You heard the princess. Are you okay on your own?”

“I could come with you to get the burger–” Mydei stands up, he’s feeling a little peckish himself. Normally he wouldn’t touch something as unhealthy as a burger, but it’s been quite the evening and he deserves a cheat day.

“NO!” Castorice said so abruptly Mydei can’t help but sit back down. “I mean, it’ll be rude to leave our new friend hanging. You guys should totally… continue your riveting conversation! Goodbye!”

“Call us if anything happens, Mydei!” Cipher says, in lieu of a goodbye.

Castorice grabs Cipher’s hand and they leave together while he looks at them like someone who’s been betrayed. Because that person is him, he’s being betrayed.

He may be a little slow on the uptake, but he’s not completely oblivious. It’s obvious to him now that Nicola is here not because Castorice likes him, but

because she’s trying to set Mydei up with him.

Her efforts are appreciated, he knows the girls worry about him, but they’re ultimately misguided. He’s in no state to get to know someone, not when Phainon is still so heavy on his mind.

Mydei is just thinking of how he could politely excuse himself from the conversation when a waiter places a vibrant yellow cocktail in front of him.

“It’s a Pina Colada,” Nicola says. “My treat. Castorice told me you preferred sweet things.”

Mydei clicks his tongue in annoyance, his sweet tooth was supposed to remain a secret within his friend group. Why is she going around telling his weakness to random strangers? But… he hated wasting a perfectly good drink. Not finding any good reason to refuse, Mydei mumbles his thanks and takes a sip, exhaling deeply at the burn as the sweet alcohol rolls down his parched throat like nectar.

If the circumstances were different, Nicola is… fine. He’s easy on the eyes, friendly, and Mydei could tell that they have some hobbies in common. But… his eye colour is all wrong, his hair colour isn’t white, he isn’t teasing Mydei in the exact way he wants to be teased, his smile doesn’t send his heart into overdrive. He just… he’s not Phainon.

It would be unfair to lead on a perfectly nice guy when his heart obviously lies elsewhere. Maybe one day, when he fully gets over Phainon, he’ll consider dating again. He doesn’t know when that day will be.

“I apologize. I’m not looking for a relationship right now.” Mydei says, making up his mind. “Not looking for anything casual, either.”

“Oh.” Nicola says, eyes widening to the point where he looks like a surprised animal. “I wasn’t… oh… okay.”

The table descends into an awkward silence.

“I’m sorry if I gave off that impression.” Nicola apologizes sheepishly. “I’m… not too good at making friends.”

“Oh.” Mydei replies, since that is truly all he can say. Guilt stabs him like a knife and Mydei feels heat rush to his neck from shame. How could he be so conceited to assume that a random guy would be interested in him in that way? How could he have shot him down so coldly and heartlessly without even an ounce of saving face? “I apologize for misunderstanding.” It was the least he could do, but it still didn’t seem like enough.

“Oh, no, no!” To make matters worse, they now seem to be looped in an endless cycle of uncomfortable apologies. “It’s my fault for coming on too strong. I met a fellow gym junkie and got too excited…”

Mydei’s facial expression twists, here was a guy just trying to be friendly, bonding over similar hobbies, and he just assumed that he wanted to get into his pants. He of all people should know how it feels like to have your intentions misunderstood just for being awkward, and here he is doing the same to someone else.

Regret for his careless actions seemed too mild a term. He is mortified, he wants to sink six feet down underground and never return. If Nikador would throw down a lightning bolt onto the very place where he sits and vaporize him on the spot, Mydei wouldn’t complain.

“It’s fine… really, I’m not offended. I’d still like to be friends, if you’re open to the idea.” Friends? Friends?? Mydei can’t even look the man in the eye. “Are you okay though? You don’t look well.”

Mydei doesn’t feel well.

“I—uhm—I’m just going to go to the bathroom,” He says, standing up so quickly it makes his head spin.

“Oh, okay… I’ll be here.” No, Mydei pleads silently to nobody in particular. Please leave, he wouldn’t be offended.

As he walks towards the direction of the restroom, Mydei feels the back of his neck prickle. It's an uncomfortable, uneasy feeling, like he's being watched, scrutinized. Mydei turns around, looking behind him. Nothing is amiss. Nicola has his back turned to him, nobody is looking at him.

Trying to ignore his agitation, Mydei takes out his phone and idly unlocks it, hoping for a distraction, any distraction.

He's not comforted one bit by the messages on his phone. Castorice and Cipher had sent messages to their *Titans of Calamity* group chat, messages that read along the lines of *'Go get him little lion!*👍*' 'Remember to stay safe and use protection!' 'Text us if you're not coming home tonight'*

Oh… they misunderstood the situation so badly. Was he really so pathetic that they felt the need to set him up like this?

He needs to get a hold of himself.

The bathroom is thankfully, unoccupied. Mydei admits he spends longer than what's socially acceptable inside, just splashing cold water on his face in an effort to sober up. Droplets trickle down his chin and drip into his collar, but the chill is welcomed, it wakes him up and brings him back to his senses.

For everything that's happened tonight he blames the alcohol. Clearly his faculties weren't all intact, and he solemnly swears not to touch a drop of drink again.

Just then, his phone buzzes with a private message from Cipher.

Cipher:
Hey little prince, hope you're not too mad that we ditched you earlier. Cassie wouldn't have done it if she wasn't sure you were in good hands, so don't worry!
It's just… none of us want to see you sad like that.
Just try… please? For Cassie's sake.

Mydei sighs and pockets his phone. He knows they meant well, but it doesn't feel good, having the choice taken out of his hands.

He glances at his reflection in the mirror to check his face and hair, noting that he looks a mess, cheeks flushed and ponytail lopsided. The bathroom window is reflected in it as well, showing nothing but the dark and deserted sidewalk outside. And while he's staring at it, something moves outside, so imperceptible Mydei wouldn't even have noticed if he hadn't been looking.

Mydei pauses, narrowing his eyes, a chill is running down his spine. It could have been anything, a shadow of a pedestrian, a stray cat passing by, a cloud briefly blocking out the moon, but it makes the uneasiness grow.

He has no proof, nothing but a paranoid, unsettling feeling.

Mydei shuts his eyes, steeling himself with a deep breath. He's going to go out there, apologize to Nicola again, grab his jacket and leave. Then, he's going to call a cab, go home, take a shower, and then sleep it off. Tomorrow, everything will be back to normal, and this will be some awkward memory he'll laugh about with Cipher and Castorice.

That sounds like a plan he can get behind and Mydei slaps his cheeks slightly to pull himself together. The night has been a disaster, no thanks to running into Phainon, but it's still salvageable.

Mydei steps out of the bathroom, but what he sees at his table stops him in his tracks.

He wasn't mistaken, that was definitely the same table he was sitting at. The same glass of pina colada, still half full, the shockingly yellow drink standing out garishly underneath the bar lights. His leather jacket is still draped over the back of his chair, waiting for its owner to pick it up and go home. Everything is exactly as he left it, with one very noticeable difference.

There is a different person sitting opposite his chair.

White hair, navy blue coat, high black turtleneck and those dazzling blue eyes hidden beneath glasses.

He saw Phainon walk out, when… or rather, why did he come back?

His uneasiness grows when Phainon turns around, sees him and gives him a megawatt smile. One that is so warm and doting that Mydei just stands there, kind of stunned for a few moments.

Because what else can a person do when they see a smile so bright and beautiful?

“Hi Mydei,” He greets warmly, eyes roaming up and down Mydei’s body abashedly.

“Where is he?” Mydei asks, there is no need for greetings or small talk, not between them. He hardly knew Nicola, but he didn’t seem like the kind of guy who would just leave someone hanging, even if their conversation had been terribly awkward. Something happened while he was in the lavatory.

Phainon tilts his head cutely, the tips of his hair brushing his cheeks. It’s the kind of innocent look that will let him get away with almost anything. “Dunno, I think he went home.”

Mydei scowls, unconvinced. He can’t just shrug it off and play dumb, not anymore. They’re two fully grown men now and this won’t work. “Really?”

“Why, does it matter? You two weren’t interested in each other anyway.” Phainon sulks, voice dipping dangerously low at the end, he sounds angry. That only pisses Mydei off even more because… what right did he have to get mad?

He was the one who walked out and left Mydei alone, he was the one who moved on first. Is it so bad for Mydei to attempt the same?

“That’s not for you to say,” Mydei replies sharply. A petty revenge, but one he thinks Phainon deserves for what he put him through.

Phainon's perfectly controlled smile doesn't drop, which further angers him because he should know how much Mydei hates it when he puts on an act. But it tightens, brittle at the edges.

That, at the very least, is pleasing. It's a sign that Phainon is not as unaffected as he lets on, that perhaps Mydei can still get under his skin in the way that only he can. He wants to see how far he can push that carefully constructed facade until it cracks, until it breaks.

"What do you want, Phainon. Why are you here?" And if Mydei can't stop the bite from entering his tone then that is only his right.

"It was always my intention to return and talk to you," Phainon says gently, like he's fragile and made of glass. "My friends were drunk, I had to make sure they got home safely first."

Mydei sighs, his mind replaying the memory from earlier, of Phainon just walking out with his arm wrapped around that woman's shoulders, not even sparing him a second glance. If he really did want to talk to Mydei, he could have said something first.

He doesn't want to be Phainon's dirty little secret that he comes crawling back to after he spends the whole day with his arm around other people. He's no longer the lovestruck young teenager who would be okay with scraps of affection given in hiding when no one else is looking. Mydei knows he deserves so much more, someone who can be open and unabashedly proud of him. That will crown him in gold and parade him like the prize that he is.

"How kind of you," He tells Phainon outright, tired of these games. "I'm going home. No need to escort me." He stands up.

Phainon mirrors his movements "But you just got here!"

"I've been here for a while." Mydei replies in a clipped tone. He picks up his jacket from the back of the chair.

“Wait!” Phainon says. He grabs Mydei by the wrist so tightly that the pain makes him wince. “Stay and drink with me, please.” He pleads.

At first, Mydei just thinks he’s just angry. But when he looks at Phainon, there’s a wavering in his eyes, a kind of desperation that leaks through his facade.

He thought he’d moved on. Then why… why is Phainon looking at him like he wants to cry?

Despite his better judgement, Mydei is curious and he complies by sitting back down.

Phainon closes his eyes, visibly relaxing as he also sinks back into his seat. His angle has shifted slightly though, blocking the only exit so that Mydei can’t easily leave without trying to pass him first.

“It’s really… been too long, Mydeimos.” Phainon’s eyes rove across him almost greedily, drinking him in, cataloguing all the changes that had occurred over time.

The scrutiny should make him uncomfortable but it doesn’t. In fact, Mydei takes his chance to do the same. Phainon is a handsome man, that much is obvious to anyone with eyes. But looking at him up close, his beauty is almost unreal. Mydei could already tell, back in high school, that he had strikingly gorgeous features. His sharp jawline, sleek nose bridge, high cheekbones, and those big blue eyes that he weaponizes. He looks even better in person than in photos, no editing needed.

Mydei forcibly drags his eyes away. It’s one thing to ogle the man when he thinks he’s not looking, it’s another to do it right in front of his face. “It has. I see you’re doing well.”

“You can say that,” Phainon smiles at him, though it seems a little hollow. “Could be better.” His eyes are fixed on Mydei, like he’s the only person in the room. It’s intense but also… a little bit exciting.

Their knees knock underneath the table, and Mydei pulls his legs back, breaking contact. He doesn't want to indulge him too much, not until he knows what Phainon's real intentions are.

"What do you mean, better?" Mydei echoes.

Mydei feels Phainon's ankle hook around his leg again, possessive, dominating. At the same time, he leans forward on the table, putting himself in Mydei's personal space.

"Better if I didn't see you flirting with another guy the second I walked out of the room." Phainon says in a low voice, his tone bitter. "I can't leave you alone for even a minute, can I?"

And Mydei's carefully maintained composure snaps. "You have no right to say that to me. Not after you left with your arm around your latest girlfriend."

For a moment Phainon just looks at him, expression bewildered. Then he lets out a bark of laughter, sharp and humourless. Mydei frowns, not liking how such a harsh and bitter laugh sounds from him.

"Wait, you thought Cyrene was-? No, Mydei, just no. She's Cyrene, the childhood friend I've known since we were in diapers. I've told you about her."

Phainon's ankle tightens around his calf, entangling their legs together. Mydei jerks forward from the momentum. They're so close now it takes virtually no effort to hear Phainon whisper.

"I've never had a girlfriend, or a boyfriend. You were my first… and my last. Surprised?"

Mydei frowns, somebody as desirable as Phainon keeping himself single… for Mydei? If it sounds too good to be true, it probably is. He's not buying it.

“So? That doesn’t mean I can’t meet new people.” Mydei continues, all the emotions bubbling to the top like a boiling pot overflowing. “We’ve been broken up for years! How dare you start caring now.”

“I’ve always cared!” Phainon snaps, hand reaching out for Mydei to grab him. And then, right before anything happens, Phainon stops himself, breaking the contact between them.

Mydei looks at him, jaw slightly agape in confusion.

Realizing he had broken character, Phainon sighs and runs a hand through his hair, messing it up. He leans back in his chair, sulking. Mydei thinks if his fans saw him like this, he would lose his picture perfect, model image so fast. Look, he would say, this is how your golden boy really is. How childish, how immature.

“Anyway, I didn’t come here to fight.” Phainon’s tone softens again.

Mydei rolls his eyes, reaching for his drink. He’s going to need it. “Then what *do* you want?” Before can grab onto the stem of the cocktail glass, Phainon takes it away from him.

“You don’t like Pina Coladas,” He says. “Pomegranate milk’s your favourite.”

Mydei pauses, it’s kind of weird that Phainon knows that. Pomegranate milk is niche in Okhema, being a recipe unique to his hometown. He only discovered the joys of it in that brief time he spent living in Castrum Kremnos. Phainon shouldn’t have known anything from his life at that point in time.

“Let me buy you a drink you’ll actually like.” Phainon continues.

The audacity makes his jaw tighten, his pride getting the best of him again. How dare Phainon presume to know what he does and does not like? Just to spite him, Mydei snatches the glass back and proceeds to down the contents in one huge gulp.

He chugs like a fratboy at a house party, never breaking eye contact with Phainon. The bitterness of the rum overwhelms the sweetness of the juice, causing Mydei's face to crinkle with disgust. He never could get used to the taste of alcohol.

"It's delicious." He makes sure to say.

Phainon just sighs lightly at him, like he should have seen this coming.

That is when Mydei notices golden lines of a tattoo peeking up from the top of Phainon's turtleneck. He tilts his head to the side, intrigued. He hadn't seen it before, not in any of Phainon's modelling shots, nor his personal photos that he shared on his stellargram before it got locked.

The idea of Phainon famous for his clean-cut, boy-next-door looks getting a tattoo somewhere as conspicuous and sensitive as his neck makes Mydei get a little excited.

"What's that on your neck?" He asks. Mydei reaches out, intending to hook a finger through the collar of Phainon's turtleneck and tug. The seemingly open and easygoing Phainon jerks back, planting his hand over his neck to cover the golden lines.

"It's nothing you need to concern yourself with." Phainon says hurriedly, turning away.

Mydei's hand hangs in mid-air between them for an awkward second, before it falls back to his lap. Disappointment wells up within him only for Mydei to shove it away. Why did he think that he could touch Phainon? Why did he think that there was anything still between them? Phainon had changed in so many ways, yet was still as secretive and cagey in the way that he hated the most.

He doesn't know how to respond so he just doesn't bother saying anything. Even after so many years, Mydei still feels like he's playing catch up.

There was no point in sitting here and making both of them more miserable.

Mydei stands up so abruptly that some of the empty glasses on the table shift, toppling over each other with loud clinking noises. “This was a mistake.” He says.

Phainon follows suit, his expression alarmed. “What do you mean?”

“I’m going to leave.” Mydei tells him, reaching for his jacket.

“Come on, Mydei, don’t.” Phainon’s voice is insistent, pushy. He stands tall, shoulders broad as though to physically block Mydei from going anywhere. “You spent the whole night staring at me. You went up on stage and sang *our* song in front of the whole bar. Now that I’m here, you don’t want to talk to me? This has always been the problem with you.”

“With me?” Mydei raises his voice, drawing the attention of other customers. Above all, Mydei can’t stand the expression on Phainon’s face right now, because he looks like he’s *pitying* Mydei. Like he has a label that says ‘fragile, handle with care’ on his forehead.

Mydei doesn’t need to be pitied, he’s doing great for himself. He’s got good friends, a job he loves, and his music career can only go upwards. Sure, his love life was in shambles, he’d never connected with anyone else like he had with Phainon, and a part of Mydei is coming to terms with just being alone. Because since the breakup, it felt like a part of his soul had been ripped away.

And the worst part is that he still doesn’t understand why it had to be this way, they were so happy.

Even after all these years the memories still sting like an open wound, with Mydei picking away at the scab to aggravate it so that it could never heal.

But he was trying, he was doing fine, he was moving on, getting his life back on track. And he’s not going to just stand around and let Mr Perfect over here put the blame on him.

The dam breaks.

“I wasn’t the one who decided to change drastically over the course of one goddamned summer without even talking to my boyfriend about it! I wasn’t the one who one-sidedly decided what was ‘best for us’. I wasn’t the one who abandoned the relationship because he needed everyone else’s approval but mine!” Once it starts, Mydei can’t stop it, there was just too much that he bottled up. “You never tried to understand how it made me feel. So as far as I’m concerned, it’s too little and too late for a talk.”

Mydei sees his attacks strike true, and doesn’t feel a stab of guilt as Phainon flinches and almost recoils from the gravity of his words.

He finishes his sentence and he realizes that the bar is quiet, too quiet. Intentionally or not, he’s caused quite the scene. The bartender is now shooting them pointed looks, with an expression that seems to say ‘take your personal matters outside’.

Mydei tries to suppress the blush rising up his neck at having lost his composure like that. Trying to salvage whatever dignity he has left, he grabs his jacket, marches with his head held high to the counter, and asks for his bill.

The staff procure the tab even before he asks, like they had been waiting for him to leave.

“Let me pay.” He feels Phainon’s warm hand landing on his shoulder and immediately shrugs him off. He guesses that is the least he could do after the mess he’s caused tonight, so he doesn’t feel bad about it at all when he looks at the bartender and says.

“He’ll pay, thanks.” And marches out without a second word.

“Mydei, wait for me outside.” Phainon tells him.

Is he crazy? Does he think Mydei still wants to talk to him after that? Mydei heads into the open street, gritting his teeth at the chilly night wind biting his skin. Dark clouds are hanging low and heavy in the sky, blocking out the moon and stars, and there is a humidity in the air that indicates that it’s going to start raining soon.

He'd best call a cab and get himself home before he gets caught in the downpour. Winter rains in Okhema are truly the worst, freezing and wet and utterly miserable.

Mydei sniffs stubbornly, at least Cipher would be proud of him for making his ex pay for all their drinks.

He turns the corner, choosing to walk down a barely lit side street instead of the populated main road with shops and pedestrians. He just needs a little bit of solitude right now, somewhere quiet enough to think. Let Phainon waste time looking for him among the pedestrians, he won't find Mydei.

The side street was deserted, quiet as a grave, not a soul around. But as Mydei walks, for a moment, the unpleasant prickling sensation on the back of his neck returns.

He grimaces and tries to ignore it. Ever since he moved back to Okhema it had been like this, that relentless feeling of being watched, stalked like prey. It was a strange feeling, as Mydei happened to be a tall, muscular, scary looking man, and people usually were afraid of *him*.

To distract himself he pulls out his phone, the white light from the screen a small comfort. He intends to look for a taxi, but instead finds himself bombarded with missed calls and notifications from Cipher and Castorice

Castorice
Mydei, are you really mad at us?
It's not like you to leave us on read…
I'm really sorry if our actions upset you… please call us.

Cipher
Mydei, I'm being serious about this, even if you're mad, call us ASAP
I have something important to tell you

A chill shoots down his spine as the feeling of paranoia rapidly escalates, Mydei hears footsteps approaching him and for a moment he has a vivid vision of fingers grabbing him by the neck, a heavy body pressing him against the wall as he struggles in their grasp.

Mydei doesn’t ignore his premonitions. He swings around, fists raised bracing himself for a fight.

But there is nobody behind him.

He could have sworn he felt a presence… Mydei turns back, walking slightly faster now. Something about the darkness, the cold, the slight dizziness he’s feeling and the worsening throbbing in his head is making him uneasy. His finger is just hovering on the call button next to Cipher’s name when–

“I asked you to wait for me.” Phainon’s voice whispers in his ear as long, slender fingers wrap themselves around Mydei’s hand, startling him to the point where he almost drops his phone.

Mydei exhales slowly, deeply. He does not jolt, jerk, gasp, or do anything to indicate that he had been caught by surprise.

“Stop following me” He chastises as Phainon pouts at him with wide eyes, his expression completely innocent and such a contrast to his actions.

“I wouldn’t have to if you just waited for me in the first place. Mydei, you may not want to talk, but I do.”

They are at an impasse, neither wanting to budge. Mydei, with his phone still clutched in his hand, screen going black from inactivity, and Phainon, his fingers tightening around Mydei’s like he might die if Mydei doesn’t hear him out tonight.

And Mydei isn’t afraid of much, but right now, Phainon scares him. Phainon with his hair white like a phantom, face pale like a ghost, eyes dark with a crazed look. He’s looking at Mydei like he wants to eat him up, to devour him and leave no remains.

It’s not because he thinks Phainon will hurt him, Mydei isn’t a weakling in any sense of the word. No, what frightens him is the way Phainon looks at him like he’s the air he needs to breathe, like Mydei is the most important

person in his life, like the years they spent apart were as much of a torment to him as they have been for Mydei.

Because it makes him cling on to a stupid feeling called *hope*, and hope is perhaps the scariest of all things.

“Let go of my hand,” He growls.

“No,” Phainon says, he’d forgotten how stubborn he can be. “Face it, Mydeimos, if you really couldn’t stand the sight of me, you would have left the second you saw me walk in. You wouldn’t spend the whole evening ignoring your friends, staring at me. If you didn’t want me here, you would just punch me right now.”

Mydei jerks his hand away, his headache is worsening, maybe due to the stress of the situation or how persistent Phainon is.

“I *will* punch you,” he threatens. Though Mydei loves a fight, he would never hit someone unprovoked. But if Phainon is asking for it…

Phainon just lets out a bark of laughter, sharp, unfriendly. “Come on, Mydei, don’t threaten me with a good time.” He leans into Mydei’s personal space until they’re face to face, until Mydei can see the way his flushed, pink lips move as he whispers.

“You know I’m down for it.”

Mydei clenches his jaw to hide how his legs just wobbled at that, he had no right sounding so hot and Mydei had no business finding it sexy.

At a loss of what to do, he just inhales shakily. “Then speak, and I will judge if I wish to listen further.”

“I miss you.” The speed at which the tone of the conversation pivots is enough to give him whiplash. Mydei chokes on air, feeling sick.

“You’re-”

“I miss you.” Phainon repeats quickly, not giving Mydei a chance to cut in. “I missed you, I still miss you. When you left me, I felt like a limb had been sawed off, that would probably have hurt less.”

Mydei blinks at him, utterly speechless. Phainon’s face is severe, serious, he isn’t joking about any of it.

“You held my heart in the palm of your hand, you always have.” Phainon continues, voice cracking from stress. “And you crushed it without a second thought.”

Mydei’s breath hitches, and guilt floods his chest, hot and heavy, suffocating.

“This is about high school.” He says, realizing hitting him. “You… you still think about that?” He thought that he’d been the only one hanging on to that thread for years. That Phainon would have no problem moving on after one failed high school relationship.

“I think about it more than I should. You’re not the only one who was hurt, Mydei.”

“So that’s why you chased away my date and followed me here?” Mydei asks, a little winded from the revelation. “You wanted *closure*?”

“Closure?” Phainon repeats a little hysterically. “I want… I don’t know- I wanted you to get mad at me, shout at me, throw your drink on me or something. Just don’t look at me like I’m a stranger, don’t keep it all bottled inside like a suffering martyr."

“I’m not angry!” Mydei growls. Anger isn’t quite the expression he felt, that is true. He felt pain, yearning, regret, and below all of it, the undercurrent of insecurity.

“I never fit in, standing next to you.” He continues softly. “You were like the human embodiment of sunshine, and I was the dark cloud hanging around you.”

“But you never cared what other people thought—"

“Hear or see something enough times and even I will start believing that it’s true. I was only a teenager, Phainon. How unaffected did you expect me to be?”

Mydei stops suddenly, chest heaving after his outburst. He hadn’t expected to speak his feelings so plainly, so used to accepting his fate. “Anger is pointless… because once we started moving in different directors, the end of our relationship was inevitable.”

Does a fisherman rage at the sky when the storm comes? Does the farmer get angry at nature when his crops are swarmed by pests? Raging at fate is as pointless as an old man yelling at the sky.

“Inevitable, hah!” Phainon’s eyes are glittering as he gazes at Mydei with an expression that passes off as scorn. “All these years I kept thinking, ‘what did I do wrong’. It turns out you just gave up on us because you’re a coward.”

Mydei should have just taken the L with that, should have just let Phainon express his frustration at the situation. These are things that Mydei had told himself after the breakup too, that he was a coward that would rather run than fight for their relationship at the time. That he was equally responsible for the heartbreak he had wrought upon himself.

But the alcohol is roaring in his veins, and the adrenaline is buzzing in his blood. Unconsciously, all his muscles are tensed up and his heart is racing, it’s flight or fight and he wants to fight.

“I’m really going to get pissed off and punch you.” Mydei declares, his voice shaking.

Phainon smiles wider, looking like this was the outcome he’d wanted all along. He subtly broadens his stance into something more stable, a move that doesn’t get past Mydei. “Then do it, I dare you. Nobody is around to see us, and if they did, they’d just think it was a drunken brawl.”

Mydei doesn’t realize it, but he’s doing the same. Stance widening, center of gravity lowering. “You’re a public figure, a model on the up-and-up. What would it do to your reputation if you were caught fighting?”

“Exactly,” Phainon grins, revealing his canines, sharp and wolfish. “The picture perfect, sparkling up-and-coming model Phainon, or the unruly Kremnoan rockstar with unsightly tattoos all over his body, I wonder who they’ll think started it.”

Mydei’s grin widens, Phainon always knew the right things to say to rile him up.

Mydei wastes no time in throwing the first punch, swinging his fist forward, feeling it connect with the bone of Phainon’s jaw.

Phainon retaliates instantly, like he had been waiting for it. Rushing towards Mydei with his full body weight, he knocks him off balance and slams him against the wall. Mydei feels the pain shooting up his spine from the impact, but such a measly attack isn’t going to be enough to stop him.

“Hah. That’s it?” He smirks, knowing that it only goads Phainon, and sweeps his legs out from under him. Phainon dodges smoothly, still slippery like an eel even all this time.

It feels like this fight is a long time coming. They are messy, dirty, scrappy, nothing held back. Mydei’s been in a number of fights in his life, so he’s not afraid of getting hurt. Meanwhile, Phainon just looks happy every time Mydei’s fists make contact with his body, like he enjoys getting beaten up, masochistic bastard.

It reminds him a little bit of the fight they had as teenagers, just for fun, testing each other’s mettle. It hadn’t been that serious back then, just two kids playfighting. They’d never meant to hurt each other, and Mydei still doesn’t intend on hurting Phainon; but when words fail, throwing fists is the only other way he knows how to communicate.

Phainon gets a lucky hit, his fist ramming straight into Mydei’s eye socket. The blow makes him see stars, and his head spins as his vision goes blurry.

Mydei blinks through the pain, his eye watering and throbbing, nearly blinding him. His skull feels like it’s going to explode.

He staggers back, Mydei knows he doesn’t have much fight left in him, which doesn’t make any sense because he usually has way more stamina than this.

He blames the drinks, he really does.

No, actually, he blames something else.

Mydei eyes Phainon’s glasses, still hanging on stubbornly on his face, even though they’re a little askewed. Those stupid glasses had been the start of every problem he’s faced this evening. If Phainon hadn’t worn them, perhaps Mydei could have kept on pretending that everything was fine.

They needed to fucking go.

He reaches out his hand to make a grab for the glasses, Phainon, thinking he’s aiming for another punch, dodges out of the way. Mydei manages to twist his finger around the edge of the frames, ripping them off his stupid handsome face and snapping the thin metal in his closed fist.

Then, he flings the remains of the cheap glasses onto the floor.

There, that should do it. Phainon has terrible vision without them, which is bound to be disadvantageous in battle.

Mydei makes a move to tackle him to the ground, securing a decisive victory for himself. Except that he’s caught off guard as Phainon sees him coming, intercepting and flipping their positions without even a second thought.

For a moment, Mydei sees nothing but the night sky as he’s flung over, his back hitting the pavement with a thud. And then it’s nothing but blue, as blue as a clear sky on a summer morning.

Phainon leans over him, pinning his arms behind his back so he can’t move further. Mydei twists and turns to no avail, Phainon is strong. His body

weight settles on top of Mydei, thick thighs straddling his hips, locking him in place.

Mydei is completely speechless with surprise, all he can do is blink. His shock must have been obvious because Phainon smirks and remarks.

“Are you surprised?”

He is. When did a mere model learn to fight so viciously? Especially with his vision impaired.

“I didn’t tell you, but I don’t need glasses anymore.” Phainon says. “I got laser surgery on my eyes as soon as I graduated from high school. My agency paid for it, they said my eyes were my best feature, and I shouldn’t cover them up.”

For some reason, this revelation hits him hard. The hole in his chest deepens, like it’s being carved out of him with a knife. Yet another imperfection that had been fixed for Phainon—his bad eyesight, the need to wear glasses. Another change that made him untouchable, unrecognizable to Mydei. The distance between them grows even further.

“Then… Why did you wear them?” Mydei asks, feeling himself withdraw, walls coming back up.

Phainon, as though sensing his hesitation, presses himself further down into Mydei, into his personal space. “I wore them for you, I thought you might like them.”

His eyes are crystal blue, and the way they are gazing at Mydei, taking up the entirety of his field of vision, seems like he wants to make sure Mydei is seeing nothing else but him.

Mydei stops struggling, limbs growing weak. He’s paying for his overindulgence on alcohol now, the way he feels sleepy, dizzy, and woozy all at once. He doesn’t have the energy to fight or argue anymore, let alone make sense of the enigma that is Phainon.

“There is something wrong with you,” he manages to utter. The tiny hope grows like a flame, terrifying him because this only seems to lend credence to Phainon’s claims Mydei has never left his thoughts, not throughout all these years.

“It… it wasn’t just the glasses I liked.” Mydei confesses, voice as soft as a murmur.

“Mydei…” Phainon whispers, soft and reverent. His cheekbone is swollen and red, blood caking from a cut on his forehead where Mydei’s nails grazed against it. And Mydei can’t help but think that he’s never looked hotter. He swallows his growing desire and breaks eye contact because he needs to stay in control.

If he dwells on their compromising positions any more, or the fact that he can feel Phainon’s cock pressed against him, he’s going to want more.

“Don’t… don’t call my name like that,” he chokes. “Get off me.” He doesn’t mean it. Mydei’s body wants him so badly that it hurts. But what’s left of his sober mind knows that this isn’t a good idea. That the problems that plagued their previous relationship weren’t so easily overcome. While Mydei is still working his way up, Phainon is still so very far ahead of him, his star hung too high in the sky to grab.

Phainon sighs, his expression softening as he looks down at Mydei. His hands move to cradle the back of his head like he’s something precious. It looks like he’s read Mydei like an open book, but is letting him keep some of his dignity for now.

“As you wish,” He says, voice impossibly fond.

True to his word, Phainon gets off him, Mydei sighs in relief as the weight pinning him down finally lifts. But Phainon still hovers too closely for comfort as Mydei pulls himself up, a hand on the small of his back, his body so close they’re almost touching. A subtle reminder of his presence, a warning that if Mydei tries to run, he will take him down again at any time.

“You look unwell,” Phainon gently brushes his knuckles against Mydei’s temple, slick with sweat. He winces in pain as it brushes across a graze. Well, he’s not feeling his best, he did just get his ass handed to him in a shameful display.

“I just want to go home and rest,” Mydei murmurs. Phainon steps into his personal space far too comfortably despite the years they’ve spent apart. He slips his arm around Mydei’s shoulders to support him like he weighs nothing, and eases him down on a nearby bench to rest.

“Let me call a cab to take you home.” Phainon offers, taking a seat next to him. He’s still close, so close that Mydei can feel his body heat. Phainon’s arm curls around Mydei as he pulls him closer to his chest, holding him possessively, almost lovingly.

“This… this is unnecessary.” Mydei protests, trying to push himself away to no avail as Phainon’s arm only tightens around him. He’s too drained to put up any sort of fight.

Phainon just laughs, not the sneering, condescending laugh from before, but something cheerful, light, like all his burdens had been lifted. “Then just think of it like you’re doing me a favour. You’ll allow me this much, right? For old times sake.”

His fingers slide into Mydei’s hair, undoing his tangled ponytail and gently threading through the soft golden strands. Mydei has to hold back a pleased hum from the back of his throat from how nice it feels. Despite the chilly weather his hand is warm, the way he strokes Mydei’s hair is so gentle, and the slow rise and fall of his chest as he breathes is nice, relaxing.

“Let me take care of you, please.” Phainon murmurs, and it works like a charm, with Mydei’s eyes fluttering closed as a wave of exhaustion overtakes him.

Mydei doesn’t know how things have come to this, with Phainon cuddling him like he’s a doting boyfriend rather than an estranged ex. But Mydei would be lying if he said this wasn’t something he had been dreaming of for a long time. To be held in Phainon’s arms again, for Phainon to pamper

him, whisper sweet words in his ear, to treat Mydei like he was the most important person in the world, the only person that matters.

It’s more than he can wish for.

There is still a lot that Mydei doesn’t understand, and he doesn’t know how long this strange, possessive, loving version of Phainon will even last. But would it be so bad if he took advantage of this? Just for a little while.

“Just close your eyes and get some rest,” Mydei’s brow furrows slightly as he feels fingers gently push his bangs aside, and a soft kiss, light as butterfly wings, lands on the center of his forehead. “Our cab will arrive soon.”

…

‘Our’ cab?

Mydei frowns a little bit at the phrase, but the feeling of Phainon running his fingers through his hair is just too relaxing, and Mydei starts to feel the knot in his chest unravel. He missed this, he missed being close to Phainon so much that it hurts. He’d assumed their breakup was permanent, that he’d never get to be held in Phainon’s arms like this again. Just this tonight already seemed too good to be true, like he’d wake up hungover tomorrow and realize that it was all just a dream.

He sighs lightly, feeling Phainon pull him impossibly closer as his steady heartbeat thumps softly underneath his sweater. Mydei listens to the rhythmic beating, letting himself drift off a little bit as he practically melts against Phainon.

“You look so beautiful like this, Mydei, all cuddled up next to me.” Phainon murmurs, running his fingers down his braid, tucking the ends of his red-tipped hair behind his ears. “You’re going to make me greedy, you know.”

Mydei’s relaxed expression doesn’t move, his breathing deep and even indicating he’s fallen asleep. Phainon doesn’t even know if he can hear him.

The events that come after are a drunken blur to Mydei, partially passed out from exhaustion on Phainon's shoulder. He remembers Phainon gently walking him into a cab, giving him sweet encouragement as he does so. He remembers Phainon's arm around his waist, warm, protective, affectionate throughout the entire car ride. He remembers hearing Phainon's voice as he made small talk with the cab driver.

"Oh, we're alright. He just walked into a lamp pole and took me down with him, he's a bit of a lightweight!"

Mydei had a bone to pick with that, he would never get hurt in such a stupid way like walking into a lamp pole. He got that injury in battle, against a worthy opponent, like Kremnoan traditions dictated. But what comes out of his mouth instead is a pathetic, half-asleep grumble.

"Haha, I guess he didn't like me calling him a lightweight."

"He's lucky he's got a nice young man like you looking out for him."

"Of course, he's the most important person to me." With the way Phainon's arm tightens around his waist as he says that, Mydei could almost believe that he means it.

Mydei wakes with a start when the cab jerks to a stop. The sudden inertia causes him to lurch forward, and then backwards again. He grits his teeth, preparing himself for the impact of hitting the seat, only to feel Phainon's palm cushioning the back of his head.

"Mydei, we're here. Can you walk?" Phainon asks, in a voice so sweet and gentle that Mydei had to look around to check that he was referring to him.

Mydei nods, his body is fighting to go back to sleep, but he insists on walking out of the cab on his own, stubborn to a fault. It occurs to him, as he steps outside the car, that he had never told Phainon his address. But Phainon had spoken as though he knew exactly where to take him.

This doesn't look like the apartment he shares with Castorice and Cipher, no, this high rise condominium is much too extravagant for anything they

can afford.

Behind him, he hears the remnants of a conversation between Phainon and the cab driver.

“Young man, if you don’t mind me asking, are you that model—”

“Mister,” Phainon interrupts, tone strained. “Here’s a tip as thanks. And… I would appreciate it if you would keep tonight between us.”

The cab driver pauses. “Well,” he says, “It’s not my business to pry into young people’s private matters.” Followed by the screech of tires as the taxi drives away.

“Where are we?” Mydei turns around, mouth thinned out into a grim line. He knows the answer already, but wants to hear it confirmed from Phainon’s own mouth.

“I did say I was taking you home,” Phainon says, expression a little sheepish as though he knows what he’s done. “My home, I meant.”

Mydei’s frown deepens, he’s feeling better, more sober, more like himself after the brief nap in the car. He’s now clear headed enough to realize the implications of Phainon bringing him here.

“I can’t do this,” he says bitterly.

Phainon blinks at him, all wide eyed innocence. “What are you talking about?”

Mydei rubs the bridge of his nose, does Phainon really take him for a fool? Well, he’s done himself no favours, considering he’s been acting like one all evening.

“Is this how you get all those one-night-stands? You sweet talk them and get all handsy until they come home with you? You're gonna try that on me too, huh?”

Phainon gapes, mouth opening and closing like a fish out of water. It's almost funny to see if Mydei's heart wasn't breaking all over again.

"If all you're offering is sex, then I don't want it." The back of his eyelids are stinging, and Mydei feels himself tearing up. It makes his injured eye burn even more. "I'm not someone you can just fuck and abandon."

Mydei closes his eyes for a beat longer than necessary, hoping it comes across as exasperation and not like he's upset or anything.

Because why would he be upset? They're nothing to each other currently, and everything Phainon was doing could be attributed to seeking closure or even tying up loose ends. He knows, *he knows*.

"What the fuck?" Phainon splutters, finding his tongue. His swearing catches Mydei off guard and he blinks in surprise, not expecting such foul language from Okhema's golden boy. "No! That was never my intention. I wanted to take you home to look after you while you sober out! You were *never* going to be a one-night-stand."

Mydei's vision blurs over, the world turning hazy before his eyes. He had not cried since the breakup, not even a single tear, today will not be the day he breaks that streak. Even though he never wanted to be a one-night-stand, it still hurts like hell to hear Phainon reject it. Because of course, what kind of insane person would consider bringing their ex home for sex? It certainly seems crazy to him.

"Then thanks for your offer, but I'll be fine." Mydei tells him, feeling his emotions stabilize as the hope in him flickers and dies. "I'll just call Cipher and wait here until she picks me up. I don't need your sympathy or your generosity."

Speaking of which, he hadn't even managed to check his phone since the last time. He wonders if Castorice and Cipher are going crazy with worry, bombarding his phone with texts and calls. He's a bit annoyed at them, but he never meant to stress them out.

“Mydei,” Phainon places an arm on his shoulder, which Mydei shrugs off. He can’t believe he let Phainon touch him so freely before, he must really be out of his mind. “You’re in no condition to be alone.”

Mydei glares at him, feeling the first drop of rain fall on the top of his head, cold and annoying at the same time. “I won’t be alone,” he says stubbornly. “I have my friends to look after me.”

“And where are they now?” Phainon asks him flatly. “Your friends ditched you in the bar with a stranger, Mydei.”

Mydei blinks, the raindrops are coming faster now, getting into his eyes and into his shirt. “Quit pissing me off. Nobody ever died from being lonely, or else I’d have died a thousand times already.

Phainon’s breath hitches, and he recoils as though he’s been hit. His eyes are shiny as he looks at Mydei, something wet trails out of the corner of his eye as he blinks. Mydei tells himself it’s only rainwater, because the alternative makes his heart ache.

“...you were lonely?” Phainon asks him softly.

Mydei swallows, feeling like he’s revealed too much. It must seem awfully spoiled and contrite of him to declare himself lonely, especially when he’s got two loving parents who are still alive, relatives who dote on him and a healthy friendship circle in both Castrum Kremnos and Okhema.

But leaving Phainon had felt like ripping out a piece of himself, a hole that he never managed to patch up. To have and to lose him was worse than never having him at all. It taught him that no matter how close you were to someone, it was only temporary.

Everything could change in an instant.

“I didn’t know what loneliness was until you changed, and I couldn’t even recognize you anymore.”

Phainon's expression twists, his fringe is flattened on his forehead from the rain, water rolling down his cheeks, and his eyes are red as he raises his voice and yells. "I changed because I thought that I could help you!" His voice cracks. "Then I became so caught up with everyone's approval, into becoming the kind of person I thought everyone would want, until I didn't even know who I was anymore."

Mydei frowns, completely speechless. He just cannot understand his way of thinking at all. Throughout his life, Mydei had grown up around people who encouraged and supported his self-expression; he had always been at odds with the rest of the world but… it never seemed to matter. Even when he entered adulthood, he met like-minded souls like Castorice and Cipher who seemed to swim against the current.

But just because he didn't understand doesn't mean he didn't *want* to understand. Listening to Phainon was something he should have done years ago, but he had been too young and stupid to, convinced that cutting off the relationship was the best thing to do.

"I devoted myself into becoming a perfect person that would make you proud, someone who could please everyone." He laughs bitterly. "Then I lost you, and it just seemed… so meaningless. The sacrifices were utterly pointless if I couldn't even keep the person most important to me. I didn't know what else to do, so I just… kept on pretending. At some point I stopped thinking about what I really wanted, or what kind of person I really am."

His admission only makes Mydei feel sad, empty. He doesn't understand why Phainon would put himself through that. The chasm of their different ideologies stretches before them, uncrossable.

"I just don't understand why you thought that was something I'd want," Mydei grits out. He can't help but be honest, even if it hurts, even if the pained whimper that comes out of Phainon's mouth stabs him like a knife. "You knew what my principles were, what kind of person I am."

"Of course you wouldn't understand," Phainon laughs, brittle and bitter. "You were already effortlessly cool without even trying. What would you

ever know about changing yourself to be wanted? I didn't have the self-assuredness that you had, the security net you had. I didn't have the privilege of moving to a whole different country if I failed!"

There were no blows exchanged this time, but Mydei flinches like he's been hit nonetheless. He knows he was lucky, he knows he was born privileged, and he has no doubt his upbringing had shaped him as a person.

"This is why we went our separate ways." Mydei only says softly. "You and I didn't see eye to eye, we still don't."

"Mm, I guess not." Phainon agrees, his expression is subdued, his eyes are dimmed. He looks like Mydei had sucked every ounce of joy and whimsy out of him.

It's a horrible, painful sight to see, and if anything, it only makes Mydei more certain that his decision to walk away was the right one. He hated that he was the one who made Phainon look like that.

"I'm sorry-" Mydei says.

He's a hypocrite, he knows. Mydei is stuck in a cycle of tormenting himself and doesn't know how to get out of it. How many times now had he told himself that he was going to move on from Phainon? That he was going to unfollow all of his social media pages and delete his accounts. That he was going to focus on his studies, his career, or his music. That obsessing over his ex is pathetic.

Mydei had always been good at restraining himself for the greater good. There are things he wants that are not good to have. Milk and cheese in his pomegranate juice, honeycakes drowned in strawberry syrup, and Phainon.

~*~

Phainon's heart sinks when he sees Mydei make that face.

It features prominently in his nightmares.

All these years and he still makes the same fucking expression. Eyebrows tightly furrowed, jaw set, mouth in a straight line, a determination in his golden eyes that indicates that he's already made up his mind.

And Phainon is 17 again, standing in a stifling park at the tail-end of autumn. Just the two of them standing side by side, but feeling like they're miles away. Phainon was so stupid then, so naive, not understanding how the subsequent events would change his life forever. And Mydei, with that same self-righteous expression on his face because he thinks he's doing the right thing.

History repeats itself, and if Phainon doesn't do something to stop him now, Mydei is going to leave him again.

Thorns are crawling up his throat, there's blood in his mouth. His chest feels too tight, his ribcage clenching around a heart that is battering at its restraints. Adrenaline floods his body, telling him that he's going to die if he doesn't move, doesn't do *something* to stop this from happening!

He's gone through it before, the hollowness of knowing that someone he loved was out of his reach. Years of surviving from scraps, looking from afar, getting updates through stalking and social media. Not being able to do anything but watch as Mydei moves on with his life, spends time with other people, smiles at someone else.

The idea that Mydei will one day find love with someone who isn't Phainon makes bile rush up his throat.

And the worst part about it all was that he still had hopes for tonight. Still thought that if he could just get Mydei to stop and listen, if he was honest for once and tore himself open to show Mydei how he felt, that they could still have a chance.

He failed.

He ripped his raw, red, beating heart out of his chest and offered it up on a silver platter and Mydei still didn’t want it.

Something in him breaks.

Phainon has tried being nice, he’s tried being vulnerable, he’s tried appealing to reason. He really was trying to do things the easy way, but Mydei’s actions had left him with no other choice.

It’s Mydei’s fault for being so stubborn.

So be it, if Mydei tries to shut him out, he’ll kick the door down, hell, he’ll smash it to pieces if he needs to. If Mydei tries to walk away from him, Phainon will track him down and bring him back. Even death would not be able to separate them, because Phainon will follow him to the underworld and back.

If Mydei still doubts his resolve, then so be it.

“Sorry-” Mydei is saying to him. Phainon can almost read his lips as he opens them to utter ‘*We shouldn’t see each other again’*.

“No need to apologize.” Phainon says, bitterness seeping in every word. “When you’re not sorry.”

When he sees Mydei tilt his head in confusion, it means he’s taken the bait.

“You’re doing it again, you know,” Phainon continues. “Jumping to conclusions, making the decision all by yourself. Bold of you to lecture me when you haven’t changed a bit, making the same mistake as you did in our youth. You’re not even going to give this a chance?”

Mydei stills, and Phainon can practically see the gears in his head turning as he thinks it over “Say I humour you, that I throw the dog a bone,” Mydei says with a sneer. “What’s your suggestion then?”

Phainon points at the sky, which is pouring. “First, we get out of the rain. You come to my place to dry off, we’ll both get some much needed rest. No strings attached.”

Mydei eyes him warily.

“What? You don’t think I’ll actually be able to do anything without your consent.” Phainon raises his hands, putting on a reassuring smile.

“Relax. There’s security cameras all over the building. The door will be unlocked, you can leave at any time. And you still have your phone. I may have won our fight earlier, but we both know I can’t overpower you in strength.” Please, if he could, he wouldn’t need to bother with mind games.

Besides, it doesn’t take a master of observation to tell that Mydei is irritated and uncomfortable. His clothes are soaked, sticking closely to his body. He’s shivering slightly from the cold, even though he’s trying valiantly to hide it, and the bruises from their earlier fight must be painful.

Phainon’s apartment is spacious, comfortable, warm, and he can see Mydei actually contemplating the suggestion.

He’s on the hook, now Phainon just has to reel him in.

“And after that, if you still want to leave and go home. I won’t stop you. In fact, I’ll respect your wishes and leave you alone. Forever.” Phainon says.

He doesn’t want to do that, he doesn’t want that at all. He’s a determinator at heart, the kind of guy who would move mountains to get what he wants. But right now, he has no choice but to tell Mydei what he wants to hear.

Mydei is stubborn, but he is also painfully naive in the way where he thinks everybody is as honest as he is. Mydei lives in a world where promises are kept, and never broken. It appears nothing has changed in that regard.

He can see Mydei’s eyelashes quivering as he comes to a decision.

“I have your word?” He asks.

Phainon nods, hand on his heart. “I promise.” He says.

With that, Mydei seems to relax. He slumps forward slightly, letting down his guard enough for Phainon to see just how exhausted he is. “Then… fine,

just for a little while.”

Victory had never tasted so bitter.

Phainon feels guilt clawing at his throat for taking advantage of Mydei’s trust in him. But it’s not like he’s lying, Phainon fully intends to keep his word.

If Mydei still wants to leave later.

Phainon’s brought himself time to show him why they’re perfect for each other.

He heaves a deep, shuddering exhale, the cold wind chilling him to the bone. He’s won the battle, for now. However dirty it is, however unseemly, a victory is still a victory.

“Let’s go,” he says.

Chapter End Notes

> The song of the day is Blame Brett by The Beaches!
> Spotify playlist
>
> This one I guess is more of an expository chapter and imo there's some really good food coming up!
> I finally finalized the chapter count... it just kept getting longer and longer the more I write OTL
>
> Thank you thank you and a million thank yous to everyone who read/kudoed/left a comment it seriously gives me the motivation to continue I cannot emphasize this enough thank you SO MUCH!!! I'm sorry I'm slow to reply it's cuz I go back and read your comments to motivate me to write!

Chapter 5: Gasoline, Pretty Please

Chapter Summary

Yeah, it’s unmistakable, as much as Mydei tried to hide it. The undeniable lust and hunger reflected in those beautiful eyes. Phainon had assumed it was rejection, but what if it was restraint instead?

What if… Mydei wanted this as much as him?

It’s dangerous to be too delusional, but Phainon feels himself falling and he’s unable to stop.
He feels his entire body shaking as he swallows. “Haha, what’s with that face? You look like I’m about to jump you.”

He hears Mydei’s breath hitch, a tinge of pink staining his cheeks before he turns away again. He can’t make eye contact when he's embarrassed, just one of the qualities he finds so cute in Mydei.
“Do what you want.” He mutters.

Chapter Notes

Good heavens would you look at the time, it's time for more gay yearning.

Alright everyone here's your obligatory reminder to *taps the sign* mind the tags as it will be getting just a little bit freakier from this point on... just a little bit y'know.

I only managed to proofread this once during my lunch break so I'm so sorry if there's any spelling or grammar errors, if any exist I will quietly fix them in the future and hope nobody notices.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When he was a student at university, Phainon had a professor that many called insane. This valued teacher had taught him that the methods did not matter, as long as he obtained results. Sure, there were many among the faculty who greatly disliked Professor Anaxagoras for his…almost sacrilegious ways, but he had some good points. Sometimes, playing a little dirty is necessary to achieve one's goal.

Mydei looks a little uncomfortable entering Phainon's swanky, upscale, modern condominium building. When his wet shoes squelch and leave muddy footprints upon the freshly mopped marble floors he hunches over so deeply into his jacket that he looks like he wants to disappear in it.

But Phainon doesn't care, he pays his cleaning fees like everyone else. Instead, he just beams and waves cheerfully at the doorman as they walk in so that he does not pay Mydei too much scrutiny as they head deeper towards the elevators.

"Don't look at him," he leans close and whispers into Mydei's ear, feeling a slight shiver as he does so. "Just look at me."

"You're too close," Mydei complains. When he turns his head, a wet strand of hair brushes against Phainon's cheek, so distracting it's driving him mad.

"I already told you I'd stay, you don't need to be so clingy."

Reluctantly, Phainon takes a single step back like it's the hardest thing in the world. Casual as anything, he keeps two of his fingers in Mydei's belt loops like a lifeline, just because he wants to touch him somewhere to know he's still there.

He can feel Mydei's skin, warm underneath the fabric and almost shivers at how close they are.

If Mydei didn't like it, he'd push him away, say something.

Mydei's silence is consent.

The wait for the elevators is excruciating. Now that Phainon's standing so close to him, he can faintly smell the floral perfume that Mydei's using. It's barely there, but it's still intoxicating. Hungry for more, Phainon subtly moves his face closer to the back of his neck, slowly inhaling the mixture of fading perfume, rainwater, and the man's natural scent.

He commits everything to memory, the feel of Mydei's warm skin, his smell, the way his chest heaves as he inhales in and out. He never wants to forget this moment.

The elevator dings, and Phainon guides Mydei gently inside, barely registering pushing the button for his floor before the doors close with a light click. That is when Phainon lets go of his grip, giving Mydei space.

As much 'space' as is allowed anyway in this cramped elevator. Even if they both stood on the opposite ends of the elevator that would still be… really close. Phainon feels it in him, the instinct to pounce on Mydei, to pull him closer… even closer to the point where he can't run away.

He wants to do that so badly, but he had promised Mydei, no ulterior motives, just to shower, sober up, and rest.

Mydei leans against the wall as the elevator begins its ascent, rocking slightly against the movement. He doesn't say a single word, just lifting his gaze to look at Phainon with an expression he can't read.

The wall he's leaning against is a mirror, and Phainon doesn't even recognize the person reflected in it. Somewhere in the back of his mind, he knows it's himself, caught at his most primal, at his worst. His eyes are darkened and bloodshot, pupils dilated until there is nothing left but a thin blue ring around the edges; his carefully styled hair is in complete disarray; and his expression looks insane.

It's perhaps the most honest reflection of himself in a long time. Is this the version Mydei is seeing now? He's selfish though, so selfish that even if this side of him disgusts Mydei, he doesn't care.

Phainon tears his eyes away from that hateful person in the mirror. He doesn't need to look at that, not when a god is standing before him.

Mydei's jaw tightens, he's clenching his teeth so hard Phainon can see the tendons on his neck protruding. He turns away, expression impossible to read as always. But not before Phainon gets a glimpse of it, the look in his eyes that makes his throat go dry and heat rush to his abdomen. It was so brief, but he'd seen it for sure, a look in his golden eyes that is a reflection of the same darkness and desire in Phainon's own. .

"Mydeimos…" He whispers, carefully brushing his tattooed cheek with the softest touch. "Look at me, please."

When Mydei refuses to turn around, Phainon takes hold of his chin a little roughly, turning his face towards him.

Yeah, it's unmistakable, as much as Mydei tried to hide it. The undeniable lust and hunger reflected in those beautiful eyes.

Phainon had assumed it was rejection, but what if it was restraint instead?

What if… Mydei wanted this as much as him?

It's dangerous to be too delusional, but Phainon feels himself falling and he's unable to stop.

He feels his entire body shaking as he swallows. "Haha, what's with that face? You look like I'm about to jump you."

He hears Mydei's breath hitch, a tinge of pink staining his cheeks before he turns away again. He can't make eye contact when he's embarrassed, just one of the qualities he finds so cute in Mydei.

"Do what you want." He mutters.

A dangerous offer to put on the table. Mydei has no idea just how badly Phainon has yearned for this. He has no idea that Phainon has jacked off to him for years, religiously, faithfully. How everyone he tries to take to the bedroom needs to have a combination of blonde hair, tattoos, or a muscular

body that can rival the gods. Nothing and nobody else comes close to making him hard. Even then, his cock turns flaccid so quickly when his brain finally catches up to his body and he realizes that no matter how he pretends otherwise, they're not Mydei, and they could never be Mydei.

Mydei has no idea how his fantasies have only gotten more perverted and obscene from years of being pent up. How many times he has thrusted his cock into his lonely fist as he watches a video of Mydei singing on his phone, how many times he's touched himself to pictures of him taken off the street like a fucking creep.

He really can't. If Mydei gives him an inch, he'll take a mile. Before he knows it, he won't be able to stop himself. The beast, once released, can't be put back into the cage. He'll eat him up, he'll leave no scraps.

This… this will have to do.

Phainon leans closer, enough for Mydei to feel the warmth of his exhale, to see the sweat beading on his temples even though the weather is cold. Their scents mingle in the narrow space between them. Mydei with his soft florals, a complete contrast to his appearance; Phainon with his clean and woody perfume, the one he had promoted once and got so many compliments on he just… kept wearing it ever since.

"Don't tease me." Phainon murmurs, low and shaky. He doesn't say more, he can't. He shoves his hands in the pockets of his coat, they're damp and cold and kind of disgusting but he squeezes the fabric with his fists. It's the only way he can stop himself from touching the beautiful man in front of him.

Is it his imagination, or is Mydei closer to him than he was before? Why is his pelvis thrust out in such a suggestive way or is Phainon reading too deeply into it? Is it an invitation, the way Mydei is baring his long, smooth neck out to him, or is he just overthinking?

The jut of his red tattoos stand out starkly against his sunkissed skin, the lines running brash and bold, the flame-like design creeping up his neck.

Phainon imagines his tongue tracing along the lines of those tattoos. They hadn't been there when he was a teenager, but it looked so natural on him that Phainon could almost assume that he'd been born with those tattoos, that they were a part of his skin. He had said so before, that he thought Mydei would look good with them. Good is an understatement, he's fucking irresistable.

He closes his eyes and tries to channel all the people in the world who do not want to jump Mydei as soon as they're alone together. How does everyone else do it? It seems totally impossible.

He's breathing so heavily, it's embarrassing. He probably sounds like a perverted freak, but he can't help that it feels so stuffy in this elevator. He tugs at the neck of his turtleneck, lowkey regretting that he chose this outfit even though it makes his body look amazing. It feels like he's suffocating in here. Nobody is speaking, so all he can hear is his own breathing. Maybe his friends were right when they called him a dog, he'd be a dog for Mydei, he'd get down on all fours and bark if that was what he wanted.

The black collared shirt is soaked with rainwater, sticking tightly to the curvature of his muscles. Mydei's pecs move along to the rhythm of his breathing, in… and out…

In… and out…

His nipples are stiff from the cold, and are sticking out through the fabric of his shirt…

Phainon is about to lose his shit.

"HKS." Mydei's voice pulls him out of it as he helplessly drags his eyes to his face, ashamed at being caught staring. "I'm not the one teasing."

And is it him but is Mydei's face so much closer now? If Phainon just shifts his head a little bit their lips would touch in a kiss.

Phainon panics, taking several steps back until he's at the other side of the elevator. "S-sorry!" He apologizes, turning around to face the elevator

doors. He can’t believe he almost broke composure and kissed Mydei. This is dangerous, too dangerous.

And isn’t this the slowest elevator ride ever? It’s a high speed elevator… but the numbers are going up at a snail’s pace, it’s torture.

36…

37…

38…

Why does his penthouse have to be so high up?

He hears Mydei sigh, followed by the sound of wet fabric squelching as he shifts. Phainon can almost imagine it, Mydei, with that annoyed look on his face, crossing his arms, pushing those breasts closer together, perhaps he’s even pouting. Argh! This isn’t helping at all, he screws his eyes even tighter and tries to think of things that will reverse—or at least slow down the raging erection in his pants.

‘Wet socks, overgrown toenails, the time I accidentally called Aglaea ‘mom’. The time I forgot to throw out the takeout in the fridge and it grew mold. Lycurgus my accountant, FUCK Lycurgus, I hate that guy, I swear he’s stealing money from me but I just don’t know how. I need to fire him but he’s the only guy who knows how to file my taxes…’

The elevator arrives with a ding and Phainon practically stumbles out, gasping for air.

Mydei is looking at him with a carefully neutral expression, though Phainon can tell when he’s confused—and he’s very confused. Still, Mydei inclines his head to tell Phainon to lead the way.

“Well?” He starts. “It’s your house, isn’t it?”

“Right,” Phainon says, taking the lead awkwardly. It still feels totally surreal, to be leading Mydei back to his house. He really meant it when he said he just wanted to look after Mydei and… and try to salvage whatever

relationship he can with him. He can't ruin that all by sleeping with him. That would be confirming his worst fears, Mydei is going to think he's nothing but a stupid playboy with a dick for a brain.

Phainon freezes in front of his front door, partially because of the revelation and also because he's suddenly feeling anxious about a lot of meaningless things. Things like… whether he remembered to vacuum the apartment, or when was the last time he scrubbed the toilets? Did he remember to throw out yesterday's takeout?

It's probably a little too late to think about those concerns now, since they're already here.

"What are we standing around for?" Mydei taps one foot on the ground impatiently as he regards Phainon with an unimpressed expression. "Getting cold feet?"

Cold feet? As if! Phainon would sooner let himself die than fumble this.

"Haha, of course not!" Phainon says, feeling himself respond with a bravado that he doesn't possess as the digital lock responds to his fingerprint with a beep. "I'm just nervous."

"You?" Mydei raises a singular eyebrow, looking at him up and down. "Nervous? Why?"

"I just… never had visitors over before."

"Really?" Mydei still looks unconvinced. "What about your other lovers? You expect me to believe you go around looking like…" Mydei's sentence trails off, but he gestures at him vaguely. "And you never got laid?"

"Looking like what?" Phainon says slyly, not being able to resist fishing for compliments.

"Why do I need to butter you up?" Mydei deadpans. "You're hot, obviously. You're gorgeous. You don't need me to tell you that."

Phainon shorts circuits. "Oh."

He asked for it, but wow, Phainon wasn't ready to deal with the consequences. It's not like he hadn't been told these things in the past, but being complimented so directly by the most gorgeous man alive makes all the air leave his lungs.

"You… you can't say these things." Phainon wheezes. He wonders if Mydei had ever spoken like this to anyone else. It would be impossible not to fall in love with the man, not to be totally head over heels for him.

"Then why did you ask?"

Yeah… yeah… he deserved that. Phainon just barely manages to push his own door open with shaking limbs as he says. "Whenever I try to have other partners…" the key word here being 'try' "I take them to a hotel."

He didn't like other people knowing where he lived, he didn't like other people to have a glimpse into his personal life. Hotels were easy, the decor was impersonal, and most importantly, he could leave whenever he wanted.

Upon hearing that Mydei looked like he'd bitten into a particularly sour lemon.

"Hmph." He huffs without any follow up questions as he steps inside the house.

Phainon takes a deep breath before following closely behind. He's taking the love of his life into his home, the love of his life who, conveniently, also looks like a sex god. Phainon hopes he can survive the night with his sanity intact.

~*~

Phainon is drunk.

He's drunk and he's making strange decisions.

Nevermind that Mydei didn’t smell any alcohol when Phainon leaned close to him, that his footsteps were as straight and steady as ever, that while all his friends were drinking, he hadn’t seen Phainon consume a drop of alcohol.

That is the only reasonable explanation for his odd behavior tonight.

Mydei doesn’t know what he expected from Phainon’s home. Something minimalist, clean with tasteful, expensive decor, complete with fancy paintings on the walls. A home that came straight out of an interior design magazine.

Well, it’s a little bit like that, sort of. The renovation and furniture looks expensive, but it has a homey, lived-in feel, full of the personality of a young man in his 20s. There are posters on the walls not of photo shoots or magazine spreads, but of video games. His TV is surrounded by consoles of various shapes and sizes from different eras of gaming, and video game memorabilia litter his shelves.

As Mydei hangs his rain-soaked leather jacket on the coat rack, he notices the most horrendous looking yellow hoodie next to it.

He snorts. It’s so ugly but… seeing it makes him happy.

It feels like the Phainon he loves is not completely lost to him yet.

“This is my home!” Phainon introduces rather awkwardly. He hangs his own coat up to dry and Mydei tries hard not to feast his eyes on the way his turtleneck clings to his body, highlighting his sculpted muscles and amazing arms.

“I recognize this…” Mydei murmurs, brushing his fingers across a particularly large poster on the wall. The characters depicted in it, alongside their fantastical outfits, are familiar to him.

Phainon puffs up his chest excitedly, like he had been waiting for someone to ask. “It’s—”

“Amphoreus Saga of Heroes, I know.” Mydei finishes his sentence. It’s the same game Phainon used to play all the time in school, the one they’d take turns playing because he sucked at it (Not that Mydei was any better). “They’re on the 7th volume now ‘As Tomorrow Became Yesterday’. Have you played it?”

“Yeah, but I’m partial to the 4th one ‘For the Sun is Set to Die’. That was the one we used to play together, do you remember?”

“We only played it daily, why wouldn’t I remember?” Mydei scoffs. “Although it was an RPG, you’d always play as the swordsmaster NeiKos.” Mydei had called him boring at the time, always picking the hero. “Come to think of it, he reminded me of you a lot, selfless to the point of ruin.”

“And I remember yours too,” Phainon says cheerfully. “You always chose PoleMos, the undying war god. And then you ironically died a lot because you never quite got the hang of his HP draining mechanics.”

Mydei huffs in laughter, despite himself. Man, that really takes him back.

His eyes sweep across the shelves nested to the sides and top of the television. They’re crowded, decorated with colourful figurines of various video game characters striking dynamic, action poses. They are clean and meticulously displayed, some of the more expensive looking ones surrounded by protective casings and LED lights. The owner obviously took good care of his collection.

“Figurines?” Mydei asks, lip curling up in amusement.

“I prefer to call them ‘collectibles’,” Phainon answers. “In a few years time you could call them antiques, even.”

Mydei scoffs. “Sure. ‘Antiques’.”

He moves on, eyes roving to Phainon’s collection of video game consoles and games, all arranged neatly in front of his television. Of course he has the entire ‘Amphoreus Saga of Heroes’ collection, from volumes 1 to 7, remastered limited editions, naturally.

He can’t help but feel himself thawing, walls lowering just slightly. Maybe this was still the same Phainon deep down, after all the pomp had been stripped away.

“So… what do you think of my house?” Phainon asks nervously. “You can see why I don’t bring people over… this stuff is kind of personal. I don’t want other people to know this side of me.”

Only you. Phainon doesn’t say it out loud, but Mydei can sense his meaning when he looks into those puppy eyes.

Mydei replies with fondness in his voice “Still the same nerdy interests. But now with more money than you know what to do with.”

The side of Phainon’s lip twitches, looking like he wants to smile. His hand shifts like he wants to reach out to Mydei, but he stops himself before he can actually do so. “See… told you I’m still the same Phainon you loved. I… I could be that for you again.”

And just like that, he crashes back to reality. Mydei thinks back to everything he’s said, and knows that despite appearances, this is a very different man from the one he knows.

Mydei isn’t really opposed to getting to know Phainon all over again. Despite everything he still really enjoys Phainon’s company, in all his years, nobody challenges him and infuriates him in equal measure.

He likes Phainon when he puts up a fight, likes it when he’s being belligerent, when he pushes Mydei buttons on purpose to get a rise out of him. Likes the petty back-and-forth, competing about everything, and the feeling of wanting to one-up another person.

And he likes what he sees too.

Mydei’s eyes trail back to Phainon, down the tight lines of his abs, his narrow waist. How the tight slacks outline his muscular hips and thighs so well. How his hair is lying damp against his temples, stickling to the

curvature of his sharp jaw, how lewd he looks just standing there in a skintight turtleneck.

Not like Mydei's faring much better.

He'd been doing his best to ignore it before, the way Phainon's looks at him with thinly veiled lust in his eyes. When Phainon drags his eyes from Mydei's scandalously opened collar down to the way his damp shirt clings to his chest, lingering where he knows his nipples are visible through the thin fabric. The intensity of his gaze sends heat pooling through his abdomen.

He said he wasn't coming for sex, that he didn't want to be a one night stand. But when Phainon looks at him like that, he's starting to have second thoughts, his carefully wound restraint coming undone.

He's not oblivious, and he knows they're both attracted to each other. Mydei is a man with needs and desires too.

Mydei runs his tongue over his lips absent mindedly as he stares at Phainon, not even realizing that he's doing it.

Maybe sleeping with his ex wasn't such a bad idea…

Just as he's contemplating the idea, Mydei barely registers Phainon moving and throwing something at him, seemingly in a panic. Thankfully, with his quick reflexes, Mydei catches it.

"..." He has nothing but questions as he looks down at the ugliest neon yellow hoodie known to man, now nestled in his hands.

"We're… we're soaking wet, ahahaha!" Phainon cuts in, too sharp and too loud, punctuated with an awkward laugh that is jarring in contrast to the previous silence. "You must be cold, put this on."

"I'm fine," Mydei says. He does feel a slight chill, but he can take much worse than this. Besides, Mydei doesn't think anything is worth putting on this ugly hoodie…

“I don’t want you to catch a cold.” Phainon exclaims. “Let me prepare the bathroom and find you something dry to change into.”

Phainon pads off, leaving Mydei alone and unattended in his living room. He’s not really in the business of snooping, so he gently puts the hoodie aside—even though it’s ugly he doesn’t want to dirty it—and busies himself by looking through Phainon’s collection of video games.

He feels the vibration in his pocket before he hears the ringtone, and guilt floods through him when he realizes it’s Cipher calling. That’s right, he left them on read, again. He’d been vaguely aware throughout the evening of his phone ringing a couple of times, but had been too distracted with other matters to answer.

He’d just picked up the call when her worried voice comes through the receiver.

“FINALLY!” She screams. “Do you have any idea how worried we were? Don’t EVER ignore our calls again!”

Mydei flinches, mostly because he knows he’s at fault. It’s not like he was intentionally ignoring his phone, it was just… something always came up.

“I’m fine, sorry to worry the both of you.”

“Where are you? We tried going back to the bar to look for you but… the bartender said you left with a white-haired guy. Mydei… you’re with Phainon right now, aren’t you?”

Mydei cringes, because she’s right on the money. “I’m at his house, actually.”

He didn’t want to lie, but that knowledge only seemed to freak her out even more.

“What? Text me your address and I’ll come pick you up right now!”

“Don’t. It’s late and it’ll be dangerous for you. Everything’s fine, listen, I can’t talk right now, I’ll explain everything tomorrow.” He can hear

Phainon moving around in the other room, and given the rather concerning behaviour he had displayed all evening, Mydei wasn't confident he'd react well if he knew that Cipher was trying to get him to leave.

"HAH? No, you listen to me! You need to get out of there right now, and I'm not joking. There's something seriously wrong with that Khaslana boy, and I should have listened to my instincts when he gave me the heebie jeebies–"

"Who are you talking to?" Mydei almost jumps into the air when Phainon comes up behind him, the smell of clean laundry invading his nose. He hadn't even heard him return, he was so quiet.

"Cipher, I got to go. I'll talk to you later." He hastily says.

"HUH? Mydei you better not be hanging up on me—" Is the last thing he hears before hanging up on her. She was speaking loud enough to break the sound barrier. He wondered how much of it Phainon had heard.

"Your friend?" Phainon asks, laying his chin on Mydei's shoulder. Mydei subconsciously angles his phone away so he doesn't see the screen.

"She's just a little worried…" Mydei says. "It's fine." He made her so mad, he'll probably wake up to dead cockroaches snuck under his pillows for weeks.

Phainon steps into his view, brows furrowed.

"Okay… anyway, you can borrow some of my clothes. And I've prepared the bath tub, take your time. Oh, I have a selection of bath salts, some are fruit scented. I think you'll love them."

"Oh," Mydei says as he's ushered towards the bathroom without preamble. A nice, hot, strawberry scented bath sounded like paradise after the night he just had.

Mydei didn't ever think he'd be the kind of guy who enjoys bubble baths, after all, it's neither a Kremnoan nor manly trait. As a teenager he'd be

perfectly content with military showers. The purpose of bathing was only to be clean, anything beyond that is over indulgence.

It's not until his friend Hyacine convinced him to give them a try, to just soak in the warm waters and relax his body and mind, that Mydei became a convert.

Which raises a question… how does Phainon know all these things about him?

The thought gnaws at him as he undresses and sinks into the waters of the bathtub.

It's warm, soothing, and despite his initial discomfort, Mydei feels his muscles relaxing, unwinding from the tension. Even the sting from his bruises are being soothed by the warm waters. There is a small cut on his knuckle, crusted with dried blood, and when he brushes his finger across the scab, the rusty red dissipates and fades into the water.

Bath salts are lined up against the tub like he's at a luxury spa, scented candles are lit up at the edges. This is all a little too much for an impromptu house guest.

He hates to admit it, but it's actually relaxing. In any other circumstance, Mydei could see himself drifting off to sleep right here, in the warm bath. But he knows where he is, and it's this singular fact that keeps him from fully letting go.

Traces of Phainon are everywhere since it's his own private bathroom that he's letting Mydei use, not a guest one. Phainon's naked body lying in this very tub, surrounded by the same scents and soaps Mydei is soaking in now. Phainon's towel hangs on a rack next to the sink, close enough for Mydei to reach out and grab it.

Against his better nature, he does just that, pressing the warm, soft fabric to his nose and inhaling deeply. It smells clean, with traces of a cool and minty body wash, and Mydei can close his eyes and imagine a freshly showered Phainon, water droplets rolling down the contours of his absurd body.

Fuck, he’s sick for doing this, for thinking like this. Because despite the front he’s putting up, Mydei wants him, badly.

In the quiet of the bathroom, when he’s all alone with his thoughts, Mydei can admit to himself that he never really hated Phainon at all, and there wasn’t anything to forgive. Part of him *liked* the thrill of being chased, that even if he ran, Phainon would follow. Perhaps it was a bad idea to toy with someone so obviously unstable, but the dark, possessive look in Phainon’s eyes whenever he thinks Mydei is about to get away is… exhilarating.

For years, Mydei had convinced himself that Phainon didn’t want him. That he treasured everything else more than he treasured their relationship. The idea that he was wrong, that in fact Phainon might want him a little too much, is immensely exciting. So exciting that he’s seen the red flags, and ignored every single one.

Mydei presses his face against the towel once again, and pretends that it’s Phainon’s warm body against him.

Heat stirs in his abdomen, travelling to his cock. He’s so aroused right now that it’s not even funny. The way Phainon had looked at him in the elevator… like he wanted to jump his bones then and there, Mydei would have let him, if he made a move. The fact that he didn’t is both commendable and infuriating.

His cock twitches, begging for attention.

Well he’s not going to survive the rest of the night in close proximity to Phainon with a hard-on, and since he refuses to give in first, something needs to be done about it.

With his free hand, Mydei reaches under the water, brushing his aching cock. Masturbating underwater is a completely new experience for him, but his cock feels so sensitive that he groans out loud as he grasps the hilt. With his other hand, he presses Phainon’s towel closer to his nose, sniffing deeply, trying to chase whatever remnant of Phainon’s scent remains on the fabric.

The towel is still, barely, ever so slightly damp, like it had been used recently. Mydei presses his cheek against it, imagining the contours of Phainon's body. He wonders, briefly, what this towel has seen. Whether Phainon rubbed it across his washboard abs, or used it to dry his fluffy hair, or even wiped his cock with it.

Mydei's pelvis thrusts upwards against his will, causing a small wave and a splash that almost sends water splashing onto the floor.

And he can't control the groan that rips out of his throat at how good it feels.

He's been so busy, and it's hard finding opportunities to be alone when you share a small apartment with two roommates. It's been a while since he had the chance to pleasure himself.

"Mydei, I'm going to take your wet clothes and put them in the dryer, okay?"

The knock comes out of nowhere, accompanied by a shadow under the door. Mydei freezes, he obviously hadn't been focusing on what was happening outside. He had no idea how long Phainon had been there, how much he had heard.

Due to his silence, Phainon knocks again. "Mydei? Is everything alright?"

He doesn't know how to explain it if Phainon decides to walk in, why he's sniffing Phainon's used towel with one hand in a compromising position.

"Yeah." Mydei replies, short and gruff. He winces a little at how wrecked his voice sounds.

"Is the water temperature to your liking? Do you need anything?" Phainon sounds unusually meek, but his shadow shows no sign of budging.

Mydei lets out a small noise of frustration as he sinks deeper into the tub, letting the water engulf his shoulders. His hand continues uninterrupted,

stroking the length of his cock, the way it slides over his hilt is a little strange due to the lack of friction, but not unpleasant.

“It’s fine.” He manages curtly. He sounds like he smokes 20 a day, it’s suspicious as hell.

On the other side of the door, Phainon seems to have noticed something, because his shadow shifts slightly, becoming larger, like he’s standing closer to the door now.

“Hey, uhm… you sure? You sound a little… weird.”

Mydei can almost hear the smirk in his voice, bastard.

Is Phainon starting to catch on? Or does he have no idea what Mydei is violating in his own bathroom, with his own towel? It doesn’t matter, either way, it’s thrilling.

Underneath the water, his hand starts to move faster and faster, creating ripples along the calm surface.

“Ha-*aah*- do I?” His cock jerks into his hand obediently as Mydei presses his thumb against the tip. He turns his head, pressing his nose into Phainon’s towel again and exhaling into it.

He hears a muffled slam against the door, as though someone is leaning their weight against it, causing the hinges to rattle.

“If you need any help… I could come inside.” Phainon’s voice is still gentle, but somewhat breathless at the same time. There are awkward, unnatural pauses between his words.

“No need, I’m just—*hah*, *shit*—relaxed right now.” Mydei hand strokes himself at a steady rhythm, the pleasure mounting up as his hips buck again. The water surface is now agitated to the point of splashing against the sides of the tub, some of it spilling past the edges and onto the floor.

“Which…” Phainon’s breath hitches as something heavy thumps the door from the other side. “Which scent did you go with?”

He must be talking about the bath salts. Mydei hadn’t given it much thought when choosing, so he turns his head over to assess the label on the one he ended up picking. “...Peaches and cream.”

The thumping on the other side was softer now, but more regular, rhythmic almost.

“...I–I see.” Phainon repeats, voice low.

Mydei grits his teeth as his hand moves faster. He imagines Phainon on the other side of the door, at his shadow that refuses to go away. Imagines him still in his outside clothes, that ridiculous turtleneck that had no business accentuating his broad shoulders so well, and wonders if he’s palming himself through his pants, or whether he just gave up and stuck his hand inside. Is it killing him knowing that Mydei is naked, pleasuring himself and they’re only separated by a flimsy piece of wood?

What kind of face is Phainon making right now?

The mental image, the smell of him on his towel, and the sound of the increasingly heavy panting from outside the room almost tilts him over the edge as Mydei feels his pleasure increase.

He’s close, he’s so close that it hurts.

He has two options, stick his head underwater to muffle the sound of his orgasm. Or literally gag himself with Phainon’s towel so he doesn’t moan loud enough to wake the entire building. A choice between submerging himself, not able to breathe, or to envelop himself in Phainon’s scent as he comes.

Easiest decision of his life.

Mydei bites down on the soft cotton of the towel at the same time his cock stiffens, the pleasure builds until his body can no longer hold it in and he comes. He watches as white ribbons shoot out into the water, merging and dissolving into the bathwater until it disappears.

And then, all is still once again.

Mydei sits up in the rapidly cooling bath, chest heaving, watching as droplets trail down his chest, into the little dip between his pecs, and then joining the rest of the tainted water. His whole body feels feverish, and it feels like there's a black hole within him hungry for more. He's satisfied, but at the same time, he's not satisfied at all.

Outside, Phainon has gone quiet, although his shadow still remains lingering at the door front, a reminder that he's still there.

Until finally, a small, quiet voice whimpers from outside.

"Mydei… wait! W-when you're done… don't throw out the bathwater. Please?"

Mydei only looks at his shadow in horror.

"What?"

"Please. I just—please?" Phainon's voice softens to a squeak until it's barely audible, accompanied only by the sound of scratching against wood.

Mydei throws his head back in wordless defeat.

It seems disgusting to fulfill Phainon's request, but Mydei doesn't want that pretty boy whining in his ear again so… it's easier just to go along with whatever his freaky requests were.

He looks at the clothes Phainon is borrowing him, and scowls. The pants are innocent enough, just normal track pants with a stripe down the sides, acceptable. But the shirt is an atrocity to mankind, there's no way he's putting that on.

This… this… eyesore of a black t-shirt, with a printed graphic of a wolf with terrifyingly human-like proportions sitting down, hugging its knees. And in plain white text, no worse, in *Papyrus* font, it writes:

I’ll protect you, kitten

Mydei resists the urge to fling it out the window as a survival mechanism.

He’s going to fling it at Phainon’s face instead.

Mydei storms out of the bathroom, hair damp, wearing nothing but the track pants hanging low on his hips and a towel around his shoulders.

To his surprise, Phainon isn’t outside, not in the hallway, in the living room, or in the kitchen. Mydei can only conclude that he’s retreated to the bedroom, and thus his rage will have to wait for the time being.

The couch in the living room has been prepared for a guest, a folded blanket and spare pillow placed atop the cushion. Mydei’s phone is lying face down on the coffee table, connected to a charger. Phainon seems to be an incredible host to the point where it’s a bit hard to believe he never has guests over.

Mydei picks up his phone, swiping to unlock it. He does feel a little bit bad about how he abruptly hung up on Cipher, maybe he’ll try to text them again.

***Phone unavailable, try again later*.**

He blinks at the screen.

And then he scoffs.

“Idiot.”

No prize for guessing the culprit, as there was only one other person who had access to Mydei’s phone while he was in the bathroom. He really had some nerve prying into his personal belongings like that. Why is Phainon so curious about the contents of his phone, anyway?

Instead of any alarm Mydei just feels annoyed, now he can’t talk to his friends, can’t scroll through social media, can’t do anything but sit there and wait for the lockout to end.

He chucks his phone to the side, sighing slightly.

And when he turns his head to regard his surroundings, he sees that same neon yellow hoodie draped over the couch.

The memories of what he was doing flood back in all at once, and heat rises to his face.

He hated to admit it but Phainon smelled really, really good. Something about his clean, fresh natural scent tied to the musky cologne is driving him crazy. If his towel smelled that good, then what about the hoodie that Phainon presumably wears around the house, all the time?

Mydei has to close his legs as his cock twitches in his pants, an utter betrayal. His libido was never this high before, what happened?

Mydei looks around to ensure that Phainon is really gone before his hand reaches for the hoodie. Before he realizes it, he's pressing it to his face, practically nuzzling into the fabric. It's surprisingly soft, and a little warm like someone had been holding it earlier. More importantly, the scent of Phainon is even stronger. If he closes his eyes, he could pretend that they're cuddling each other.

A sharp twinge shoots through his chest. What they could have been if neither of them were stupid…

There's no changing the past, but it's not too late for the two of them to have a future. Because based on Phainon's actions tonight, it's clear he is not over Mydei either. It's not that Mydei doesn't want him, it's pathetic how much he's yearned for Phainon. But… he can't ignore the fear and hesitation.

If Mydei allows himself to fall all over again and it doesn't work out, he's not going to survive it.

He hears footsteps approaching, followed by someone calling out to him

“Myd–”, the person barely gets his name out, before he gasps. When Mydei turns around, all he can hear is the sound of rapidly retreating footsteps, followed by the sound of the bathroom door slamming shut.

Mydei’s blood turns cold. Shit, he saw everything, didn’t he? Mydei’s desperation, his pining, his weakness. He’s mortified, but at the same time a little excited.

If Phainon can make the first move, break the stalemate between them…

Then coming here tonight won’t have been a waste.

The minutes tick by slowly without his phone. Deprived of his main source of killing time, Mydei finds his mind wandering to what Phainon is doing in the bathroom with Mydei’s literal bathwater. Is he also bathing in Mydei’s fluids? Pleasuring himself to the image of him? Is this man half as depraved as Mydei imagines him to be? The idea of a naked Phainon makes his insides ache, though, so he doesn’t think about it too hard.

Eager for a distraction, Mydei eyes the colourful magazines spread out on the coffee table. They’ve been left there messily, some face down, others with the pages bent and dog-eared like someone had just thrown them there with little regard for their condition.

He picks one out at random, drawn by the bright and neon coloured cover. Phainon stares back at him from the cover page, posing together with a woman in a stairwell, both dressed in streetwear. Mydei recognizes the woman as the same one hanging out with him at the bar earlier. Cyrene, he had said her name was, his childhood friend.

Mydei racks his brain, trying to recall if he really had mentioned her before. He comes up blank. Phainon might have mentioned a childhood friend whom he lost contact with once or twice, but Mydei hadn’t connected the dots, wouldn’t have connected them even if he remembered her name.

Seeing them so close at the bar, Mydei admitted he got a little jealous. Cyrene is gorgeous, the kind of feminine beauty that makes heads turn when she walks down the street. Long, silky pink hair, an expressive face

with delicate facial features, a walk so graceful it almost looks like she's dancing. Phainon could have her, if he wanted. He couldn't imagine anyone saying no to him.

So why settle for Mydei even after so many years?

It boggles his mind.

As he flips through the pages, he realizes this magazine is from the future. Flicking to the front cover again, he notices that the date printed on it is a few days from now. This is probably an advanced copy sent to Phainon since he's got an interview feature in it.

The Phainon fan pages that he still follows would go into a frenzy if they knew he got his hands on such a treasure.

He could leak it…

…or not.

Shaking his head, Mydei perishes the thought. It may be a little selfish, but he wants to keep this find to himself; the fans won't die from waiting a couple of days. One of the perks of having a personal relationship with Phainon.

He starts reading the feature.

The shirt? Supima Cotton.
The man? Boyfriend Material.
Phainon Khaslana reflects on his views on relationships, career, and whatever comes in between.

It's all contrite, polished fluff, but Mydei finds himself combing it from line to line anyway. Anything that could give him an edge on understanding the man Phainon had become would be welcomed.

But he finds nothing.

The version of Phainon interviewed is refreshing as a spring breeze, the nation's perfect boyfriend. A kind and handsome gentleman whose tastes are… bland at best. His favourite colour is white, his favourite drink is water, his favourite animal is the dog, his favourite season is winter. It's almost offensive in its inoffensiveness, like he's a caricature designed to appeal to everyone.

Up until yesterday, reading this article would have bothered him immensely.

But tonight he's seen Phainon's B-side, the side that picked a fight with Mydei so they would both feel better. Who is so obviously, deeply into him that it's flattering and embarrassing. Phainon who is needy and pathetic and a bit of a loser yet is all the more endearing for it.

Mydei is still combing the article when Phainon finishes his bath, walking into the living room while running a towel through his hair.

He freezes when he sees Mydei sitting shirtless on the floor, wearing nothing but borrowed sweat pants and leafing through a magazine with Phainon's face on it.

Mydei looks up, seeing Phainon staring at him, mouth agape, as though his brain had decided to shut down for the day. He's frequently shirtless at home, and the girls think nothing of it except that he's gross. He'd forgotten how it felt like to be looked at with such thinly veiled lust.

Not that Phainon hadn't been looking at him that way all evening, ever since their eyes met in that bar. It was just easier to ignore when there were other obstacles in the way, other baggage they hadn't worked out.

Now though, there's really no excuses or distractions.

"I…I see you still haven't put on the shirt." Phainon mutters, eyes fluttering away. "I chose it because it was black, and that's your colour. You don't like it?"

“I don’t. That shirt should be set on fire,” Mydei says flatly. “I refuse to wear it.”

Phainon’s lower lip juts out in a pout, utterly unfitting for someone whose face is plastered on the cover of magazines. He changed into loungewear too, and the pathetic aura is amplified by the white t-shirt he’s wearing, printed with a graphic of two chimeras cuddling alongside a caption so lame it doesn’t even bear acknowledging. The purple track pants do nothing to redeem the look, and his hair looks like an uncombed bird’s nest.

He doesn’t look anything like the picture perfect hottie in the photograph, quite the opposite. And Mydei must be down bad, down horrendous even, because if he had to choose, he’d pick this version of Phainon any day.

“I didn’t know those kinds of magazines would interest you.” Phainon tilts his head towards the magazine in his hand. “I thought you’d prefer like.. Nature or something.”

Mydei shrugs, he does enjoy subjects like nature and history a little more, but he’ll read pretty much anything he can get his hands on. Knowledge is powerful, regardless of the topic. “It was a very interesting article.”

“You’re making fun of me,” Phainon scowls. “Stop.” He eyes the magazine like it had personally insulted him. “I tried to talk them out of it, but they really insisted on going with the ‘boyfriend’ angle.”

“I’m not making fun of you,” Mydei says. “I thought the writer was being very sincere.” He says, accidentally giving away the fact that he had read the feature cover to cover. “You have qualities that many would consider desirable in a partner.”

Instead of cheering him up, Mydei’s reassurance seems to have done the opposite, as Phainon’s shoulders droop, making him look even more like a soggy wet dog. “A lot of people, but not you, right? I have money, I have fame, I have looks. I can be the perfect man, the ideal boyfriend.”

His voice cracks, and it suddenly becomes apparent to Mydei that this has been a source of their insecurities for a long time.

“But it’s still not enough for you. Because no matter what I become, how high I go, it’s never going to make you want me.”

Mydei closes his eyes, exhales out slowly. He’s not the short-tempered youth he used to be, time and maturity had mellowed him out. He wonders if Phainon had somehow missed all the signs, or whether he deluded himself into thinking that the feelings weren’t reciprocated.

“HKS.” Mydei curses. “Who says I don’t want you?”

Phainon blinks at him in confusion “I mean I assumed-”

Mydei rolls his eyes “And of course you assumed incorrectly.”

He grabs Phainon’s cheeks and squeezes them in his hand, it makes his lips purse like a pufferfish. He looks stupid and lost and totally adorable as he looks at Mydei with confusion. “Listen to me, because I’ll only say this once.”

“You have always been enough for me, exactly as you are. I never wanted more from you. My only wish was for us to remain the same forever. I couldn’t understand why you needed to capture the hearts of others when you already had mine.”

Mydei flushes and releases his grip on Phainon, breaking eye contact. He may be honest, but he’s also a guarded man who’d rather keep his thoughts to himself, or skirt around the issue especially when it’s something personal to him. Airing his heart out like this made him feel vulnerable, but he supposed if anyone deserved the truth, it was Phainon.

This man who had apparently waited for him for years, even though there was no guarantee they’d ever cross paths, much less get back together. The man who haunts his thoughts more often than not, that Mydei inevitably compared every new potential partner to. The man whose red string of fate he could never break, no matter how far they drifted away.

Maybe one of his hopes when he moved back to Okhema was the idea that he would meet Phainon again someday.

Phainon exhales, long and deep “You know,” he murmurs, resting his head on his knee “I’m trying so hard to be a good boy tonight. You’re making things… difficult.”

The way his voice drops in timbre sends jolts of excitement down Mydei’s spine, he feels like he’s toying with someone who's on the verge of snapping.

“How,” Mydei teases, resting his chin in his palm. “Am I making things difficult?”

Phainon tilts his head to regard him, now that the turtleneck is gone Mydei can clearly see the golden lines on his neck, tattooed in the likeness of a sun. The shape is familiar, but Mydei can’t put his finger on why…

“You pleasured yourself in the bathroom without me.” Phainon says, counting off his fingers. “You almost kissed me in the elevator, and now, you’re sitting here, practically naked, showing off that absurd body of yours, in my living room.”

“It’s like you don’t even know what you’re doing to me.”

Mydei smirks, and then he drops the magazine on Phainon’s lap to cover the signs of his obvious arousal. Raising his arms over his head, Mydei stretches, slow, relaxed, like a cat. His back arches, shoulders pushed backwards, chest up and out. As he feels his abs clench, he knows the way it makes his tight muscles stand out.

“So?” He replies, belligerent.

Phainon gapes at him, at a loss for words. Then he turns away, face the same colour as an apple, discreetly wiping his sleeve across his mouth.

“I can’t.” Phainon murmurs, burying his head in the crook of his elbow, face burning. “You told me in no uncertain terms that you didn’t want sex.”

“Then you spectacularly misinterpreted my intentions,” Mydei corrects. “I said if all you’re offering is sex, I don’t want it.”

Phainon's voice is muffled as he's still hiding in his elbow, but Mydei can vaguely hear the words as he sulks "Yes I heard you very well the first time."

"If you're offering something more, though."

Phainon turns his head a little bit, just so that one blue eye peeks out underneath his curtain of hair. The quivering of his pupil almost… hopeful as he says in a tiny, meek voice. "More? Like what?"

"Hmm, I dunno." Mydei thinks he's spoken enough, left hints that even the most clueless would pick up. "That onus is on the one offering."

Phainon gulps, licks his dry lips, and looks down at the floor.

"So." Mydei continues. "What do you want, Phainon Khaslana?"

Chapter End Notes

> The song of the day is Gasoline by HAIM
> I love this opening line in particular so much: *You took me back/But you shouldn't have/Now it's your fault if I mess around.* and it was definitely a big inspiration in this fic.
> Spotify playlist
>
> Here is my twitter!
>
> On a random note I usually like staying at least 2 chapters ahead of the posting schedule when I write so I SHOULD be working on the second last chapter right now but why does it keep getting longer and longer? Why do I keep adding more stuff to it save me!! Thoughts and prayers that I don't exceed my predicted chapter count.

Chapter 6: Tonight You Are Mine

Chapter Summary

> “I love you.” He blurts out, not able to stop all his emotions from leaking out.
>
> “Stupid.” Mydei’s words are harsh, but his voice is so unbearably gentle. His face looks like he’s trying hard to hold back a smile.
>
> “Say it back.” Phainon says, tugging at Mydei’s clothes, voice soft and weak like a child. Because he’s insecure, because he needs the reassurance, because even if he somehow manages to fuck things up again at the very least he can record that soundbite to loop in his mind for all eternity.
>
> Without saying a single word, Mydei leans forward and kisses him.

Chapter Notes

> I have been accused of edging my readers last chapter. These accusations are all true and I regret to say that the edgings will continue.
> /The crowd boos, tomatoes are thrown at me, Phainon and Mydei are having gay sex in the back row.
>
> Some additional CWs: Female OC (don't worry about it she is just there to move the plot along), dry humping, oral, stalking

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Back in high school, when Phainon was the student council president, his vice-president had once asked him what he would like to receive as a present.

“What?” Phainon had said, caught off guard. They were sitting across from each other, two opposite sides of the table. As usual, Phainon’s side is

stacked with paperwork, student proposals, flyers that needed to be distributed and displayed and checklists that needed to be vetted. Their school's open day was in less than 2 weeks, which meant that things were really hectic. Phainon barely has time to eat, much less think about things like this.

"Yeah, a gift," his vice-president said cryptically. Her name was Arielle, a straight A student, captain of the basketball club, the kind of girl that was universally adored by both teachers and students. She tilted her head to regard him, long blonde hair falling like a curtain over her shoulder. "Your birthday is soon, isn't it?"

Phainon had no idea, he'd genuinely forgotten about it.

Birthdays at the Khaslanas were quiet, family oriented affairs. His mother would bake him a birthday cake, their family's secret recipe, and they'd sit down for a family dinner. If they were still in Aedes Elysiae, they'd probably have invited the neighbours over for a birthday party, making things livelier.

But not in Okhema. He couldn't expect his parents to take additional days off just because it was his birthday. He dares not ask for more, dares not seem ungrateful, since his parents had already sacrificed so much already by uprooting their lives to move here when he got his scholarship.

There was once a time where he had dreams about adding a 4th person to his birthday celebration. He'd invite Mydei over to his small, humble apartment, they'll play dumb party games and he'd sneak him out to his favourite takeout spot down the street after his parents had gone to bed.

Mydei would whine and complain all the way there because he hated unhealthy food. But he would give in eventually, because he always let Phainon do whatever he wanted.

Now it was just… a stupid fantasy he had, nothing worth thinking too deeply about.

“A gift? For me?” Phainon deflected the subject with an easy smile. “Well, I’d like some cushions for the chairs in the student council room, they’re pretty uncomfortable. Or something like a label maker would be great! I’m always getting confused on which tray the approval forms are supposed to go in.

“I’m not asking about what the student council wants,” Arielle repeated blandly. “I’m asking you what *you* want.”

Now he feels put on the spot. Their conversation had drawn the attention of the other student council members working in the room, and they were now staring at him in anticipation.

It suddenly occurred to him that everyone was invested in this conversation because despite spending the entire year working closely together, none of them knew him well enough to choose a present for him.

What did he want, anyway? Phainon had no idea.

The things that came to mind he wouldn’t classify as ‘wants’. More like… deep desires that he doesn’t let himself indulge in.

He wanted Mydei back. But even Phainon knew when something was downright impossible. Mydei’s in Castrum Kremnos now, doing okay for himself from the sparse content he uploaded on social media. Besides, nobody knew they dated, and it seems weird to dig up a dead horse.

He wanted everyone to take responsibility for their own problems for once instead of pushing everything to him because he’s the student council president. That included the teachers, who frequently added to his workload because he was such a trustworthy and competent student.

He wanted people to stop looking at him like he’s some kind of messiah for just a moment. And yes, the irony wasn't lost on him, he molded himself into this image on purpose and now he wanted out? Try not to laugh.

No, no, a want should be something more tangible, something actually obtainable. Something he could hold in the palm of his hand, something

like…

“...the limited edition ‘Amphoreus Saga of Heroes’ Dawnmaker enamel pin?” He thought.

“Huh?” Arielle asked, eyes nearly boggling out of her skull.

Phainon quickly backtracked, he’d said too much, he wasn’t supposed to share that out loud. “Or dogs? I love dogs! Any dog themed item is good with me!”

Everyone likes dogs, don’t they? And Phainon is a little dog-like himself so that makes total sense. It was the safest option to pick.

He doesn’t actually expect to be given something.

When his birthday arrived, the student council members pooled their funds together to get him a coffee mug that said ‘Stay Pawsitive!’ with a silly cartoon dog on it. It was impersonal, appropriate, and so utterly *basic* that Phainon couldn’t help but let out a sigh of relief.

It’s for that very reason that it was perfect.

Aside from the usual well wishes, a few handwritten birthday cards and a surprise celebration thrown in the classroom during lunch, nothing out of the ordinary happens. It’s nothing he can’t handle, it’s nothing he doesn’t deserve.

The curveball came when they said their goodbyes after school and Phainon turned around to head home.

Arielle calls his name to stop him right as he’s walking out of school grounds.

“Is there something wrong?” Phainon racked his brain, he’s pretty sure he’d completed all his duties for the day. Stamped every form, filed every document.

“No! Nothing’s wrong,” Arielle shifted on the soles of her feet, uncharacteristically nervous. “I just wanted to give you something.”

Phainon started getting a bad feeling about this. “Can it wait?” He asked, trying hard to exit the situation but not in a way that would cause offense. “I’m sorry, it’s just– I’m in a hurry.”

“It will only take a second!” She pleaded, pressing her palms together like a prayer.

Her blonde hair was tied in a half-ponytail that day, glimmering in the light of the setting sun. Her hair tie had cherries on it, bobbing playfully as she moved her head. Phainon made it a note to notice these little things about people because he knows that pointing it out made them happy.

Mydei would look good with a little cherry hair tie. His hair is short but he should still be able to tie the longer locks back. He’d get so mad though, if Phainon tried it on him. Something about being too cutesy, something about making him look like a fool.

Geez, Mydei had been gone for a year and Phainon still thought about him, he’s hopeless.

“Okay, what is it?” Phainon asked, dragging himself back down to reality. Mydei’s not the one standing in front of him, Arielle is. She deserved basic respect, at least.

She wrung her hands as she continued speaking. “I just… well… you said you wanted this. You backtracked about it later, but I just thought… maybe you were just too embarrassed to say you wanted it. So here!”

She pulled it out of her pocket before offering it to him, the Dawnmaker pin he had his eye on.

Phainon stared at it for a beat longer than necessary.

Arielle continued speaking. “I looked up this game and… this is the sword the main character uses, right? The hero. It makes sense, because you’re…

you’re the hero of our school.”

“This is too expensive.” Phainon said immediately, mouth dry. “I can’t accept it.”

“No! No, it’s fine. I stumbled across an online listing. Someone was clearing out their collection, so I got it for cheap.” She was lying, because Phainon stalked the listings religiously and he knew that none of them had been sold for anywhere near ‘cheap’.

Guilt flooded his entire chest. He knew that she’d gotten it to make him happy, and he *wanted* to be happy. The collectible Dawnmaker pin was something he’d had his eye on for a long time.

He should have just accepted the gift with gratitude but instead, Phainon felt sick. He wished he hadn’t mentioned his stupid, selfish request at all, wished she hadn’t listened, wished she didn’t go out of her way to spend money on it.

He didn’t want to feel like he owed her something.

“Can I pay you back?” Phainon asked, panicking.

Arielle smiled, but she looked annoyed enough for Phainon to know that he’d said the wrong thing.

“That’s not the point of a gift,” she pouted. “Plus, you’re always wearing that sun pin on your blazer, so, I thought you’d like this.”

Phainon unconsciously grasped at the lapels of his jacket, feeling the pointed edges of the metal engraving dig into his palm. He hadn’t realized anyone noticed. He’d been so careful that he normally wore it on the inside of his blazer, hidden from view.

He’d found it in Mydei’s locker the day after Mydei stopped coming to school. He had just been checking it to make sure Mydei hadn’t left anything behind, there was no other reason. The craftsmanship was sublime, the metal was probably real gold, and the etchings were in a

language he couldn’t read, presumably Kremnoan. It seemed obvious that it was a gift Mydei had intended for him, and ended up never actually giving it to him because of… everything.

When Phainon realized this, he took the gift home and cried. He'd kept it on his person ever since, not able to bring himself to part with it.

“Y-you noticed?” Phainon repeated shakily.

Arielle blushed, tucking a lock of hair behind her ear. “I mean… sometimes you hang your blazer on the chair in the student council room and I just… see it.”

The thought that he was being scrutinized so closely made him uncomfortable. He preferred to be the one observing, noticing things about people. He did not like having the same done to him.

He was not dumb, nobody would pay this much attention to someone they weren’t at least a little interested in. He knew Arielle harboured a crush on him, it was obvious!

“C-can I put it on you?” Arielle gestured to the Dawnmaker pin again, face flushing pink.

Phainon nodded shakily. He supposed there was no harm and… he couldn’t really say no. Not after she went out of her way to get him such a thoughtful gift.

But when her hand reached out to him, his heart seized with panic because her hands were on the wrong pin. For some reason, she’s fumbling with the sun pin, Mydei’s pin, the last scrap of himself that he left behind before disappearing from Phainon’s life.

“That’s not yours!” He snapped, voice clipped. Before he could think about it he’s reached out to grab her wrist, stopping her from doing anymore damage.

Arielle looked up at him, green eyes wide with surprise and fear. And with a start, Phainon realized he'd let his composure slip. That wasn't gentlemanly of him, it didn't suit the prim, proper, gentle image he'd built for himself over the past year.

He quickly let her go, but his hand hovered over to the pin, clutching it like a lifeline. "Sorry! It's… very important to me. Please don't touch it!"

"I only wanted to adjust it as it was crooked." Arielle said slowly. "I'm sorry."

He watched her carefully, almost warily as she pinned the Dawnmaker onto his lapels, correctly this time.

"There," she said, stepping back and surveying her handiwork. "It suits you."

It didn't. Dawnmaker is the sword of a hero, and Phainon was nothing but an imposter.

"I…" Phainon swallowed, feeling the pit in his stomach grow. "Thank you. It's a wonderful gift, truly. How can I make it up to you?"

Arielle shrugged, a small smile on her face. "You don't have to. It's a gift. You do so much for everyone else, you deserve something nice too."

Phainon wanted to grab her by the shoulders and shake her until she opened her eyes because he did not. He is a mess and has made so many mistakes and is fucked up in ways she cannot even imagine.

But he couldn't say any of that, so he simply smiled. "I really want to repay you somehow, please?" He looked at her intently in the way that he knew many students found irresistible.

And she folded like wet tissue paper.

"Then… maybe we could go out for coffee sometimes?" She squeaked. "Not for student council stuff, just you and me." She shrugged, casual as

anything, though the action was given away by how red her face was getting.

Phainon understood immediately, she was asking for a date.

The relief made his shoulders sag down, of course, everything is transactional, this was what he understood of the world. Mydei was an anomaly, somebody who threw the axis of his world off balance precisely because he never asked for anything in return.

But when he thought that Mydei was just like the rest of them, that his love was conditional as long as Phainon adhered to the image he wanted… it broke him.

Bitter with the memories, Phainon plastered a smile on his face. “Okay,” he agreed. “We can do that.”

Arielle smiled at him so brightly that Phainon told himself it was fine. Agreeing to date her hurts no one and costs him nothing. That was what he’s good at, bearing everyone’s wishes on his shoulders, making others happy. Just a blank slate for other people to project their ideal man onto.

Even something like wanting a stupid collectible keychain led to him being in a relationship he didn’t want to be in, one that dragged on for two months before she finally dumped him right before graduation.

The experience taught him that wanting always came with a price tag.

Even now, sitting here, Mydei is laying his heart at Phainon’s feet and saying it’s his if he wants it. And Phainon… still can’t say anything.

“I… I’m not sure.” Phainon murmurs, hugging his knees. He feels small and vulnerable and weak and stupid.

It’s just… he’d thought that as long as he had Mydei in his life, he’d be okay with that, no matter what unconventional, toxic form their relationship

took. Mydei was the person who understood him most in this world, and losing him again was unthinkable.

If Mydei hated him, he'd claw back into his good graces. If Mydei disappeared from his life, he'd chase him down until he finds him again.

It's impossible to explain all this without sounding completely unhinged, and Phainon doesn't even know where to start.

Mydei sighs, and maybe even looks disappointed? Phainon isn't sure.

"I'm sorry if I put you on the spot. You don't need to give me an answer right now."

With that, he shifts away, creating distance between them.

"W-wait!" Phainon says, panicking. What if his indecisiveness has annoyed Mydei and he wants to leave, the straw that broke the camel's back? Phainon would give him an answer now! Is 'everything' a valid response? He'll take whatever Mydei is willing to give him!

"I don't want you to rush. Take all the time you need to think about it," Mydei says gently, like he read his mind. "Just do me a favour, and make sure that you'll be thinking about what you want, for once."

"Huh?" Phainon repeats dumbly.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "You heard me. When you've come to a decision, make sure it's one that you're making for yourself."

With that, Mydei gets up. The air around Phainon feels much colder from his absence. The man makes himself comfortable on the couch, pulling on Phainon's favourite old worn yellow hoodie for warmth—a seemingly casual action that is driving Phainon a little insane, because he had no right looking so good in it.

Mydei stretches out on the couch horizontally, relaxed and lazy, before he grabs his phone and starts scrolling through it.

“Are you going to sleep now?” Phainon asks softly.

“I don’t think I’ll be able to get much sleep tonight,” Mydei says honestly. “But thank you for allowing me shelter at your home.”

He knows Mydei is giving him an out, respecting his personal space and comfort. He’s a coward who led the lion into his trap and now doesn’t know what to do with it. He wants Mydei, that had never been in doubt. But it’s hard when Mydei’s also the cautious type, the type who puts the ball in his court, an open invitation to come and get it, if he’s brave enough.

They both can’t dance around each other forever.

He watches Mydei quietly as the latter’s phone buzzes incessantly, message after message flowing in. The blue light from the screen softens his features, and Phainon can’t help but think that he looks gorgeous like this. But as the messages keep coming, and Mydei’s beautiful face is marred by a light frown, feelings of anxiety come flooding in.

He’d overheard the conversation between Mydei and his friend, Cipher earlier. She was warning him about Phainon, something about him being a psychopath, that he was dangerous. She’s not… totally wrong, but he never meant any harm. He would admit to loitering around places where he knows Mydei has been. Sometimes it’s enough being in the same place, breathing the same oxygen. Sometimes… it’d take a little more to satisfy him. Little trinkets, or souvenirs to remember where he’d been; proof that Mydei was there.

One man’s trash is another man’s treasure, or so the saying goes.

He didn’t think anyone noticed, he’d been so careful about it.

“Who are you talking to?” He tries subtly looking over at Mydei’s phone screen. There are… definitely a lot of messages from the same person.

His worry spikes.

“If you wanted to look at my phone…” Mydei says calmly, eyes still fixed on the screen. “You could have just asked. I didn’t appreciate being locked out.”

Phainon’s blood freezes.

So he knew?

Phainon hadn’t intended to go that far. The phone was just lying there, and he couldn’t resist the call of temptation. Phainon had tried several different combinations of Mydei’s birthday, only to get irrationally upset when none of them worked. He’d felt frustrated that he didn’t even know Mydei well enough to guess his phone password, and in a fit of hubris had tried his own birthday.

That locked the phone, and sealed his fate.

“I’m sorry!” The apology spills out of him frantically, and he defaults to grovelling now that his cover has been blown. Panic floods his veins. What if this is the breaking point for Mydei? The straw that breaks the camel’s back and makes him decide that Phainon is too… too *much*, too crazy, too obsessed, too unhinged. “I… I was just too curious. Please don’t get mad at me?”

“I’m not mad, I’m just–” Mydei says.

But Phainon has already spiralled, and he can’t stop. Things had been going so well, they were going SO well and he just HAD to ruin everything with his stupid impulsive decision.

He knows that rifling through somebody’s phone is a terrible offence. Unforgivable, even. Phainon would hate it if the same was done to him. He’d feel so violated, so disrespected.

“There’s no way you’re such a saint,” Phainon says.

“Not a saint. Just… don’t have any secrets, not from you.” Mydei admits quietly. “So if there’s something you wanted to know, just ask. I’ll tell

you.”

He can’t say things like that so casually, it makes him feel sick. It’s like he’s baring his weak spot and offering Phainon the blade. The amount of trust he’s put in Phainon makes him unwell, it makes him want to dig and dig and make his home in Mydei’s skin.

“What… what is your friend telling you about me?” Phainon musters the courage to ask.

Mydei purses his lips, silent, but angles the phone for him to see.

Message after message of accusations, with evidence to back it up. His friend is pretty impressive to have collected this all within a few hours. Grainy security footage of himself in disguise outside Mydei’s gig venues. Another clip, several seconds long, different venue, different disguise, but undeniably him. There’s even one of Phainon loitering in front of an apartment block, which, according to the panicked messages, is the one that Mydei is currently living in.

He swears that the last one was a coincidence, because if Phainon knew where he lived earlier then well… he wouldn’t have waited until now to make a move.

But, regardless, she knows, she knows a lot more than he thought. Alarm surges through him, his fight or flight hackles rising. His secrets are coming forward much faster than he expected, the ugly side that he tried to keep hidden. He thought he had more *time*, damnit!

“I can explain!” He says, mouth dry.

Mydei just looks at him quietly, expression unreadable. And if Phainon stopped to think about it a little more, he’d realize that Mydei would have known he was a creep already. He hadn’t been subtle about the red flags. Mydei is smart and perceptive on his own, even without the warnings from Cipher, he would have figured it out.

But Phainon isn’t thinking rationally. Blind panic is running through his mind, thoughts splintering into primitive desires that fall along the lines of ‘Please don’t go!’ and ‘I need you!’ and ‘I’ll die if you leave me again!’.

Because he realizes he has nothing, no valid explanation for why he’s acted this way. What it looks like is exactly what it is! He knows the difference between right and wrong and what he’s done is very, very wrong. He knows it’s neither sane nor healthy but he just– he needed to be close to Mydei. With or without his consent.

“The look on your face says it all,” Phainon starts shakily, swallowing. The rapport he’d carefully built up with Mydei over the evening is falling apart in front of his eyes and he doesn’t know if he can fix it. “I know it’s weird. It’s wrong. I’m sick. I’m crazy!”

His eyes are burning, and Phainon knows that he has nobody to blame but himself. He’s so pathetic that it hurts.

“For how long?” Mydei just asks, quietly, calmly.

There is no point obscuring the truth. Mydei is bound to find out eventually anyway, and lying would worsen the situation. “Since knowing you moved back to Okhema. Knowing you’re living in the same city, breathing the same air, but not able to see you. I went insane!”

Phainon manages to choke out some awkward laughter, it does nothing but make him feel worse inside. It’s the slow creep of shame when one knows they’ve done something wrong and is now reaping the consequences of their actions. But Phainon knows he doesn’t regret it, he’d do the same thing all over again, given the chance.

It’s like asking someone to stop breathing. Impossible, right? That’s what Mydei is to him, like oxygen.

Mydei just frowns, quiet. He’s thinking about what he wants to do with this information. Phainon wishes he would just accept it and let go, knowing that Phainon means no harm. But what sane man would make that kind of decision?

“I… I won’t stop.” Phainon declares, the honesty feeling like a weight lifted off his shoulders. “I never meant you harm. I’ll do anything to make it up to you, be anything you want. Just promise me that you won’t make me delete everything.”

Mydei tilts his head to the side. “Delete everything?” He repeats slowly.

The room falls into deafening silence.

“What else do you have on me?”

Oh, he’s done it now, dug himself into deep shit.

But yet, it feels like a relief to have it all out in the open. This guilty little secret he’s been carrying around with him for so long, this side of him that he cannot show to anyone else.

Mydei is the only one who understands him best, after all.

Phainon takes out his phone and hands it over to Mydei like an offering.

“The password is 108642.”

Mydei’s expression is open and curious as he unlocks Phainon’s phone. And of course, it doesn’t take him long to find the photo album that he’s labelled as ‘M’ with a big stupid heart emoji next to it.

“These are…” Mydei murmurs as he scrolls through his phone, uncharacteristically at a loss for words. Phainon cringes, he knows what Mydei is seeing right now. Years of accumulated pictures. It started innocently, an archive of Mydei’s stellargram photos when Phainon thought he was going to be blocked, and then photos from his friend’s stellargrams. And then the pictures exponentially increased once Mydei started his musical career and posted more, trying to get his name out there.

Public photos first, harmless. And then screenshots taken from his temporary stories, still within the realm of normalcy. But then, around the time coinciding with Mydei’s return to Okhema, a sudden shift. More invasive now, blurry candids taken of Mydei from afar when he’s

interacting with someone or busy with something else, moments where he didn't know he was being watched.

"All me…" Mydei murmurs. "Just me…"

Yes, Phainon had taken great care to crop out anyone else that wasn't Mydei. It wasn't because he was being magnanimous or anything, he just hadn't been interested.

Mydei's face does not budge as he scrolls through what has to be 40 different photos taken at a show where he happened to be performing shirtless.

"I never saw you at our gigs," he points out.

Phainon huffs. "It's not like I could show up in person." Not after their history, not with his public identity. "I usually pay someone to go in my place." The gig market was amazing. You could pay anyone to do anything, however bizarre the request.

Mydei raises an eyebrow, but keeps his thoughts to himself.

Phainon exhales nervously. He feels raw, like his body had been eviscerated open for Mydei to see, laid out on a slab for him to vivisect, heart wrenched out of his ribcage and beating bloody and vulnerable to his whims.

This is the part of himself he had tried to keep buried, the part that he deigned wasn't good enough to be shown to the world. He kept telling himself that it didn't matter if Mydei rejected him, he wasn't going to take no for an answer anyway.

But that was just false bravado. The truth is, he doesn't want to be rejected, not again.

After what feels like an eternity of tense silence, Mydei huffs and tosses his phone back to him. "If that's all you got, that's child's play."

"Wha–?" Phainon starts, utterly confused.

“So what? A handful of blurry candids and publicly available photos from my pages? When you started panicking I thought you were a real freak. Turns out it was all a bunch of nothing.” Mydei waves his hand dismissively. “That's weak. I’m disappointed. I could do better.”

Better?? What has Mydei done that’s ‘better’? Phainon’s head swims at the implications and he practically crawls into his lap with haste.

“Better how?” He pleads.

Mydei simply leans back, closing off his body language. “Hah, like I’ll bear my heart out to you.”

Phainon isn’t buying it, there’s no freak-off competition that he wouldn’t win. He’ll prove it to Mydei. He has no idea about the deep desires Phainon harbours, how sick and twisted he is. How he doesn’t just love Mydei, love is too shallow a term for his feelings. He wants to completely own him, body and soul, wants them to be fused together into a singular being, his other half. Wants to entwine himself like a parasite, to crawl inside his skin and live there.

“If… if you say things like that, I’ll misunderstand.” Phainon says, voice small, timid. “I’ll think you’re accepting me, all of me.” Phainon is scared, like he is standing on the precipice. And when he stepped over the edge, there would be no turning back.

Mydei’s voice is abnormally soft as he looks at Phainon and says “The chance to accept you in your entirety is all I’ve ever wanted.”

A choked sob makes its way up Phainon’s throat, which surprises him. Throughout his career he’s been called Aglaea’s protege, a disciplined professional who never complains, whose smile never slips. At work he was known to be so unshakeable, so composed that some had said he was made out of porcelain. Beautiful, flawless, elegant; but tough, difficult to break.

Just like Phainon himself, who appears untouchable.

At least until Mydei brings the hammer, and Phainon falls to pieces around him.

“You’re upset?” Mydei asks, his honeyed eyes dart between Phainon’s face and his hands frantically, like he isn’t sure what to do about the situation. At a total loss, he wipes the back of his hand across Phainon’s cheek, and it comes away wet, streaked with tears.

“I’m happy.” Phainon sniffs. “You asked me earlier what I wanted and I couldn’t answer you. But the answer is you, it’s always been you.”

Mydei blinks at him, speechless.

Phainon continues “If I made you feel otherwise, like I didn’t want you, like you were not important… I’m sorry. I’m so, so sorry Mydei. I don’t know if anything I can ever do will make it up to you, but I’m willing to spend the rest of my life trying.”

And then he asks, slowly, afraid of the answer, the question that had been on his mind ever since Mydei walked out of his life.

“Do you think… you could ever be mine again?”

Phainon’s done a lot of things, said a lot of things that made him feel utterly vulnerable tonight. Flayed himself open for Mydei to judge but this… this one takes the cake. He’d spent years telling himself Mydei didn’t see him as important, that if Mydei truly loved him he wouldn’t have left. Years trying to hide away this twisted and imperfect side of himself. He is a pane of cracked glass barely holding it together, and Mydei is a nail with the ability to completely shatter him with just one word.

Mydei smiles at him, expression softening, beautiful, ethereal, fond. “My heart has been yours from the start. You only needed to come and get it.”

Phainon feels relief flood his chest, his vision goes blurry. Fuck, how could he ever had let this man go? If he could go back in time, he’d strangle the high school version of himself for being so fucking stupid. Sure, they had made up now, finally, but how many years had he wasted? How many years

did he spend being single, miserable, empty? How many times had he lied next to strangers in an attempt to fill the void, regretting all his decisions and loathing himself for the person he'd become?

"I love you." He blurts out, not able to stop all his emotions from leaking out.

"Stupid." Mydei's words are harsh, but his voice is so unbearably gentle. His face looks like he's trying hard to hold back a smile.

"Say it back." Phainon says, tugging at Mydei's clothes, voice soft and weak like a child. Because he's insecure, because he needs the reassurance, because even if he somehow manages to fuck things up again at the very least he can record that soundbite to loop in his mind for all eternity.

Without saying a single word, Mydei leans forward and kisses him.

Phainon's brain freezes for a moment, it takes him a while to process the entire situation. He's overwhelmed, not able to believe that Mydei, *his Mydei*, is actually kissing him. Mydei's hand is cradling his jaw, the damp locks of his bangs are pressing against his forehead, his lips are soft and warm, it's sensory overload, too much.

He feels lightheaded. All his fantasies behind closed doors, in the dead of the night. All the random strangers he kissed to try and replicate just a fragment of the spark couldn't compare to this. They were nothing but pale imitations of the real thing.

Phainon's eyelids flutter shut as he leans forward into Mydei's space, hungry, desperate. It feels good. It feels so good that Phainon thinks he's going to die.

But he'll die happy.

"That's my answer." Mydei pulls away, Phainon stares at the string of saliva that connects their lips together right as it snaps. That's not right, those lips shouldn't be talking, they shouldn't be moving. There is no place those lips should be other than on his.

“I forgot the question,” Phainon says as he dives in for another kiss.

Once he got a taste, he can’t stop. Like the first drop of rain hitting the wheat fields after a long drought, he wants to be like the soil sucking it dry, devouring until there’s nothing left. He pushes forward, their bodies sinking deeper into the couch. Jaw moving as their lips slot together again, and again, and again. A perfect fit.

Like the gods have designed them to fit each other.

An unwelcomed thought enters his mind, it always does when he’s on the verge of being happy. This time it whispers, wondering how Mydei got so good at kissing, confident, smooth, no trace of awkwardness at all. He must have had practice, right?

The intrusive thought refuses to leave, the idea of a faceless person holding Mydei close like this, kissing him on the lips like that. How many times had Mydei given himself to another because Phainon was too stupid to hold onto what’s good for him?

It was his own fault, but the mere thought makes Phainon so jealous that he might explode. He doesn’t blame Mydei, he blames himself, he should never have let him go. All those people who got to kiss Mydei before him should just die.

He deepens the kiss more aggressively now, tracing the shape of Mydei’s teeth with his tongue. He licks around the sharp canine teeth and doesn’t even mind when Mydei bites down and snags against the corner of his lip, nipping the skin with a sharp sting.

“You’re slobbering all over me,” Mydei complains, but he doesn’t break the kiss.

His next move pretty much makes Phainon blue screen.

“Down, boy,” he murmurs. Mydei’s hand moves down to his waist to steady him, gripping him tight. Phainon jolts, and blood rushes to his cock so quickly that it catches Phainon by surprise, and he could do nothing about

the high-pitched whimper that escapes from his lips before he can think twice.

He blinks panickedly as Mydei simply stares at him with an incredulous expression. He can almost read his mind ‘*I was joking, but you liked it that much?’*

Phainon doesn’t know how to explain away what just happened. So he does the only thing he can think of, he sinks his hips down, rubbing his crotch against Mydei’s pants like the disgusting dog in heat that he is.

He feels Mydei smile rather than see it.

“Fucking pervert.”

Well that is the truth, thanks for noticing.

“Hah, finally realized it?” Phainon says, belligerent.

“I thought as much when you asked for my used bathwater. After knowing what I was doing in it? You’re sick.”

He says that, but his hips are moving back and forth against Phainon’s and he’s *hard*, he’s fucking hard so he’s one to talk.

Ugh, why did Mydei have to bring that up? His body seizes and he lets out another groan, cock desperately begging to be touched. He thought he’d gotten rid of his urges earlier, in the bathroom, surrounded by the smell of Mydei. Now that he knew what the man sounded like when he masturbated, how was Phainon ever supposed to be normal again?

“What were you thinking?” Phainon groans, annoyed, sinking his head into Mydei’s chest.

“That I needed to get myself off before I did something stupid.”

“No.” Phainon repeats, frustrated. That wasn’t what he was asking. “I mean. What were you thinking OF?”

“Oh.” Mydei grins at him wolfishly. Mischievous, playful, like he knows he’s about to say something that Phainon won’t like. “You don’t need to know that.”

Phainon should have left it there, he shouldn’t have taken the bait. But Mydei knows him too well, knows just where to prod to rile him up. He crawls onto Mydei, practically climbing him like a tree as he looms over him on the sofa. “Mydei–”

“What if… I wasn’t thinking of you?”

“Don’t… don’t mess around with me.”

Phainon’s brain immediately rejects the statement. Surely it had to be Phainon he was thinking of, there is nobody else, there *cannot* be anyone else. He would have known, would have seen them once or twice, would have some inkling, some sort of crumb.

Completely aware of Phainon’s rapidly deteriorating sanity, Mydei lifts his hips up, grinding against him again, slow and deliberate.

“Why, jealous?”

Phainon is, he sits up, one hand ruffling through his already messy hair.

“So what about it?” He asks, voice quiet, low, dangerous.

“Well, what are you going to do about it?” Mydei smirks. He looks so gorgeous spread out on the sofa like this, even Phainon’s ugly yellow hoodie doesn’t do a single thing to detract from his beauty. His hair lies scattered around his head like a golden halo, and when he tilts his head slightly to regard him, his jawline is so sharp that it could cut glass.

He looks like he knows exactly what he does to Phainon.

Well, if anything happens, he will say that Mydei asked for this. That he was the one who walked into his home, pleasured himself in his bathtub, teased him until he couldn’t take it anymore. That everything that happens after this is his fault.

“Remember that you made me this way.” Phainon says, one final guttural warning before he leans down. “Even if you want to back out, I’m not taking no for an answer.”

Every cell in his body is screaming. *‘Take him, break him, make him yours. Make him see that you are truly meant to be, that there is no point ever thinking of anybody else!’*

“Talk is cheap.” Mydei says, shoving him away playfully. “Prove to me your tenacity.”

Mydei’s playful resistance is no match as their lips meet again, ferocious, unyielding like two waves crashing against each other. The riptide current pulls them closer together, a clash of spit and teeth and tongues. Phainon travels down the side of his neck, feeling Mydei’s tendons grow tense underneath his lips. It makes him want to tease him with a gentle nibble.

Or at least, Phainon had intended to be gentle, he really had, but he was never good at controlling his strength. He bites down a little too hard, and Mydei winces as the taste of iron hits his tongue. He’d sunk in too deeply, but luckily, Mydei is the only one who could take his full strength and give it back in equal measure.

As to prove his point, when Phainon looks into his eyes, Mydei’s gaze is intimidating, almost feral. Phainon licks his canine teeth, still able to taste the blood on them, Mydei’s blood.

But as he pulls away to readjust their positions on the couch, Mydei’s hips thrust upwards to follow him. He wants him so desperately that his body cannot hide it, it’s way too cute.

“Not that I don’t love seeing you in my clothes. But I need you out of that hoodie 5 minutes ago.” If he does not stick his face in between Mydei’s tits right NOW, he is literally going to die.

Mydei shifts his torso slightly to allow Phainon access when he reaches to pull the hoodie off him. But again, Phainon underestimates his own

strength, and in his excitement yanks the hoodie too hard until there's the sound of a huge *rrrrip* and the seams on the side give way.

"Oh," Mydei says, raising an eyebrow in amusement. "No big loss there."

Yeah… Aglaea would probably cry tears of joy. She'd always hated that jacket.

Now that the hoodie is out of the way, Phainon is getting a first class seat to the glorious body that he usually only admires from afar. His tattoos are so vivid up close, sprawling down Mydei's arms, curling around his ribs, the dip between his pecs, and even on his hipbones. Phainon traces the red ink with the pad of his thumb, feeling the smooth skin underneath.

"You're staring." Mydei says.

"They're just too beautiful, can you blame me? The tattoos suit you, I always knew they would."

"You got a tattoo too," Mydei points out. He reaches out to touch the sun inked on his neck, and unlike before, Phainon doesn't pull away.

He'd gotten it done in spite of everyone's advice. It was not encouraged for a model who depended on his face, on his body, on his squeaky clean image to get a huge tattoo somewhere so conspicuous. But Phainon had wanted it. He eventually worked around it by covering it with makeup on shoots, or having it edited out in post, wearing clothes when he was in public that covered up his neck.

But to be honest, he likes it and is proud of it. There's nothing he wanted to do more than parade it out.

"Why did you choose a sun?"

Phainon freezes, embarrassed. He couldn't say that he had been inspired by a past gift he'd fished out of Mydei's old locker like some kind of freak. Besides, there were other reasons he was drawn to sun imagery.

“Well, in Aedes Elysiae the sun is a symbol of good harvest, and my parents always called me their little sunshine!” It’s not lying if he doesn’t tell the complete truth.

Mydei brushes the edge of his thumb against the tattoo fondly, a small smile on his face. “I agree, I always thought the image of a sun suited you.”

Of course Phainon knew that, Mydei was the one who had chosen the sun pin for him in the first place.

He nuzzles his head against Mydei’s chest and says nothing. Even though his torso is so heavily inked, the tattoos don’t go over his nipples. The red line just barely traces the edge of his dark, perky nub, that’s right there in front of his eyes, ripe for the taking.

Phainon quietly whispers his thanks to Kephale, Nikador, and everyone in between for the meal. He starts slowly, laying gentle kisses around the edge. Mydei shudders but doesn’t push him away, which Phainon takes as permission to be bolder. He licks the nub, soft and pliant, pushing down with his tongue and feeling it give way in his mouth.

He feels Mydei’s chest expand as he breathes in, a ragged inhale complete with a moan that sends blood running straight to his cock.

Too horny to think, Phainon acts on instinct, he clasps the bud of his nipple in between his teeth like he thinks milk will flow from it.

Mydei’s jerk of pain is immediate. “HKS!” The familiar curse flows like honey from his tongue. “You…”

“You’re so hard.” Phainon coos, because he can feel the stiffness of his cock right through the fabric of his sweatpants. “You want me so bad.” He teases, because it’s the truth.

“Ugh, I do.” Mydei grumbles. “Even though your stupid shirt is turning me off.”

Phainon looks down at his t-shirt. It’s one of his favourites, well-worn, loose, and comfortable. It’s adorable too, with a picture of two chimeras cuddling with the slogan ‘Awoo means I love you in chimera!’

Phainon looks him straight in the eye and grins.

“Awoo.”

“Shut up!” Mydei groans immediately. But he’s laughing, so Phainon must be doing something right. “Now, kiss me again.”

That’s a request that Phainon would never refuse. Their lips meet each other again, soft and indulgent, there’s no biting, no mashing of tongues, just their lips gently parting around each other. Phainon memorizing the shape of his mouth, the taste of his lips.

His lower half rolls against Mydei in an almost lazy pattern, and every time their dicks brush, Mydei gives a low groan of satisfaction. It feels good for Phainon too, it feels so good that he can’t hide it. He thinks he could cum from dry humping alone, which is pretty pathetic. He promises he’s not a virgin.

“God… Mydei…” Phainon murmurs, he chases the feeling, his aching cock begging for release. Even through the fabric of his pants, the sensation is unbelievably intense and Phainon grinds his hips down harder, pushing deeper.

More, more, it feels so good!

He feels too good.

The sofa shakes and squeaks underneath their combined weight, their bodies writing on the narrow cushions.

“Fuck… Phainon.” Mydei murmurs against his mouth and his voice is almost enough to make Phainon bust his load.

His hips jerk, and then his world flips around.

Phainon sees the ceiling lights fly over his head.

And then he lands on the carpeted floor, hard, all the breath knocked out of him with a loud ‘thump’.

He blinks, seeing stars. What… what just happened?

Mydei looks down at him over the edge of the sofa. From this angle, he truly looks like an angel that’s come down to Amphoreus for the sole purpose of testing Phainon. Golden hair haloed by the light that brushes his forehead and jaw, eyes of molten gold curved into half crescents, and a playful smirk on his face to complete Phainon’s demise.

“Guess the couch is a little small for the both of us.”

“I guess…” Phainon whines, disappointed beyond belief. He’d been so close, a little bit more and he was sure he would have come. His cock withers in his pants. Unwanted, unloved, untouched.

Phainon props himself up with an elbow, reaching for Mydei’s outstretched hand. Instead of getting back up, he decides to pull Mydei down to join him instead. Caught by surprise, Mydei goes tumbling down, landing on top of him.

“HKS! What is the meaning of–” Phainon expertly reverses their positions so that he’s the one pinning Mydei to the floor. Without waiting for him to finish his incredulous question, Phainon starts kissing him again.

He’s waited far too long, he’s waited years for this moment. He’s not going to let anything stop him now.

He squeezes Mydei’s hips between his thighs, feeling the flex of his hipbones against his legs. Mydei is giving resistance, but not enough for Phainon to think that he’s being serious, so he doesn’t relent, squeezing his thighs together harder, pinning Mydei in between them.

Mydei grins at him, sharp and full of teeth, it’s feral and too fucking hot. It’s obvious he’s turned on based on his heavy breathing and flushed face.

And the erect cock pushing against the front of his pants is also quite evident.

His body is on fire, Phainon is burning alive on the inside, and he desperately needs release. Hot, it's too hot.

Phainon reaches for the hem of his t-shirt, tugging it over his head and out of the way.

Mydei's honeyed eyes trace over his bare torso, and Phainon preens at the way his gaze lingers on his finely sculpted muscles and the biceps that he was so proud of. Phainon knows he looks good, his body is his livelihood, after all. And while he's used to people gawking at his body constantly, it doesn't mean he likes it. Most people looked at him like he was a slab of meat, not a human being.

But all those hours spent in the gym molding his body into something undeniably attractive was all worth it when Mydei stares at him with such lust in his eyes.

"You have another tattoo?" Mydei traces his index finger over the gold line etched across his chest like a chain.

"Y-yeah." Phainon shivers slightly at the contact, not ready for Mydei's cool finger as it runs across his sensitive nipple.

Mydei tilts his head to the side, as if assessing his opinion. Phainon feels exceptionally vulnerable under his gaze.

"Sexy." He concludes. That single word makes all the blood in Phainon's body go on a pilgrimage from his brain to his cock.

"*Fuck*." Phainon nearly doubles over with want, voice a hoarse whimper. He humps Mydei's body pathetically, the friction rubbing against his cock bringing tears to his eyes. It's so annoying, he wants nothing more than to rip his pants off, rip Mydei's pants off and touch him without anything getting in the way. But it just feels too good right now.

He knows Mydei is enjoying himself too, if his heavy breathing and grunts of pleasure are any indication. Mydei's eyelashes flutter shut and a hoarse groan tears out from his throat as their bare chests rub against each other, slick with sweat.

"Mydei…" He pants, aware that his tongue is lolling out of his mouth and not being able to do a damn thing about it. "Need you…"

"Yeah…" Mydei runs his hand down Phainon's abs, fingers tracing the curves and dips of his muscles like he's playing the piano. The touch is cool and lightly ticklish and Phainon feels his hips buck again as Mydei's hand stops shy just above the drawstring of his pants.

Phainon's hands are shaking as he reaches downwards for his cock. If he can just reach down there, touch himself a little bit… Phainon is sure he will come in seconds.

"Don't you fucking dare," Mydei orders. Phainon's hands snap to his sides obediently on command.

Mydei's head moves lower, which initially makes Phainon panic, because there's no reason, *no reason*, for Mydei to prostrate himself. But then he stops at the edge of Phainon's sweatpants, face close enough to his erect cock to kiss it, and then Phainon panics for an entirely different reason.

"This, this is mine." He toys with the string of Phainon's sweatpants by taking the tip into his mouth and pulling with his teeth, his intent unmistakable. Phainon is going to go crazy while he can do nothing but watch, whimper, and maybe drool a little.

"Yours!" Phainon digs his fingers into his carpet, anchoring himself. Repeats the words like a mantra, eager to please. "I'm yours!"

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Really?" He presses his cheek against Phainon's erection, opens his jaw and gently nibbles against Phainon's—still fully clothed, by the way—cock with his front teeth. It's such a teasing sensation and Phainon can't feel more than something lightly pressing against his cock, but that only makes it all the worse.

Because with this view in front of him, Phainon's imagination proceeds to fill in the empty spaces. Mydei's lips around his shaft, taking his entire cock in his mouth, his tongue licking his quivering, eager, dick. His hips buckle again just thinking about it, and Phainon just barely stops himself from creaming his pants right there and then.

"Look at you, when did you get hot? So sexy, always in the public eye. You have so many fans." Mydei juts his lower lip out in a pout, but his eyes are sharp, hungry. "What makes me so special?"

Under any other circumstances, Phainon would have caught on that Mydei was just teasing, not being serious. But Phainon isn't thinking properly, his mind is a haze. He wants to prove to Mydei, more than anything, that he'll be the most loyal man in the world. He means it, he'll change every part of himself if it meant that Mydei would never leave him again.

"The modelling stuff doesn't matter. The fame, money, fans, none of that matters." Phainon finds himself saying, words tumbling over each other in their haste. "I'll quit if you want me to! I'll block all my friends, delete my socials, disappear from the public eye."

Mydei paused in his movements, eyes wide open with shock.

"I was just joking, there is no need to go that far."

"I'm not joking!" Phainon emphasizes, eyes wild, desperate. "We can move to Castrum Kremnos together, or stay in Okhema, or go somewhere else. I don't care. I have some savings from my job. I could be your stay at home husband while you work on your music career. Being in the spotlight isn't important to me."

Mydei is gaping at him, jaw hanging open. Bet he hadn't realized that Phainon took it so seriously, that he had put a *lot* of thought into this.

His bottom lip quivers, barely noticeable before Mydei's pulling himself together and roughly tugging down Phainon's pants with reckless abandon. "You… You're a fool! Fuck you… ugh, fuck me!" He grabs Phainon's

exposed cock with urgency before he has any time to process what's happening right now.

Before he realizes it, Phainon gasps as his cock is enveloped by something warm and wet. (Mydei's mouth!), and he can feel the tip hitting the back of something hard (Mydei's throat!), feel something soft and hot running up his shaft (Mydei's tongue!), the edges of something sharp as it lightly scrapes across his sensitive foreskin (Mydei's teeth!).

There is no time at all to register this when the only thought flying through his head is 'Oh my god, holy shit, Mydei is giving me a blowjob' and he suddenly, abruptly, unceremoniously cums—hard—into Mydei's mouth.

"*Aaah*-" Phainon says out loud, his legs feeling like jelly as cold sweat drips down his spine. The mortification hits him like a train, that he came way too fast, way too early the moment he had been touched. "I'm sorry! Spit it out Mydei, spit it–"

Mydei makes a face as his throat bobs, and when he opens his mouth Phainon can't see anything but remnants of stubborn cum sticking to his teeth and the sides of his gums.

His first mortified thought was that Mydei swallowed it.

His second thought was that the sight of Mydei with cum in his mouth might be getting him hard again.

"I was hoping you'd have more fight in you." Mydei licks his teeth clean in a way that reminds him of a lion finishing a hunt.

"Oh… I do." Phainon gulps. He could go all night, he could probably go for 10 days straight. His body doesn't know what a refractory period is, all it knows is that he needs Mydei so badly right now that he might spontaneously combust if he's denied any further.

Mydei seems to feel the same way as he kisses him again, Phainon can almost taste himself on Mydei's tongue. "Yeah… fuck me, Phainon. I want you to…" Mydei murmurs in between heated kisses.

And he did not know a single soul, human or otherwise, who would say no to that request, not when Mydei is looking at him so needily.

Mydei doesn't deserve his cold, hard floor. Mydei deserves his bed, where he'll pound him until the mattress rips and the bedboard snaps. Make him feel so good he would never think about anyone else ever again.

Yeah, that sounds like a plan.

He scoops Mydei up into his arms, carrying him like he's a princess. He hears Mydei gasp, arms instinctively curling around his shoulders, thighs protectively grasping his hips as though he's afraid Phainon might drop him.

"Fucking… hell…" Mydei curses, face burning. But it was obvious from the smile that he tried to bury in the crook of Phainon's neck that he liked it.

He'd tried holding himself back, giving Mydei ample chances to leave. But now that he had willingly walked into his trap, there was no going back.

Phainon won't let him go, now.

Chapter End Notes

Song of the day: Tonight You Are Mine by The Technicolors
Spotify playlist

I wasn't sure if Mydei would get his nipples tattooed over, since hoyoverse characters models are nippleless, therefore i spent a lot of time studying Mydei's shirtless pics - for SCIENCE. I take my research VERY seriously.

The next chapter is almost completely smut guys I don't know what came over me. Phaidei are so hot I just get possessed and keep writing about how hot they are pls send help-

Amazing Artwork by fanumonu on twitter thank you so much!!! Mydei looks so hot here I'm- BARKBARKBARKBARK- sorry I got possessed by Phainon for a sec

Chapter 7: I'm the Jealous Type

Chapter Summary

Phainon spreads Mydei’s legs open, feeling the thigh muscles twitch underneath his touch. Fuuuck…. These strong tattooed thighs have been driving him crazy whilst they were wrapped around his waist. What Phainon wouldn’t do to just sandwich his head between these muscular legs and maybe have Mydei squeeze his neck a little…

The idea is enough to make him drool.
Some food for thought for another day.

Phainon’s shaky fingers reach for the lube, always kept conveniently in the drawer nearest to the bed for when he got some… late night urges. But he’s clumsy, a little too excited, and he accidentally spills way too much when he meant to apply only just a dab. The way the sticky, clear liquid drips down his fingers looks obscene.

If only that were Mydei’s bodily fluids instead.

Chapter Notes

When you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, want the Mydei hole but I, the evil and intimidating horse, make you go through 8k words of begging and crashouts first.

Before reading, please check the tags again as I've updated some of them and make sure you're okay with it before proceeding! I finished this chapter a few days ago and sat on it for a bit thinking of how to tag.

Additional content warning: This chapter contains discussions of Phainon's previous sex life (and the obvious implications of him being not a virgin). Yes he will crash out about it, there will be groveling. The angst is minor, imho, but I think it's safer to just warn anyway.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Small, dainty, and delicate are words that could never be used to describe Mydei. He’s built like a brick wall, a gladiator, even a goliath, you might say.

So when Phainon picks him up and carries him like he weighs as little as a feather, it makes his knees go a little bit weak. He grabs onto Phainon’s neck, feels his strong biceps flex underneath his weight, and uses the loss of balance as an excuse to feel him up a little more.

The gesture is stupid and romantic and something Mydei never imagined he would ever be the recipient of, so yeah, his heart is racing, sue him.

He’s not completely blinded by love to realize that something is deeply wrong with Phainon. Something possessive and unsettling that makes him unhealthily dependent on Mydei. If Cipher, Castorice or other sane minds were around, they’d tell him to run far, far away. Stalking, invasion of privacy, non-consensual photography, the red flags lined the runway.

If Mydei so desired, he could probably report him to the police, he has enough evidence to completely ruin him.

But he’d never do that.

Because Mydei fucking loves it.

He loves being the object of Phainon’s all encompassing obsession, that despite all these years, he’s never left his mind. That Mydei’s own madness is reflected back at him, reciprocated tenfold. That even in a room full of people, Phainon’s eyes will always seek him out. While he is beloved by so many people, practically a celebrity, Mydei holds him in the palm of his hand, able to crush him with a single thoughtless word.

If Phainon is trash, then so is Mydei. Because there’s a twisted part of him that loves the chase, loves being pursued, and loves the freefall of not knowing what comes next.

Despite outward appearances, they had always been two mirrored images. If soulmates existed, how lucky he was to find his without even needing to search for it.

He can’t believe Phainon is his.

“Phainon.” He says, and when Phainon snaps his head to look at him, the obedient puppy that he is, Mydei kisses him, tongue and teeth and all. His arms latch around his neck so tightly it leaves stripes of red against his pale skin. Mydei makes a grab for the short hairs around his nape, yanking enough to make Phaion tilt his head back, deepening the kiss.

Mydei feels Phainon’s previously sturdy arms shake, possibly from exhaustion, possibly also from desire. Phainon wobbles on his feet, losing his balance and stumbling, ramming himself into the wall. Mydei jostles in his hold, the force strong enough to send tremors down his spine.

“If you drop me, I’ll never let you hear the end of it.”

“You think too little of me.” Phainon grins, boyish and mischievous. Mydei thinks he’d like to kiss that cocky smirk off his lips, so he does.

Mydei pulls away to enjoy the view. Phainon’s face is flushed a deep scarlet, his eyes are glazed, pupils so dark they resemble an eclipse. His mouth hangs open stupidly, his hair is sticking out all over the place, and his eyes are slightly crossed.

Somehow he looks hotter than ever. It’s almost unfair, really.

Mydei wants him, carnally, sinfully, instinctively. It curls in his gut and begs for release, hot and heavy.

It’s funny, he never really considered himself a person with a high libido. That isn’t to say he didn’t have urges, of course he did, he was only a man. He just never thought it… important to have sexual intimacy with someone, especially a person whom he didn’t have feelings for.

But well, when he saw Phainon again tonight he realized it wasn't that he was above sexual desire. It was simply that he didn't want to give himself over to anyone other than the best. And the desperation Phainon is showing him now is ticking all his boxes.

It's like he hadn't even recognized he was starving until a whole buffet was spread in front of him.

And now, what else can he say but bon appetit?

Phainon passes through the doorway of his bedroom, turning Mydei slightly to the side to avoid his legs bumping into the frame. He shuts the door using his hips, and it closes behind them with a soft click.

His room is so quiet, to the point that Mydei can hear his own heavy breathing as Phainon gently sets him down upon the bed. And then, to his absolute chagrin, he hears Phainon gasp before his body warmth disappears.

The bedsheets are cold as they press against his bare back. Indeed, Phainon has the audacity to leave him high and dry.

But still, not wanting to break the moment, Mydei waits patiently. Ten seconds, twenty seconds…

He hears the scuffling of someone moving around the room. It's so dark that he can't really see anything but the ceiling above him.

"Hey." He grunts out impatiently.

"Sorry, just a second!" Phainon calls back, his voice is clearly still in the room, but distant enough for Mydei to know that he's not within grabbing distance.

What could Phainon be so busy with now that Mydei is here, eager and willing, half naked in his bed? Is this not the most important thing to both of them right now? He shouldn't be doing… whatever it is that he's doing. Phainon's muscular torso should be leaning over him, messy white hair

falling over his vision, Mydei staring up at nothing but eyes as blue as the morning sky.

Well Mydei isn't the kind of man who just sits and waits for things to fall into his lap, he'll take it for himself. Mydei rises up from the bed, erection painfully hard in his pants, groping around blindly for Phainon so that he may physically *drag* him back to bed.

His hand hits the wall, feeling the smooth paper of something stuck onto its surface, a poster or some sort.

"Ah— wait— Mydei that's–" Phainon's voice is unusually panicked as the lights flicker on and Mydei gets the fright of his life.

For a moment he thought he'd seen a doppleganger, or a phantom.

But no, he's not seeing double. Right there on the wall smack dab opposite the bed is a giant poster of none other than himself.

What… the fuck.

Mydei's mouth opens and closes several times as his brain buffers, trying to think of something to say. It ultimately decides to give up, and Mydei is left with his jaw hanging open like an idiot as he stares at this massive blown-up image of himself.

The *Titans of Calamity* had never sold anything like this, because the three of them curate every piece of merchandise individually. He would know, he would know if something this ridiculous was in their catalogue because he would have never allowed this to see the light of day. Nobody would buy this! Nobody would be this fucking *insane!*

But yet there it is, his photograph printed out in glossy HD. It's at least 4 feet tall and depicts Mydei mid-performance, mouth open in a snarl. One side of his loose collared shirt is already slipping off his sweaty shoulder, exposing a generous helping of muscles and tattoos. The picture is of such good quality that he can even see the beads of sweat on his own neck and forehead.

Okay that's… barely within the realm of normalcy, it's normal for fans to have posters of their idols in their bedrooms and stuff, right? Even if Phainon never told him that he was a fan, and also it's kind of weird to idolize someone you've previously dated, and Mydei is just some nobody artist who didn't even have a recording contract until today.

But the gaze of the Mydei from the poster, the beastly amber eyes that seem to almost glow in the dim bedroom lighting. His gaze is directed straight ahead, right at the bed.

Seriously, who'd want their ex's unblinking 2D gaze on them as they slept. Or to be the first thing they saw when they woke up and opened their eyes, or even… while they jacked themselves off in the middle of the night in the comfort of their own room?

Yeah, Mydei understands why Phainon never had guests over. How could he even begin to explain this?

He meets Phainon's gaze, still wide eyed and panicked like a deer in the headlights—or maybe a dog in the headlights. He's still, unmoving like a statue. In his arms he holds a variety of other band merch, and most likely had been in the process of hiding it or clearing it out before Mydei caught him in the act.

"I can explain." Phainon whimpers.

Mydei's gaze shifts to the pile in his arms, there's even more here. DIY band posters, a physical EP that he swears they only distributed to friends, a couple of brightly coloured wristbands that Castorice made for him that he *thought* he'd lost at a particularly rowdy gig. And there was more displayed in his room that Phainon had yet to clean up. Among them, a worn out guitar pick of Mydei's preferred brand that has a protective casing around it like some kind of treasure instead of the junk that it actually is.

Mydei's breath hitches, the sight in front of him needs no explanation. "You made me a shrine."

He’d heard about these before, proof of someone’s adoration towards a fictional character, idol, or celebrity. He thought these were reserved for people who were famous, whose existence was so profound, so meaningful that they altered the course of another person’s life. For someone who was so out of reach that they were practically deified.

Phainon opens his mouth like he wants to say something, and then closes it again, voice dying in his throat.

“But why?” Mydei repeats like a broken record.

Who does that?

Who even fucking does that?

Mydei should feel freaked out, he knows he should. This is not normal, *can’t* be normal. Red flags? Hell, this is a red carpet.

And yet…

He’s so aroused that he’s going to cum in his pants if Phainon makes him wait any longer.

The explanations can wait.

“Why are you trying to hide your collection now? If you don’t come over here to kiss and fuck me right this instance, I’m punching you through the wall that has my face on it.”

“Not my poster!” Phainon says, which takes the award for the most loser shit he’s ever said and he has said a lot. Mydei doesn’t even remember ever seeing this picture of himself so this was definitely custom printed. He hopes Phainon paid the photographer a fortune for it, he hopes they milked him dry.

“The real thing is already here, so what are you waiting for?” Mydei growls, and that’s the one line that finally makes the gears click in Phainon’s head.

That he’s still here, that he’s somehow still into him against all odds, even though Phainon is a certified freak.

“...Fuck.” Phainon says, dropping everything in his arms in favour of ravishing the real thing on the bed.

Phainon’s cock is already hard as it rubs against his body. It hadn’t been that long ago that he came into his mouth, and yet it seems he’s ready to go again. This man has no refractory period, another absolutely ludicrous fact about his body. But this much is only to be expected of the only man worthy of being Mydei’s other half.

Mydei wraps his arms around Phainon’s broad shoulders to pull him closer and kiss him again. The return kiss is eager, passionate, some might say a little too much. He winces as Phainon accidentally bites down and presses on the bruise that’s already there. The guy has always been poor at controlling his own strength, like an overexcitable large dog that doesn’t know when he’s hurting others. Or maybe he does know, and a part of him enjoys it. Or maybe Mydei’s just weird and likes it when it hurts a little because it makes him feel alive. Or maybe they were both just freaks, that seemed like the likelier option.

“Mydei… please, I need to feel you.” Phainon practically pants into his mouth, his hands are roving all over Mydei’s body like he doesn’t know which part he enjoys groping more. His abs, his chest, or maybe his butt, from the way Phainon moans when he reaches behind to cup a squeeze.

Mydei does his part to wriggle out of his pants when Phainon tugs it off him, and then his underwear until his cock is exposed, flush and erect against the cool air. Phainon inhales shakily as he gazes at it, his eyes dark and his face flushed. Mydei can only imagine what he must be thinking right now.

Slowly, Phainon looms over him until his shadow completely engulfs Mydei, his hand settles carefully, almost reverently on his cock. The sight makes heat churn in Mydei’s gut because Phainon’s hand is so big that it almost envelopes his dick when he wraps his fingers around it. What do they feed the children from Aedes Elysiae?

And then, Phainon starts stroking. Up and down, gentle pumping motions that make Mydei's hips jerk up and his teeth clench. His hands are rough, callouses on his palms from lifting weights, and they rub against his sensitive skin, the friction ripping through his nerve endings.

"Ah— faster." Mydei manages to choke out between gritted teeth, his hips are moving alongside Phainon's hand, up and down but it's not enough. He needs more, all this teasing is driving him crazy. He lifts up his legs, wraps them around Phainon's hips and squeezes.

"*Fu-fuck*, Mydei." Phainon pants, a thin line of drool slipping out from the corner of his lip and dripping onto his chest..

And despite feeling so good that his back arches off the mattress, that his sweaty fingers are leaving wrinkles on the perfectly pristine bedsheets as they clench down, that his thighs squeak as they slide over Phainon's sweat soaked skin. Mydei still has it within himself to snark "That's what I'm hoping for."

"Be patient." Phainon snarks back, his teeth stark white as he matches Mydei's feral grin. His own cock is tenting in those sweat pants that are trying their valiant best to contain it.

"*Asshole*." Mydei isn't sure if he's calling Phainon an asshole, or he's telling him where to put it. Both, maybe.

"J-just let me enjoy the view a little longer. You're beautiful, Mydei." Phainon praises, catching him totally off guard. "If only you could see yourself right now. You look… unreal, it's driving me insane."

Mydei doesn't see it, he thinks he looks like a mess. Hair sticking to his temples with sweat, body contorted in a weird position, dick erect and leaking and aching to be touched, and he doesn't even want to know what kind of face he's making but it can't be anything pretty. And yet Phainon… what, thinks he's beautiful?

"You don't need to flatter me." He says flatly. Mydei doesn't need compliments or false praises, and he dislikes empty words. He's plenty

turned on as it is already anyway so further foreplay would just drive him crazy! When is Phainon going to stick it in already?

“Flattery?” Phainon pauses in his gentle stroking, and Mydei releases a noise that sounds very much like a mewl as he rocks himself back and forth in an effort to keep the pleasure going. Something in the air has changed, he can feel it, like he stepped on the wrong stone in a path full of traps. “Oh, if you think I’m flattering you. You’re solely mistaken.”

Mydei scowls, he’s not very sure he wants to have this conversation right now. Can’t they just bury it and carry on? Like they’ve always done?

“I know what you’re thinking.” Phainon says in a sing-song voice. “You’re thinking… can he just get on and fuck me already? When my cock is so dripping wet already.” And just to punctuate his point, he gives Mydei’s cock a single jerk.

Mydei’s legs, still wrapped around Phainon, clench so hard that the man bends over and wheezes. He looks like Mydei was one step away from snapping his spine but yet, he’s grinning like he enjoys it, masochist. “If you know, then *get on with it*.”

“Oh… Mydeimos.” Phainon hums, totally ignoring his impatience. “Would you consider quitting your music career?”

A ridiculous notion.

“You know I won’t. I love what I do.” Others had warned him that the path was tough, but once Mydei made up his mind, nothing would stray him from it.

“Hmm…” Phainon hums, and then he murmurs, soft enough for Mydei to barely make out “I should have thought as much.”

And then he says, a little louder. “You’ll hit it big, I know it. You guys are good. Amazing, even.”

Mydei knows it, he believes that. He always gives his 110% in whatever he's doing so he knows they're going to hit it big or die trying. But the way Phainon phrases it isn't just praise, it feels like a double edged sword and Mydei is dancing on the tip.

But luckily he's never really been afraid of playing with fire.

"What? Is Mr. Famous Model jealous?"

Mydei raises his gaze to regard Phainon, he's still smiling pleasantly but it's not reaching his eyes. The blue is sharp, icy, calculative as it regards Mydei like it's contemplating whether he wants to eat him up now or save him for later.

"Jealous? Oh, you haven't seen me jealous." Phainon says, voice low. Mydei simply raises an eyebrow. Oh, so chasing away some random guy he'd been talking to was not 'jealousy'. Trying to hack his phone password so that he could peek at his messages was also not 'jealousy'.

"They'll be people fawning all over you. Obsessed with you, listening to your songs on repeat, putting up posters of you."

Phainon pauses to flick his head backwards, motioning to the gigantic poster on the wall. "Like that."

Mydei's gaze follows the flick of his hair, and he grimaces at the sight.

"So?"

"I can live with that. I can… force myself to live with that. But other people thinking that they know you? I hate that."

His hand squeezes Mydei's cock enough to keep the blood circulating, keeping the pleasure from fading. Mydei grits his teeth again, feeling the bedsheets slide beneath his back.

"They'll never know you like I know you." He says it like a threat, but it's the sweetest threat that Mydei has ever heard.

Mydei just chuckles low in his throat, he loves this man. If this is the real Phainon, then he's in love with him. "You're crazy." It comes out more lovesick than he'd like because he's fond, so unbelievably smitten.

"You're the reason I'm crazy, so you better take responsibility. I have to let the whole world know you're mine." Phainon kisses him again, languid and slow, staking his claim. His one hand massages the flesh of Mydei's thigh, while the other continues stroking Mydei's cock. First gently, then not-so-gently, Phainon speeds up his movements, and Mydei gasps, vision flooding with stars.

"I hope you can live up to your promises." He barely manages to eke out in between heavy breaths and muffled grunts. "I have– *hngh*– I have high expectations."

Phainon's head drops forward, focusing all his attention on stroking Mydei. Beads of sweat pool on his temple and make their lazy descent down the sides of his face. Mydei kind of wants to lick it off him, if only he could reach that far.

His hand is moving faster and faster, Mydei starts to shift his hips at how unbelievably good it feels. "Phainon… slow down… I can't…"

Phainon's hand stops moving, as he requests. But it doesn't really, because his thumb is still massaging the tip of Mydei's cock, precum dribbling in rivulets down the bone of his knuckle. He shifts his fingers away from his shaft, and to Mydei's dismay and delight starts tracing the outlines of the veins etched on the side of his balls.

"Fuck." His hips buck upwards again, not expecting how sensitive they were.

"Good?" Phainon asks coyly like he doesn't know how much Mydei is unravelling before him.

"*Ah*– good– *fuck*, it's." Mydei doesn't get to finish his sentence before his brain gets overridden. His abs muscles clench with effort as he cums, white splattering across his abdomen. The areas where it overlaps with his tattoos

turns pink, cum beads onto his smooth skin, dropping into the dips of his abs, which are heaving as he breathes heavily from the overstimulation.

“Wha–” Mydei’s cry is aborted by a sharp whine as something warm and wet runs up his belly. Phainon’s tongue. Phainon is *licking* the cum off him, tongue rolling around the rise and dip of his abs as though he can’t even waste a single drop.

Mydei thinks he might spontaneously combust at the sight of Phainon lying in between his legs, face flushed, expression horny as sin, licking cum off his skin. He decides that nothing else in life matters when Phainon licks his lips clean, making sure to catch the final droplets off the tip of his tongue, before his dark pupils lazily flick to Mydei’s direction.

“All clean~” he croons. His tone is innocent, but the look in his eyes is anything but.

A belated shiver travels up Mydei’s spine. It was like someone had flicked a switch in Phainon. From a pathetic loser who almost cried at being caught red-handed hoarding weird merch, now composed, languid, like a predatory toying with prey. Mydei can almost feel the weight of his gaze on him, pressing against his chest.

And Mydei wants him so bad he could fall onto his knees and worship at the altar.

Phainon tilts his head, white hair falling over his eyes, regarding Mydei quietly.

“The look on your face is driving me crazy.” He says. “If I lose control, then this is all your fault, you know. I’m not going to stop even if you beg or cry.”

Mydei’s smile is reflexive, involuntary. Oh, if he thinks Mydei is going to be begging for him to *stop*, he’s not familiar with his stamina.

“The only thing I’ll be crying about is how slow you’re being. Before I die of old age, if you please.”

~*~

When his prince asks him so sweetly, what else can Phainon do but comply? Of course, he's eager to please.

Phainon spreads Mydei's legs open, feeling the thigh muscles twitch underneath his touch. Fuuuck…. These strong tattooed thighs have been driving him crazy whilst they were wrapped around his waist. What Phainon wouldn't do to just sandwich his head between these muscular legs and maybe have Mydei squeeze his neck a little…

The idea is enough to make him drool.

Some food for thought for another day.

Phainon's shaky fingers reach for the lube, always kept conveniently in the drawer nearest to the bed for when he got some… late night urges. But he's clumsy, a little too excited, and he accidentally spills way too much when he meant to apply only just a dab. The way the sticky, clear liquid drips down his fingers looks obscene.

If only that were Mydei's bodily fluids instead.

Phainon swallows, shaking his head—and those thoughts—out of his mind. He spreads his fingers in between Mydei's ass cheeks and feels the man shiver. The skin there is warm, much warmer than the rest of his body. And while Phainon knows it's impossible, that he's imagining things, it feels almost like it's scalding him.

"Is this okay?" He asks carefully, suddenly nervous. He's wanted this for longer than he daren't admit, but he doesn't want it to be just his pleasure alone. He wants, no, he *needs* for Mydei to feel good too, to know that he isn't just empty talk. Wants to be the one that makes him feel so good that he keeps coming back again and again, even if he has options, even if there's other people vying for his attention, even when Mydei finally realizes he's too good for Phainon and always has been.

He wants Mydei to choose him over and over, forever and ever.

That is… a lot of pressure to put himself under.

“Just put it in. *HKS!*” Mydei snaps, a shaky, guttural noise that betrays his true feelings, more telling than the way his thighs are shaking.

Phainon puts in one finger, hearing Mydei wince and clench involuntarily. It’s tight inside, and warm, and wet.

“You’re so tight, baby.” The pet name unconsciously slips out of his lips, and at the sound of it Mydei groans and his hole clenches again, grips Phainon even tighter as though he wants to suck him inside.

“Don’t call me that.” Mydei complains, though the way his body is reacting so positively is telling a different story.

Phainon wordlessly slips in a second finger, revelling at how gorgeous Mydei looks as he hisses and bucks his hips at the additional stimulation. His own cock is throbbing in anticipation but he resists for now, he doesn’t want to come until he’s inside Mydei.

“If only you knew what you’re doing to me right now. I’m so hard for you, I want to be inside you so badly.” He moves his fingers in and out, in and out, feeling Mydei’s sphincter gradually relax as he does so. The poor, abused sweatpants he’s wearing that has seen too much this evening is damp with various bodily fluids. He wants to take them off, wants to touch Mydei skin to skin, just a little bit more, they’re almost there…

“Then hurry it up! Your fingers are—*ah*—they’re doing *nothing* for me!” That’s a bald faced lie from the way he’s clenching and moaning every time Phainon even does so much as shift. But he’s loosening up, relaxing enough for Phainon to slide a third finger in.

“Are you sure? Because you’re taking them in so well.” Phainon spreads them apart slightly, pressing gently on the walls to find out what makes him moan the loudest. “You’re just naturally talented at this are you?”

Or maybe he’s had practice. Phainon pushes down a little harder than he intends to but from the way Mydei almost mewls, he knows he’s hit the jackpot.

“I want to make you feel good, Mydei. What position do you like? Face to face? Facing away? I’ll be happy with whichever way you have me.” Phainon says, as he pulls his fingers out only to hastily tug off his own pants and underwear, stretching out the fabric with how roughly he was pulling.

He can’t believe he’s here, one step away from consummating his love to Mydei. Maybe he’ll fall off the bed, hit his head, and realize he’d been in a coma this whole time. It just seemed too good to be true.

“I don’t fucking know.” Mydei snaps, writhing in annoyance at being empty, even if it was just for a second. Patience, be patient, it won’t be long till Phainon fills him up again. “It’s not like I’ve done it before, just do whatever you think would feel good.”

Phainon pauses in the middle of kicking his pants to the floor, one side of the fabric hanging comically in the air. “Wait. Y-you’re a virgin?”

For the first time that evening Mydei looks insecure. His cheeks flush a vibrant red as he stares at a random point on the ceiling and says almost defensively. “Is that going to be a problem?”

Phainon scrambles back on all fours until his butt nearly touches the edge of the bed. Is it a problem? His body says not at all! His cock says the idea of taking Mydei’s virginity is enough to make him come… again and that he needs to save this memory for future masturbation material. His lizard brain says he better hurry up and claim that before Mydei changes his mind.

But his rational brain, the one teeny, tiny part of himself that’s still sane protests.

“I… I can’t take your virginity!”

Mydei sits up, golden eyes flashing. His entire body is glistening with sweat, chest still rising and falling hard from his heavy breathing. His hair hangs wild and damp, strands sticking to his forehead, his cheeks, and his neck. Annoyed, he sweeps his bangs back with his hand, exposing Phainon to his sharp features and the full blast of his glare.

He only utters one single word in a guttural growl.

"*What*?"

And now, this gorgeous and furious demigod is looking at Phainon like he wants to smite him like a bug. Phainon certainly *feels* like a cockroach, like he's nothing more than garbage. If he could travel back in time and take back all the times he'd ever had sex with another person he would, he would!

Because if he's going to be Mydei's first, then Mydei should have been his first as well.

Phainon scrambles to explain himself, his fingers digging uselessly into the bedsheets. "I… I'm not good enough for that!"

All these years and Mydei waited, never taking another lover, not even a convenient lay. Of course, Phainon isn't delusional enough to think that the restraint was meant for him, Phainon, in particular. But this must mean that sex isn't something casual for Mydei, it's something important. That whoever he deems worthy to give himself to must be someone truly special.

And Phainon… Well he's not proud to admit it, but in the past few years he'd devolved into the kind of person that would sleep with any warm body that reminded him of Mydei. Or at the very least, he'd try to get into their pants. Even if he often bolted out halfway before anything could really happen, even if he built himself a reputation as a player, even if he made his friends' lives a living hell the next morning with all his moping.

Because he had *tried* to distract himself and forget but every empty encounter just leaves him feeling hollower, lonelier.

He doesn’t deserve Mydei.

“What the fuck… you already put your fingers up my ass. You couldn’t have said this earlier?” Mydei sounds genuinely mad, he sounds like he actually wants to wring his neck.

“It’s just–” Phainon trips over his words. “I’m not!”

“Not what?”

“--not a virgin.” He ends up whimpering.

Mydei simply stares at him for what seems like a long time.

“I know,” he says flatly. “Wasn’t expecting you to be.”

“If it bothers you so much, I could go and lose my virginity to someone else first–”

“NO!”

Mydei’s eyes widen slightly with shock at Phainon’s explosive outburst.

Before he realizes it, Phainon is moving on a hunter’s instinct. He pins Mydei to the bed, planting his arms on both sides of Mydei’s head, caging him in. “Don’t even think about it.” His words are low, guttural and dangerous, he can barely recognize his own voice.

To be honest, the intensity of emotions that flare up at that statement even scares himself a little. Phainon just knows that that would be the worst case scenario, the one thing he absolutely cannot allow to happen. The mere idea of Mydei walking into someone else's arms throws his stomach into knots, makes his head spin, makes him possessive and territorial like an animal in heat.

Mydei just tilts his chin up at him coolly, unfazed by Phainon’s aggressive outburst. “Then there is nothing to discuss further. Continue.”

Phainon hesitates still, because he feels something in the air change, something is wrong. He's asking Phainon to continue but… Mydei's body language is closed off, his walls are coming back up. When the tip of his cock touches his entrance, even his hole feels like it's tightening up again, clenching up when Phainon tries to enter. Mydei doesn't say anything, would never say anything to voice his discomfort—Phainon is well aware of his penchant for suffering in silence—but there's a furrow in between his brows.

He's in pain, not just physically, but it's obvious that their conversation bothered him.

Phainon pauses, a wave of self-loathing rolling over him that makes him sick. This is because of him, he hurt Mydei, he put that expression on his face.

"I… I can't do it." Phainon whimpers, holding himself back even though a part of him wants to pound Mydei until there's a hole in the bed in the shape of their entwined silhouettes. "I'm hurting you."

"A bit of pain is to be expected on penetration," Mydei explains to him condescendingly like he's 5. "Though you would know that, given your 'experience'."

Phainon's breath hitches, there it is. "I knew it. You're not okay. It bothers you."

Mydei bares his teeth in what looks like a snarl, then he turns his head to face the wall, anything but looking at Phainon. "Of course it bothers me! But it's not like we can change the past!"

The lowlight highlights the sharp angle of his jaw, the spread of blood red hair on the pillow, he looks unreal, like something carved out of marble instead of flesh and blood. He's so beautiful, truly like an angel descended to the mortal realm. Phainon doesn't deserve him at all.

"It's not like you can go back in time and get back the firsts that should have belonged to me. There is nothing either of us can do but move

forward.”

Those lines hit Phainon like a dump truck. Mydei is right, of course, he often is, and Phainon knows that the concept of virginity is archaic, outdated, irrelevant. But the thought makes him feel miserable, absolutely wrenched anyway.

There is nothing he can do to undo what has already been done. Of course, there are a lot of firsts that do belong to Mydei: His first kiss, his first relationship, the first time he falls so deeply in love with someone that there is a gnawing hole in his chest when they’re not around. But there are a lot of others that should have belonged to him, and were squandered away on some fleeting, meaningless encounters instead. First time getting drunk together, first time stumbling into bed, all entangled limbs and writhing bodies, finding their clumsy way around in the dark. First time falling asleep beside someone and waking up next to the same person.

All these firsts were wasted on strangers that he didn’t even like. Who he only picked because they bore a passing resemblance to the man he actually loved.

He’ll never get those back.

The regret weighs him down like an anchor, thick and suffocating. And for the first time, he is at a loss. He doesn’t have an explanation that can justify his actions, doesn’t have a plan to appease Mydei’s wrath, he doesn’t even have an excuse to hide behind. Whatever pain he felt from that breakup, he’s sure Mydei suffered double. And yet the man never bent, never broke, remained steadfast in his conviction.

“I…” Phainon licks his lips. “I just missed you so much, and… I was so sure that even if we met again, you wouldn’t want anything to do with me. So… there was a point where I did things I would regret, I just wanted the pain to stop.”

Mydei is quiet, he’s still staring at the wall, but now and again, Phainon thinks he sees the flicker of golden pupils glancing back at him.

“And how did that work out for you?”

Phainon laughs dryly, humourlessly. “It didn’t. I was terrible at it. I picked people who reminded me of you, and then made them turn away so I didn’t have to look at their faces. Most of the time I couldn’t even finish… I just felt disgusted the moment I remembered that it wasn’t you.”

“A lot of nights I just gave up and went home to jack off to pictures of you. Rumours started going around that I was impotent and overcompensating. In the end I just… accepted the fact that I’ll only ever be attracted to you.”

His lip curls up in a sardonic smile. “And now I’m making you listen to my pity party. I’m pathetic.”

Mydei scoffs, his voice is rough when he speaks, frustration seeping through every word.

“Yet, here I am getting jealous. Maybe I’m the pathetic one.”

“Jealous?” Phainon echoes, honing in on it like a spear finding its target. The idea of Mydei being jealous shouldn’t have made him feel so good, but it does.

Mydei being jealous means that he likes Phainon enough to care, and that he cares enough to get upset. It means that his feelings are not completely one-sided. It means that somewhere inside Mydei, there is a little bit of insanity to mirror Phainon’s own.

There’s absolutely nothing for him to be jealous of.

The mere idea itself is just too absurd, and Phainon can’t help the laugh that escapes from his lips.

“What's so funny?”

“It’s just… I’m laughing because you’re jealous.” He feels Mydei rear up his leg for a kick that will certainly end his life, and quickly backtracks. “Wait, wait—listen. You won without even doing anything, you weren’t

even in the same country. You were just living your life, not thinking about me. And still, you obtained a total and complete victory."

He sees Mydei's eyelashes quiver, knows that he's slowly coming around. Mydei had always liked winning, they both did. He's willing, more than willing, to utterly surrender to him. But that's still not going to be enough, there is nothing he could do that would ever be enough.

"Remember this feeling…" Phainon takes Mydei's hand, guiding it to his neck. "And take it out on me."

"Wha–" Mydei opens his mouth.

"Because I'm the worst." Phainon says, feeling Mydei's fingers flutter around his neck like he's hesitant to put force on it. He's aware of how hysterical he sounds, how hysterical he must look. "For even thinking I could get over you."

Mydei finally turns his head to look at him, his bangs have fallen over his face, obscuring one of his eyes. The other eye fixes on Phainon, the look dark, ravenous, and lustful.

"I won't ask you again."

When Mydei is like this, commanding instead of asking, direct instead of careful, it turns Phainon on like nothing else. Mydei's hand at his throat tightens slightly, not enough to feel anything, but just enough to remind him that it's there. That Phainon is completely at his mercy.

Shit–shitshitshit! He needs him, *now*!

Phainon sinks his aching cock into Mydei's waiting hole, it's fully erect, and the size is nothing to scoff at, but Mydei takes it all valiantly with nothing but a slight curl of his lip and a sharp inhale to indicate his discomfort.

He's actually inside Mydei, Phainon can't even believe it. He's fucking Mydei and not in a dream this time, in real life.

Phainon draws his hips back, shoving his cock all the way in to the hilt, deeper than it was before, the deepest it can go.

Mydei throws his head back, a groan escaping his throat as his hand involuntarily clenches around Phainon's throat, fingers squeezing tight around his windpipe.

Phainon wheezes as the pressure increases around his neck, his heart racing as oxygen supply gets cut off. He feels like he's floating as he grows lightheaded, his lungs struggling to take in air. His muscles clench with exertion but the things it's doing to his cock…oh shit… he thinks it just got bigger…

It felt good to get all of that off his chest, his guilt, his shame, his regret. Mydei's hand on his neck is his punishment, his redemption.

Right as Phainon feels like he's about to pass out, it stops, the pressure loosening as Mydei releases his grip. His fingers remain curled around Phainon's neck, warm and intimate.

"*Fuck*…" Mydei gasps, sounding utterly wrecked. "You're sick."

If he is sick then he doesn't want to get better.

Phainon's also gasping, just catching his breath, but he continues to move, he doesn't stop, chasing the pleasure like a dog chasing the bone. He pulls his hips back, it feels like all his nerve endings had migrated to his cock for how vivid and sharp the sensation of it sliding between Mydei's walls. And then he pushes forward again.

"*Argh*." Like clockwork, Mydei's fist tightens around his throat and squeezes, this time for a little longer until Phainon loses strength in his core and collapses his body weight on Mydei.

"Fuck…" Phainon repeats, already losing control of his rational mind. "*Fuck*." Mydei's skin is sweaty and sticky and scorching and every press of their warm bodies feels like he might meld them together as one.

His hips don’t stop moving, they continue thrusting hard into Mydei as the latter's body is forced to follow the rhythm. Phainon’s usually sturdy bed creaks under them, it feels like even the floorboards might be shifting under their combined weights.

And every time Mydei’s fist tightens around him, even when his throat starts to burn, even when tears spring to his eyes and his pulse starts to race, Phainon feels… amazing. Better than he’d ever felt. In this moment, his world has narrowed to three things. Mydei’s heat, Mydei’s power, and Mydei’s pleasure.

“Phai–there… there!” Mydei’s voice sounds unusually haggard and even his strength is starting to wane as the lust overwhelms him. The grip on his throat gradually weakens until Phainon can hardly feel it until Mydei is just holding onto him for support as their hips rock together.

“Good… gods, Mydei it feels so…” Phainon chants like a mantra.

Mydei’s replies get lost in an ocean of panting and heavy breathing. His heaving chest is almost too much for Phainon to bear and he gives in to his baser instincts by leaning down and taking his nipple into his mouth, nibbling on the tip with his upper teeth.

“Hah– Ahh– I’m gonna…” Mydei grits his teeth as his walls clench around Phainon tightly again like they want to squeeze every drop of cum out of him.

“Yeah… yeah… me too.” Phainon just barely manages to say. He moves up to kiss Mydei again on the lips, and it’s sloppy and clumsy and utterly perfect.

Mydei’s eyes are sharp, focused as though in deep concentration. Sweat drips down his forehead and rolls down the contours of his perfect nose. He looks so intense and serious and focused even though his body is shaking head to toe from the pleasure. Even when he’s having an orgasm he’s still so composed, so dignified. Ah, Phainon had wanted to wreck him so badly, but this is pretty good too.

Ahh… he’s so cute… his Mydeimos is too cute. Phainon is going to…

His whole body shudders as he cums while still buried within Mydei. It goes on for a long time, longer than Phainon’s usual orgasms. He can’t do much but cling onto Mydie’s shaking body, leaving indentations of his fingers into those firm muscles.

“So… much…” Mydei manages to murmur before he shudders and goes silent again.

And it feels so good, it just feels too good, Phainon didn’t even know sex could blow his mind like that. Reaching climax often felt pleasurable, but doing it with Mydei was like blowing the ceiling wide open and exposing him to the sky.

He’s not sure how long he remained in this absolute euphoria, but he could get addicted to this feeling.

Phainon tries to pull himself away, only to realize that sometime during sex Mydei had wrapped his arms around him, like a clingy koala bear, refusing to let go.

His Mydei is so adorable, acting aloof while he was secretly so needy. Phainon wouldn’t mind staying like this, buried inside him forever with Mydei as his own personal cockwarmer.

But…

“Mydei, I need to move us,” he whispers tenderly.

“Yeah… yeah…” Mydei’s voice sounds rough and frayed as he reluctantly lets go. The sticky feeling of sweat soaked skin peeling away sends a sudden chill through Phainon, who already misses Mydei’s heat. Looks like being apart for even just a second was a no-go.

Phainon pulls out slightly and hears the squelch as his cock shifts in Mydei’s hole, still filled with cum.

Mydei makes a face of mild disgust.

“How do you feel?” Phainon asks him anxiously.

“It hurt.” Mydei tells him blandly. Phainon freezes, anxiety flooding through him.

“But after that… fuck, it felt *incredible*.” Mydei’s lip curls up in a grin, a flash of white teeth dangerous in the lowlight. “I could consider making you my full time lover.”

Lover. The word rings in the empty space between his ears.

Lover. Bouncing between the bones of his skull like a pinball.

Lover. Sinks down and buries itself deep into his heart.

That’s right. He’s Mydei’s lover. Not his ex-boyfriend from high school, not his creepy stalker, not even some model he can only admire from afar. Mydei said it himself, they were lovers. There are no take backs now, and Phainon will never let him go again.

Overwhelmed with both love and lust, Phainon leans down, kissing him roughly before flipping Mydei around so that he’s lying on his front. Mydei, too surprised to respond properly, finds himself chest down, bottom tilted up in a scintillating display, cum still dripping out of his hole.

“Say that again.” Phainon demands.

“What?”

Fuuuuuck, the way Mydei’s back looks as it arches is so scandalous that it’s making him hard again. Phainon realizes that he’s starving, he’s absolutely famished.

“Please, Mydei. Let me do it again. I need more. I need to have you again.” Phainon begs. He’ll get on his knees, he’s literally already on his knees. His cock is halfway inside already and even though Mydei is already full, he pushes through it.

“HKS! Now? We literally just finished.” Phainon ignores the complaints, after all, he had warned Mydei that he wouldn’t stop, there’s no point crying over spilled milk. Who was the one earlier bragging about amazing stamina? Who was practically pleading to be fucked?

Phainon’s hips jerk, thrusting his cock even deeper. White fluids squirt out as Mydei hitches a surprised gasp.

It’s so cute and kittenish that Phainon is taken off guard for a second, he’s never heard that kind of noise before.

“Say it again!” He demands.

“Say what again?” Mydei asks, voice quivering. His fingers curl helplessly on the bedsheet, gripping onto them for dear life as Phainon continues thrusting.

“Call me your lover again.” Phainon begs. He leans down, as Mydei turns his head to meet him halfway. Their lips slot into each other clumsily, drool trickling down the sides of Mydei’s chin until Phainon is practically drinking him in. It tastes like the sweetest nectar.

And he doesn’t stop there. Phainon kisses down the sides of his neck, leaves red marks around his scapula and along his broad shoulders.

“Ah–” Mydei cries as his body jerks. His spine is sensitive, as Phainon is starting to find out, every nip and bite along the middle of his back gets a very positive reaction. “...*lover*?”

“What’s that?” Phainon leans closer, hips still moving in a jerky and uncoordinated rhythm as Mydei gasps with every thrust. The sight of that marked, broad back in front of him is truly driving him crazy!

“--*love y*-” Mydei’s words are aborted by a sharp hiss as Phainon drags his knuckle, soft and slow, down the middle of his spine.

His finger circles the base of his spine, around the protrusion that marks the bone of his vertebrae. Then he bends, planting a soft, unhurried kiss on the

spot.

Mydei's reaction is immediate, going slack and lax as though he had found his off button. A betrayed moan escapes his lips before he can swallow it down.

"Say that again? I couldn't hear you." Phainon murmurs.

Mydei takes a deep, long exhale. It seems that there is a part of him that wants to remain stubborn, that wants to resist. But when Phainon gently rocks his hips back, cock rubbing against his prostate, Mydei whines and falls completely to pieces.

"...fuck me." He says.

Phainon's hips buck again, like a wild animal that had spiraled out of his control.

"*Phainon-*" Mydei groans again, latching onto his bedsheet so hard that Phainon hears something tear. Mydei actually ripped his bedsheet, that's fine. He can buy new ones.

"I know. I got you baby, I got you." Sweat trickles down his nape as the pet name spills out of his lips unprompted.

Mydei's breath hitches again, not able to protest it even though he so clearly wants to.

"Hngh…" he says instead, voice wrecked, almost inaudible. "You're a beast."

"Your beast." Phainon says, overwhelmed with stimulation. "Only yours. Always. I love you Mydei."

Mydei's breath hitches as the muscles in his back tense in a way that seems to drive Phainon's cock even deeper inside.

"Yours." He repeats. There was never any question, every part of him had always belonged to Mydei, even if he didn't know it yet. "Say it back."

“Ahh—*hngh*–”

“Say it!” Phainon demands, more desperate, pushier. His hips move at an even faster rhythm. He needs to hear Mydei say it back, even if the hints had been laid out for him, even if Mydei thinks it’s obvious. It’s not, not to someone insecure like him. It’s something he needs to hear from Mydei’s own lips, even if he has to pry them open.

“...I love you!” Mydei surrenders.

Phainon’s head is literally spinning like he’s run out of oxygen. He pounds into him, harder, deeper, as Mydei’s hips buck up again. His insides are so tight it’s like he’s trying to squeeze Phainon’s cock dry, begging to be pumped full with his cum again.

“Again!” Phainon pleads greedily.

“I love you!” Mydei has his face turned away from him, and his elbow is covering his eyes like he wants to hide in it. He’s just way too cute! Phainon can’t get a good look at his expression, but something wet is trickling down the sides of his cheeks.

Tears, and not just one or two, they’re dripping, spilling almost. His breath keeps hitching, chest racking in a way that almost sounds like a sob. His body is loose and trembling and pliant as Phainon continues to pound into him.

“You’re mine.” Phainon agrees. The word had never sounded so good.

Mine. *Mydei*. Mine. *Mine*!

The thought turns him on so much that Phainon comes harder than he ever had in his life, nearly collapsing into a heap on top of Mydei’s back as his mind goes blank from the orgasm.

“Shit…” Mydei pants, breathless. When Phainon looks down he can see fresh streaks of white fluid down Mydei’s thighs, as though he had came again too sometime during sex and hadn’t even realized it.

The sight is so hot, he doesn’t know how he can keep himself sane for the rest of the night.

“Again?” Phainon whimpers before his brain can catch up to him.

“...Are you serious?”

Chapter End Notes

The song of the day is I'm the Jealous Type by Doja Cat. This is like the phaidei theme song for me I don't take criticism.
Spotify playlist

Nobody sent thoughts and prayers for my wordcount so the chapter count got extended by one... Chapter 8 will be out very soon, in less than a week! It's because I intended for these two to be one chapter, but ended up deciding to split them.

If you're still here and reading, I thank you so much! Words cannot explain how grateful I am that you're reading my fic, and I appreciate you immensely! <3

Chapter 8: Same Color as the Sun

Chapter Summary

> Phainon doesn’t take heed of any of the commotion as he gazes at him, his intense blue eyes look crystallized when they’re this close, and they’re all Mydei can see.
>
> “Just remember.” He murmurs, voice quivering, palm warm in his. “That if you leave me, I’ll die.”
>
> And then just as abruptly, the energy dissipates. Phainon’s body goes lax, he lowers his head and nuzzles it in the crook of Mydei’s neck, a picture of utter surrender and submissiveness.
>
> “That’s a bit dramatic.” Mydei says when he finally finds his voice again.
>
> “I’ll die.” Phainon repeats pathetically, completely serious. He’s not pretending, he’s not exaggerating for the hell of it, this man believes it as his absolute truth. “I’ll… I’ll hunt you down. I’ll follow you home. I’ll even hurt myself if it will make you pay attention to me.”

Chapter Notes

> When I said the next chapter will come out in less than a week just call me Phainon because I delivered!
>
> Additional content warnings: None for this chapter, if you got this far pls enjoy the fluff and smut! We deserve it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei’s eyes flit open tiredly when the sunshine hits his eyelids, and his first thought is that this isn’t his room.

He keeps a strict daily routine, waking up at nearly the same time everyday. He prepares breakfast for himself and the roommates, goes to the gym, wakes said roommates up (if applicable), and then gets on with whatever he had planned for the day.

But today, when he opens his eyes, he gets the fright of his life.

The massive poster of himself on the opposite wall gazes back at him.

“Fuck–” He curses. He’d known it was there, even made Phainon fuck him in front of it multiple times. But in broad daylight it is even more embarrassing. His snarl is so exaggerated and forced, and those eyes seem to be filled with disdain as they judge him for how low he stooped last night.

How can Phainon even enjoy waking up to this?

Speak of the devil, a warm body is wrapped tightly around him, clinging like he’s going to disappear if he doesn’t hold on tight. One of Phainon’s arms is draped over his chest, his leg is wrapped possessively around his thigh. It feels like he’s being suffocated by a very heavy weighted blanket, or even a straitjacket.

When Mydei moves, it wakes Phainon up.

“You’re awake?” Phainon’s breath is warm in his ear as his body cuddles up to him impossibly closer, long limbs entangling him like octopus tentacles. “Good morning, Mydei!”

How is it that Phainon can be an absolute scoundrel in bed at one moment, and then a complete puppy the next? Mydei doesn’t understand it at all.

He wrestles Phainon’s limbs away from him, rolling over so he doesn’t have to look at the massive poster of himself.

“You should take those pictures off the wall.”

“But I like them,” Phainon quips.

“They creep me out.”

“Mmm… I guess that now I have the real thing, I don’t really need them,” Phainon says. Mydei feels something heavy rest in between his shoulderblades, soft hair nuzzling against the nape of his neck.

Mydei shifts his legs, feeling the ache in his lower back when he raises his hips. Shit… how many times had Phainon fucked him last night? He’d lost count after the 3rd orgasm. He didn’t even know it was humanely possible to produce so much semen, is this man even human? They’d cleaned up afterwards before he collapsed into the deepest slumber of his life, but when he moves… he still feels like his ass is full of cum.

“Where are you going?” The tentacle monster is back. Phainon’s long limbs curl around his body like he wants to drag him to the bottom of the sea, grabbing onto his waist so tightly he can feel the bruising imprints of fingertips on his ribs.

“Up?” Mydei replies incredulously. “Take a piss? Brush my teeth? Have breakfast?”

Phainon’s arms clench a little tighter as he presses his forehead against Mydei’s bare back, and he inhales, long and deep, like he wants to breathe him in.

And then he abruptly lets go.

“I’ll handle it.” Phainon says, bounding out of bed cheerfully as though nothing had happened. “You just rest more.”

Mydei stares at him as he leaves the room, face tinged with disbelief. How is he going to take a piss on his behalf? Yet, it seems like too much of a bother to argue against it so Mydei does as he’s told and lies down on the bed again. Without Phainon there, it already feels much colder.

He looks at his phone screen, it’s only 9 in the morning, the day is still young. The number of unread notifications on his phone is something that he doesn’t want to deal with right now, and Mydei ends up shooting a quick

text to the Titans of Calamity group chat. Just something to say that he's fine, that he's sorry for worrying them, that he'll be home later, and please don't change the locks before he gets to explain himself.

And then he lies in bed just looking at the ceiling, trying to come to terms that the cute nerd he used to know is long gone. Gone was the cute, shy youth with oversized sweaters, glasses and fluffy hair. Phainon seems like an entirely different person now. Somebody volatile, possessive, pretty intense, a little well—a lot insecure, but still really sweet.

Maybe he had always been that way though, a wolf hidden in sheep clothing, and Mydei just hadn't realized. And maybe what he's seeing now is the real Phainon.

He doesn't mind it at all though.

At some point, Mydei drifts back to sleep, and when he opens his eyes he gets startled for the second time that day. Instead of his own face, it's a huge pair of blue eyes blinking at him.

Phainon beams as though he hadn't been caught in the act staring at a sleeping person.

"You could have woken me up instead of being weird and staring." Mydei grumbles, pulling himself up to a sitting position. He yawns, the muscles in his body aching pleasantly when he stretches. Sex with Phainon was clearly not for the weak, his whole body hurt like he'd been tossed around like a rag doll.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says pleasantly, not sounding sorry in the slightest. "You're so beautiful when you sleep. I just wanted to look a little more."

"Creepy." Mydei says, pushing his hair back where his bangs have fallen messily across his forehead.

"Your creep." Phainon leans forward and plants a kiss on his exposed forehead, the skin burning where his lips touch. He's acting like a doting

boyfriend. Are they dating again? Is that something he even needs to bring up in conversation?

“I made you breakfast if you wanted some,” Phainon murmurs, oblivious to his inner turmoil.

“You can cook?”

Phainon puffs his chest up at the insinuation. “Of course I can!” He huffs. “I’m sure I’m not as good a cook as you, but I had to learn at some point.”

“I’ll be the judge of that,” Mydei says, making a move to get out of bed. Phainon pushes him down by placing a palm in the middle of his chest, and Mydei is forced back into a supine position.

“No, no, you don’t need to get up. I’ll bring it to you. Breakfast in bed!”

“Hah?” Mydei grumbles, getting annoyed as Phainon scampers out of the room like he has places to be and things to do. He knows that ‘Prince’ is the loving nickname his friends like to call him, but he’s really not the kind of guy who wants to be waited on hand and foot.

He thought they had sorted this out last night. Perhaps they should have talked it out with their words instead of their dicks.

But well, Mydei is distracted once again when Phainon returns with a plate full of honeycakes, his stomach grumbling in protest. Sex burns a lot of calories, alright?

And while he is loath to admit it, the honeycakes are delicious. Fluffy, warm, with the sweetness of honey balanced by the saltiness of butter.

“Thank you,” Mydei says, trying not to find it weird how instead of having any himself, Phainon spent the entire time staring at him while he eats.

Trying and failing because it is weird and he can’t just ignore it anymore when he blurts out. “Why are you acting so strange?”

Phainon just blinks at him. “How so?”

The innocent tactic won't work on him, but Mydei commends his shamelessness in trying anyway. "You try to stop me every time I want to get out of bed."

"Oh," Phainon seems to wilt. "It's going to sound stupid…"

"Then it will be nothing new for you."

"Mean." Phainon whines, though his lips do quirk up in amusement slightly before they tug into a frown again. "I… ah… the truth is, I'm just a little scared that if I let you leave, you're going to leave for good."

Mydei nearly faceplants into the plate of honeycakes in frustration, which he doesn't do, because that would be a waste of perfectly good honeycakes.

"That's illogical." They're not in the dark ages anymore. They have mobile phones now, and Phainon has shown him that he's more than capable of stalking his socials.

"I will need to leave at some point, Phainon." Mydei points out bluntly. He needs to go home, he needs to go work, eventually Cipher and Castorice are going to come around with a battering ram if he doesn't go back to defuse the situation.

"You won't reconsider quitting your job?" Phainon says in the way where he pretends he's joking but is actually semi-serious.

"Phainon." Mydei fires a warning shot.

"Alright… alright." Phainon sighs. "I got it. Just, finish your food first." He places his chin in the crook of his elbow as he leans against the side of the bed, watching Mydei eat his breakfast. He paints a picture of utter misery, a submissive little puppy begging its owner not to leave.

Which is a total deception, Mydei personally experienced how he wrecked him in bed the night before.

"I meant it," Mydei says, staring at the last piece of pancake, light glimmering off the honey dripping decadently down the side of his fork.

“What I said last night.”

“Which part?” Phainon says cheekily. “Is it the part where you begged me to fuck you until you couldn’t walk?” Oh, he certainly delivered on that front.

“Or maybe the part where you called my cock the sun that’s destined to rise?”

“I did not say any of those things,” Mydei says hurriedly.

“It was… maybe around the 4th round or so?” Phainon counts off his fingers. Titans, how many times did they do it last night? No wonder he feels so tired. “You were pretty delirious by then so you probably don’t remember.”

“Whatever–” Mydei suddenly feels exhausted. “I meant the part where I said that I loved you.”

Phainon’s breath hitches.

“And that I wanted to get to know the real you.” Mydei continues. “I’m not expecting things to go back to what they were before, it will take time to rebuild what we have.”

He reaches for Phainon’s hand and entwines their fingers together. Phainon was obviously repressing it, but from this close, he can tell that his hand is trembling. His fingers are warm as they curl around his, clinging on tightly like a lifeline.

“But… I have a good feeling about it,” Mydei finishes.

Phainon’s pale eyelashes quiver as though he’s holding back strong emotions, slowly, he brings his other hand over their entwined ones. Pulling Mydei’s hand closer, he places a reverent kiss on the knuckle of his ring finger.

“You were always the kind of man who keeps his promises.” Phainon says. “And I know you’re still like that so… I’ll take your word on it.”

Good, at least Phainon remembers what kind of person he is.

And then out of nowhere, Phainon tugs. The combination of his absurd strength and the surprise factor sends Mydei's torso flying towards him, the sheets flung aside recklessly. The plate on his lap clatters to the floor, and the crashing sound echoes through the room.

Phainon doesn't take heed of any of the commotion as he gazes at him, his intense blue eyes look crystallized when they're this close, and they're all Mydei can see.

"Just remember." He murmurs, voice quivering, palm warm in his. "That if you leave me, I'll die."

And then just as abruptly, the energy dissipates. Phainon's body goes lax, he lowers his head and nuzzles it in the crook of Mydei's neck, a picture of utter surrender and submissiveness.

"That's a bit dramatic." Mydei says when he finally finds his voice again.

"I'll die." Phainon repeats pathetically, completely serious. He's not pretending, he's not exaggerating for the hell of it, this man believes it as his absolute truth. "I'll… I'll hunt you down. I'll follow you home. I'll even hurt myself if it will make you pay attention to me."

Mydei wonders whether something went wrong somewhere. What did he do to turn a sweet, loving boy whose only wish was to make everyone else happy into… this twisted man?

He's not sure, except that he needs to take responsibility for it. He'll be quite happy to, as a matter of fact.

Even when everyone is looking at Phainon, desiring him, drawn in by his magnetic energy, he only reserves his true self for Mydei.

"Then we have a deal." He cups Phainon's chin and seals their promise with a kiss, coating the inside of his mouth with honey. He hears Phainon inhale

sharply, but doesn't give him a chance to respond as he deepens the kiss, lips melding together, the taste sweeter than sugar.

When he finally pulls away because his lungs heave for oxygen, the surface of Phainon's lips are coated with a glossy sheen, ripe and plump like a pomegranate.

His cheeks are dusted with pink, standing out starkly against his pale skin and hair. He watches as Phainon licks his lips and then swallows, savouring the taste.

"Sweet." He murmurs.

"It's the honeycakes," Mydei tells him smugly.

"Let me taste them again," Phainon leans in enthusiastically, closing the gap between them once more. Mydei smiles as ticklish kisses pepper his cheeks, his nose and his forehead. And then their lips meet again, coated in honey, drowning in adorations as he drinks him in, all of him.

A shift of the mattress and Phainon has crawled nearly onto his lap, clumsy fingers grasping at Mydei's waist as his kisses get hungrier, greedier. And when he inevitably moves lower to cup a feel of Mydei's ass, he grunts.

"You're insatiable."

"Only because it's you," Phainon grinds against him, slow and easy. Mydei's body is still aching from last night, but his body remembers too well how it made him feel, because his lower half flares up with interest, a gnawing void that wants to be filled.

"I haven't even showered."

It's like Phainon's metaphorical tail starts to wag. "Let's take one together. You've seen my shower, it's big enough for two."

Mydei feels heat rush to his cheeks. Phainon's bathroom holds uh… memories. "I think it's a little too early for a couple's shower."

“Mydei.” Phainon says, expression disgruntled. “I came in you no less than 5 times last night.”

Titans! “Okay fine, let’s shower together.”

What he didn’t account for was Phainon pushing him roughly against the shower door the second it clicked shut behind them. The shower water hadn’t even had time to heat up yet, as it splashes icy cold against his bare skin.

“Cold.” Mydei grumbles. He’s shivering, partially because of how fucking chilly the water is, and partially because Phainon is running his hands up his bare thighs, over the curve of his hips, his ass, and tracing the small of his back.

Mydei scrunches his eyes shut as Phainon’s fingers trace lightly over his vertebrae, he’d found out that weakness last night and was using it to do devastating damage to his mental state. Even now, Mydei is already half-hard, and the walls of his anal canal clench desperately, wanting to be filled again.

“It’ll warm up soon,” Phainon promises, squeezing his hips and planting kisses along the curve of his neck. “Mydei, have I ever told you your body is absurd?”

“Only about 5 times a day.”

“Hmm…” Phainon’s breath tickles his neck as a sharp pain nips at his shoulderblade. Another hickey in the expansive collection littering Mydei’s tattooed skin, perhaps in another life, Phainon had been a vampire with how eagerly he’s leaving marks. “Not enough then.”

The water splashing onto his back is getting warmer as the water heats up, steam rises up, fogging the transparent glass which his chest is pressed against, obscuring his view of the rest of the bathroom.

The rising heat makes the shower cubicle even more stifling, until Mydei is aware of only Phainon’s increasingly desperate panting as his cock brushes

lightly against his hole.

Unconsciously, he arches his back, pushing his hips backwards until it makes contact with Phainon. He knows it makes him seem a little—no, a lot—desperate, but his body is so needy that he can't help himself.

"Mydeiii…" Phainon whines. "You're unbelievable."

He's not sure whether the rising temperature is because of the water, or because of the heat between them.

"Want me to help you wash your hair?" Phainon offers sweetly like he hadn't been fucking him like an animal all night long.

Wash his hair, hah, like Phainon isn't just looking for an excuse to touch him. He doesn't hate it though, the idea of Phainon's coarse fingers scratching his scalp, blond hair wrapped around his fingertips, pulling as he fucks Mydei slow and deep.

"Do whatever you want," Mydei says, though Phainon is already squeezing shampoo into his palm.

The sweet scent of cherries envelops his senses as Phainon rubs shampoo into his hair, starting at the roots, working his way to the tips. He can't help but close his eyes and let out a rumble of satisfaction as Phainon's nails brush against his scalp, scratching an itch he didn't even know he had.

"So cute, like a big cat," Phainon coos. Mydei turns around to glare at him. Phainon looks handsome like this, a sight that can make anyone weak in the knees. His wet hair is slicked back away from his face, highlighting his unfairly perfect features, those pale lips curled up in a smirk. His muscles are even more well-defined in the daylight, and the droplets of water trickling down the dips and curves of his muscles only make Mydei jealous–of the water! He's jealous of fucking water! How far he's fallen!

"...I'm not a cat." He can only murmur, mind going blank.

“Of course not.” Phainon’s hand moves to wash the back of his hair, his gentle touch running up the bare nape of his neck, making Mydei shiver despite the heat.

And then, followed by a sharp pain as his fingers get tangled in Mydei’s hair, his head getting dragged slightly back as Phainon grabs a fistful of his hair and tugs.

“If you were a cat I could lock you indoors.” The sigh in his ear is warm and wistful. “Keep you safe from the outside world.”

The pressure on the back of his head eases as Phainon returns to washing his hair. A silent apology in the way his fingertips rub his scalp in circular, relaxing motions.

Still, Mydei loves testing the waters.

“Keep me safe?” He smirks. “Or keep me all to yourself?”

“You test me.” He can feel Phainon’s grin as he presses his lips against the top of his ear. “Why ask questions you already know the answer to?”

Phainon is coy like that, he likes obscuring his true intentions by asking rhetorical questions, expecting Mydei to get it. It’s the philosopher in him. It’s not that he can’t read between the lines, but it’s so much more fun to hear the words straight from Phainon’s mouth. The things he says might sound crazy to anyone else, but to Mydei, it’s a reaffirmation of his love.

“Isn’t it obvious? I like to hear them.”

He feels Phainon’s fingers leave his scalp, soapy hands moving to cup his shoulders, massaging the sore muscle with the pad of his thumb.

“Of course I want you all to myself.” A ticklish nibble as Phainon bites the top of his ear, a move that Mydei enjoys more than he’d like to admit. “Of course I want to lock you away where there’s zero chance of people eyeing you up. Zero chance of other people trying to take you away from me.”

His hands move lower down, brushing the bones of his ribcage and eventually resting in the curves of his waist.

“You’re cruel for making me admit that.” Phainon is gripping at his waist so tightly the skin is turning red in parts where he’s pushing a little too hard.

Mydei unconsciously juts his hips backward, hitting the front of Phainon’s cock and continuing to push even though they’re not at the right angle.

“Unfortunately, locking me up isn’t an option.” Mydei says, his casual tone sounding a little strained as Phainon’s cock presses up against his entrance. “I guess you’d have to show me in other ways why you’re the best.”

Phainon places his thumbs in the dip of Mydei’s hipbones, anchoring himself as he pushes deep into him. It goes in smoothly, Mydei moans, feeling his entrance stretch to accommodate him like a second skin. It had only been one night, but his body had adapted so quickly, like Phainon was tailor made to fuck him.

“Shit.” He murmurs, his legs grow weak and he claws at the wall for support, leaving handprints on the foggy glass as he helplessly scratches at the shower door. It’s impossible to get a good grip on the slippery glass, and Mydei ends up collapsing against it, bracing himself with his elbows as Phainon starts to move.

“Hah…” Phainon’s breath is hot and heavy in his ear, he’s thrusting into Mydei so deeply he feels like he’s either going to heaven or dying every single time he pulls back. “I’ve been… wanting to do this for a long time.”

“...I feel the same.” Mydei gasps. He remembers sitting in Phainon’s bathtub yesterday, wanting him so badly that he didn’t know what to do with himself. Thinking that he would settle for Phainon’s scent alone and that it would somehow substitute for the real thing. Now that he had a taste, it wasn’t even remotely comparable.

“No.” Phainon murmurs, pulling out and then slamming it in again, the tip of his cock brushing against Mydei’s prostate in a way that just felt too fucking good. The perfect length, the perfect girth, the perfect angle, truly

Phainon had mastered the art of pleasing him in a single night, what a quick study. “You don’t.”

What? He’s doubting the reciprocity of Mydei’s feelings?

Mydei’s retort dies in his throat as the breath gets knocked out of him when Phainon wraps both arms around his waist and hugs him so tightly that his organs are getting crushed. He hugs Mydei like a drowning man holding on to a lifebuoy, like letting go would mean certain death.

Their proximity pushes Phainon’s cock deeper, further than Mydei thinks it could ever go, and it feels so good that all rational thought subsequently leaves his mind, including his knowledge of language.

“I’ve wanted to do this ever since we were *teenagers*.” He emphasizes. Mydei suddenly recalls that stiflingly humid afternoon, realizing that he was having sexual thoughts about his best friend for the first time and feeling guilty about it.

“Taking a guy with a massive crush on you to your room when your parents weren’t home. You were so innocent it was scary. You’re lucky I was such a gentleman.” Mydei shivers as something warm and wet licks its way from his earlobe, running across the edge of his ear.

“I didn’t know you had a crush on me.” He remembered being unsure, he remembered being enamored, being quietly hopeful that Phainon reciprocated his feelings.

“It appears that you were unaware of a lot of things.” Phainon murmurs, voice low like a rumble.

Mydei gasps, his breathing interrupted by short, pitiful moans as Phainon’s rhythm increases. The slick sound of wet skin slapping against wet skin mingling with the sound of running water.

He’s not trying to be obtuse, Mydei likes to think he’s generally in touch with his own emotions and the emotions of others. But Phainon makes him

so crazy that he overthinks everything, too scared of seeing patterns when there are none that he swerves in the complete opposite direction.

“You really worry me sometimes.” Phainon rests his chin on Mydei’s shoulder as he continues thrusting mercilessly. His legs are so weak that he’s pretty sure Phainon is single handedly holding him upright, which is also very hot in itself. “Someone could flirt right in front of your face and you probably wouldn’t even realize.”

“T-that’s…” *not true,* he wanted to say. But Mydei isn’t able to make any sound aside from guttural noises that sound vaguely human.

Like that guy at the bar, Mydei forgot his name, he’d assumed he was being flirty, which was then proven incorrect.

Mydei’s thoughts are dragged away from this tangent when Phainon pulls out, almost all the way before plunging into his slick hole again, hitting his prostate so good that Mydei can’t think anymore.

“Good thing I’m here to pay attention for you.”

Not in past tense like ‘I was’, and not future tense like ‘I will be’, but an everpresent ‘I am’. A promise that Phainon’s eyes will always be on him, that being around Mydei is just an irrefutable fact of the universe. Like he’s Mydei’s guard dog, always watching his back.

He loves the thought more than he can ever imagine, and Mydei comes with a soft, breathy gasp, white hot liquid spilling down his thigh, getting washed away by the running water.

“Titans, seeing you come is so hot… I almost can’t bear it.” Phainon murmurs as he thrusts again, languid and gentle. Mydei’s walls are so sensitive that every brush sends electricity up his spine. With a quiet gasp of his name, Phainon comes too. The sensation of being filled up so thoroughly feels so familiar to him now that when Phainon eventually pulls out he feels… weird, empty, like he’s missing something.

Phainon is turning him into his cockslut without him even realizing it.

His legs are trembling harder than a new born fawn taking its first steps, and Mydei finds himself leaning against the wall for support. Phainon's hands on his waist are warm and steady, supporting him from falling over.

"Now," His voice is so smug, entirely too pleased with himself. "Let me help you clean up."

Incorrigible, absolutely incorrigible.

Later, Mydei stands in front of the bathroom mirror fixing his braid to get ready for the day. His shoulders and collarbone region are peppered with teeth marks and hickeys. He looks like he got mauled by a wild animal. It's like Phainon wanted the whole world to know that he—yeah that was probably what he was going for.

"By the way, have you seen my jewelry from yesterday?" He seemed to have a vague recollection of taking them off along with his outdoor clothes, right before he took a bath yesterday. But while his clothes are now dry and folded neatly on the counter, the jewelry is nowhere in sight.

It's not that he thinks Phainon would steal them, but a nagging part of him was worried that he had dropped them somewhere while he was out last night. Some of those pieces had been passed down from his mother's side of the family, they were important to him and he didn't want to lose them.

"I didn't want them to get lost," Phainon calls out from the shower where he's still getting dressed. "So I put them together with the rest of my jewelry, on the dresser."

Mydei pauses to admire the reflection of Phainon's broad back in the mirror and the way his muscles flex as he pulls on a shirt. Those red faded scratched marks, some of them still streaked with dried blood, stand out starkly against his pale skin. Huh, did Mydei do that?

It doesn't take him long to locate the jewelry box on Phainon's dresser. It's a humble, small, unremarkable box, the wood darkened with age. The

etchings on the lid look hand carved, and feel nice and worn when Mydei runs his fingers over it. It looks like something Phainon had brought over from his village, rather than something he purchased from the city.

It definitely doesn't look like something a famous model should keep his jewelry in, and Mydei's heart melts a little bit with affection at the realization that Phainon's still a village boy, deep down. It seems that Phainon still doesn't care much for material things, even though he could probably afford most of it with a flick of the wrist.

Inside, there's some watches, necklaces, bracelets, all kept neatly in their compartments. They look untouched, probably gifts from his sponsors. One of them does catch his eye though, a brown leather choker that looks a little more well-worn than the rest. Mydei imagines it wrapped around Phainon's pale and slender throat, the way the cutout sits perfectly on top of his tattoo to bring attention to it.

Such a shame he doesn't wear it more often, Mydei would like to see it.

Mydei's jewelry is there too, nothing out of place. He exhales in relief when he sees the ruby earrings passed down from his mother, and the chunky golden necklace with the sapphires that he's so fond of.

But right when he takes them out of the jewelry box, he pauses. Something glints in the depths, capturing his attention immediately.

Mydei usually doesn't make it a point to pry into someone's personal belongings, but Phainon is invasive enough about him that he fishes the pin out without a second thought. And then he just… stares at it, completely stunned at its familiarity.

It's unmistakable, Mydei would never forget the brassy finish that he spent hours polishing by hand, the exact angle of the sun rays that he bent himself. Even the Kremnoan words etched into the surface that he had spent days agonizing over. It's exactly the same. This is the last place he expected to find this old gift, he thought he had thrown it away.

Years have passed but the surface is still polished and gleaming, like someone had attentively cared for it all this time.

“Did you find them?” Phainon’s voice gets louder as he approaches, nuzzling his face into the crook of Mydei’s neck while damp hair strands tickle his skin.

He freezes, falls silent when he sees the badge Mydei is holding in the palm of his hand.

“I- uhm-” And then he stops talking halfway, uncharacteristically at a loss for words.

Mydei scoffs, traces the bumpy surface of the pin with the pad of his thumb, warm and familiar in his grasp. He had forgotten about this gift, thought he would have no problem letting it go just like he let go of their relationship. But Phainon had found and kept it, held onto it throughout all these years even though there was no guarantee that they would ever reconcile.

Still he quietly nurtured and cared for it, just like he did for their relationship.

“You kept this.” Mydei says, voice unbelievably fond.

He can feel Phainon’s throat bob as he swallows, and when he next speaks, his voice is wispy, like something is lodged in his throat. “Of course, you made it for me.”

“And…” He touches the side of his neck, bringing attention to his tattoo “this was also kind of inspired by your gift.”

Mydei follows suit, hand brushing the edges of his tattoo lightly. He can feel the quivering of Phainon’s throat as his eyelids flutter shut. He feels… overwhelmed with emotion and doesn’t know what to say.

The weight of it is hitting him all at once, Phainon’s devotion in his every action, how he must have been haunted by Mydei’s ghost these past few years, and yet remained persistent to the point of obsession.

Phainon was right, Mydei was the one who had given up on their relationship because of his own insecurities. And was this close to leaving again for good.

He’s glad Phainon didn’t let him.

Preferring to speak with actions rather than words, Mydei spins around, catching Phainon by surprise. He cups his face with both hands and leans in to kiss him lightly on the lips. Unlike their kisses before it’s not messy, not desperate or fervent but something more affectionate, gentle, a promise.

“Thank you.” He simply says, watching as Phainon’s cheeks start to flush red.

“Ah… a-aah…” Phainon replies like an idiot. There’s something extremely satisfying about rendering a smug bastard like him completely speechless.

He remained quiet as they continued preparing for the day, lost in thought. Phainon has put on a simple black t-shirt, tight enough that it outlines his physique beautifully. Mydei is surprised by the wardrobe choice, since their… activities the night before had left his neck in quite a state.

Phainon’s pale, elegant throat is marked with bruises, some which had darkened to purplish black. He couldn’t possibly go out looking like that.

“Shouldn’t you cover that up?” Mydei asks, staring at the angry red and violent purple marks on his milky white skin.

“Don’t want to.” Phainon chirps cheerfully. He motions for his jewelry box. Mydei steps aside to grant him access, only for him to reach out for the leather choker Mydei had been admiring earlier.

He can only stare mesmerized as Phainon wraps the thin fabric around his neck, fastening it with a click. It looks even better than Mydei imagined, how did he know Mydei wanted to see it? Did he read his mind?

It’s almost like he’s doing it on purpose, drawing attention to the bruises on his neck. It’s like… Mydei’s mark of ownership, like Phainon is claimed.

By him.

Mydei bites his tongue and quietly recites nursery rhymes in his head to stop his thoughts from going to someplace unholy.

“Are you not worried about what the media would say? You look like you’ve been assaulted.” Mydei tries asking again in a last ditch effort to salvage his reputation.

“And you looked like you were mauled by a wolf. So I’m hoping they’ll put two and two together.” Phainon says, still entirely too happy about the situation.

Hm… it’s not like he hates the idea of people knowing that Phainon belongs to him.

“You know…” Phainon murmurs, sneaking up behind him in a hug, arms snaking around Mydei’s abdomen like a dragon carefully curling around his treasure. “As good as you look in that shirt, I do hate to see you in it.”

“Let me guess,” Mydei says dryly. “Because you think I look better out of it.”

“Well, that,” Phainon shrugs like he hadn’t just admitted to something utterly shameless. “But mostly because it means you’re planning to go out, and I hate that.”

The time has come for Mydei to leave, and it’s not like he was looking forward to it either. Cipher and Castorice will be waiting for him, probably armed with a slipper to throw if he doesn’t adequately explain the situation. But they are his precious friends, and he was acting poorly last night. An explanation is the least they deserved, and Mydei will just have to accept his fate like a warrior.

Mydei tilts his head back and gives him a look.

Phainon sighs, releasing his waist and putting his arms up in surrender. “I know, I know. I’m not trying to stop you. Don’t worry. At least… let me

drive you home."

"No thanks," Mydei says immediately. "My roommates might try to kill you on sight. Better if you let me smooth things over with them first."

Mydei does a quick sweep of the bedroom, making sure that he hadn't left anything behind. Phainon trails behind him, like a clingy puppy that doesn't want to give its owner even a modicum of privacy. "But now that we're back together again, I need to go over and introduce myself as your boyfriend."

Mydei steps out into the living room, and freezes.

In Phainon's mind, it seems like they had skipped several steps and jumped straight to dating, a leap of Olympic level proportions. It's like the years they've spent apart were nothing but a mild inconvenience, an annoying footnote in their story.

That is… terribly efficient. So to be honest, Mydei doesn't really mind the idea.

But to an outsider, this must look insane. Just 24 hours ago, his friends didn't even know he had history with Phainon. Surely, this would seem way too fast, way too soon to the point that it's suspicious. On second thought, he better ease them in slowly.

"Again, I must decline."

Mydei realizes he's made a mistake when Phainon's face falls, his eye twitches, even his hair seems to wilt like a plant that hadn't been exposed to sunlight.

"Decline introducing me or decline me being your boyfriend?" He asks shakily, voice dangerously soft. Mydei feels like he's threading on thin ice, and one wrong step could cause the whole surface to collapse.

"Phainon, that's not what I mean." While he loves even the intense, unstable side of Phainon, he doesn't feel like dealing with another crashout

right now.

He puts his hands on Phainon's shoulders and squeezes, feeling the muscles tighten under his grasp. "I want to be your boyfriend, I really do. But–"

"Then why not make it official now?" Phainon hurriedly says, hands going up to grip his wrists tightly. "I don't understand why you're making me *wait*."

"Because it's too soon, people are going to think it's strange. They're going to think we brainwashed each other."

"I don't give a fuck what other people think." Phainon interrupts sharply, words coming out almost venomously, gaze sharp and piercing. "This is what broke us apart in the first place, caring too much about what everybody else thought."

Mydei pauses, Phainon's hands are gripping his so tight that his knuckles are white and trembling.

"I don't want to wait anymore. And I don't want to make that same mistake again. So… let me ask you this time." Phainon pleads. Mydei sighs and closes his eyes, knowing what question is coming.

"What do you want, Mydei? Do you want to be with me?"

What an unfair question to ask him. The answer is yes, the answer has always been yes. Even when he tried to bury it, even when he pretended that he had moved on, the feeling was always there, in the back of his mind. It lingers like a parasite he can never shake off.

Even the most carefully built fortress will crumble when faced with Phainon's sincere and clear blue eyes, his expression open and vulnerable.

"Yes. I do." Mydei surrenders, waving his white flag. "Fine. You win. But you will be in charge of explaining to my friends why we got back together so quickly."

Phainon's lip curls up into a smile, slowly, like he's still in disbelief that Mydei has even accepted him. It lights up his face to the point where Mydei has to look away lest he be blinded by the radiance. His ability to suddenly transform from a cold, handsome beauty to an adorable puppy in the blink of an eye should be studied.

"That's easy!" Phainon says cheerfully. "I could talk for hours about your incredible personality, your absurd body, your *amazing* ass, how sweetly you moan when-"

"Shut up! Now." And there is no better way to shut Phainon up than by kissing him into submission.

And well, one thing leads to another, and they may have gotten a little carried away. Next thing he realized, they're on the couch again. Mydei's shirt is crumpled, one side of it tucked out and wrinkled. The collar is open by a few additional buttons, revealing the fresh new hickies on his neck and collarbones. His braid is messy, he will need to do his hair again.

Mydei is starting to realize that this level of physical attraction is not conducive to his daily life. He can't keep his hands off his (no longer) ex-boyfriend, which is a very real problem. He won't get anything done like this!

But when he sees Phainon sitting with his head tilted back against the couch, lips swollen from kissing, a matching hickey on his neck over that godforsaken choker and a smirk that could set him on fire, it makes Mydei want to throw all caution to the wind and jump his bones all over again.

That would be extremely unproductive, so Mydei mentally reminds himself to stay strong and tries to distract himself by having a better look at Phainon's collection of video game paraphernalia. He'd been fairly interested in it since last night, but admittedly he had been… quite distracted with other matters back then.

Looking around, Phainon really is a huge 'Amphoreus: Saga of Heroes' fanboy. He has a collection that many fans would kill to have. In addition to the games themselves, he's got the artbooks, limited edition foil prints,

figures, and even a poster signed by the developers. On the edge of a shelf is a corkboard, cluttered by various keychains and pins dangling off it, smaller trinkets he had collected over the years.

Mydei's eyes catch on to one in particular. "Oh." He remarks, plucking it out for a closer look. "The limited edition Dawnmaker enamel pin. You finally got it. You used to yammer on about wanting this non-stop."

He remembered Phainon whining and whining about how much he wanted it and how cool it was because it reminded him of his favourite hero.

Mydei had considered getting it for him as a gift, he could certainly have afforded it. But in the end he opted for some dorky handmade pin instead. He didn't know why he did that, in hindsight. Maybe from some innate need for it to be special, for it to be the only one of its kind.

He always figured he'd have the chance to go out and buy the Dawnmaker pin some other time.

But it looks like Phainon managed to obtain one anyway.

"Oh," Phainon shuffles his feet, looking uncharacteristically nervous. Mydei hadn't even asked him how he obtained it, it didn't cross his mind. But Phainon blurts it out like he's been carrying it as a guilty secret for some time.

"Actually… it was gifted to me by… uhm-" He seems to wrestle with himself for a second before admitting. "...one of my exes."

"Huh?" Mydei clenches the pin in his fist.

These collectible pins, although limited edition, were still produced en-masse by a gaming company. They were made of cheap alloy, probably nothing as good quality as say—authentic Kremnoan steel. And when Mydei applies pressure on the narrower part of the sword, like so, it bends slightly under the force, feeling like it would snap.

“I’ll throw it away!” Phainon grovels. “I should have done that years ago! It just… never came to mind. I completely forgot about it! That’s how little it meant to me.” He steps closer, hands flailing like he’s not sure whether he should touch Mydei to comfort him or not.

“Mydei, don’t be mad, please?” His blue eyes are watery, voice tinged with panic.

“I’m not mad!” Mydei says calmly (or so he thought) as the pin snaps into half under his grip with a sharp ‘crack’.

They both stare at the shattered pieces of the enamel pin.

“I’m sorry,” Mydei apologizes, alarmed. He’d been annoyed, but hadn’t meant to break it. He’s not the type of guy to just destroy things he doesn’t like. He generally tries to keep himself under control so this was all terribly embarrassing.

“No, no. You just did what I was going to do.” Phainon trails off, and as he keeps looking at the broken pin his face gets progressively redder. “You just snapped metal using your bare hands. That was… kinda… sort of–”

“Don’t say it.” Mydei groans.

“--really hot.”

“Phainon.” Mydei replies testily.

“Sorry, I couldn't help myself…” Phainon says sheepishly. “But it’s true, this trinket meant nothing to me. So there’s nothing to feel jealous about. Your gift was more precious than this entire collection combined.”

He supposes that it makes sense. Mydei’s gift had been carefully preserved in a jewelry box, while this one is carelessly strewn over old videogame boxes and other miscellaneous knick-knacks, there’s even a thin layer of dust on it.

Still, he is a petty, possessive thing. That sort of personality trait isn’t exclusive to Phainon alone, and Mydei’s no saint.

“You’ll throw this away, and get rid of anything you’ve received from other exes.”

Phainon nods his head so quickly that his fluffy white hair bounces. “I swear, there’s nothing else, I stopped accepting gifts a long time ago. This probably slipped my radar because I shoved it into my collection and forgot-”

“I will get you a new one.” Mydei has future rockstar money he’s banking on, and a collectible badge is nothing in the grand scheme of things.

Last night, when Cipher and Castorice had been discussing what they’d like to spend their money on once the band took off, Mydei hadn’t been sure of his answer. He’d never been big on material things, didn’t care for private jets, fancy mansions, or expensive cars.

But now, he thinks he’s finally decided on something he would like to spend money on. And that is replacing everything in this apartment that ever came from someone else.

“A better one,” he adds, eyes flickering to Phainon again.

“Okay, I promise.” Phainon kisses him on the cheek sweetly like he’s consoling a child throwing a tantrum. “You’re cute when you’re pouty.”

“That really isn’t… ugh–” Mydei scowls, pushing Phainon away halfheartedly only for the man to latch onto him like a jellyfish again. In the end, he gives up and lets Phainon pull him back to the couch.

He stares at the stack of magazines on the table, most of them containing Phainon’s face, and asks. “Have I ever told you how my family adopted the original Kokopo?”

Phainon seems surprised at this sudden change of topic. “Kokopo? You mean your cat? No.”

“When I was a child, around 7 or 8 years old, I lived in a large house in a wealthy part of Castrum Kremnos. Our neighbour had a child too, a boy,

just a few years younger than me. He was a little spoiled brat who would throw tantrums and let the whole neighbourhood know when he didn't get his way."

Phainon tilts his head to the side, confusion plainly written on his face. Despite that he lays his head on Mydei's shoulder, a silent motion for him to continue.

"He begged and pleaded with his parents for a pet, and after some time, they relented and got him a cat. Cute, tiny, fluffy, stupid looking little creature."

"He was insufferable about it, took his little minion around and showed it off to everyone he met, including me. But kids like him get bored easily, so after a few weeks I noticed he started neglecting his cat, never played with it, never bought it treats."

Mydei pauses as Phainon hums to show that he's listening, idly running his fingers down Mydei's back through his thin black shirt.

"So I did. I took care of it and treated it like it was my own. Fed it and combed its fur, let it stay over sometimes when it wandered into our yard. I even gave it a name, the Great Beast of Kremnos: Kokopo the 1st."

"Your neighbour's kid didn't mind?" Phainon asks.

"Oh, he minded." Mydei says, voice smug. "One day the brat saw me feeding Kokopo through the fence and threw a huge fit. Even had his parents come over to speak to mine."

He looks at Phainon. "Said I shouldn't interfere with things that didn't belong to me."

"Even though I had gotten attached to Kokopo, I knew I had to let it go. I was a good kid who didn't want to cause any trouble for my parents. I figured that it was just a cat, Kokopo would eventually forget about me if I gave it distance and moved on."

Phainon is quiet now, his expression thoughtful. His eyes looked sad somehow, like he understands the story a little too well.

“One day, a huge storm ripped through our neighbourhood, tore a hole through the fence. That’s when I saw Kokopo just… standing there, staring at my house. So I thought… what was going to happen if I called out to it.”

Mydei reaches out his hand, laying it on Phainon’s thigh, running his hand down until he reaches his knee. Phainon gulps, eyes flitting downwards as he gets distracted by Mydei’s touch.

“A-and?” He asks shakily. “What happened?”

“I called out to Kokopo, told it I’d let it come back and live with me if it wanted to, and it came running.”

Mydei smiles at the memory. “Of course, I knew a cat wouldn’t understand me. But sometimes I wondered… what if it did?”

Mydei lifts his hand off Phainon’s knee, and the latter whimpers, he gestures for Phainon to come closer, and he unconsciously does.

“The neighbour’s brat, of course, raised hell. He accused me of stealing his cat, his parents even threatened to file a police report against me.”

Phainon is not even aware that his body is practically laying over Mydei’s lap when he asks “What did your parents do about that?”

“Are you kidding? I was also a spoiled brat, of course they took my side.” Mydei says with an amused huff. “They saw the state Kokopo was in when I took him back, and stood by whatever decision I wanted to make.”

Mydei reaches down and runs his fingers through Phainon’s soft, white hair, almost like he’s petting a dog. Phainon finds himself nuzzling into the touch. “And the neighbours?”

“The neighbour’s parents didn’t want to deal with mine, and promised their son they’d get him another present. He didn’t like that outcome, and

actually tried stealing Kokopo back a couple of times until he accidentally broke his arm doing so.”

“...Accidentally?” Phainon repeats.

Mydei smirks down at him, devastating and beautiful. “They could never prove it was me.”

Phainon looks at him like he’s fallen in love all over again.

“Mydei… why have I never heard of this side of you?”

Mydei hums, thinking about it for a moment. “I don’t know. It was so long ago that I forgot until now. I wasn’t proud of what I did, but the kid was a jerk, so he had it coming.”

Mydei continues stroking Phainon’s hair as he cuddles into his lap, happy with the physical closeness. “You see, when Kokopo came back to me, I decided that he was mine.”

“And until the day that he died, Kokopo was my most loyal companion.”

Mydei’s gentle fingers curl into the short wavy strands at the back of Phainon’s head and he tugs, just enough to make Phainon shift his head. The model hardly reacts, too busy looking up at Mydei with hearts in his eyes.

“All that is to say… once I decide that something is mine. I don’t share the things that belong to me.”

Chapter End Notes

> Song of the day: Same Color as the Sun - Flor
> Spotify playlist
>
> Omg, we're here, at chapter 8, I can't believe it! You know, I had this Mydei - Kokopo monologue all plotted out since I started working on this fic, back when it was supposed to be like only 5 chapters and 30k words... max lol. It was meant to be plot twist like - oh Mydei is also

possessive but I think we already leaped past that point long ago fork found in kitchen and all that but I still really like it.

This is essentially the end of the story, the next chapter is an epilogue of sorts, it will be uploaded a little later than usual, maybe 2-3 weeks instead of the usual 1-2 because I only just started writing it
They demand for more sexy rockstar Mydei
They demand for more jealous and possessive Phainon

Who are they you ask? Why of course the voices in my head 👉👈

my twitter

Chapter 9: Honey, Are U Coming?

Chapter Summary

Mydei’s signature red guitar rests across his lap, his hand caressing the fretboard like a lover. His tight leather pants make his legs look endless as they stretch out beyond the borders of the page.

Phainon is already drooling, and he hasn’t even looked at Mydei’s face yet!

His neck is tilted back over the edge of the chaise, golden eyes looking straight at the camera like he wants to devour the viewer whole. The red crystal pendant hanging off a chain around his neck is held in between his teeth as he smirks at the camera.

Phainon’s throat bobs as he swallows. His saliva feels thick, his legs are weak, his head is swimming. He feels like he’s going to pass out.

“…Do you need to sit down?” He hears Castorice ask.

Sit down? No… no, he needs a defibrillator.

Chapter Notes

I know I said I wasn't going to extend the chapter count anymore but when my epilogue hit 16k I decided it might be best to split it into two parts so uhm... surprise ehe!

The song of the day is HONEY (ARE U COMING) by Måneskin
I've also made a spotify playlist of the songs that inspired me while writing this fic. So please give it a listen if you like that sort of thing!

Additional CWs for this chapter: uhhhh the evils of capitalism
As usual there are multiple POV switches for this chapter because I love it unabashedly.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The IPC's strategic investment department, true to its name, invested in anything that looked likely to make a profit. Properties and large commercial developments were their go-to's, but their portfolio didn't stop there. Entertainment, agriculture, professional sports, the list was endless. As long as it could make them money, the IPC wanted their fingers in the pot.

Topaz, as an executive of this department, was tasked with management of their assets to ensure they bore fruit.

It wasn't always an easy job, but she enjoyed the challenge.

Her most recent acquisition, a rock band called *Titans of Calamity*, had a lot of promise. And aside from being great at music, they were also really, really good at giving her headaches.

"What do you mean the actor won't be showing up?" Topaz barks into the phone. The frazzled IPC executive is balancing her laptop on her forearm, while her cellphone is pinched in between her ear and shoulder.

"We booked him weeks in advance!" She grits her teeth, only pausing to hear what the person on the other end has to say.

"A surprise casting call for a Goldweaver campaign? *That's* why?" She repeats in disbelief, as though she can't believe her ears.

"I don't care if he's so called 'perfect for the role' or if this is a 'once in a lifetime opportunity'. He was hired for a job and has failed to show up! Unprofessional behaviour will not be tolerated by the IPC. Consider this bridge burned."

With a growl she abruptly hangs up, her footsteps almost leaving a dust cloud as she storms across the studio.

"The director is going to chew us out again… we're delayed as it is…" She complains, her hand is gripping her phone so tightly that it seems like it'll be crushed in her grasp.

Misfortune after misfortune had plagued the *Titans of Calamity*'s first video shoot until they were delayed by a whole 24 hours. They were supposed to have this wrapped up by yesterday. Acclaimed director Mr Reca's services did not come cheap, and with the budget she was given, they didn't have enough to extend filming for another day.

She needs some time to think

We're taking a short break while I sort things out." she says to the cast and crew before storming out, her heels making clicking noises as she walks.

Mydei sinks into the nearest chair, grateful for the break after spending nearly the whole day on his feet. It doesn't take long for Cipher and Castorice to join him, muttering complaints about how their high heels were giving them blisters.

It had been half a year since they put their names down on that contract, signing away their souls to the IPC. From then on, everything had been a whirlwind, things moving at a breakneck pace.

Six months ago, they were playing in shitty dive bars as nobodies with nothing to their name. And now? They have an album, a real studio recorded album that people can hold and listen to. They've played gigs on real stages aided by professional stage crews, attended by crowds who actually *wanted* to be there! They've done promotional shoots for brands who actually reached out and wanted their faces on the products. They're filming a music video right now for their lead single that will even go on television.

Sometimes, it still feels a little insane how quickly their lives changed.

The band's living situation had also improved drastically, the IPC had generously paid for himself, Castorice, and Cipher to move into a bigger, nicer home. They still lived as a trio, because he was used to it, and also because it was more convenient to brainstorm new material this way. But he

would say that yes, having his own ensuite bathroom is a luxury that he could get used to.

Plus, the larger rooms made it easier for his roommates to maintain their sanity when Phainon came over which was… extremely often.

The early days of (re)dating Phainon had been dicey, his friends did not take kindly to Phainon inserting himself back into Mydei's life.

"What is he doing here?" Cipher had asked the moment she laid eyes on him. "Mydei, why did you bring him into our home?"

In her hand she held one of her fuzzy house slippers, and it was aimed straight at Phainon.

Mydei tried to diffuse the situation, knowing how painful one of those smacks could be. "He insisted on coming up. It's okay, Cipher, he knew where I lived anyway."

His reassurance backfired spectacularly when Cipher's face darkened.

And Phainon, shameless in the worst of ways when it came to Mydei, strided forward with confidence, hand outstretched. "It's great to meet Mydei's friends. Greetings. I'm Phainon Khaslana, Mydei's boyfr-"

Phainon didn't even get to finish the sentence before the slipper hits him in the forehead with a resounding smack.

It was well deserved. What was not so well deserved was the second slipper that came flying Mydei's way when he started explaining what had happened the night before and what 'boyfr-' entailed.

Cipher refused to let Phainon take a single step into their home for months.

With his trademark persistence Phainon had eventually won her over, or at least made her reluctantly accept the fact that he was part of a combo set with Mydei now. But she still bristled like a cat every time that head of white hair wandered into her peripheral vision.

Even Castorice, Mydei's number 1 apologist, had been hesitant about his decision. She knew how hurt he'd been by the breakup because she had, unfortunately, seen a lot of the pathetic love songs he wrote in his notebook about 'nobody in particular'. Still, it didn't take her long to come around when she saw how Phainon treated him.

"He looks at you like you're his whole world," she told him as a response when he asked why she stepped in to mediate when things between Phainon and Cipher got a little heated. "I can't hate someone who looks at you like that."

Yeah, she's too good for this world, too pure. Fame hadn't changed her at all.

Fame hadn't changed any of them, really. They had more disposable income now due to the IPC's generous paychecks, and were recognizable enough to occasionally get stopped on the street for a selfie, but aside from that, the rockstar life isn't all it's cracked out to be.

Mostly, it was a lot of work. Long hours crammed in the studio writing songs and crashing out over one note in the chorus that didn't sound right, take after take in the recording booth ensuring that everything was perfect, not even a breath out of place.

And the fucking meetings!

Mydei thought he would never have to attend one ever again when he walked away from the family business. Well let him just put his clown makeup on because little did he know, he would have to sit in as IPC suits talked about things like 'market trends' and 'building audience anticipation'.

He just wanted to play music, but there was a lot of other bullshit that came with it.

Album launches, listening parties, small intimate gigs for the superfans, cryptic social media posts to build up hype, press interviews. The IPC poured money in, and they expected to collect it all back—with interest.

Like Topaz said on the day she signed them, the IPC doesn't make deals that don't pay off. They saw potential in Mydei's band, and were going all in until they hit it big or collapsed under the pressure, whichever came first.

And while the *Titans of Calamity* were prepared for hardship—this was their dream and none of them were letting go without a fight—it didn't change the fact that it was exhausting.

"If I have to hear this song one more time, I'm going to lose my mind." Cipher complains, putting a finger gun to her head and miming pulling the trigger. She lights a cigarette, even though she knows she shouldn't be smoking indoors.

Mydei's eyes track the thin trail of smoke as it floats upwards, and he thinks, fair. He didn't know much about the music industry prior to joining it, and had no idea that artists didn't sing or play their instruments live while filming a video, that everything was lipsynced to the recording, and that it took days to complete a single 4 minute music video. Redoing the same takes from multiple angles, repeating the same scene over and over until it was perfect.

Their lead single, which they had been so proud of, had been playing on loop until he'd started to hate the sound of his own voice. And this was only the beginning.

"Better get used to it," he says. "You heard Topaz. Lead single means we're stuck playing it in every set for the foreseeable future."

"It's a good song," Castorice says, closing her eyes with a blissful expression like she had accepted her fate. "I think I was sick of it yesterday, but today, I'm coming back around to loving it."

Cipher takes a long drag of her cigarette and exhales, smoke rings forming in the air.

“May we all match your level of insanity soon,” she sighs.

“Hyacine taught me something the other day…” Castorice hums thoughtfully. “She said, if you’re going through rough times, sometimes it helps to take a moment to realign, remind ourselves why we’re doing this.”

Yeah… Mydei seemed to recall her saying something like that. Something cheesy about staying grounded, and remembering what really matters.

He shrugs. “Worth a shot.”

“Why the fuck not?” Cipher murmurs, leaning forward in her seat.

Castorice looks pleased as the band huddles into a circle, putting their heads close together like a pre-show ritual. “Then on the count of three, let’s each shout out the one thing that keeps us going.”

“Fine.”
“Whatever.”

Mydei and Cipher didn’t sound delighted about it, but at least they weren’t complaining as Castorice counted cheerfully “One… two…three!”

“The fans!” she says enthusiastically.

“The music.” Mydei says dryly.

And then a sharp voice cuts through both of theirs as Cipher yells at the top of her lungs.

“FOR THE MONEY!”

Mydei and Castorice fall silent, staring at her in wide-eyed shock.

“What?” She turns to address them. “You two need to get your priorities in order, or this industry will eat you alive.”

Mydei snorts despite himself. It was a little ridiculous, but he does feel a little bit better. He appreciates all they're doing for him, his bandmates, colleagues, and best friends.

He relaxes in his seat, tunes out the sound of their conversation as he checks his phone. Phainon had been busy all day with a shoot but he should be done about now… right on cue, there are notifications for new messages on his screen.

Puppy
Finally finished the shoot! ヽ(・∀・)ノ
Are you guys still filming?

Mydei
We're delayed again
Background actor didn't show up
Not looking good

Puppy
Huuuh? (＃`Д´)
I'm on my way will be there soon.
Have you eaten? Are you hungry?
Nvm I'll grab your favourite Kremnoan takeaway on the way (´▽`)

Mydei
It's fine, I'm not hungry

Puppy
Don't worry me like this…
I noticed that you haven't been meeting your protein intake for the past 2 days
And you drank coffee this morning, you hate coffee!

Mydei
?
We didn't see each other today

Puppy
One of the staff members tried to be clever by sneaking a shot of you on stellargram.
I already reported it.
You looked tired, I didn't like it.

Mydei
HKS

He eyes the three dots that indicate Phainon is typing.

"That's enough!" Cipher snatches his phone away like he's a toddler with too much screen time. "Always on your phone texting your boyfriend, you haven't even listened to a word I said! Put down your phone and talk to someone. Geez, you're becoming as much of a hermit as Princess Homebody."

Castorice yelps as she catches strays while Mydei just stares at Cipher with an unimpressed expression.

"You know that's not true, you just have a vendetta against Phainon. Give it back."

"No," Cipher clutches his phone with both hands and holds it behind her back, out of his reach. "You two are going to learn how to live apart. Don't make me throw away your phone."

Mydei crosses his arms, narrowing his eyes as he sizes her up. "Try it, he has a tracking app installed, so he'll just find it anyway."

Cipher throws the phone into his lap like it's a poisonous frog. "What the fuck is wrong with you two!"

Well, true, he realizes the relationship he has with Phainon isn't exactly normal. Sometimes, Mydei wonders if he had gone too easy on him when he agreed to get back together. He should have been a little more cautious,

held back a little, made him work for it. He'd been too caught up in the moment, he supposed, and his judgment slipped.

Phainon had taken it as permission to speed run the relationship, he moved *fast*. Gifts, blowing up his phone 24/7 with messages, romantic gestures both big and small, his commitment to the craft was terrifying. Mydei's roommates still brought up the 'Hyacinth incident', where he stood outside their home in the rain for 2 hours holding a bouquet of hyacinths just to commemorate Mydei's 5th consecutive loss to him in some stupid video game competition they were having.

He was intense, Mydei will give him that. The protagonists of romance movies had nothing on him. He was insecure in ways that he never showed to anyone but Mydei. Like a needy dog, prone to spiralling into despair if Mydei was too busy to give him attention. And sometimes, he could be suffocating in the way he hovered around him, like he was scared Mydei would forget about him as soon as he turned his back.

But to Mydei, falling in love with Phainon was the easiest thing in the world. In fact, he didn't think he'd ever stopped being in love with him. Mydei loved all of him, even the parts that were a little too much. It was exactly what he wanted, and he wasn't about to complain about his steak being too juicy, his lobster too buttery.

Sure, it was a little eerie when Phainon knew things about him that Mydei never shared, and he had an uncanny ability to read his mind even before his thoughts could fully form. He thinks Phainon does it to prove that he's the only one who knows him inside and out.

But eh, Mydei was slowly getting used to it.

"It was a compromise we agreed on," he told Cipher. "After I ghosted him for hours when we had that listening party last month."

She looked at him like he had lost his mind. "Why would you–nevermind, I don't know what goes on in your pretty little head. I've never seen someone have such a bad crashout over a few missed calls. It wasn't even your fault, the line was shitty."

Mydei shrugs. “He was fine.”

Cipher gives him a look. “No he wasn’t. I actually feared for your life when he dragged you into the recording room.”

Mydei smirks when he remembers the memory. Phainon, nearly delirious with worry, pushing him against the wall and having his way with him. The dark look on his face had been so hot as he failed to keep his composure.

“Stop.” Cipher immediately says, “Whatever you’re thinking about just. Stop. I don’t want to know what you did that day.”

“He was upset, wasn’t he?” Castorice asks, trying and failing to hide her obvious curiosity. “Was he jealous?”

“Cas, no.” Cipher puts her hands over her ears.

“Would you say it was more a subtle, simmering jealousy, or the intense, explosive kind?” Mydei doesn’t answer that, which only made her eyes shine brighter.

“Oh, I see. And after that, would you say you blissfully made out or was it like… rougher?” Castorice continues, procuring a notebook out of nowhere, she’d been carrying it around with her a lot lately, calling it ‘journalling’.

“Little lion, I’ll kill you if you answer that,” Cipher snaps.

Mydei shakes his head with a small smile, looking back at his phone. According to his messages, Phainon was on his way with an ETA of 10 minutes.

He didn’t know why Phainon had been so insistent on showing up to the video shoot. He still worked as a full time model, and was always busy. But Mydei knew not to deny him when he wanted something, and it wasn’t like his presence was going to be a bother either. Mydei likes having Phainon around, as due to their busy lives, the time they spent together always felt way too short.

So, he had told his model boyfriend that he could stop by whenever he liked.

It's too bad they were delayed, because they could have wrapped up by now and Mydei could get some precious rest in, maybe even take a nap.

"Hey, Mydei, mind if I touch up your makeup?" Their makeup artist, Siobhan asked.

Getting his makeup retouched means that there was still filming to be done, so much for an early night. But as usual, Mydei reminds himself that he should be grateful for the opportunities that were offered. Siobhan is a renowned professional makeup artist who usually worked with artists far above their level. People like Robin, THE Penaconian superstar, and the highcloud quintet, THE rock band of their generation.

It still made him feel a little starstruck, if he stopped to think about it for too long.

He nods and lets her do her work.

~*~

In his mind, Phainon keeps a hit list of people who have wronged him. He would never share it with anyone, and he never intends to act on it, but it's one of his many methods to keep his destructive tendencies at bay.

Who was on it? Principal Caenis, for starters, for all the shit she put him and Mydei through in school. His accountant, Lycurgus, that slimy bastard, whose very smile sends chills down his spine. Caelus, his college roommate, was not on the list, but he was on thin ice from the time he touched Mydei's bicep without permission and exclaimed 'Phainon, dude, your boyfriend's body is insane.'

Only Phainon was allowed to say that.

And now, the IPC had earned an honorary spot on that list.

Who were they to occupy so much of Mydei's time? Okay, so maybe they were his employers or whatever, but weren't they overworking him a little too hard? He barely has time to spend with Phainon anymore, and when he does he looks so tired, like he might keel over at any moment. Phainon hates it.

The IPC, one of the biggest corporations in the world, knew what they were doing. Every investment they put into the band was expected to be reciprocated tenfold. They weren't just selling their music, they were selling the band themselves. Each member was considered a part of the product.

So the first thing the company did was assign each band member a defining attribute. Something they would be known by, a marketable trait they could milk.

Mydei had insisted that they have no manufactured personas, but the IPCs were masters at bending the rules. It wasn't fake or manufactured if the characteristics they enhanced were all true.

For Cipher, it was her unique fashion style. They stole her signature cat ear hoodie to mass produce and it became a styling trend overnight. Everyone had their own; little kids on the street, influencers on stellargram, high school girls who thought they were cool. It was everywhere, and Aglaea hated the trend so much she still grits her teeth thinking about it.

For Castorice, it was her softness and femininity, or as the IPC executives called it—'wife material'. Her quiet, gentle nature had been exaggerated for people to project their ideal woman onto. Someone who was strong, but still submissive; a cool girl, who was also fragile. A version of her with the edges sanded away that would be palatable to the general public.

It was a strategy that Phainon was uncomfortably familiar with, the way it had been used on him throughout his career, and he had played into it without a second thought.

Mydei… Well, it was obvious what they would focus on, his sex appeal was undeniable to anyone with eyes. They made sure to strip him in almost every photoshoot, putting him in ‘clothing’ that emphasized his downright absurd body. Even the way he was posed in front of the cameras, pecs and abs on full display, was obviously intended for the enjoyment of the viewer. A full course meal for the ears and the eyes.

And like, Phainon can’t even be too mad about it because they were completely right. His boyfriend was fucking HOT, too hot for his own good, hotness that couldn’t even be measured on a scale. And Phainon is starting to understand why fans would scream and lose their minds when looking at pictures of their idols because he feels like doing that every single time they release new promotional content of Mydei.

But aren’t the IPC doing a little TOO much to promote the band? He knows that they need to turn a profit but the *Titans of Calamity* were a rock band and bands were supposed to be defined by their music, right? Like, they didn’t need to strip Mydei Every. Single. Time. Right?? And why is Mydei just going along with it? It’s driving Phainon INSANE!

Because the strategy is working, of course it is. And Phainon always says he’s okay with it when Mydei runs through the concepts with him at night in bed, but he’s lying. It’s easy to say that he’s hypothetically okay with the idea of his boyfriend flaunting his perfect abs in front of tens and thousands of fans, many who openly lust after him on social media (although, if he’s being honest, he’s not even okay with it hypothetically). But it’s a lot harder to practice what he preaches when Mydei looks like that.

If he wants to keep him, Phainon needs to prove that he can be a supportive and loving partner. He’s normal, healthy, and he’s definitely NOT a jealous asshole who fantasizes about locking his lover up in a cage whenever someone makes eye contact with him for a second too long.

He arrives at the filming location all smiles, muscular arms laden with delicious, warm, containers of food. He’s even bought some extra to hand out to the other staff members. People smile and greet him cheerfully as he walks in, knowing him well enough as ‘Mydei’s charming model friend’ to let him do as he pleases.

Some of the staff members thank him profusely as he offers them the additional food, probably the first proper meal they've had all day.

"The pay is shit, the hours are gruelling, but at least the hottest man alive sometimes shows up to bring us food." An employee sighs to her colleague when she thinks Phainon is out of earshot.

Unfortunately, he isn't. Phainon meets her eye, and she freezes in place instantly.

It's too awkward to pretend that he hadn't heard it, so he just smiles at her and watches as her face turns pink.

It usually is that easy to make people like him.

"I'm happy to be of service. Please enjoy the snacks." He says.

"Oh my gods." he hears another employee say as he heads deeper into the set. "He's even better looking in person!"

"Handsome, rich, sweet, dreamy. He's the full package."

He pays no heed to their gossip, though he's not oblivious to the rumours that are going around the staff. Who is he to Mydei? Why do they always seem attached at the hip? He thinks their relationship should be obvious enough to anyone who spends any significant amount of time around either of them. But as long as nothing is confirmed, people will continue to speculate.

Neither have made official statements about the nature of their relationship, not yet, at least. The IPC didn't want any scandals jeopardizing Mydei's up and coming music career, and while he was loath to admit it, Phainon agreed. He had a pretty rabid fanbase himself, and Mydei deserved so much more than to be torn to pieces online by nameless faceless nobodies.

Hiding their relationship is the smart thing to do, he knows it is. But… it's torture, absolute torture. Not being able to hold Mydei in public, kiss him, hug him, let the whole world know he belongs to Phainon. He has to live

everyday knowing that Mydei is in close proximity with other people. People who, more often than not, were physically attracted to him because… duh, they had eyes.

And what he sees when he finally catches sight of Mydei doesn't improve his mood at all.

A blonde woman is looming over him, leaning way too close into his personal space as she touches up his makeup. He knows he's being overly possessive, knows he's being unreasonable. He even knows Siobhan personally, she's an industry professional who is definitely not attracted to men. But it doesn't stop him from getting jealous nonetheless because she does not know how lucky she is to get unfiltered access to that perfect bone structure, his beautiful eyelashes, his luscious hair.

As Phainon stands there, seething over something inconsequential, Mydei spots him from the corner of his eye. He can't turn his head or call out, but his lips curl up in a smile nonetheless.

Fuck! His chest hurts, Phainon's going to die young from a heart attack.

Mydei isn't the only one who notices him, Castorice is here too. She waves cheerfully when he approaches, actually happy to see him.

He'd bonded with her over realizing that they'd gone to the same university, just a year apart, and even took the same philosophy class under the same cutthroat professor. It's crazy to think that if he'd joined university a year later and befriended Castorice he could have entered Mydei's life more organically, rather than barreling into it ass first. But Mydei seems to like that about him, so he couldn't complain.

And today it is Castorice who beckons him aside, smiling at him coyly with her arms behind her back. She normally is pretty reserved, so Phainon can't help but be curious.

"It's good to see you, Castorice. And where's the lovely lady Cipher today?"

“She went out for some fresh air, but this is good timing. I have something to show you.” Castorice nearly bounces on the soles of her feet, looking excited to share this good news.

He doesn’t have to be kept in suspense for long, because Castorice looked like she absolutely couldn’t wait anymore as she pulled out the magazine she was hiding behind her.

“We received the advanced copies this morning, I thought you’d appreciate one.” She tells him sweetly.

Phainon gapes at the gift in front of him. He wants to fall to his knees and thank her profusely, she’s an angel.

It’s the latest issue of ‘The Rolling Tones’ magazine, a renowned music publication. It’s important because the *Titans of Calamity* are being featured on this issue, and although Mydei never said it out loud, he was quietly buzzing with pride when he told Phainon the news.

He’s been dying to get his hands on an early copy, with no luck… until now.

Phainon takes it reverently like he’s accepting an offering. The magazine paper feels smooth and glossy underneath his fingertips..

Castorice had been like this for a while now, drip feeding him with little gifts, factoids about Mydei like his upcoming schedule, stories about what happened while they were touring, filling in the blanks on what he missed out on when they weren’t together. Phainon knows why, it’s guilt, guilt that dates all the way back to when she had tried to set Mydei up with a random stranger.

Phainon doesn’t have any hard feelings towards her, it wasn't her fault. As much as it devastates him to admit it, they were broken up. Mydei was single. Nothing wrong with talking to someone new, trying to move on.

Of course Phainon had been fucking furious, he’d been mad enough to kill! But mainly, he was angry at himself for not staking his claim sooner. For

making it seem like Mydei was available. For anyone to think that trying to set him up was even an option..

Still, Castorice was quietly trying to make amends, and if a part of those reparations included smuggling him hot pics of Mydei before it was released to the public, Phainon wasn't going to look a gift horse in the mouth.

He looks at the magazine she's placed into his arms, a fanboy's treasure. It features the whole band on the cover, background dark, spotlights shining down upon them from outside the camera's view. Cipher and Castorice are featured in the foreground, posing casually while looking away from the camera. Mydei's the tallest so he stands at the back, towering over the others.

Phainon hums a little with indignation, because how *dare* they put him at the back! And yet, it's unfair how well he draws attention to himself, despite being out of focus. It's like he doesn't even have to try.

The distressed black denim jacket looks so good draped against his broad frame. The rips around the elbows and ironed on patches across the chest really painting the image of a rebellious punk. Underneath, a tight white t-shirt clings onto the curves of his muscles for dear life, almost translucent enough to hint at the tattoos underneath. Metal accessories catch the light, glinting across his fingers, his neck, and all along the sides of his ear. His hair is artfully done up in a messy half ponytail, blond and red strands blending together, sunglasses perched on top of his head. Combined with his cool and indifferent expression, he is truly breathtaking.

He hitches a breath, eyes glued to the cover page. This man is going to be the death of him, truly.

The headline simply reads: *Calamity Approaching: The New Titans of Rock*.

Oh, this one is definitely getting framed in his room.

"Open it up." Castorice tells him, her eyes are sparkling, posture impatient, like she knows something Phainon doesn't "To the center spread."

Curious, Phainon does as she asks. The photograph that greets him threatens to stop his heart on the spot.

The center spread had been dedicated entirely to Mydei. It was like the magazine editors regretted putting him at the back and were determined to shoot Phainon dead twice.

Mydei is draped over a chaise, completely shirtless, relaxed and languid like a regal lion. And this is what Phainon means when he says the IPC are totally taking advantage of his incredible body and sex appeal! A shining example right here!

The angle is shot from above, the camera looking down onto this perfect meal. The spotlights shine down upon him, highlighting every dip of muscle, the light sheen of sweat, the bold red strokes of his tattoos. Just how close did the photographer have to be to get this shot? He imagines some nameless, faceless photographer standing above his boyfriend, close enough to see it all in high definition. Angling for titans knows how long until they got the perfect shot. Argh… that bastard… that lucky bastard is going on his hit list for sure! He ought to wring their neck!

“Oh, that’s a good reaction. But Phainon… you’re going to crush the page.”

Castorice’s voice pulls him back to the present and Phainon forces his fists to relax. He doesn’t want to crumple the page, this is his prized treasure now and he needs to take good care of it.

With a shaky inhale, he looks back at the photograph, eyes roving, raking in every detail, studying every pixel.

Mydei’s signature red guitar rests across his lap, his hand caressing the fretboard like a lover. His tight leather pants make his legs look endless as they stretch out beyond the borders of the page.

Phainon is already drooling, and he hasn’t even looked at Mydei’s face yet!

His neck is tilted back over the edge of the chaise, golden eyes looking straight at the camera like he wants to devour the viewer whole. The red crystal pendant hanging off a chain around his neck is held in between his teeth as he smirks at the camera.

Phainon's throat bobs as he swallows. His saliva feels thick, his legs are weak, his head is swimming. He feels like he's going to pass out.

"…Do you need to sit down?" He hears Castorice ask.

Sit down? No… no, he needs a defibrillator.

How is he supposed to be normal after seeing that?

The magazine looks to be in the late stages of production, it's probably finished its printing run and will be circulating to stores soon. What can he do to stop its publication? Nothing, the answer is nothing. He can't let the public see this version of Mydei, but Phainon is powerless to fight against the IPC.

He has no choice but to go and buy up every single copy before the general public can get their hands on it.

He's going to need Aglaea to book him more work…

"I'm just going to take it that you like the shirtless look," Castorice says rather unhelpfully, scribbling something into her notebook with a pen. "I knew that pose was a good idea, I helped with a lot of the shoot direction. Did a lot of research on the internet."

"Et tu, Castorice?" Phainon wheezes, shocked that Castorice casually admitted to being the cause of his demise. "You were supposed to protect his modesty!"

She should be helping Mydei look less attractive, not more. This… this is sabotage!

Castorice just blinks at him sweetly, though Phainon is starting to realize that she's not as innocent as she's letting on. "But Mydei himself doesn't

have a problem with it? And apparently, neither do you."

Phainon sucks in a breath through his teeth, he's been called out. Castorice casts a knowing glance in his direction, and he knows that she's testing him in her own way.

Mydei values honesty above all, and Phainon had no doubt that he'd tell the IPC where to shove it if Phainon, as his boyfriend, expressed even the slightest discomfort with the way he's being marketed. And likewise, if Mydei wanted him to quit his modelling job, Phainon would do so immediately and without hesitation.

But… Mydei had already done so much to accommodate him and his insecurities, more than a normal partner should need to. Like giving him his phone password and letting him put a tracker on his device. He was always thoughtful too, running the upcoming concepts by him and giving him the chance to object. Even though he was just doing his job, even though saying no would have consequences with his employers.

Phainon had asked for so much already, and Mydei had always given without asking for anything in return. It seemed unfair to demand more. It would be wrong for him to tell Mydei to stop doing something he loved just because Phainon was jealous.

Probably sensing his inner turmoil, Castorice decides to be merciful and drop the subject. Her expression is softer, and her voice more empathetic when she says "I think Mydei's makeup is done, let's go over."

Phainon nods. "Just… let me put this away somewhere safe first." This magazine is his family heirloom now.

Cipher is back by the time he and Castorice regroup with the others, greeting him with a bombastic side eye. "Well, well, if it isn't the deliverer boy," the dumb nickname that she picked because he always had a gift in hand, more often than not.

"What a surprise to see you here." Her tone is sweet, artificially saccharine. If she had a cat's tail, it would probably be flicking behind her in irritation

right now.

“I thought you were too busy to show up,” Mydei greets him with a smile, and the way he looks so genuinely happy sends Phainon’s heart into overdrive.

Even though they’re literally dating, sometimes Mydei just looks so good that it makes Phainon feel shy, standing before him, butterflies in his stomach like he’s a teenager again. Just like right now.

The black jacket he’s wearing looks expensive enough to cost an entire month’s wages. It’s adorned with heavy looking golden chains and matching fine embroidery, regal and luxurious. But in contrast, his baggy red jeans which are torn at the hems give off a harsher, more rugged look. A king that doesn’t quite belong to either world, but somehow embodies the best of both. What a fitting outfit for Mydeimos.

His makeup is subtle, just a fine dusting of dark eyeshadow in the corner of his eyelid, nothing that takes away from his natural beauty. Just slight contouring to draw attention to the sharpness of his cheekbones, red eyeliner to emphasize the gold of his eyes.

Siobhan has outdone herself, he’s mesmerizing.

Though, if you asked Phainon, he would look just as incredible with nothing on—*especially* with nothing on.

Everyday he counts his blessings that he has this adonis as his boyfriend.

“And miss my boyfriend’s first official video shoot? I could never.” Phainon raises his hand with the takeout like it’s an offering. “I got you all some food, dessert included. Honeycakes for Cipher and Mydei, and for Castorice, the small tarts with the strawberries that you like.”

Remembering Mydei’s friends favorite foods is a sure fire way to get them to warm up to him, and it works like clockwork. Right before his eyes he sees Cipher’s gaze soften, her pupils dilating slightly.

“Are you trying to buy my favour? You scoundrel!” Despite her harsh words, Cipher looks pleased as she accepts the food with a gleeful, hungry look.

“Oh, we haven’t eaten all day, you’re a lifesaver.” Castorice says gratefully.

“I suppose the little doggy deserves a treat.” Cipher opens the takeout box, takes a deep indulgent inhale of the pleasant aroma wafting from the food, and immediately proceeds to dig in. “What about this, one embarrassing story about the little prince in his college days.”

“Cipher,” Mydei growls dangerously.

Phainon finds himself leaning forward in anticipation. “This is the best thing that’s happened to me all day!”

“How about… the time he thought one of his coursemates was into cannibalism?”

“How was I supposed to know ‘you’re so cute I could eat you up!’ was a figure of speech? Nobody speaks like that in Castrum Kremnos.” Mydei argues back petulantly, arms crossed, dusting of pink across his cheeks. Ugh, he’s so cute that Phainon wants to just… put his teeth on the apples of his cheeks and chomp down. “Who says that kind of stuff to another person anyway? What was I supposed to think?”

The smile slides off Phainon’s face like someone had dunked him into a bucket of cold water.

“Wait… who’s saying that to you Mydei?” He asks slowly, carefully. Cipher clams her mouth shut and suddenly gets really into eating as Castorice starts scribbling into her notebook furiously.

“Forget it, that was all in the past,” Mydei hastily says. Phainon won’t forget about it, he’ll interrogate him about it at home later… preferably in his bed.

“Anyway,” Castorice chirps, smoothly changing the subject. “Phainon, will you be coming to the Soulglad promotional event next weekend?”

Phainon tilts his head to the side inquisitively. “What’s that?”

“I was going to tell you later,” Mydei says as Phainon looks at him with a betrayed expression. He *thought* he’d synced up Mydei’s phone calendar to his so he’d be aware of his schedule. Obviously… something had slipped through the cracks. “Just some brand ambassador thing, same stuff you do everyday. You’re probably bored of them already.”

Phainon’s smile tightens, he’ll be the judge of that. He had hoped that after so many months of dating Mydei would just stop worrying about whether Phainon would like something or not and let Phainon smother him like he’d always wanted. He knows Mydei means well but… that’s the problem, isn’t it?

Cipher is smirking like she has a trump card up her sleeve. “You think your deliverer boy will miss out on the life sized cutout auction they’re doing?”

Phainon snaps to attention. “What?”

“For charity,” Mydei turns to him. “Not that I think anyone will even buy such a freaky thing. But I guess it’s better than throwing it away.”

Phainon needs it like he needs air, immediately, imperatively, vitally. There *cannot* be a life sized cutout of Mydei sitting in someone else’s home, he will not allow it. “I’ll be there,” he says. “Text me the details. Nevermind, I’ll look them up myself.”

Damn it, how can he even think of quitting his job? Or retiring early?? It’s clear that he will need money now more than ever. He’ll cash out on his investments, and in the worst case scenario he still has his savings to tap into, but he had intended to use those on a downpayment for a house so–

“Deliverer, no.” Ever since Cipher started calling him that, Mydei also unconsciously picked up on the nickname. Though, Phainon likes it a lot

more when it comes from his lips, his voice always dips down low in the middle syllable and it’s so hot.

“You will not waste your money on such frivolities. Your room is disturbing enough as it is and haven’t I told you that I can obtain anything you want for free?”

Phainon’s shoulders deflate, well he did say that, but that’s not the point. It’s one thing to get something for free because of his connections, and another to snatch it out of the hands of another fan to prove he was better. The latter was far more satisfying.

“But… I want to support you financially.” Phainon says weakly.

“HKS.” Mydei reaches out and grabs his chin, holding him in place. His golden eyes stare deeply into his and Phainon feels his mouth go dry. “Everything that you own is mine anyway. Or have you forgotten that?”

In the background, Cipher gags, while Castorice’s pen moves even faster.

A woman’s voice interrupts them as she clears her throat, he recognizes her as their manager, Topaz from the IPC. Mydei jolts only slightly, stepping away from Phainon and pretending they weren’t anything. It hurts. Another reason for him to add the IPC to his hit list.

“I hate to be the bearer of bad news.” Topaz sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose. “The actor we hired for the shoot isn’t coming. It’ll take some time to find a replacement so let’s just… wrap up early and continue another day.”

The band looks slightly disappointed at this turn of events, but nobody protests.

Topaz sighs again, the eyebags beneath her eyes are like dark shadows. “I need to return to the office to recalculate the budget. This kind of delay won’t be cheap. We’ll need to make up the margins elsewhere, maybe another brand collaboration, or some extra tour dates.”

Once again, nobody objects. They're far too realistic for that, they knew what they were getting into the moment they signed the contract. But Phainon does see the way Castorice's face falls in disappointment, Cipher's eyebrow twitching with irritation. Even Mydei, expression stoic as ever, looks slightly put out by the news.

Extra tour dates or collaborations means more work, more travelling, more exhaustion.

"I'm already sleep deprived as it is…" Cipher sighs.

"Polyxia says she's starting to forget what I look like even though we're twins…" Castorice mumbles.

For Phainon, this is absolutely unacceptable. More tour dates means more nights Mydei will be away for work, less time they can spend together. For the rest of their lives already isn't enough time, he's not going to let that number drop even further.

The band do not stop him when he slips away to go after Topaz, too busy mulling over their own predicament.

It's easy for him to catch up to her despite her quick strides, and he stops her by tapping her on the shoulder.

"Excuse me, Miss Topaz, right? I'm–"

"I know who you are," Topaz spins around briskly, as though she had been aware of his presence all along "What can I do for you, Mr Khaslana?"

"I guess we can skip the introductions," he smiles wryly, he expected no less from an IPC executive. "So I'll get straight to the point. It's more a question of what I can do for you."

Topaz arches a brow, but she's not shutting him down. In the corporate language of the IPC, this is her telling him that she's interested.

"I can fill in as the actor for Mydeimos' scene. I'm sure a simple internet search should tell you that I have all the required qualifications."

To her credit, Topaz does not seem surprised by his offer.

“More than that, I’d say you’re a little overqualified.” She says coolly. “I’m aware of your appearance fees, and we can’t afford it. We’re running on a tight budget.”

“I haven’t even said anything about money,” As expected of the IPC, Topaz is a shrewd negotiator. But Phainon will offer her something she cannot refuse. “What if I said I’ll do it for free?”

Topaz taps her pen on the edge of her lip, expression bemused. “That’s a very generous offer. What’s in it for you?”

Phainon shrugs. “Just wanted to help out a friend.”

Her lips quirk up in a smirk. “I’m sure. I suppose you’ll be a good fit for the role. The two of you already have chemistry, after all.”

Not for the first time, Phainon wonders just how much she knows. To his knowledge, Mydei had never disclosed their relationship to anyone within the IPC, but it must be obvious enough to someone as sharp as Topaz. Phainon is anything but subtle when it comes to Mydei. If he could be all over him 24/7, stuck like a parasitic organism, he would like that.

“Then we have a deal?”

“Not so fast,” Topaz puts her hand out, stopping him mid sentence. “I haven’t made my decision yet. You stand out, Mr Khaslana, whether you like it or not. We can’t have an extra overshadowing the main subject of the video.”

Okay, now *that* is insulting. As if anyone can outshine Mydei on his home turf. You could put the literal Goddess of Beauty Idrila in the same room and Mydei would still shine brighter.

But he can’t lose his temper, not when he’s so close to getting what he wants. He knows this is all a test by the IPC anyway, so Phainon forces himself to smile brighter.

“That won’t be a problem,” he says disarmingly. “You’ll find that I am very good at playing my assigned role. Just give me one chance to show my worth, you’ve got nothing to lose. Do you?”

Topaz eyes him warily, he can almost see the gears turning in her head, weighting the risk versus the benefits. But he knows he has a winning hand, there is very little reason for her to turn down his offer.

She purses her lips, nods slightly to herself, and asks no further questions. “Well, it can’t hurt to try, since we already paid for Mr Reca’s time anyway. And rumours will spread once the public realizes it’s you in the video, but any publicity is good publicity as far as I’m concerned.”

She taps on her phone and tilts her head, barking orders into her headpiece to get the film crew back in position. There was a lot of work to be done.

Right before Phainon gets ushered off to the dressing room to change into his outfit, Topaz glances at him from the corner of her eye and sighs “Just… try to keep it PG-13.”

Phainon points at himself innocently, why is she trying to insinuate that he’s up to something? Of course, he’ll be on his best behaviour.

~*~

When a production assistant comes running over to tell them not to leave yet, that a last minute replacement had stepped in to shoot the scene with Mydei, Cipher rolls her eyes, Castorice giggles behind her hand, and Mydei feels like laughing.

No, no, it’s nothing. He thinks it’s funny, that’s all.

What are the odds that on the day he was supposed to film his first one on one with an actor, the guy can’t show up due to a surprise casting call—from Aglaea the goldweaver of all people.

And to add to that, Phainon just conveniently happens to be here. Available, ready, and more than happy to step in to fill the now vacant position.

Topaz had pitched the scene a couple of weeks ago, and well, Mydei knew this day would come eventually. The IPC had been milking his sex appeal for a while now, taking any opportunity to strip his clothes off when it comes to photoshoots or promotional material. Mydei… doesn't really mind, he knows he looks good, and if it wasn't him it would be one of the girls, which he didn't want them to be subjected to. Sex sells, like it or not, and if one of them had to do it, it might as well be him.

But it's not just his opinion he has to consider, Mydei has a boyfriend now, a clingy, devoted, touchy dog of a boyfriend who gets jealous if he even looks another guy's way. So of course, he had to talk it over with Phainon first.

To his surprise, Phainon had said it was fine, giving his blessing even though Mydei had emphasized that the scene was going to be steamy, that the IPC wanted him and the actor being close to each other, to really sell the illusion of wanting, of yearning. It was… disappointing how easily Phainon gave his approval. Even though Mydei should be happy that his boyfriend now feels secure enough not to fly off the handle at the idea of him acting out an intimate scene with someone else.

But he supposed that Phainon would know all about acting intimate with other people. It was a model's bread and butter, after all.

He did it all the time, suggestive photoshoots with other people. Celebrities, models, advertising a brand new perfume or a designer brand. A hand on another person's waist, arm around their shoulder, gaze smoldering as they stared at each other, all plastered on billboards for everyone to see.

Mydei knows it's just work, and it's not like he feels insecure about it. Because at the end of the day, he's the one that Phainon comes bounding home to, tongue lolling, tail wagging, and begging for praise.

This is common in the entertainment industry, and Mydei had better get himself used to it. In his case he didn't even have to make skin to skin

contact with the actor, suggestive camera angles and strategic lighting would be doing all the work. It was just an illusion of passion for the cameras.

He gets into position for the scene, just like they rehearsed. He’s sprawled out on a couch, legs spread, elbows draped over the backrest, playing the part of a confident rockstar. The actor is supposed to be an ordinary guy dressed in a crisp white shirt and a black tie that Mydei allows to approach him. It’s a classic trope, the fantasy between a rockstar and an ordinary fan.

“Is our last minute actor ready?” Mr Reca hollers at the dressing room “Everybody’s waiting for him.”

“Just finishing hair and makeup, director!” A staff member replies as Phainon walks out onto the set.

And Mydei’s breath catches in his throat.

Fuck him.

Chapter End Notes

I'M SORRY FOR THE CLIFFHANGER you'll understand why next chapter there was no other place I could have split it.
The next chapter will be out by next week since I'm almost done with it (I know I said it would take 2-3 weeks for the epilogue and it has taken me... much longer, in my defense I overestimated my writing speed). It has been such a journey but I really enjoyed writing it and I hope you enjoy reading it too. Thank you so much!

my twitter where I glaze Mydei a lot

Chapter 10: You're the Death of Me

Chapter Summary

> “How do I look?” Phainon mouths playfully, lips curled up in a shit eating grin as he places a knee on the sofa, right next to where Mydei is sitting. Like this, he’s almost straddling him. He’s close, closer than Mydei expected him to be, closer than he planned for. If Phainon leans forward just a little bit more, the tips of his messy white hair would touch Mydei’s face. “Do you like me like this?”
>
> The answer is yes, pathetically so, soppingly so. But Phainon’s head is big enough without him stroking his ego even more. Someone needs to push him down a peg or two.
>
> “You look stupid.” Mydei mouths back, making sure to enunciate every word.
>
> Phainon snorts, tilting his head to the side so that his hair brushes his shoulder. Whatever he’s thinking about, he seems to come to a conclusion when he snorts and flashes Mydei a smile, white teeth peeking through pale lips. Mydei watches him mouth a singular word.
>
> *“Okay.”*

Chapter Notes

> Song(s) of the day are Obsession by Thornhill and Death of Me by Amira Elfeky! I couldn't decide on which one to use and both fit this chapter really well imo so I remembered I had free will and used both. And the spotify playlist that inspired the fic this is the last time I get to be annoying about it so pls bear with me
>
> Additional CWs: Return of the choking kink
>
> Also this chapter contains customcss at the end so please make sure your creators workskins are enabled for the best experience! :) Full

credit once again to hsr chatbox guide by jihnari I would be nothing without you.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei's acting partner isn't supposed to be super attractive, that was kind of the point. They were supposed to look like a nondescript every man. The kind of person ordinary viewers could project themselves onto so they could imagine hooking up with a handsome rockstar after the show.

Phainon is obviously… not that. There is no universe where he can ever be considered 'plain' or 'nondescript' even though the hair and makeup crew had tried their best.

A collared white shirt that doesn't fit him properly, plain black slacks and neck tie in a perfect Windsor knot. The thick black rimmed glasses look comically fake the way they stand out against his face, the lenses so thick that Mydei can hardly see his blue eyes. His hair's been mussed up deliberately, bangs covering almost half his face.

It's so different from the way Mydei is used to seeing him. And it's unfair that Phainon still looks this good despite all efforts made to dim his light.

Phainon always knew exactly how to drive him insane.

And now Mydei can only stare, gobsmacked, as his boyfriend walks towards him; heat curling in his abdomen, cock stirring in his pants. None of which is decidedly professional behaviour.

Mr Reca motions for the cameras to start rolling. "Take one. Mydeimos, you know what to do. Khaslana, as we discussed earlier, follow the script. Now… action!" He snaps the clapperboard as the song starts playing from the speakers.

The original idea was for Mydei to ignore the actor as he approaches, playing the part of a nonchalant rockstar. But this time, he can't help but look up when footsteps approach him. Phainon's shadow envelopes him, the angling and lighting making his already impressive frame look even broader. The lines between the pursuer and the pursued are getting blurry.

“How do I look?” Phainon mouths playfully, lips curled up in a shit eating grin as he places a knee on the sofa, right next to where Mydei is sitting. Like this, he’s almost straddling him. He’s close, closer than Mydei expected him to be, closer than he planned for. If Phainon leans forward just a little bit more, the tips of his messy white hair would touch Mydei’s face. “Do you like me like this?”

The answer is yes, pathetically so, soppingly so. But Phainon’s head is big enough without him stroking his ego even more. Someone needs to push him down a peg or two.

“You look stupid.” Mydei mouths back, making sure to enunciate every word.

Phainon snorts, tilting his head to the side so that his hair brushes his shoulder. Whatever he’s thinking about, he seems to come to a conclusion when he snorts and flashes Mydei a smile, white teeth peeking through pale lips. Mydei watches him mouth a singular word.

“*Okay*.”

What’s that supposed to mean?

All of a sudden, Phainon darts forward quickly, like he’s trying to shove Mydei down. They don’t touch, but Mydei goes down like a stack of cards anyway, sideways until his back is pressing against the seat of the couch. Caught off guard, Mydei reaches and grabs the end of Phainon’s neck tie.

“What are you doing?” Mydei asks. He’s going off script, but that is the least of his concerns as his words come out in a panic. They are muffled by the loud music, but they’re close enough that he’s sure Phainon can hear him. He’s vaguely aware of the fact that he’s probably wide-eyed from shock, losing control of the situation.

“Nothing. Just playing my part.” Phainon’s voice is cocky, teasing. He’s so close that Mydei can feel his warm breath on his cheek when he speaks close to his ear, and Mydei instinctively shivers. “Why are you so scared suddenly? I thought you rehearsed this.”

Mydei exhales shakily, his body is on fire. He itches to lay his hands on Phainon, to run his fingers down over the contours of his body and feel the muscle flex beneath that thin white shirt. He's so turned on right now but he can't let it show, and it's taking every ounce of discipline he has just to stay sane.

It's a world away from rehearsing it jokingly with Castorice and Cipher, bodies all entangled, laughing at how cringe the entire concept is. It would be easy for him to stay professional and just do his job if the other party is an actor whom he doesn't know and has no feelings for. But it's a whole different ball game when it's his sexy, handsome, insanely attractive supermodel boyfriend leaning down over him. His restraint can only go so far before it snaps like a thread.

"Relax," Phainon murmurs into his ear as Mydei's body tenses in a way that's anything but. "Anything he can do, I can do better~ I'll make you look so good."

Mydei scoffs with the belated realization that Phainon is somehow competing with a faceless, nameless person neither of them had ever met. But of course he had no doubt that Phainon would emerge victorious, that was as obvious as saying that the sky is blue.

Meanwhile the song is still blaring in the background and Mydei knows he needs to focus. The next verse is starting, and he seems to recall that he should be doing something with it but finds that all rational thought has flown out of his head when Phainon smirks down at him like that.

Glasses tilted low enough to see the blue of his eyes as he peers over them, fluffy white bangs falling over his forehead. His shirt is tailored for a much smaller man, and of course there was no time to get one that actually fits. The white fabric stretches tightly over his broad shoulders, tapers his narrow waist. The buttons look like they're holding on for dear life, barely keeping the two sides of the shirt together. When his torso shifts and the shirt moves, smooth skin and defined muscle peek out from the gaps where the buttons fail to do their job.

Their thighs touch as Phainon moves closer, brushing against Mydei's on accident. Touching was not in the script, but it was natural for mistakes to happen when two people were in such close proximity.

Well… 'mistakes'.

Mydei is just about to reach out, fingers itching to pull him even closer until the distance between them can be measured with mere molecules when a sudden shout cuts through the clamour.

"CUT!"

The music abruptly stops, plunging the set into silence, the sudden shift in atmosphere snaps him back to reality.

"Mydeimos, you missed your cue." Mr Reca's voice is calm as he addresses him, but Mydei can hear the slight frustration in his tone. "Let's try that again."

The set fills with noise again as the crew bustles to get themselves in position for a retake.

Mydei glares at Phainon accusingly, this is all his fault. He made Mydei lose focus.

The infuriating man just smiles at him, fully knowing the effect he has on Mydei. "Try not to get distracted this time," he says in a sing-song voice.

In response, Mydei spitefully wraps the necktie around his knuckle and tugs, pulling Phainon forward until their noses almost touch. Even though he'd been at work all day, Phainon smells so good, musky cedarwood mingling with the gentle scent of peaches.

"Then stop distracting me," Mydei huffs. "You're doing this on purpose."

Mydei shifts uncomfortably in position, the sweat on the small of his back causing his jacket to stick to his skin. He's suddenly aware of how fucking hot the set is with the studio lights shining down on them like that. How close Phainon is when all he can smell is his perfume.

He barely registers Mr Reca’s call of "Take two!” until the song starts up again in earnest. Same guitar riff, same drum beat, his same infernal voice singing the same damn chorus over and over again.

“Let’s hurry it up, think I’m starting to hate this song,” Mydei grumbles, now that he’s listening to it for the billionth time, everything sounds so embarrassing. The lyrics are corny and the way his vocals dip low at the end of the line sounds so fucking forced. It’s starting to not even sound like his voice at all.

Phainon tilts his head slightly as he gets back into the starting position. “Well I love this song.”

Mydei is about to roll his eyes in protest when Phainon moves into his space again, really pushing the limits on what ‘no touching’ entails. The back of his hand barely brushes the edge of Mydei’s shoulder, sending chills down his spine. The warmth emanates off his torso as he body rolls over him, and Mydei feels like he’s about to suffocate on his own saliva because–

Fuck, when did Phainon learn to move his body like that? 6 months of dating and he’s still learning new things about him all the time.

His movements are smooth, purposeful as though he knows exactly how good he looks and what kind of impact he has on Mydei.

Phainon’s eyes rove over Mydei’s naked torso before lifting up to meet his gaze again, and he smirks.

Oh, does he flirt like that in all of his shoots? Mydei *thought* he had nothing to be jealous of but maybe he ought to reconsider that. Should he be worried?

“CUT!”

The director’s shout is like being dunked into a sobering bucket of icy water. It leaves Mydei feeling like an idiot as Phainon pulls away from him, and he’s acutely aware of the staff’s gazes on them, director Reca included.

“Mydeimos, you’re as stiff as a corpse!” Mr Reca complains. “Where is the passion? Where is the fire? Only Mr Khaslana is putting in the work, but the affection should be reciprocated.”

Mydei groans, knowing that he messed up the take again.

The director sighs. “Let’s take a quick break, and we’ll continue filming in five. Mydeimos, take some time to cool down, drink some water.”

Mydei takes a deep inhale, and exhales shakily. “I got it.”

Cool himself down, ha, that’s easier said and done when Phainon is still up in his personal space. And… oh, is he flexing his biceps or are they just naturally that muscular? They’re bulging through the sleeves, that’s just too much.

“Do you want me to get you some water?” Phainon asks.

Mydei has a sudden unhelpful intrusive thought about spilling water down Phainon’s abs and then licking it off. For his sanity, he decides not to pursue that train of thought. “No need, I’m fine.”

He closes his eyes and tries to forget about all the ‘distractions’ around him. He shouldn’t even be this worked up because Phainon is his boyfriend, he’s seen him naked all the time, they have done unspeakable things in and out of the bedroom so it makes no sense for him to get shy about it now.

Phainon is not helping one bit when he looks at him, hunger reflected in those crystal blue eyes and asks. “Then… maybe you’ll relax if I touch you, Mydei?”

Unlike before, when the music was loud enough to drown out what he was saying, Mydei could hear every unfortunate word loud and clear.

He glares at Phainon. “Certainly doesn’t stop you from doing so every night.”

Phainon just sighs forlornly like he’s the world’s most troubled man, eyebrows knitted downwards. “If only it was every night...”

But his hand moves downwards anyway to settle on his bare waist, the sudden chill making him shudder. It's not that Mydei doesn't want Phainon to touch him, of course he does… any sane person would. It's just that he's aware this is still a workplace, and he has to remain professional.

"Phainon," He squeaks, his voice coming out a pitch higher than he would have liked. "N-not here…"

His cheeks feel red hot, the heat spreading all the way down to his neck and chest.

He feels Phainon freeze in place, his voice a low hiss as he exhales.

"*Fuckkk*…" Phainon sighs, dragging the word out in a way that makes Mydei's thighs stiffen. "Do you know what you do to me when you act cute like that?"

He had a weird idea of what 'cute' is. Mydei is not trying to act cute, and he never was any good at it. Except for Phainon and his mother, nobody would dare call him cute to his face.

Phainon had always liked to tease him like this, knowing how much it flustered him. But this isn't the right place nor the right time, so, Mydei stubbornly closes his eyes, hoping that he can somehow will the arousal away.

"Not fucking fair." Phainon leans down and whispers, warm breath caressing his shoulder. His hand moves down Mydei's waist, tracing the line of his hipbone to the waistband of his pants. Mydei shudders, wishing that he was wearing a shirt for once. His pants are just loose enough for Phainon to slip a couple of his fingers in, hooking into the fabric of the underwear he's wearing underneath.

"Why *not* here?" Phainon complains, lips pursed into a pout. "Why can't we ever do anything in public?"

"Are you crazy?" Mydei's eyes open, his words coming out with an offended hiss. Seriously, this man cannot be thinking of propositioning for

them to do *it* in front of his colleagues and his employers! It's scandalous! Degenerate! Unprofessional!

It's not that Mydei doesn't want Phainon to touch him in public, of course he does… any sane person would. Wanting to rip Phainon's clothes off regardless of the time or occasion was a daily struggle in his life. It was either they looked too bad and had no business being on his body—or they looked too good… and had no business being on his body. Sometimes, even Mydei thinks about throwing all caution to the wind and taking what he wants because how can anyone possibly keep themselves under control when their boyfriend looks like that??

Phainon's head is tilted down, he doesn't respond to Mydei's question.

He hears Mr Reca call out again. "Actors and crew, we're back on, cameras are rolling. Take three, ACTION!"

The music starts up again in earnest. The wail of his guitar is accompanied by Castorice's heavy bass riff and Cipher's crashing cymbals.

Mydei looks at Phainon again, trying to read his expression. He can't. Phainon's hair is covering his face, and what he can see of his blue eyes through the thick lenses of his glasses are hazy, maddeningly neutral. Sometimes, he really can't tell what Phainon is thinking.

Whatever, Mydei tries to reset his thoughts and focus on the task at hand. He needs to wrap up this shoot otherwise he and the rest of the crew will not be able to go home. And if he can't go home, sex with Phainon is definitely off the table.

Mydei takes a deep, grounding breath and puts his all into getting the job done, forcing a cool and indifferent expression on his face like the script wanted. He relaxes his posture, elbow on the armrest, fist on his chin, a king on his throne as he regards Phainon in the haughty way that just seems to come naturally to him. He tells himself he's doing a good job, he's absolutely nailing this take. He counts the beats to a metronome in his head, hits all the actions on cue, and opens his mouth in sync to the lyrics with perfect timing.

He’s definitely not thinking about how close Phainon is to him, how his breath tickles when he leans against him like that. How close his hand is hovering over his skin that he can feel the warmth radiating off his palm. How Phainon’s stray hairs get blown around by the breeze and how the white strands sparkle when the light hits it. How his gaze is dark and intense behind the thick glasses, lacking the usual softness that he was so used to.

Indifferent rockstar, indifferent rockstar, don’t break character.

He’s only thinking about work, and not about any of those other things at all.

It was going so well too, until Phainon did something to disrupt his concentration. This time, his hand brushes against the side of Mydei’s ribcage, just brief enough for plausible deniability, at an angle which wouldn’t show up on any of the cameras. So it just looks stupid when Mydei jolts at the sudden contact.

“Hey–” He complains, eyes roving up to glare at Phainon.

The look on his face is one that Mydei is intimately familiar with. Face shadowed, pupils darkened, eyes losing some of that boyish roundness to the point where they appeared almost… sharp, jaw tensed. That’s the look he gets whenever he’s angry, or about to devour Mydei in bed.

Mydei swallows, his body’s response is almost pavlovian the way his heartbeat quickens and heat rolls to his abdomen. No way… did Phainon actually train him to have a physical reaction to that look?

“You look tense.” Phainon’s murmurs. Out of the corner of his eye, Mydei sees the camera lens still aiming down on them, a sobering reminder that they’re being filmed. From this angle, all they would be able to see is the back of Phainon’s head and his own face reacting to it. He’s not sure what kind of footage they’re getting right now, Mydei’s feeling flustered and he’s sure his expression is reflecting that. But Mr. Reca hasn’t stopped them, so they must be doing something right. “Let me help with that.”

Frankly, he’s had enough of Phainon’s ‘help’, if only because it makes his job so much more difficult. Phainon runs his hand down Mydei’s forearm, leaving tingles where their skin makes contact until he eventually threads fingers with Mydei. Holding hands is downright chaste when it comes to the two of them, but something about being so vulnerable under the cameras and spotlights makes it feel extra intimate.

Mydei can do nothing but quietly thank all 13 titans that his pants are baggy enough to keep his growing erection hidden. Judging by Phainon’s knowing smirk though, he thinks he already knows. Phainon could always see through the things he tried to keep hidden.

He doesn’t know if he can last until the end of the shoot.

“Later,” Phainon’s mouth moves like he’s read his mind. “You’re supposed to be working now, stay professional.”

How dare he chastise Mydei about staying professional when he’s the cause of all this!

The next line in the song is coming up… he can’t miss it again. He has to focus, but it’s difficult to think when his boyfriend has half his torso nearly pressing on him, firm muscles pushing against his body. He is only a man.

Luckily, Phainon knows the lyrics to all of his songs and is all too happy to help him out a little bit as he opens his mouth to the words.

Your beauty feels like suffering, I’ll take it all

Cause what we do in the dark has got me thinking

In the back of his mind, Mydei wonders if the camera is capturing all his facial expressions including the stupefied, foolish lovestruck look he’s probably giving Phainon right now. Heart eyes and all.

Phainon’s jaw tightens when he looks at him, like he’s holding himself back despite already being at his limit.

It makes Mydei want to tease him a little, to see who will break their composure first. So when the music dips, he softly murmurs something only the two of them can hear.

“My love.”

Mydei had contemplated what to say to get the most entertaining reaction. Saying his name would be too ordinary, and Phainon had heard ‘HKS’ way too many times to have a reaction to it. ‘Baby’ or ‘honey’ made him cringe too hard, but ‘my love’ had a nice ring to it.

Phainon’s reaction was beyond his expectations.

His eyes widen behind the comically thick lenses and he stares down at Mydei with pure, unfiltered shock. And then without warning, he closes the distance between them and kisses him, any semblance of ‘professionalism’ smashing to smithereens when their lips touch.

Mydei kisses back a little too eagerly, snaking his elbow around Phainon’s neck to hook him in place. In the back of his mind, he’s vaguely aware of the commotion they’re causing on set. Crew members not so subtly gawking and exclaiming at the turning of subtext into text, and a high pitched squeal ripples among the audience that sounds suspiciously like Castorice. Above all, Mr Reca’s clear voice rises above the clamor.

“That’s it! That’s the chemistry I want to see. Make sure you capture every second, don’t you *dare* stop filming!”

He doesn’t even seem angry that Mydei and Phainon had derailed the entire shoot because they couldn’t keep their hands off each other.

Making out sloppy style with his boyfriend in front of all his colleagues during working hours was not on Mydei’s agenda today, but he feels powerless to stop it from happening. This was inevitable the moment Phainon stepped on set dressed like the goddamn sexiest nerd on the planet.

And he might be just a little, teeny weeny bit pent up. Their lives were both so busy and it was hard to find time to spend together. He misses his boyfriend, obviously. While Phainon was definitely the clingier one between them, it didn’t mean that Mydei doesn't yearn to be by his side at all times, he was just a little more reserved about showing it.

Phainon’s tongue enters Mydei like he intends to taste every crevice of his mouth and then some. They swap spit until it overflows and trickles down the side of Mydei’s mouth and he does nothing to stop it because he’s so far gone it’s fucking *disgusting*. Instead, he only tightens his chokehold around Phainon’s shoulders, pulling the collar of his white shirt so hard that it starts to stretch.

He wants to see more of it, the choker encircling Phainon’s pale and slender neck like a collar. He’d started wearing it everyday once he realized Mydei was really into it, and the way seeing it turns him on even after so many months proved that it was the right choice. The shit eating grin he had when he noticed Mydei staring a little too long at one of his photoshoots which prominently featured that damned choker sealed his fate.

But Mydei can admit that he doesn’t hate it, quite the opposite. It really is like a collar, and he likes to think of it as a small sign to indicate that Phainon belongs to him, even if they can’t be around each other all the time.

Maybe for his birthday, he should get Phainon a choker that has his name embroidered along the side. Some food for thought for another day.

Phainon breaks the kiss if only to catch his breath, and Mydei chases him unsatisfied, wanting more. He can’t wait anymore, he wants to rip that shirt off him so badly that it literally hurts—

“CUT!” The shout echoes through the room, so loud and sudden that he instinctively shoves Phainon away. When he returns to his senses, he realizes both of them are red-faced, panting, staring at each other with eyes as wide as saucers.

And Mydei's dick is so hard that it's a wonder that none of his colleagues are calling him out on it but that is neither here nor there.

Now that blood supply has returned to his brain, panic shoots down his spine, cold and alarming. What had he done? Forget the loss of professionalism this is… this is downright obscene! In front of his manager, the director, the staff, his own bandmates… okay, well, it's nothing Castorice and Cipher hadn't seen before but the rest of them! He hadn't even broken the news to the IPC that he was seeing someone!

But he can't bring himself to regret it, because the truth had to come out eventually. With how infatuated he and Phainon are with each other it was only a matter of time. He just hoped his career wouldn't suffer too much as a result… the IPC still needed him to make money, right?

Well, he might as well start by apologizing profusely to the director. To his surprise, Mr Reca doesn't seem mad at all as he stands reviewing the footage from the latest take, one hand placed on his chin deep in contemplation. On the contrary, he looks the most pleased he has been all evening, he didn't even think Mr Reca was capable of smiling so widely like that.

"The sexual tension, the thinly veiled desire, the heat in your gaze, that was a perfect take! The two of you were utterly convincing as people attracted to each other to the point of insanity!" He exclaims, eyes lighting up. Mydei doesn't know whether to take that as a compliment or not.

"Mr Mydeimos, you may have some talent in acting after all." His namecard appears seemingly from thin air as he slides it into the pocket of Mydei's jacket. "And as for the more uh… explicit scenes, eh, we can edit those out in post production."

And with that encouraging remark, Mr Reca claps his hands once, twice, and motions for the crew to wrap up and go home. After days of hard work they are finally finished with the filming of their very first music video.

Mydei sighs, shoulders relaxing. Now that work is out the way there is nothing to stop him and Phainon from–

“Mr Khaslana, may I have a moment of your time?” Except his boss Topaz, and her boss the multi billion net worth conglomerate that could end both their careers with a snap of the finger. Topaz’s smile looks like it’s plastered on, and there is a menacing aura surrounding her that even Mydei doesn’t dare mess with.

Oh, she’s *pissed*.

He exchanges a glance with Phainon, and while Mydei is grateful he’s not the one in trouble this time, he can’t bear the thought of having to wait even a moment longer. The throbbing in his pants is getting kind of insane, and his underwear feels damp and sticky. He… he doesn’t even think he’ll make it all the way home at this rate. Having to say goodbye to the crew, remove his makeup, change into regular clothes, travel home, shower, and THEN sex? That’s just too much to ask of him.

Leaning closer to Phainon, he whispers a command soft enough that only the two of them can hear.

“Meet me in the dressing room when you’re done.”

The resulting beam on Phainon’s face could blind the sun as he nods so vigorously his glasses go askew. That’s enough to convince Mydei that there is nothing, no man, no aeon, not even the IPC, that would stop him from showing up to that dressing room.

“It’s a date,” Phainon punctuates with a wink before bounding off to Topaz like a dog who has threaded mud all over the floor and feels not an ounce of shame about it.

Mydei retreats to the dressing room, a private place allocated for the band to get changed and rest. It’s empty, even Castorice and Cipher’s belongings were gone. Well, they had run slightly over time, so it’s not inconceivable that the girls were in a hurry to get home and rest. They could at least have told him they were going ahead first, though.

Oh well, it’s not that he minded. Perhaps they had sensed the tension in the shoot and knew that he and Phainon would want some alone time, they

were always thoughtful like that.

Even the musky and humid air of the dressing room feels refreshing after the sweltering heat of being under the spotlights, so close to Phainon. Mydei takes a moment to cool down, the breeze from the air conditioning prickling pleasantly against his sweaty skin. He leans against the dressing table for support, crosses his arms, closes his eyes and just tries to relax by taking deep breaths.

That was too close, far too close. If the shoot had gone on for any longer, Mydei would have shown the whole set a real incident when he starts dry humping Phainon on the sofa in front of everyone. He normally considers himself a composed and reserved man but there is something about Phainon's teasing that tips him over the edge, makes him lose all semblance of rational thought and do things he normally wouldn't do.

Ugh… how long will Topaz keep Phainon? Realistically, he probably hadn't been waiting for more than a couple of minutes, but Topaz could give one hell of a lecture if she wanted to. Phainon honestly deserved it but… Mydei needs release *now* and he doesn't care how he gets it.

Secretly, he was relieved and a little grateful he didn't have to shoot an intimate scene with an unfamiliar actor. Mydei didn't like strangers getting into his personal space and had been feeling uneasy about it. But he's really glad that it turned out to be Phainon, he's always been the person that Mydei feels the most comfortable around.

Even if the downside is that he gets a little… too comfortable.

His pants are held in place by a myriad of intricate belts, more fashion than function. Taking off all of them one by one to go to the bathroom was a pain in the ass, so Mydei decides to get a head start on it before Phainon arrives. His fingers feel uncharacteristically clumsy as they finger the metal buckles and fumble with the hooks and holes. Mydei sighs in relief as his pants loosens around his hips and sags, revealing the fine line of golden hair that disappears underneath his underwear.

Mydei can’t take it anymore as he puts his hand down the front of his underwear, groaning in relief as he gently rubs his hard cock. The tip is already wet from precum, the shooting relief from his strokes making him nearly double over in pleasure as he rubs harder, more aggressively.

Phainon’s going to be so mad at him when he finds out.

But it’s his fault for being late.

It’s almost regrettable that masturbation is no longer the same since he’d lost his virginity to Phainon. He used to be able to masturbate to completion with pictures or thoughts alone. Nowadays, it seems like he won’t even be able to orgasm if he doesn’t have the dick of a certain deliverer inside him. Even his cock only gets hard when Phainon is nearby, like it only reacts to his physical presence. And with that, Mydei comes to the rather sobering conclusion that just like Phainon, he’s also become a rather well-trained pet.

Biting down on his lip, Mydei rubs himself harder, faster, his breath coming out in short gasps as the intensity mounts. He’d been holding back during the shoot, but the truth is that he can’t stop thinking about the way Phainon touched him; sly enough that nobody would notice unless they were paying close attention, but vivid enough for Mydei to feel every brush of their skin. Something about doing it right in front of everyone with them being none the wiser was terribly exciting.

Even now he replays the feeling, imagining Phainon’s fingers brushing their way past his hipbones, down his groin and grabbing his cock like now, rubbing it like so in the way that he knows always turns Mydei on…

“Hah… Phainon…” Mydei throws his head back and gasps into the empty room. He wasn’t expecting an answer, but…

“Starting without me?” The door opens and promptly shuts with a click as Phainon’s gentle voice enters the room. It sounds a little different than it usually does though, softer, lower, the dissatisfaction plain.

He strides closer to Mydei, loafers squeaking slightly with every footstep. Sighing, he removes the fake glasses he was wearing for the shoot and tucks them into his collar. The action is so effortlessly sexy that it only makes Mydei feel even hotter.

Mydei has one hand propped on the side of the dressing table for support as he jacks himself off with the other, it's this hand that slips, a combination of sweaty palms and losing his balance. He stumbles, but Phainon is close enough to stabilize him, grabbing him by the shoulders to hold him upright.

"I'm upset, you know. That you're touching yourself when you know I'm getting a verbal lashing from your boss." The pout on his face is obviously fake, and Mydei is, as always, very weak to those huge, watery, sky blue eyes.

He smirks and tilts his head to the side, amused by Phainon's antics. "Well, you started it, *De-li-ve-rer*." Making sure to carefully enunciate each syllable, tone dripping with sarcasm.

Phainon sucks in a breath between his teeth. "Stop, you're going to make me hard every time I hear that nickname."

That would be amazing if he could actually pull that off, Mydei tucks in a mental note to make it happen.

"Touch me."

"As you wish." Phainon murmurs, wrapping his arms around Mydei's waist and leaning in to kiss him. Mydei puckers his lips, only to be left in the cold as Phainon bypasses them in favour of nibbling on his earlobe, his pinna, the sensitive skin on the side of his neck. Mydei unconsciously tilts his head to give him access, groaning as the ticklish sensation of teeth on his neck makes him shudder.

"I am *crazy* for you, Mydeimos." He whispers, lips moving slow and arduous down the length of his neck until they reach Phainon's favorite part of his body, his chest. As usual, he spends extra time on it, kissing the nub

of Mydei’s sensitive nipples, which stiffen with the excitement of what’s to come next.

“What were you thinking? Trying to seduce me at work like this.” Mydei grumbles, though it doesn’t come out as effective as he likes the way his hips buckle and a small mewl escapes him as Phainon’s tongue licks around the side of a nipple.

“Trying?” Phainon’s voice is amused as he looks up at Mydei with a playful look in his eyes. “I’d say I succeeded."

“You seduce everyone you work with like this?” Mydei teases.

Phainon’s brows furrow, his gaze serious as he says “I couldn’t care less about the people I work with. There’s only you, Mydei, I swear it.”

The hands encircling his waist tighten, and Mydei feels his center of gravity lowering as Phainon lowers him into a chair. He feels awfully vulnerable as he sits there, fly unzipped, underwear clearly visible, the silhouette of his cock prominent with a damp spot on the front of it. Combined with Phainon looking down with his muscular arms caging him in position.

“On the contrary.” He says slowly. “Do you always look at your acting partners like you want to be eaten alive?”

Then he lowers his volume even more until Mydei has to strain his ears to hear.

“Thank fuck I was able to intervene in time.”

That gives Mydei some pause.

“You had something to do with the delays?” Truthfully he had suspected *something*, but hadn’t really followed through with that line of thought. It was strange for the actor not to show up when he had already been pre-booked and contracted. The opportunity to work with the IPC was desirable, and no actor in their right mind would burn a bridge this lucrative.

Not unless a really spectacular chance came by.

For example, a once in a lifetime opportunity that seemed tailor made for him.

“Hey, don’t blame me for everything. I only begged Aglaea for a favour, the rest of it was plain bad luck.”

Mydei snorts “Maybe not so bad luck, since it ended up with you in between my legs.”

Phainon pauses, before he laughs gleefully. “Everytime I think I’ve crossed the line… you always manage to surprise me, Mydeimos.” He looks at him with an expression so doting and loving that his heart skips a beat. He thought that after months of dating, the butterflies would have subsided, but he finds that’s not true at all.

Phainon leans down to kiss him, his lips are extra red from where Mydei’s rouge has rubbed off on him and hm… he looks really good, Mydei should consider putting on lipstick more.

“I was never going to allow you to do that kind of photoshoot with someone else.”

“Ha…hahaha.” Mydei cant help but laugh. He knew it, he knew that Phainon wasn’t okay with it. He’d never been good with sharing, he wasn’t even good at letting Mydei out of his sight.

Thank goodness. There had been niggling thoughts in the back of his mind when Phainon agreed to it without a fight. Irrational thoughts like whether he was getting bored of Mydei, or falling out of infatuation, or maybe he was only in love with the Mydei in his head and other stupid things like that. But it seemed like he had nothing to worry about.

“What’s so funny?” Phainon has lowered himself until he’s now sitting in between his legs. He tilts his head, resting it on Mydei’s meaty thigh like it’s exactly where he wants to be. He looks exactly like an obedient dog

with his choker, fluffy white hair, and attentive blue eyes staring up at Mydei.

“Nothing.” Mydei reaches out and grabs him by the chin, and Phainon doesn’t say anything but his pupils flicker downward, his lips curled up in an expression of poorly disguised glee. Ah, so that’s how he wanted to play it.

Luckily, Mydei is in a good mood today.

“My eyes are up here.”

Phainon looks up, makes eye contact with him, and Mydei can’t stop his heart from fluttering at that boyish, mischievous gaze.

“Sorry, I just can’t stop staring at how good you look in these clothes,” Phainon croons smoothly, ever the flatterer.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. Clothes? What clothes? His jacket is barely hanging onto his torso and his pants are falling open at the groin. “My clothes?”

Phainon nods his head eagerly. “I keep thinking how they look easy to take off.”

Mydei jerks Phainon’s head to the side slightly, and while he does wince, it’s accompanied by a shit-eating smirk.

“Is that all you thought about during the shoot?”

Phainon’s gaze quietly flickers to the bulge under his underwear

“...I may have thought about some other things.”

Mydei leans back in his seat. “Well? Show me then, I’m waiting.”

Phainon looks like he’s almost drooling before he swallows his spit and asks boldly. “If I may just request one thing.”

Mydei hums in curiosity, head tilting to the side. “What is it?”

Phainon takes a deep breath before speaking quickly.

“Can you wrap your thighs around my head and squeeze?”

Mydei blinks, taken aback by the request. It wasn’t the first time Phainon had begged to be choked in some form or another. Putting him in a headlock, squeezing his neck during sex, pulling on his choker like a rein and riding it until he couldn’t breathe were just some of the things they tried. But this… this is a new one, Phainon always finds such creative ways to surprise him.

“I’m not sure about this.” Mydei says with concern. While he could control his strength, did they really have to go this far? Thigh muscles were among the strongest in the human body, and Phainon’s neck looked delicate in comparison. What if he hurt him on accident?

“Please?” Phainon pouts, placing the crook of his chin onto Mydei’s thigh. The way his eyes are fixed on him, watery, pleading, huge and pathetic is a total knockout. “Pleasepleasepleasepleaseplease–”

“Alright! Whatever you want.” Mydei relents easily to the begging, having never been good at denying any of Phainon’s requests.

Phainon’s voice sounds wrecked as he pulls Mydei’s pants to the floor, leaving him naked from the waist down.

“I can never get over what beautiful legs you have, and I can’t believe that these gorgeous thighs are mine.” Phainon carefully positions his face in between those so-called glorious thighs, before taking Mydei’s cock into his mouth like he can’t possibly wait anymore.

Mydei’s breath hitches at the feeling of Phainon’s wet mouth wrapping around his cock. His soft, pliant, warm lips around the tip, and his slick

tongue running up and down his sensitive shaft. He instinctively clenches his thighs around Phainon's neck and Phainon moans loudly in response, a satisfied sound as though he was the one getting blown instead.

Phainon just knows his body too well. He knows how to work his mouth around the sensitive nerves in his cock to make him jump, how to run his tongue in circles around it in a way that marks Mydei throw his head back and cry out his name. He's had a lot of practice, hours figuring out and understanding what Mydei likes, down to the way he gives short, kittenish licks across the tip of his aching cock that sends electric shocks up his spine.

"Phai– Phainon." Mydei gasps, feeling like he could come there and then from the way Phainon is sucking him off so good. His cock disappears again into Phainon's mouth, a slight bob in his throat as he rocks from front to back. Mydei's cock is not small by any means, but Phainon is taking it as easily as eating a particularly delicious popsicle.

"Shit…" Mydei murmurs, flushing red hot at the sight of Phainon between his legs, white hair mussed up, eyes slightly bloodshot, still moving his lips around Mydei's cock like he's eager to squeeze every last bit of cum from it.

Mydei hadn't even registered how tense his legs are, how his thigh muscles are strung tightly, clenching around Phainon's neck and shoulders until the skin around them turns red, veins bulging from the pressure. The sweet gasps and moans coming from Phainon lets him know that he likes it though, he was always so loud when it came to expressing his enjoyment. It's Phainon's way of letting him know that he could keep going, that he isn't being too rough, and Mydei is grateful for that gentle encouragement.

"That's it… right there," Mydei jerks and gasps happily as Phainon's tongue licks across a sensitive spot. The hand that is nestled in his white strands pulls, and Phainon's head moves along with it.

"I… I think I'm gonna come," Mydei whimpers, his thighs squeezing around Phainon's neck a little harder this time as he loses control of his strength. As though to tease him, Phainon bobs his head up and down even

faster. The slick, wet sound of him sucking Mydei off is the only sound both of them can hear and it's driving him crazy.

"Y-you better swallow everything." Mydei finds himself saying shakily. The jacket he's wearing is sponsored and worth a lot of money, it has to be returned in good condition or else. "If my outfit gets dirty you have to p-pay."

Such a sentence is enough to subdue most people, but not Phainon. It only seems to excite him all the more and he sucks down on Mydei's cock so hard that his vision goes blurry. Mydei's hips clench with pleasure and he comes in Phainon's mouth, filling up his throat until he nearly gags on it. Trickles of white dribble out the sides of his mouth, down his neck and stain the collar of his white shirt, which definitely cannot be returned after this.

Mydei tosses his head against the back of the chair without even registering the pain. There's sweat beading on his forehead and he's breathing heavily, still high from the euphoria, not wanting to come down. Phainon is not faring much better, his shoulders are heaving as he tries valiantly to swallow it clean. He doesn't succeed, not completely as several drops of warm liquid escape down his chin and drip onto Mydei's bare thighs.

"Too much for you to swallow?" Mydei teases, knowing how Phainon liked to make everything a competition. "You can just admit defeat." When he sucks Phainon off, he never wastes a single drop, Mydei takes pride in that.

"Defeat? Never, I swallowed every single drop. I swear it." Phainon's voice is deep, hoarse and raspy in the way that it gets after spending the last 10 minutes with Mydei's cock down his throat. He wipes the stray droplets with the back of his hand, and both he and Mydei startle when they notice that it's not cum dribbling down his chin, but blood.

Mydei finally takes a good look at him, past the red marks on his neck and shoulders, down his sweat stained collar where the front of his shirt is dotted with drops of bright red, stains of stubborn crimson spreading across the pristine white fabric.

“Phainon, you’re bleeding.” Mydei states the obvious, not able to hide his alarm as he lifts up Phainon’s chin to inspect his face for any injuries. Phainon just blinks at him hazily, a drop of blood trickling from his nostril down his philtrum, tracing the shape of his lip before spilling down the sides of his chin.

Well, he looks as pretty as ever, and doesn’t seem to have any visible injuries. That’s a relief. Mydei had been worried that he’d broken something while in the throes of receiving a blowjob, he’d never be able to live that down.

“Huh?” Phainon still sounds confused, and when he rubs his face with his forearm, it comes away bloodstained. “No, I’m not hurt or anything. I’m… I’m fine.”

“HKS, keep your head down. No talking when you’re having a nosebleed.”

Phainon, while dutifully doing so, laughs through his nosebleed, which makes the blood flow even more. “I think I was so turned on by you that I started bleeding.”

“Pervert.” Mydei says, face turning red.

“Yeah,” Phainon replies wistfully like he’s gone far past the point of trying to hide such a fact.

Maybe the only thing that was broken is Phainon’s brain.

A sudden knock on the door interrupts the moment, followed by the slow turning of the doorknob as somebody tries to enter. Mydei hisses and jolts upright in shock.

“Hide!” He tells Phainon urgently as he tackles them both into a rack of clothes. Their bodies are enveloped by soft and warm fabrics as they plunge into the darkness of the hiding spot.

“Hello?” An unfamiliar voice calls out as the door swings open. He wished they had locked it before doing the deed, but it was too late to have regrets

now.

He holds his breath as the staff member enters the room, and then leaves without suspecting a thing when they flick the lights off after checking that nobody was inside.

The door clicks shut and all is quiet once again, and it's only then when he dares exhale in relief. It's also then that he realized the position he placed them both in, with Mydei pinning Phainon down close to the ground with his body.

"Maybe we should continue this at home." He suggests, feeling flustered by his behaviour. That was really far too close, and he really would not be able to live it down if one of his colleagues had walked in on him receiving a blowjob by the famous model Phainon.

Besides, he's feeling bone tired, the exhaustion of the past few days catching up to him. He's already looking forward to a hot shower, getting comfortable and cuddly in his bed, and who knows, maybe he'll even fall asleep before they can go for round 2.

"...Did I say we can stop here?" Phainon's demeanor changes when Mydei tries to pull away. He pulls himself upright, and as Mydei's eyes adjust to the darkness, he can see a dark shape shifting as Phainon loosens his tie with one finger. It's times like this where Mydei can appreciate how big and tall he is, possibly beating out Mydei himself even if it's only by half an inch or so. It's just that he's usually so careful about how he's perceived, intentionally making himself look as approachable and non-threatening as possible that Mydei tends to forget this fact until he's backed into a corner like this. "You don't get to tease me and get away with it, Mydeimos."

And then he starts yanking clothes off the racks. Anything Phainon can get his hands on gets thrown onto the ground messily.

At first Mydei is confused as to what he's doing. Then it dawns on him… Phainon is making a nest. A nest of *extremely* expensive designer clothes.

Aglaea would have fainted at the sight of such nice clothes being treated so disrespectfully.

“Hey, those are on loan,” Mydei protests. If they get damaged they’ll have to pay for it, and the band’s budget definitely couldn’t afford that.

“Don’t worry, I’ll buy them all after this.”

Mydei just blinks at his boyfriend incredulously.

“You don’t have that kind of money.” He automatically says. Phainon had no idea how expensive some of these clothes were. The jacket he’s wearing is worth more than some people’s monthly salaries!

“Mydei, don’t patronize me. I’ve been in this industry for years. I do have that kind of money.” It sounds so arrogant but it’s true and Mydei knows it from having stalked his stellargram for years. Phainon gets paid well, even if he doesn’t show it.

“At least don’t waste it on clothes for me.” He tries to protest again.

Phainon’s eyes darken. “I guess you’re not one for an extensive wardrobe, considering you like performing half-naked a little too much.”

Half-naked… what a way to describe that he simply prefers going shirtless during a gig rather than stew in his own sweat and ruin another shirt because a fan reached and pulled on it a little too hard.

“I… I don’t do that,” is all he has to say for himself as Phainon pushes him into the middle of the soft nest of clothing.

“And you’ll look so pretty when I fuck you in every one of these outfits, even the dresses.” Phainon’s eyes glint with thinly veiled excitement as he says that. “Especially the dresses.”

“...” The things he would do for Phainon, the things he would let Phainon do to him.

Mydei hooks his finger into the choker around Phainon's neck, and pulls them closer together into the pile of clothes that surround them, soft and warm, like their own little world.

"If you're a good boy… I might let you do that." He croons softly, watching Phainion's eyes shimmer with something eager and almost desperate.

Phainon looks like he's at a loss for words, a pink tongue darting over his lips.

"I can be such a good boy, I'll be the best boy for you– really, I–."

And then he loses control, surging forward with enthusiasm that can only be described as hunger. Phainon mauls him with wet, sloppy kisses all over his face, neck and collarbones. It reminds Mydei of the slobbery licks of an overenthusiastic puppy. A very handsome, very large puppy.

Phainon's heavy body pushes down against him, deeper into the heap of clothes as his body settles in between his legs. Mydei can feel how hard he is already, the shape of his dick as it presses against his thigh.

And although his mouth is incredible, and his blowjob leaves him seeing stars, it doesn't leave him truly satisfied, not really.

There's only one thing that can really satisfy him these days.

"Are you going to put your dick inside me, or what?" Mydei snaps, used to getting his way.

Phainon simply clicks his tongue. "You can be a little nicer than that, Mydei."

Fuck him, playing hard to get as though it's a competition over who wants it more. Like Mydei can't feel his erect, leaking cock pushing against his thigh like he isn't begging for it. As though Phainon's metaphorical tail isn't wagging as fast as an airplane propeller. Sometimes, Phainon finds sick joy in making him beg, making him squirm and plead to be fucked

until he’s nearly in tears. Other times it’s a battle of endurance, seeing who gives in to their basal desires first. .

“Please, Phainon,” Mydei drops his voice to that saccharine sweet low purr that he knows drives him abso-fucking-lutely *crazy*. “Fuck me. Please? You’re such a good boy, such a good boyf- *fuck*!”

He was intending to finish the sentence by saying boyfriend, but he hadn’t expected the way Phainon’s entire pelvis bucked forward at the praise. For someone who insisted that he wasn’t a dog, Phainon sure liked being spoken to like one.

“You– you’re really killing me. I can’t win against you.” Phainon’s voice is weak and raspy as he shrugs off his pants. His cock is hard and red, veins bulging along the surface, the tip already slick with precum. Mydei feels no resistance as he enters, in fact, the stretching of his anal cavity is downright pleasurable. His nerves are already tingling with excitement from the promise of being fucked until he can’t even speak.

“Fuck… it feels so good. It’s like you’re made for my cock.” Phainon tugs the collar of his shirt again, hard enough that another button gives way with a pop, revealing the flushed and chiseled muscle of his torso underneath. He’s sweaty and dishevelled, damp locks of hair sticking to his temples and his forehead in a way that makes him look even hotter. His plush red lips, swollen from kissing, hang partially open as his tongue flicks out to lick at the dried blood along the top of his lip, a remnant of his earlier nosebleed. His golden tattoos are almost glowing in the dark, and for a moment, Mydei is stunned into silence.

He looks ruined, and Mydei made him this way.

What had he done right in a past life to get such a gorgeous hunk of a man to look at him like that? Whose life did he save? Which god had he earned the favour of?

Although he doesn’t admit it often, he feels just as obsessed, clingy and possessive towards Phainon as his boyfriend is towards him. He might be even worse. So he understands all too well the primal instinct of wanting to

keep what belongs to him. And if someone even tried to steal his boyfriend away… well… there is no way he'll let that happen.

Mydei's eyes blink hazily as he hears Phainon calling out his name, he hadn't been listening, got distracted. It was so overwhelming. The feeling of Phainon's cock rubbing against his prostate, sending electric shocks up his spine, somehow seems to amplify his sudden surge of love and affection for the man in front of him.

"Mydei… Mydei, darling, why are you crying?" Phainon is whimpering like it had been his fault. He closes the distance immediately, head rubbing against Mydei's cheek, damp strands of hair tickling his cheek. "Did I hurt you? Did I do something wrong?"

It takes Mydei a moment to even process what he means. Of course everything is fine, why wouldn't it be? Belatedly, he registers the warm trickle of something wet against his cheek.

He rubs it off with the back of his hand, feeling it come away damp. How embarrassing, Kremnoans didn't cry. But he had just felt too overstimulated in that moment, too much, too many, all the emotions he had kept down bubbling to the surface all at once.

"I'm fine." He murmurs reassurance as Phainon makes a sad noise from the back of his throat, eyes huge and wet in a way that makes him look rather pathetic. For some reason, the kicked puppy expression greatly endears Mydei, and he plants a soft, affectionate kiss on his forehead.

Phainon makes a soft noise of confusion.

And because Mydei is always the type to say exactly what's on his mind, he just replies "I was thinking that I really love you."

Phainon's breathing pauses, and his eyes shine like jewels as they gaze at him in the darkness.

"I love you too," he says reverently, like his words will be carried away by the wind if he raises his voice. "I love you so much, I always have."

He pushes in again, gentler now. Although it’s slower, or maybe because it’s slower, the sensation is so much more intense. Mydei throws his neck back, fingers tightening around Phainon’s shoulders as he feels Phainon’s cock slide along his prostate, agonizingly delightful.

“...kiss.” Phainon manages to gasp between ragged breaths, having lost the ability to form complete sentences as he continues thrusting into Mydei. It takes a few tries for their mouths to connect, clumsy as they are in the dark, but when they eventually slot together, Mydei wonders why they didn’t start sooner.

Phainon always kisses Mydei passionately like he’s been given 5 minutes to live and won’t have another chance to kiss him. His lips are always warm, impossibly soft, and fit perfectly in between Mydei’s. His nose is filled with the smell of Phainon’s natural musk mixed with his sweet cologne, and when Phainon opens his mouth to gasp, Mydei takes the opportunity to deepen the kiss, still able to taste the remnants of himself stuck to Phainon’s gums.

Phainon parts his lips and makes a desperate, needy whine straight into Mydei’s mouth. His pathetic warbles and teary eyes tell him all he needs to know.

The thrusting is even more aggressive now, fast and erratic with an uneven rhythm, his grip on Mydei’s waist is so tight that he can feel the indent of his fingerprints sink into his skin. He knows exactly what Phainon wants without him even asking for it.

“You want to come?” Mydei asks.

Phainon nods so quickly that his hair flies around his head.

“Please, please please please Mydei,” he wails, finally finding his words. “Please let me come inside you.”

Mydei pretends to consider it.

“Nah.”

Phainon's resulting whimper sounded like someone had kicked him in the gut. Seeing him close his eyes in obvious distress as he continues rutting into Mydei with no release makes him feel a little bad, but only a little. Because even when Phainon's eyes fill with tears and even when every thrust is punctuated with a small, needy whine he obediently holds himself back. No matter how much he wants more.

Watching him like this, ragged breathing, trembling shoulders, teeth clasped together in a look of utter concentration might be one of the hottest things Mydei has ever seen.

"Well," Mydei pretends to reconsider even though he already knows exactly what he wants. "I'll let you finish inside me if you're a good boy."

Phainon's head springs up with alarming speed. "I'll be a good boy, I'll be such a good boy for you. Anything you need, anything you want. Just name it. I'll do anything–"

Mydei wants to laugh, he's completely wrapped around his little finger.

"Then satisfy me."

He's covered in sweat and his body wants Phainon so bad it's nearly sucking him in. But it's not enough, still not enough, he wants more. He's so selfish when it comes to Phainon, only for him.

And as usual, whatever Mydei wants, Phainon gives.

It's like a switch is flipped in him, turning him into a different person, transforming from a snivelling mess to an absolute beast as his thrusts get rougher and harder. Mydei feels like his guts are getting rearranged, and he absolutely loves it. Phainon pushes his cock so deeply into him that he cries out, tightening his grasp around Phainon's neck until he's sure to leave marks, toes curling at the spike of pleasure that rips through him.

"More, *more*, ah–" His mind is reduced to its baser instincts, all thoughts lost as Phainon's dick hits that sweet spot in the back of his prostate. Mydei doesn't remember what kind of sound he makes as he hits his climax, but it

most certainly contained several iterations of Phainon's name combined with a mixture of expletives.

Whatever he did seems to have excited Phainon even more, because Mydei feels a growing fullness inside him to the point where, if he squints, he thinks he might see the outline of Phainon's cock through his belly.

That's insane, is that even real?

Mydei doesn't have time to ponder on that as the thrusts are now so frequent and so vicious that their entire bodies get jostled around with every movement. His skin feels oversensitive, stinging in places where he scraped against fabric and leather and denim so many times, but he's hardly in a headspace to notice such minor discomforts.

"Mydei…" Phainon pants again, his voice deep, hoarse, and completely wrecked. "Can I come inside you? Please… I'm going insane. Can I?"

Honestly, Mydei is pretty much at his limit too, he's overstimulated to the point of pain, his insides rubbed raw. Through the haze of lust crowding his thoughts he barely has the energy to nod weakly, but that is all the confirmation Phainon needs.

He can feel the moment Phainon absolutely crumbles. When his body shudders violently and he collapses his entire weight on top of Mydei as he orgasms, forgetting how to support his own weight. The way he cries Mydei's name sounds like a prayer, a fervent declaration of his devotion.

It's followed by a feeling that is now familiar to Mydei, the sensation of being completely filled to the brim.

And then they both just lie there for a bit. Spent, exhausted, and utterly satisfied.

Mydei is aware of nothing but the movement of his own chest as he breathes in and out, trying to recirculate oxygen to his body. His muscles ache pleasantly, limbs boneless, thoughts dragging along sluggishly through the haze. Above him, Phainon's body lies limp and heavy, a deadweight.

Every now and again, his muscles twitch as though recalling the feeling of coming over and over again.

Mydei just sighs and throws his head back onto the soft fabrics that cushion their bodies, the smell of sex still lingering in the air. And in that moment, he feels so cozy and appeased that he could probably fall asleep right then and there.

The shuffling of footsteps outside quickly pulls him back into reality. Right, there were crew members staying late, probably cleaning up. The problem with having sex in an area that anyone could easily access at any time means that falling asleep directly afterwards isn't an option.

"We… we should get going." Mydei reluctantly pushes Phainon off him, aching muscles protesting at the movement. They're not the only ones protesting, because the way Phainon whines as he pulls out makes it sound like he's been asked to do something impossible. Immediately, Mydei feels empty, missing the warmness and closeness of before.

If they were in the comfort of their own home, sometimes he'd let Phainon keep it in a little longer after sex. Just… let him stay there and maybe fall asleep with Phainon inside him. Cockwarming feels nice, intimate, just comfortable, a sign of their love and trust for each other.

It's times like these where he yearns for a home with Phainon more than anything. Somewhere that is truly theirs, somewhere where they didn't have to hold themselves back from showing affection, somewhere where Phainon can freely cling to Mydei like an oversized dog.

He'd even tolerate seeing Phainon's freaky ass collection of Mydei's merchandise, life sized cutout and all, if that's what it would take.

"Phainon…" Mydei murmurs softly. "Let's go home."

Phainon just smiles dopily at him, expression totally blissed out.

"Okay."

Mydei's memories of arriving home are hazy at best. He vaguely remembers Phainon lugging his very large, very sleepy, and very annoyed ass into the car. Then out of the car, into Mydei's apartment, then into his shower where he leaned against the cubicle half asleep as Phainon washed his hair for him.

Luckily for them, they didn't run into anybody along the way. No exasperated Cipher sideeyeing their PDA, no curious Castorice collecting more material for her journal. It seemed like the girls were equally exhausted after working so hard and had turned in early for the night.

It's not until they're both tucked into Mydei's soft, warm, king-sized bed, Phainon latching onto him with all four limbs like some oversized octopus when Phainon circles back to a topic he thought they had dropped.

"So… who's been telling you that you're so cute that they could eat you up?"

Mydei snorts in laughter before he can help himself.

"You think this is funny?" Phainon tightens his hold on him until he can't even move, and he can practically hear the pout in his voice. "I asked you a question, Mydeimos."

"She was a single mother who went back to college after having her 2nd kid, Phainon. I don't think you have to worry about her."

He feels Phainon's shoulders sag in relief, and a soft thump as he presses his face in Mydei's back, between his shoulderblades.

"Thank the gods…" he sighs.

Ridiculous crisis averted, for now. But this is probably something that needed to be addressed, and now's as good a time as any.

"You've been acting strange lately," Mydei brings up, feeling Phainon stiffen behind him, followed by obnoxiously fake laughter.

“Is that so?”

“Yeah,” stranger than usual, at least. Phainon had always been a little weird. “You know, if you’re not okay with the photoshoot concepts, all you had to do was say something.”

There is a pause, and he feels Phainon’s arms tighten around his waist followed by a soft, timid ‘I know....”

Phainon continues meekly. “I just didn’t want to seem like I was too jealous or controlling. I want to support you in your career.”

Mydei feels his heart melt, how adorable is this man?

“Trust me,” He brushes his thumb against Phainon’s hands, which are tightly linked together in front of his bellybutton. “I feel plenty supported by you.”

These days, he even dreads stepping into Phainon’s penthouse because of all the Mydei merch he owns. He’s starting to suspect that his boyfriend may have a hoarding problem.

“Besides,” Mydei continues. “I like that you get jealous… It makes me feel like you really want me.”

Phainon is quiet for a little while, but when he speaks again his voice is light, tinged with an undercurrent of hurt and insecurity that he can’t fully hide. “The hundred times I talk about you everyday still doesn’t make you feel like I want you?”

Mydei rolls his eyes, Phainon is a HKS to the core. Six months of dating and he’s still insecure about their relationship? But it’s not like Mydei can blame him, since the scars of their past were not so easily healed. It’s all they can do to comfort each other in small, tender moments like these, to reassure that the love was reciprocated.

Mydei rolls on the bed, turning to look at Phainon face to face. Without saying a word, he tucks the loose locks of white hair behind his ears.

They’re still slightly damp from where Phainon hadn’t dried his hair properly, very soft to touch, and small faintly of his own strawberry shampoo.

He starts to feel a little bit bad at the sight of Phainon’s crestfallen expression. “Sorry, that’s not what I meant. I just didn’t think that you from 6 months ago would be okay with me doing these sorts of shoots so part of me just wanted to… push you a little.”

It kind of sounds worse when he airs it out in the open like that.

And Phainon catches on quickly.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon says, propping himself up on a single elbow. “If I didn’t know any better, I’d think you were accepting these jobs on purpose to test me.”

Heat immediately flows to Mydei’s face. It’s not like he was going out of his way to do so… the IPC had pitched these as legitimate marketing strategies, and refusing it would have made all of their jobs significantly more difficult.

But… maybe… okay, *maybe* there was a part of him that wanted to see Phainon get a little bit jealous.

Phainon unlatches his fingers only to dig them into the dips above Mydei’s hips and squeeze lightly, a threat. Ever since discovering that Mydei was ticklish, he had used his powers for evil, to devastating effect.

He jabs a finger into the flesh under his ribs, and that’s enough to make Mydei’s entire body jolt.

“Well? Were you?” Phainon asks again, faux innocently. He wriggles his fingers into Mydei’s tender flesh again and Mydei nearly throws him off the bed this time.

Mydei just glares at him, face feeling hot and flushed. He doesn’t want to admit the truth, that would be too embarrassing, but he doesn’t want to lie

either, so Mydei opts for a third option and changes the subject completely.

“I saw something interesting when browsing your fanpages the other day,” he starts casually.

Phainon stops tickling him to literally cringe when he mentions the fanpages.

“Come on…” he says sheepishly. “Stop browsing those tabloids. You know I’ll tell you everything you want to know.”

“Humph, only if you stop buying my merch. I can’t even take 10 steps into your house without seeing my face everywhere.”

“So you can be a creepy fanboy but I can’t do the same?” Phainon protests, Mydei ignores him because he does not want to acknowledge the hypocrisy that he also runs his own fan account for Phainon.

A fan account that, by the way, broke a hundred thousand followers just last week, an impressive milestone. People online loved it because it always somehow managed to get shots of the elusive model that nobody else was able to, something different than the usual blurry walking snapshot taken off the street. Gym selfies, pictures of Phainon mid-nap, exclusive behind the scenes shots at a photoshoot. Netizens often speculated that it was Phainon’s own management running the account to generate hype but the real reason… is Mydei’s little secret.

Mydei lifts up his phone from its charger, the black screen flashing to life when he opens it to show Phainon the bookmarked posts of him out and about, captured by his competitors (other fanpages). There is a familiar pink-haired woman walking next to him, their arms linked together by the elbow.

Scrolling through the comments, opinions varied, but most seemed to speculate that they were dating.

Phainon just blinks at the pictures, like he hadn’t expected to be caught in the act. “Wait, wait wait wait– Cyrene was just–”

“I’m not accusing her,” Mydei says flatly, shutting down that train of thought. “She was the one who called me first.” He remembered picking up the phone thinking there was an emergency due to how panicked she was, only to find out she was just desperate to prevent a misunderstanding before it happened.

“You’re the best thing that’s ever happened to Phainon,” She told him fervently. “Those years where you were broken up he was just so… so wrong. I’ll do anything I can to avoid that outcome again.”

He adored Cyrene, his initial impressions of her had been completely wrong. Once he got to know her a little bit more, he found out she was kind, thoughtful, funny, an amazing friend, and they got along wonderfully. It wasn’t long before she became one of his most trusted confidantes.

“You could have told me if you were looking for jewelry. I could have gone with you.” It’s a bit hurtful because Phainon of all people knows how much Mydei loves jewelry. Rings, necklaces, earrings, he’s rarely seen without wearing some of it on his person, and his entire fashion sense revolves around accessories. What? Is Mydei’s taste not good enough for him or something? Like Phainon’s taste in clothing is any better? Those t-shirts he always wears are atrocious.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “But I guess we shouldn’t be seen together in public going jewelry shopping.”

Their public relationship is a contentious subject, and it turns into an argument every time it’s brought up. Logically, he knows why their relationship should be kept secret, and it makes sense. Mydei’s career is still tenuous, one wrong move might turn into a scandal that mars his reputation, but the one he’s really worried about is Phainon.

Phainon with his passionate fanbase, Phainon with his squeaky clean public image. He thought he’d grown out of the mindset, but a part of Mydei couldn't help but fear that he wasn’t good enough. That people would still look at the two of them and think why the hell Phainon would date someone like him.

It seemed… easier to just avoid the topic altogether, so that's why he continues to insist on keeping their relationship secret. Even though Phainon has made it clear that it's not what he wants.

Phainon flushes pink for some unknown reason. "No… you're misunderstanding, it's not because of that I… argh…" he groans, running a hand through his hair.

"?" Mydei's confusion is almost audible in the darkness.

"I was kind of hoping to keep it a secret for a little while longer," he finally admits.

And Mydei admits that he is totally lost. "A secret that you went jewelry shopping?"

Why does that even need to be a secret?

Then he sighs, quietly hurt but letting it slide. He shouldn't be pushy. Phainon has always been honest with him and will tell him the reasoning when he is ready. He shouldn't be jealous either, but sometimes the intensity of his own feelings rage violent and terrifying, like a wave he can't tame.

But that isn't Phainon's problem, it's his, so Mydei has to do his best to control his own emotions.

"Sorry," he says. "I shouldn't have pushed. Good night, Phainon." And with that, he turns himself so that he faces away from Phainon and tries to go to sleep.

"Hey, hey. I'm not done talking." Phainon can get really pushy when he wants to be, and there is no subtlety in the way he grabs Mydei's shoulder and flips him over like he's nothing more than a pancake until they're so close that their noses almost touch.

Mydei just waits quietly for him to speak as Phainon's face gets redder and redder. His boyfriend licks his lips, uncharacteristically nervous.

“I… I was looking at rings.” Phainon says after a moment, voice so soft it can barely be considered a whisper.

Mydei squints, thinking he’d misheard. “Come again?”

Phainon’s gaze darts to the side. “I know that we’ve not been together for very long, but I was going to ask you to marry me. It kills me that we can’t make our relationship public, I understand the reasoning, but… it would make me feel better if you wore my ring, so that people knew you were taken.”

Mydei blinks, his chest feeling all warm and tingly all of a sudden. Phainon had already thought that far ahead?

Marriage… Mydei had never thought too deeply about it, it always seemed like something that was out of his reach. His parents were happily married and adored each other deeply, and sure Mydei had hoped he could obtain something similar for himself one day but it’s just…

He just… never really let himself linger upon it, that’s all.

“You really want to marry me?” He’s not prepared for how fragile and vulnerable his voice sounds, like he’s on the verge of tears.

“Of course,” Phainon says warmly. “You didn’t think I’d spend all those years chasing you only to let you go, did you? Marriage would bind us together, forever.”

He takes Mydei’s hand and holds it, pressing his fingernail against the base of Mydei’s ring finger until it hurts. When he lets go, there is an indentation of fingernail marks at the position where a wedding band would sit.

“Because you’d have to swear an oath to me too, and I know you’ll never break a promise.” Phainon continues.

Mydei’s lip curls up into a smile. “You don’t need marriage for me to surrender my heart to you when it has always been yours. And I don’t see why you can’t have the rest of me for the rest of our lives too.”

He’d always been a man filled with certainty, and this is no exception. “I would choose you over and over again.”

Phainon mirrors his smile, teeth shining bright in the darkness.

“You are so…” He appears so moved that he can’t even finish his sentence. “Well… it will take me some time to formally propose, not any old proposal would do, you know? You deserve something incredible. As for the engagement ring… maybe something to match the sun brooch you got me…”

Mydei clicks his tongue, it’s always embarrassing whenever he brings up that silly teenage gift as though Mydei hasn’t gotten him anything nicer since they started dating. “HKS, stop bringing that up.”

Phainon laughs cheerfully, bright and relieved before leaning in to kiss him. It’s not one of those desperate kisses that tries to eat him alive, this one is gentle, soft. It doesn’t turn him on or make heat shoot down his loins; it just feels… good, right, perfect even. It feels like Mydei could kiss him forever.

And what’s stopping him from doing so? Nothing.

“You took tomorrow off, right?” Mydei asks as Phainon lazily pulls away from him.

“Of course,” he chirps cheerfully. “It’s your first day off in forever. It’s been too long since we went on a date, just you and me.”

“Let’s go shop for rings together,” Mydei suggests abruptly. “I don’t want to wait anymore.”

Phainon gapes and he nearly chokes on his own saliva, pale eyelashes fluttering as he blinks frantically. “What?”

“Can’t let you go and choose something terrible for me.” Mydei says, like it’s a foregone conclusion.

“But the tabloids–”

“Are going to have a field day.”

“--And the IPC–”

“Are going to be so pissed off and there would be nothing they can do about it.” He genuinely likes Topaz and is sorry for all the extra work that he's going to put on her. But not sorry enough to change his mind.

Phainon still looks unconvinced. “But my fans, your career–”

“Are going to be fine.” Mydei tells him firmly. “Or do you not trust me to have everything under control?”

“No, of course I trust you,” Reassured by his words, or perhaps the utter confidence in the way he declares it, Phainon’s unease melts away. The smile is back, more blinding than ever, so bright it could light up the entire room.

Mydei thinks he looks best this way, at ease and smiling, happy and healthy, no trace of despair or loneliness in his blue eyes.

With a smile that shines as brightly as the sun.

Mydei’s own personal sunshine.

~The End~

Hyacine’s Group Therapy

Days since last traumatized: 24

March 7th shared a link

http://www.thedailyamphorean.com/

The Daily Amphorean - PUBLICITY STUNT or OPPOSITES ATTRACT?! Rising rockstar Mydeimos spotted cozying up to fashion’s IT boy Phainon Khaslana in jewelry shopping spree!

Did you guys see this?

They went public already?

Phainon said I would be the first to know...

RESET THE CLOCK!

Cipher updated the group status to ‘Days since last traumatized: 0’

What happened this time?

I don’t want to say too much but

@Hyacine can me and Cassie stay over tonight?

Of course! You’re always welcomed!

Ooh can I join too?

Is this a sleepover? I’m in!

Me too! And so is Dan Heng!

Caelus, March, don’t invite yourself to things without permission.

Don’t worry, you’re all welcomed. There’s enough room for everyone ♥

If any of you have brain bleach that would be appreciated.

Where’s @Castorice? She seems unusually quiet today…

Castorice shared a link

archiveofourown/works/77611626

Take Me Into Eternity - Chapter 1
Author: princessbutterfly
Fandoms: Titans of Calamity, Fashion Model RPF
Characters: Mydei (Titans of Calamity), Phainon Khaslana

Summary: Childhood sweethearts Phainon and Mydei have been secretly dating for a while now. Whilst the alpha supermodel desperately wants to make their relationship public, the rockstar, who has been hiding his omega status from the world, is a lot more hesitant. Things become complicated when Mydei falls ill, and takes a pregnancy test that will change both their lives forever.

Did you finally finish it? I can’t wait to read it!

Yes I saw some things today that gave me motivation to finish it :)

Thanatos just take me now

Chapter End Notes

> And that's the end of the fic! I would like to take this opportunity to thank each and every one of you who read, commented, left kudos, or shared it with others. I appreciate your support immensely and honestly this fic wouldn't be half as long without your encouragement and support. It really means a lot to me and seriously Thank you thank you so much! I think this is actually my longest complete fic to date which is a big deal for me because I'm such a flake fr.
>
> If you enjoyed reading this, I would love to hear from you. Even if you're reading this in the future (please tell me if Phaidei get an sp), I would still love to read your comment! I try to reply to every single one of them and I strive to entertain y'all in the comments section as well :D
>
> Now I can't wait to sit back, catch up on all the amazing fic I've been procrastinating on reading, and maybe finish some of my other

published fics.
My dozens of new Phaidei ideas in my docs: ADDRESS ME

Until next time! :)

my twitter

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!